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UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA

Los Angeles

# The Poetics of Sleep: Representing Dreams and Sleep in Latin Literature and Roman Art

A dissertation submitted in partial satisfaction of the requirements for the degree of Doctor of Philosophy in Classics

by

Emma Jane Scioli

2005

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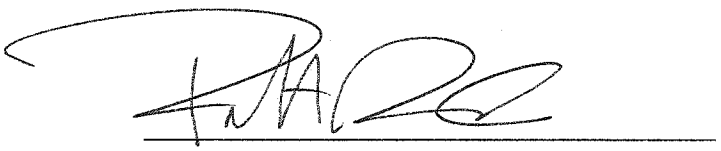
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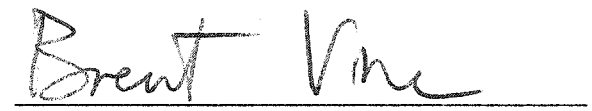
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For my parents and for Phil



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towards rocky ground or into unfriendly seas. He helped me to express my ideas clearly without ever making me feel that I was writing this dissertation for him. His guidance and friendship have been exceptional. Kathryn Morgan and Trevor Fear offered valuable advice while I was still developing my ideas. Carole Newlands has provided insightful criticism at various stages of the project. Christine Walde has been a treasured resource and a good friend over the past year.

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ABSTRACT OF THE DISSERTATION

The Poetics of Sleep: Representing Dreams and Sleep

in Latin Literature and Roman Art

by

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Doctor of Philosophy in Classics

University of California, Los Angeles, 2005

Professor Sander M. Goldberg, Chair

The Romans conceived of sleep as an outside force, sometimes personified as the deity Somnus, while dreams, whether visions of the dead, or symbolic messages that required decoding, were personal and characterized as internal mental experiences. There was often a tension between the exterior and interior forces of sleep and dreaming. This dissertation identifies several Roman attitudes towards sleep, dreams, and insomnia through the study of representations of the sleep experience in the poetry of Propertius



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and Statius as well as the depiction of sleeping figures in the visual arts. Not only are sleep and insomnia the dominant themes of two of these authors' best-known poems, but study of their works opens up important insights into formal and thematic issues raised by this topic. Thus, a comparison between the introspective, first person narration of elegy and the detached, third person viewpoint of epic illuminates the complex relationship between the interior and external aspects of the experience of sleep in Roman thought.

I argue in chapter 1 that the parallel between the experience of dreaming and that of looking at art is more complex than a simple analogy between the content of Propertius' dream images and the composition of certain wall paintings. Rather, the poet's construction of a dream image in visual terms reveals a sensibility shared by his artistic counterparts, one which exploits the tension between interior experience and exterior viewership. My analysis in chapter 2 compares Propertius' representation of sleep to related instances in the visual arts, chief among them the case of Rhea Silvia. The figure of Somnus in Statius' *Thebaid* (the subject of chapter 3) is an oppressive and powerful external force, whose ability to subdue a sleeper is corroborated by his personification on numerous Roman sarcophagi. But Somnus' absence, the insomnia which afflicts many of the epic's characters, is equally formidable, as it reflects the destructive circumstances of the *Thebaid's* fratricidal narrative. The dissertation's final chapter looks at how authors have used insomnia as a trope in their writing to reflect its desirable and abhorrent aspects, and to convey information about their own poetics.



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# Introduction

*umbrarum hic locus est, somni noctisque soporae*
-Virgil, *Aeneid* 6.390

## Beyond dream interpretation

In a recent article in which she uses ancient dream discourses to illuminate the fictional language of Apuleius' *Metamorphoses,* Vered Lev Kenaan coins the term "dream poetics" to describe the connection between the subjective experience of the dreamer and the creative imagination of the author.[1] Indeed recent scholarship has made productive use of the parallel between dream interpretation and textual hermeneutics.[2] In this dissertation I define and explore a "poetics of sleep." This rubric, which comprises dreams, sleeping figures, Somnus (the external personification of sleep), and insomnia, includes all of the facets of sleep. Although each has received adequate attention individually, there has been no study that compares their representation and function within one author's work. This is one innovation of my approach. Additionally, to appreciate a poetics of sleep we must acknowledge Roman attitudes

[1] Lev Kenaan (2004) 269-70. Lev Kenaan's article presents a refreshing look at the role of the dream experience (and the dreamlike) in Apuleius' *Metamorphoses.* She draws on a number of dream discourses from antiquity as templates for understanding Apuleius' literary technique.

[2] Netta Berlin (1994) used a close reading of specific dreams as a way to access narrative technique in her study of the Latin epic poets Virgil, Ovid, and Lucan. In a recent treatment of dreams in Plato's *Theaetetus,* Kathryn Morgan (2003) 102 suggests that "dreaming can be seen as an analogue for the experience of fiction." Therefore, her analysis identifies in Plato the analogy that both Lev Kenaan and Berlin flesh out in their work. The related connection between prophecy and the narratological function of dreams is a feature of the studies of Bartsch (1989) 32 ff. and MacAlister (1996) 36 ff. Bartsch argues for Artemidorus' categories of interpretation as important hermeneutic tools for reading dream accounts in the Greek novels. The analogy between dreaming and the creation of fiction is also adduced by scholars who work on literature from other periods and cultures. See, for example, Canovas (1994) 119, who writes of Baudelaire that "the effect literary dreams produce on the reader is closer to fiction's than to dream's." Carol Schreier Rupprecht (1993) has edited an entire volume entitled *The Dream and the Text,* whose essays are devoted to exploring the overlap between creating fiction and dreaming in the literature of various cultures and time periods.



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toward sleep that extend beyond the fascination with dream interpretation. Therefore, in this project I expand upon the noted parallels between dream and narrative, which are too often restricted to textual narrative alone, with an examination of the equally interesting and relevant visual coherence (or incoherence) of dreams. This has enabled productive consideration of instances from the visual arts in conjunction with the textual exempla, which is the second innovation of my approach.

My study examines the role of dreams and sleep in the works of two authors who devote significant attention to their representation, and for whom the textual function of nighttime phenomena reflects a particular characteristic of their respective poetic styles. I am interested specifically in the role of sleep and dreams in the work of the poets Propertius and Statius, and what this reveals about the formal and thematic elements of their poetry. For I am convinced that a close reading of these features contributes significantly to our understanding of the poetic technique of these authors in a manner that has been surprisingly undervalued in studies of their work. Thus the identification of a poetics of sleep in Propertius' poetry involves noting the correspondence between dream imagery, the mystery of the sleeping figure, and the potentially deceptive power of vision. In the poetry of Statius, a poetics of sleep refers to the connection between the restless sleep of the characters of his *Thebaid,* the sinister characterization of Somnus, and the statements he makes about his own experience of writing the epic. Rather than isolate and extract individual episodes for comparative analysis, I examine the relevant passages in context to elucidate their function within the larger corpus of each poet's work and to appreciate how they represent its dominant stylistic features.



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The study of dreams in antiquity[3] -- whether in literature, philosophy, or in ancient culture in general -- must always acknowledge the dichotomy between a dream's

[3]The history of scholarship on dreams in antiquity is substantial. There are certain topics which seem to have perennial interest, such as dreams in epic poetry. Note that one of the earliest works on dreams in literature is J. B. Stearns' *Studies of the Dream as a Technical Device in Latin Epic and Drama*, a doctoral dissertation from 1927; one of the most recent is J. Bouquet's *Le songe dans l'épopée latine d'Ennius à Claudien* (2001). Bisecting these almost exactly is A. Grillone's 1967 *Il sogno nell'epica latina*, which also ranges from Ennius to Claudian. While Stearns includes two genres and Bouquet's work includes authors who were undoubtedly outside of the canon of Stearns' potential subjects, each of these works is guilty of excising the dreams from their contexts and looking at them as isolated incidents. Of course each study is valuable in its capacity as a compendium, but I find that the desire to excerpt the dream from its literary context and to treat it as a mode for comparing stylistic development within a genre has only limited application and relevance. These sorts of studies tend to become more like dream diaries, where the dreams themselves become the sources for comparison as though they existed independently of author and text. In this kind of study, there is a tendency to interpret the dream as though it were an account of an actual dream, rather than a literary creation. In some notable cases, the focus shifts to the similarities between the dream as described in the ancient source and its resemblance to the experience of dreaming familiar to the book's contemporary modern readers, thus highlighting the bizarre or surreal qualities of the passage in question. G. Devereaux's 1976 *Dreams in Greek Tragedy* is perhaps the pinnacle of this approach in that he excerpts the dreams of the characters from various Greek tragedies in order to subject them to a Freudian analysis. This results in an investigation of character motivation, as if the characters he is dealing with have lives and histories that predate the text in which they appear. Another recent work which takes this "compiling" approach, although it includes a variety of sources, is G. Weber's 2000 *Kaiser, Träume und Visionen in Prinzipat und Spätantike*, which is a formidable study of the dreams of the Roman emperors from Augustus through Constantine and into the Byzantine period. This work also runs the risk of creating too great a division between literary dreams and the "actual" experience of dreaming in antiquity by placing the historians in a separate category.

P. C. Miller made a significant contribution to the study of dreams in a particular period by defining dreams as "tropes that allowed the world -- including the world of human character and relationship -- to be represented" *Dreams in Late Antiquity* (1994) 1. By conceiving of dreams as representative modes, she opened up a way of studying the relation of dreams or their description as receptacles for the cultural concerns of a specific age. One of the most important recent works on dreams in literature is C. Walde's *Traumdarstellungen in die griechisch-römischen Dichtung* (2001), an exhaustive work which considers Greek and Latin poetry from different genres in its attempt to establish common features in the literary representation of dreams from Homer to Lucan. Although this type of work must by necessity be somewhat cursory, Walde manages to pinpoint the function of the dream in the specific literary context for which it is created in a limited amount of space. Walde's commitment to understanding the dreams in these authors as literary devices is very important for turning the discussion of dreams away from the ancient practice of divination and specifically towards understanding the hermeneutics of their literary function. Despite the encyclopedic nature of her work, a feature of its style, Walde succeeds at using modern literary and psychoanalytic categories of classification with great success.

There is another branch of the study of dreams that has tended to privilege interpretation and the function of dreams in the ancient society. See W. V. Harris' recent article (2003), where he challenges the very assumption that the majority of Romans believed their dreams or invested them with great importance, by seeking out categories of types of "truthfulness" in dreams. He also provides a summary of the relevant previous literature on the subject.



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possible divine (objective) or personal (subjective) source and its value (or irrelevance) for the of prophecy of events to come, which was central to ancient dream discourses.[4] We can profitably consider this division as one manifestation of a larger distinction between external and internal phenomena. The tension caused by this polarity is prominent in the representations of dreams, sleep, and insomnia in the poetry of Propertius and Statius and is important to the successful illusionism of certain examples from Roman art. The goal of my study is to understand the poetic and artistic function of this tension. The difference between internal and external, as it is relevant to the study of sleep and dreams, can be charted along two lines: the most obvious is the division between types of dreams, as mentioned above, into what we might call subjective and objective dreams; the second is the distinction between dreams in general as internal phenomena (regardless of their origin) and sleep as something that envelopes the sleeper from the outside (regardless of the fact that it is experienced physically as internal). In my approach to the intricate expressions of these tensions, dreams are a point of departure for the extended discussion. The sophisticated interplay between internal and external in Propertius' dream poems and its illumination of the role of visuality elsewhere in his poetry establishes a paradigm for the observation of similar tensions in the interaction between viewers and sleeping figures. This, in turn, paves the

[4] These distinctions are made by the primary surviving sources for the classification of dream categories pertinent to the interpretation of dreams. Artemidorus, for example, distinguishes between the ὄνειρος and the ἐνύπνιον, as prophetic (objective) and non-prophetic (subjective or 'psychological'). Macrobius uses the terms *somnium* and *insomnium*, respectively (see commentary on chapter 3 of the *somnium Scipionis*). See also Plato, *Republic* 9.571c - 572b for another type of distinction between species of dream, those created by the "rational" part of the soul and those created by the "irrational."



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way for an analysis of the dynamic at work in the relationship between Somnus and the characters of the *Thebaid,* and his ability to favor or deprive a sleeper of his gifts.[5]

**Dreams as visual experiences**

It is important to recognize that the Romans considered dreams visual experiences. Divination through dreams would have relied as much upon a dreamer's recollection of a dream's visual images as upon his recounting of its narrative content.[6] A form of the verb *video* often prefaces the description or retelling of a dream in a text, thereby reminding the reader that a visual experience is being translated into textual terms. This has precedent in Greek literature, where forms of the verb ὁράω are used to describe the experience of dreaming.[7] In Latin literature, the verb usually appears in one of its passive forms, as we see in Ilia's account of her dream of Mars in Ennius'

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[5] The study of dreams has tended to exclude consideration of other related phenomena, such as sleep or insomnia. Georg Wöhrle's book (1995) is a study of Hypnos/Somnus in Greek and Latin literature. Even more than its counterparts in the study of dreams, this book has little to say about the context, mostly poetic, of its excerpts. Beginning with the earliest references to the genealogy of sleep, the book is a sort of biography of the personification of sleep without probing too deeply into any of the instances it presents. An examination of the table of contents for a recent publication entitled *Sleep* (T. Wiedemann and K. Dowden, eds. (2003) Bari) reveals that it contains a collection of essays that deal mostly with the cultural attitude towards sleep, with only one essay on the personification.

[6] When Artemidorus introduces the concept of the ὄνειρος (a dream with significance for the future), he defines it as follows: κίνησις ἢ πλάσις ψυχῆς πολυσχήμων (1.2.16). *LSJ* gives as the primary definition for the adjective πολυσχήμων "of many shapes, varied in form". The adjective likely refers both to the physical appearance of the dream image and its narrative content. Artemidorus also uses the verb ὁράω to describe a person's dream experience (see, for example, his claim that a frightened man will see in his dreams the very things he fears, 1.1.19). This verb is also used by Aristotle in his discussion of divination through dreams (see for example, *De Divinatione per Somnum,* 463b18).

[7] Two examples from tragedy will illustrate this point. In Aeschylus' *Agamemnon,* the chorus recounts Menelaos' mournful dreams and their deceptive powers as follows, ὀνειρόφαντοι δὲ πενθήμονες / πάρεισι δόξαι φέρουσαι χάριν ματαίαν / μάταν γὰρ, εὖτ' ἂν ἐσθλά τις δοκοῦνθ' ὁρᾷ, / παραλλάξασα διὰ / χερῶν βέβακεν ὄψις, οὐ μεθύστερον / πτεροῖς ὀπαδοῦσ' ὕπνου κέλευθοις (lines, 420-26, Denniston and Page). In Sophocles' *Electra,* Klytemnestra's dream is reported by Chrysothemis as follows: λόγος τις αὐτὴν ἐστιν εἰσιδεῖν πατρός / τοῦ σοῦ τε κἀμοῦ δευτέραν ὁμιλίαν / ἐλθόντος εἰς φῶς (lines 417-19, Jebb). Note the underlined words.



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*Annales: nam me visus homo pulcer per amoena salicta...raptare* (1.38-9 Skutsch).[8] The use of a periphrasis for visual experience, as in *et iuveni ante oculos his se cum vocibus offert* from book 7.420 of Virgil's *Aeneid,* where Allecto appears to Turnus disguised as an aged priestess--although less common--conveys the importance of dreamer's visual perception of the dream.[9]

In Latin literature and in its precedents in Greek literature, the dream account consists of a visit from either a god in disguise or a dead figure who has come to convey a message or make an important request. The impact not only of what the visitor says, but the mere fact of his presence in the private space of the dreamer typically leaves an indelible impression upon the dreamer after waking. This type of scene reveals one explanation for the phenomenon of dreaming in antiquity: that it was an experience imposed upon the dreamer from the outside.[10] When we do read accounts of more personal, symbolic dreams, we become aware of the complexity of relaying visual experience in textual terms. Even to the person recounting his experience, the

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[8] Ilia uses the passive form of *video* twice more in her description: *errare videbar* (line 40) and *pater me voce videtur* (line 43). The latter example shows that Ilia's visual memory of the experience is as important as the recounting the words he spoke to her.

[9] Use of the active forms of *video* is rare. One important example occurs in Propertius 2.26a.1 (discussed in detail in chapter 1).

[10] This is the case for Aeneas' dream of Hector in *Aeneid* book 2.270 ff., where Aeneas emphasizes the visual quality of his dream (*ante oculos maestissimus Hector / visus adesse mihi...*) in recounting Hector's bloodied and distorted appearance. Aeneas is shocked by this invasion of a figure from the past into the realm of the present, a surprising intrusion also of the dead into the realm of the living, and of the immaterial into the realm of the dream (lines 281-86). He then goes on to recount the content of Hector's speech, which has great significance for his subsequent action.



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incongruities of the dream are jarring and the confusion surrounding the potential deception of its visual imagery is evident.[11]

The attempts to account for dreams in scientific terms are also pertinent to a discussion of the visual quality of dreams in ancient literature. Plato, who presents the earliest such account, discusses the nature of dreams in various works from different periods.[12] In the *Timaeus,* however, he presents a biological explanation for the experience of dreaming, which, as R. D. Archer-Hind puts it, "might excite not unreasonable surprise," since Plato is usually so careful to avoid discussion of the material world, as he thought it was unknowable by men.[13] But his exceptional account in the *Timaeus,* a work devoted to the origin of the visible world, is especially interesting for a discussion of the visual quality of dreams, primarily because Plato makes no claim for the divine visitation dream, which attributes a dream's images to an external visitation; rather his account attributes dreams to internal phenomena. This version of human dreaming is particularly relevant because it forges a connection between the acts of viewing while awake and seeing images in dreams.

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[11] Penelope's dream of the geese in *Odyssey* 19.535 (discussed later) is the paradigm for the symbolic dream whose images confound the dreamer. See also Medea's dream in book 3.616 ff. of Apollonius' *Argonautica,* where her dream of fighting the bulls causes her such anxiety that she cannot leave the room nor think how to relate to her sister what she has seen. Ismene's dream of her disrupted wedding to Atys' in book 8.622 ff. of Statius' *Thebaid* provides an example of a dream-image that conflicts with the dreamer's own self-image to such an extent that she is hesitant even to retell the dream, much less try to interpret its meaning.

[12] See also, *Republic* 476c-d and *Theaetetus* 157e-158d, for example, for Plato's various accounts of dreams and dreaming, all of which are summarized in Vegléris (1982). In these passages, Plato is interested in the deceptive and false quality of dream images, as they are replications of the objects they appear to be and, hence, farther removed from the truth.

[13] Archer-Hind (1888, rev. 1973) 46.



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There are two salient passages in the *Timaeus* (45d-46a and 70d-72d), which, although difficult to reconcile with one another, are helpful in establishing an early precedent for the interconnection between vision as a sense and vision in dreams.[14] For my purposes, it will be helpful simply to refer to the first section (which draws on material from 44d onward), where Plato claims that our visual flow, that which we emit during the day and which enables us to see, is unable to function at night, and is therefore trapped within. Its function at this point is to calm the internal motions in order to enable us to sleep peacefully, but this is prevented if the internal motions (i.e. those left behind from things perceived and internalized during the day) are particularly strong. These motions give rise to dreams (ἀφομοιωθέντα ἐντὸς ἔξω τε ἐγερθεῖσιν ἀπομνημονευόμενα φαντάσματα); that is, internal images that resemble the motions and are remembered as external when the dreamer wakes up. When the visual flow that is responsible for enabling us to see during the day loses its effect once trapped inside the body, another sort of visuality dominates, in this case, one caused by motion. This explanation posits dreams as internal phenomena, which are allowed to arise when the power behind external vision is overcome. As Archer-Hind explains in his commentary on this passage, "dreams are the results of motions which are not thoroughly calmed down, whereby semblances of external things are presented to the mind from within."[15] In Holowchak's words, "by linking dreaming so close to vision, Plato must have known

[14] A helpful summary and analysis of each of these sections can be found in Holowchak (2002) 25-37.

[15] Archer-Hind (1888, rev. 1973) 158.



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that oneiric images most often correspond closely to waking, visual phenomena."[16] Dreams represent, then, a personal manifestation of the extra-personal objects that are viewed and internalized by us every moment that we are awake.

Certain aspects of this explanation of dreaming persisted and influenced the writings of subsequent dream theorists. The notion that the images a dreamer sees just prior to falling asleep often reappear in his dreams is discussed in Cicero's criticism of oneiromancy in *De Divinatione*.[17] Elsewhere in this treatise Cicero discusses the concept of the *imago* in trying to debunk the idea that what a dreamer sees has an external source and to prove instead that the dreamer's own mind is responsible for conjuring the dream image (*De Div.* 2.137-38).[18] Virgil also uses the term *imago* to denote the visions of the monsters that Aeneas sees hovering before the entrance to the Underworld in book 6 of the *Aeneid (et ni docta comes tenuis sine corpore vitas / admoneat volitare cava sub imagine formae,* lines 292-93). While these are distinct from the dream images that cling to the leaves of the elm nearby, they are similar in their empty and illusory qualities.

In considering the representation of dreams in literary contexts, it is just as important to keep in mind the Roman conception of dreams as visual phenomena as it is to think of them as narrative passages that have a metonymic relationship to the surface

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[16] Holowchak (2002) 30.

[17] See Cicero, *De Divinatione,* 1.46, e.g., where Quintus tells the story of the mother of Phalaris, who falls asleep looking at the images of her domestic gods and dreams of the statue of Mercury.

[18] Cicero uses *imago* to connote the external phantoms that emanate from objects according to Epicurean theory, while *forma* describes the images conjured by the dreamer's mind.



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narrative of a text. The poetry of Propertius reflects a keen grasp of the importance of the visual aspect of dreaming, and his exploitation of this awareness is central to his representation of dreams. Furthermore, his sensitivity to visual experience and his ability to evoke scenes or dynamics from the visual arts complement his preoccupation with the power of sight in the relationship between the lovers in his poems. Thus forging a connection between the various types of visual experience in Propertius' poetry can be helpful for establishing other similarities between them, such as the potential of the image to deceive the viewer, or the shift in power between viewer and viewed image.

**The Visual Arts**

In trying to recuperate the experience of dreaming in textual terms, Propertius often evokes elements of the visual arts, while in artistic representation, the symbols and illusionistic imagery of dreams tend to be avoided. Why does the very mode in which dreams are expressed -- the visual -- show such great reluctance to represent the contents of a dream?[19] The search for a way to answer this question informs my decision to use material from the visual arts so prominently in this dissertation. My interests in literary accounts of dreaming and viewing works of art intersect in the representation of sleeping figures in Roman art, for these figures embody the outward manifestation of the interior experience of dreaming. Let us first consider the representation of Endymion, a sleeping

[19] The representation of symbolic dream images seems to be an innovation of the early Christian period that flourished in the medieval period and beyond. For more on this see Ringbom (1980) and Barasch (1997) 132-53.



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figure paradigmatic in Roman art.[20] In virtually all depictions of his story, we see the mortal Endymion asleep and being approached by the goddess Selene who keeps her nightly appointment with him. Depending on the context, there are sometimes other figures -- Cupids, torchbearers, and personifications of Somnus or Nox -- in the goddess' entourage. What does the external viewer of such a scene see? The viewer appears to see the scene objectively, as though his or her perspective is the same as that of a viewer internal to the scene. But it is also possible that the viewer sees the external manifestation of the dream of Endymion, the visual accompaniment to his eternal sleep, a state that the poet Theocritus called "shiftless sleep."[21] Since it is exclusively in sleep (or death) that he encounters Selene, one way to understand these depictions is to think of them as images of his dream as he is experiencing it. If the scenes indeed do depict the subjective perspective of the dreamer, then their artists have found a way to answer a question that the sleeper himself can never answer: "what are you dreaming?" In so doing, the artist anticipates the viewer's speculation about the sleeper's dream.

Aside from the possible representation of visitation dreams such as Endymion's, however, there is no evidence for the depiction of dream symbols or narratives beyond one frame. It is not as though artists lacked the sensibility that would allow them to

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[20] For representative examples of Selene and Endymion in Roman art, see Rizzo, G. E. (1929), *La pittura ellenistico-romana,* Milan: Fratelli Treves, fig. 125 (first century A.D. wall-painting from Herculaneum, now in Naples Museum); McCann, A. (1978), *Roman Sarcophagi in the Metropolitan Museum of Art,* New York: The Metropolitan Museum of Art, p. 39, fig. 35 (late second century A.D. marble sarcophagus from Ostia, now in the Metropolitan Museum of Art); Blanchard-Lemée, N. et al. (1995), *Sols de la Tunisie romaine,* Paris: Imprimiere nationale, p. 242, fig. 182 (early third century A.D. polychrome mosaic, from Oduna, House of the Laberii, now in Bardo Museum, Tunis). For a comprehensive discussion of the Endymion myth as it is represented on Roman sarcophagi, see Koortbojian (1995) 63-99.

[21] Theocritus *Idyll* 3.49-50: ζαλωτὸς μὲν ἐμὶν ὁ τὸν ἄτροπον ὕπνον ἰαύων / Ἐνδυμίων.



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represent things that were unreal or imaginary -- for example, depictions of fantastical creatures and those from the realm of myth abound in ancient art. It seems more likely the case that the cumbersome literal representation of dreams ceded to the incorporation of elements of the dream-like into other types of visual representation. As Plato tells us in his *Theaetetus,* a person spends an equal amount of time sleeping and waking, and is convinced that what he experiences during each of those times is real (καὶ δὴ ἴσου ὄντος τοῦ χρόνου ὃν καθεύδομεν ᾧ ἐγρηγόραμεν, ἐν ἑκατέρῳ διαμάχεται ἡμῶν ἡ ψυχὴ τὰ ἀεὶ παρόντα δόγματα παντὸς μᾶλλον εἶναι ἀληθῆ, 158d). I notice a connection between the perceptual illusionism which accounts for the seeming authenticity of the dream experience in Plato's account, for example, and the complex illusionism of Second Style wall-painting. Lucretius also refers to the dreamer's conviction of the reality of what he sees and experiences. In his discussion of the dreams of animals (*De Rerum Natura,* 4.984 ff.), Lucretius claims that while horses lie motionless, they appear to sweat and pant as though running a race; likewise, humans experience the same delusions in dreams (lines 1011 ff.). Kings, for example, imagine that they are in battle, performing acts that require great movement all without leaving the spot where they sleep (*reges expugnant, capituntur, proelia miscent, / tollunt clamorem, quasi si iugulentur ibidem,* lines 1013-14). We should consider that viewing in certain contexts might have been like the experience of dreaming, in that the realism of what the viewer saw enabled him in a sense to transcend the confines of the circumstances under which he experienced them. Lucretius' description of the dreamer believing that one is moving without stirring (*ibidem)* can be transferred productively to



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the idea that viewers of the vistas of the Second Style were encouraged to believe that they were looking beyond the very walls that confined the viewer himself to a restricted space.

**Internal and External: the origins of dreams, the personification of sleep**

The dream as internal vision or external creation

The tension between external and internal has early precedent in one of the paradigmatic examples of the dream experience in literature. Penelope's dream of the geese in book 19 of the *Odyssey,* is often cited for its introduction of the concept of the gates of sleep, which was popularized in the Roman world through Virgil's version of it in *Aeneid* 6.[22] But it should also be noted that this is the only symbolic dream (i.e. non-visitation dream) in all of Homer.[23] In lines 536-53, Penelope relates her dream of the slaughter of her pet geese by an eagle and her subsequent grief over their death. In the dream, the eagle returns to tell her that the dream has relevance, for the geese represent the suitors who have been taking advantage of her generosity, while the eagle himself is a symbol for Odysseus, who has come back to kill them. The personal relevance of the dream is obvious to the reader, but the dreamer's confession of belief in an external source for the dream reminds the reader of the ancient understanding of these features as not mutually exclusive. For in the dreamer's opinion, the external source of the dream and hence its potential for deliberate deception is more compelling than its obvious

[22] See, for example, the reference to the dream in Harris (2003) 21.

[23] Rutherford (1992) 194 ff. gives helpful commentary on this passage is helpful for history of scholarship on this scene.



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connections to the waking preoccupations of the dreamer. Penelope introduces her retelling of the dream with a statement about the nightly isolation she feels from other sleepers as she lies awake fraught with worry (αὐτὰρ ἐπεὶ νὺξ ἔλθῃ, ἔλῃσι τε κοῖτος ἅπαντας, / κεῖμαι ἐνὶ λέκτρῳι, πυκιναὶ δέ μοι ἀμφ' ἀδινὸν κῆρ / ὀξεῖαι μελεδῶναι ὀδυρομένην ἐρέθουσιν, lines 515-17). What follows her retelling and the interpretation of her disguised interlocutor is a warning about trusting in one decoding of a dream's symbols (ξεῖν', ἦ τοι μὲν ὄνειροι ἀμήχανοι ἀκριτόμυθοι / γίγνοντ', οὐδέ τι πάντα τελείεται ἀνθρώποισι. / δοιαὶ γάρ τε πύλαι ἀμενηνῶν εἰσὶν ὀνείρων, lines 560-62). Thus she reveals her belief that the dream would be sent in response to some waking concern, rather than occurring in reaction to it. This is perhaps the very paradox that Roman authors such as Cicero and Lucretius were reacting to among their peers as they argued against the external origins of dreams. Let us turn to their attempts to resolve the conflict.

An argument against the external, divine origin of dreams is the subject of book 2.119-148 of Cicero's *De Divinatione*. Without going into the Stoic argument for divination presented by Quintus in book 1 and Cicero's multi-faceted skeptical rebuttal in detail, it is sufficient to point out the crux of Cicero's argument, which is the absurdity of the belief in an external implantation of dreams (2.129). The lines follow:

> *venit enim iam in contentionem, utrum sit probabilius, deosne immortalis, rerum omnium praestantia excellentis, cursare omnium mortalium qui ubique sunt, non modo lectos, verum etiam grabatos et, cum stertentem aliquem viderint, obicere eis visa quaedam tortuosa et obscura, quae illi exterriti somno ad coniectorem mane deferant? an natura fieri ut mobiliter animus agitatus, quod vigilans viderit, dormiens videre videatur?*



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> The question now arises as to which is the more probable: do the immortal gods, who are of surpassing excellence in all things, constantly flit about, not only the beds, but even the lowly pallets of mortals, wherever they may be, and when they find someone snoring, throw at him dark and twisted visions, which scare him from his sleep and which he carries in the morning to a dream expert to unravel? Or does nature bring it to pass that the ever-active soul sees in sleep phantoms of what it saw when the body was awake?[24]

It is not the argument itself, however, but the way it is presented, which interests me here. The difference between the external implantation of dreams and their internal development is defined in terms of visual experience. In his explication of the passive receipt of a dream, Cicero imagines the sleeper as the object of the gods' vision *(viderint),* while the material that the gods send him are called *visa.* It is the sleeper's reaction to these things seen that sends him to consult the dream interpreters, about whom Cicero has few good words to say. By contrast, the natural explanation for dream images returns the responsibility for their creation to the sleeper's *animus.* Furthermore, his dreams reflect the very things he sees while he is awake; secondly, they are not arbitrarily hurled at him, but culled from the store room of his memory, thus making it more likely that what the sleeper seems to see while he is sleeping is, to him, as real as what he sees while awake. The distinction between actual sight (the active *viderit)* and vision in dreams (the passive *videre videatur)* will be explored further in chapter one.

Lucretius also observes that people dream of their daily preoccupations and interests. Lawyers, he claims, dream about arguing cases and sailors battle the winds

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[24] Translation by W. A. Falconer (1923, rep. 2001).



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(*De Rerum Natura,* 4.965-68); likewise he himself dreams of writing the nature of things in his own language (*nos agere hoc autem et naturam quaerere rerum / semper et inventam patriis exponere chartis,* lines 969-70). But rather than simply dismiss divine intervention in the lives of sleepers, as Cicero does, Lucretius tries to explain the physical origin of dreams. In fact, these statements come on the heels of a lengthy discussion of the formation of dream images from the films of external objects.[25] His theory of dreams is predicated upon the notion that dreams derive from images that originate outside of the dreamer and filter in through the eyes by day, lingering while the body goes to sleep (*mens animi vigilat, nisi quod simulacra lacessunt / haec eadem nostros animos quae cum vigilamus,* lines 758-59). Reconciling the personal and impersonal facets of the experience is difficult for Lucretius. In his view, the external becomes internalized and this accounts for the similarity between waking and sleeping vision. This argument points out the tension inherent in trying to account for the seemingly objective (or realistically impossible) images and the very familiar, subjective material of a person's dreams.[26]

The external personification of sleep

The personification of sleep as the deity Somnus is familiar from both artistic and textual contexts. In Hesiod's genealogy he is the son of Night and brother of Death (and

[25] See 4.722 ff., in particular 757 ff. for a discussion of the forceful impression of external films upon the mind of the sleeper.

[26] See Holowchak (2002) 58-61 for more discussion of this problem.



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Dreams).[27] The close relationship between sleep and death is corroborated by his depiction on Greek vase paintings as the nearly identical counterpart to his winged brother, charged with escorting the bodies of the dead to Hades, a role also associated with the god Hermes (or Mercury) in his role as psychopomp. On Roman sarcophagi, he is often shown pouring his sleepy liquid onto the head or the chest of a sleeping figure, who, we can imagine, represents the occupant of the sarcophagus. This personification of the god plays a vital role in embodying the agency of sleep and accounting for the mysterious process by which the sleeper seems overtaken by sleep's force. The presence of the personification in a funerary context also undoubtedly diminished to some degree the mystery of death by demonstrating for the living that the two states of consciousness were not dissimilar.

In the *Annales* Ennius refers to a sleeper as *somno leni placidoque revinctus* (1.5, Skutsch). This description highlights a contradiction in the experience of sleep from the perspective of the sleeper: he is physically bound by a sleep that is characterized as gentle and peaceful. The philosophical writers characterize sleep in a similar way, as they account for sleep as a physical process. Aristotle, for example, calls sleep a kind of 'fettering': ὁ γὰρ ὕπνος πάθος τι τοῦ αἰσθητικοῦ μορίου ἐστιν, οἷον δεσμός τις ἀκινησία (*De Somno* 454b9-11).[28] In his estimation the perceptual part of the body is bound in sleep, but this does not prohibit the images that come in

[27] *Theogony*, lines 211-12 and 756-67.

[28] As David Gallop (1990) 17 points out, "a certain tension may be observed between them [sleep and dreams]...If dreaming is taken to be a mode of perceptual awareness during sleep, yet sleep is defined as a state of perceptual incapacitation, the very notion of a dream seems threatened by self-contradiction."



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dreams; rather this binding is part of the process that enables dreaming. Likewise in Lucretius, the body's sensation is hindered in sleep: *sensus...quem sopor impedit esse / tum nobis animam perturbatam esse putandumst / eiectamque foras* (4.921-23). But his description of the physical process of sleep is followed (in lines 962 ff.) by his statement that men dream of performing their waking occupations. This juxtaposition casts the binding of sleep as an explicit prelude to the individual images and actions of dreams, thus creating a connection between sleep as something that binds physically and indiscriminately and the freeing experience of dreaming, whose subject matter is unique to the dreamer. The very nature of personification is paradoxical, for a personification embodies and externalizes something immaterial and internal.[29] Thus it is in keeping with his twofold nature that sleep, a process which is intimate for the sleeper and familiar to all living creatures, is consistently personified as an external force in ancient literature and art. Consideration of the personification of sleep adds another dimension to the distinction between internal and external, as the visions of dreams are contained within the mind of the dreamer, or seen exclusively by him, while sleep, the condition which allows for dreams to exist, acts upon him from the outside.

Genre: elegy and epic

I have chosen to focus upon the works of Propertius and Statius specifically, and the genres of elegy and epic more generally, because I think that a comparative approach to the representation of dreams and sleep in the contexts of different genres affords

[29] See Feeney (1991) 364 ff. for extensive discussion of the role of personification and allegory in epic with particular attention to Statius' *Thebaid.*



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greater scope for analysis. Furthermore, neither of these authors has been the subject of a study which focuses upon the connection between the author's poetic program and his representation of dreams and sleep.[30] Propertius and Statius may initially seem an unlikely match for a number of reasons -- they stand at a chronological distance from one another and they represent different literary genres. Furthermore, the formal and thematic differences in their poetry are numerous: elegy, told from a first-person perspective purports to give the reader a subjective view of the interior life of the narrator, while epic, told from the perspective of a third-person narrator transports the reader to a world of myth, which is seemingly detached from the world of the author and reader.[31] Rather than allow these divergences to thwart a productive combined study, I think that it is precisely an acknowledgement of the variety of evidence provided by these ostensibly different authors that frees us to look for points of comparison in their modes of representation that might not be immediately apparent. Thus by choosing

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[30] Among the Latin epic poets, Ennius, Virgil, and Ovid have already received attention in studies of dreams in Roman epic. This type of study has an early precedent in Stearns (1927). Two of the most recent treatments of dreams in epic, Berlin (1994) and Walde (2001), stop at Lucan. Bouquet (2001) treats the dreams in the *Thebaid* in a cursory fashion and makes little attempt at contextualization. He has no discussion of Somnus or insomnia. Walde is very thorough on Propertius' individual dream poems, but these form merely a small section of her much larger chronological treatment of dreams in ancient literature.

[31] This distinction is obvious even from comparison between the opening lines of the first book of Propertius' elegies and book one of Statius' *Thebaid.* Propertius 1.1.1-2 reads: *Cynthia prima suis miserum me cepit ocellis, / contactum nullis ante cupidinis.* The poetic conceit is apparent: the narrator will write about his personal experience. While Cynthia's name is placed significantly at the beginning of the line, the pronoun *me* is also given prominence as the object of the verb, thus establishing the dynamic of interaction between the lovers which will pervade the subsequent books. The first three lines of the *Thebaid* read *fraternas acies alternaque regna profanes / decertata odiis sontesque evolvere Thebas / Pierius menti calor incidit...* From this the reader learns that the subjects of the poem are unnamed enemy brothers and that the poet himself is merely a vessel of inspiration for telling their story. He is mentioned neither by name, nor by pronoun. The reader also learns that the setting for the tale will be Thebes, a land far from Rome and a site associated with criminal violence (*sontes)* and family strife.



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Propertius and Statius, I have selected exemplars from diverse genres to evaluate the intricacies of the Roman attitude towards the phenomena of dreams and sleep. The works of these two authors exemplify important characteristics of the split between internal and external aspects of these phenomena.

By the late first century B.C. the opposition between the poetic genres of elegy and epic had become commonplace, particularly in the statements that Latin love poets made concerning their own poetry.[32] In fact, the very topic of Statius' epic, the story of the Seven Against Thebes, is the particular focus of Propertius' antipathy in one instance where he defines the subject matter of his own poetry in direct contrast to that of the story of the sons of Oedipus. In poem 1.7, Propertius recuses himself from writing epic poetry by singling out Ponticus' epic poem on the theme of Thebes' fratricidal war as a foil for his own love poetry.[33] Poem 1.7 opens with a contrast between the endeavors of the two poets as follows (lines 1-8):

*Dum tibi Cadmeae dicuntur, Pontice, Thebae*
*armaque fraternae tristia militiae,*
*atque, ita sim felix, primo contendis Homero*
*(sint modo fata tuis mollia carminibus),*
*nos, ut consuemnus, nostros agitamus amores,* 5
*atque aliquid duram quaerimus in dominam;*
*nec tantum ingenio quantum servire dolori*
*cogor et aetatis tempora dura queri.*

While you are composing songs about Cadmean Thebes,
Ponticus, the mournful arms of fraternal strife,

[32] See the prologue to Callimachus' *Aitia* for his specific injunction against writing overblown verse, which for the Roman poets was equated with epic. For more on the relationship between Propertius and Callimachean aesthetics, see Hubbard (1974) 68-115 and DeBrohun (2003) 1-32, 201-209 et passim. In general, see Clausen (1964) and Cameron (1995) 454-83.

[33] Thebes is also mentioned antagonistically in this regard in poems 2.1 and 2.34.



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and, may I be so lucky, you vie with Homer, the very one
(may the fates only be kind to your poems),
we, as we are wont, keep busy with our love poems,
looking for something to use against our harsh
mistress; I'm not a slave so much to my talent as I am to
my pain and I'm compelled to lament the bleak times of my life.

Here we see some of the same distinctions that became apparent in the juxtaposition of the first lines of each author's work (see note 31 above). The opposition between Thebes as a remote realm is underscored by the use of the adjective *Cadmeae,* which evokes the distant mythological past by recalling the tale of Cadmus and the founding of Thebes. Line 2, with diction similar to that of Statius' own beginning to the *Thebaid,* refers to the arms of fraternal warfare, which will comprise the subject matter of Ponticus' epic. Again we see an emphasis upon the anonymity of the protagonists, as the brothers are referred to by the adjective *fraternae,* rather than by name.

The subject matter of Ponticus' epic is further distanced from that of the elegist through the narrator's reference to Ponticus' rivalry with Homer, the master of epic poetry, whose name alone is enough to conjure martial and heroic themes. In line 5 the objective *arma tristia* are contrasted with the narrator's own poetic material, *nostros amores.* The elegiac narrator refers to his activity with the verb *agito,* which mingles the notions of writing about his loves and actually carrying on his love affair.[34] This is significantly more ambiguous than the *dicuntur* of line 1. Thus Ponticus writes objectively about his traditional subject matter, while the narrator of Propertius' poetry is

[34] See *OLD* definition 6a for *agito,* "exercise (oneself or one's mind in a pursuit)". The *amores* of line 5 refer to his love poems (especially if we read *aliquid* in line 6 in apposition), but the word also reminds the reader of the narrator's love affair itself, the subject of the poetry.



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actively involved in what he writes about. This is, of course, one of the successful conceits of love elegy; the narrator claims to write from personal experience and to use his writing to influence his relationship with his mistress, the *domina* of line 6. Furthermore, the fact that the poem is crafted as an admonition to Ponticus about the hazards of denying the power of love poetry in favor of martial epic draws attention to its personal rather than universal dimension.[35] This example demonstrates again the difference between epic and elegy, conceived by the elegist not only as one between the subjects of war and love, but between distant, mythological conflict and personal experience.[36]

We can overlay the basic distinction between the professed interiority of elegiac poetry and the third-person, chronologically removed narration of epic onto a more

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[35] The distinction between the material of epic and elegy is reinforced later in the poem, when the narrator offers his warning to Ponticus that love will catch up with him and that he will be unprepared to write love elegy as he has devoted too much effort to epic subjects. In lines 17 and 18 the *castra* and *agmina septem* will be mourned, unresponsive to Ponticus and collecting dust as he struggles to write love poetry. The *aeterno situ* may also be a reference to the amount of time that these topics have existed as fodder for epic verse: just as the dead and wounded lie upon a battlefield collecting dust after a fight, as the Thebans and Argives have since their initial encounter in the deep past, so too do the stories about them, which epic poets are free to revive and use in their tales. Again the very subject matter of epic is treated as something with an existence prior to Ponticus' attempt to write about them. He is merely one among epicists who has chosen to take up these themes when it suits him. His abandonment of them may last, but they will endure and be available as subjects for future epic poets to take up.

[36] Of course further analysis of the works of Propertius and Statius shows that the distinction along strict genre lines breaks down, as each author's work exhibits some characteristics traditionally associated with the other. The poems of Propertius' fourth book deal with historical and mythological themes that are traditionally associated with epic, while in the *Thebaid* there are passages that express a subjectivity and psychological depth (the dreams of Ismene or Atalanta, for example) that is reminiscent of what we find in elegy. Thus insisting upon a strict division between elegy and epic points out that the boundaries are more fluid than initially assumed. Furthermore, Propertius and Statius are actually aligned by their shared allusion to and influence by the Hellenistic poet Callimachus. The Callimachean aesthetics of Statius are the subject of recent studies by Carole Newlands (2002), where she focuses on the Callimachean elements of the *Silvae*, and Charles McNelis (2000), who makes specific reference to the implications of this for the narrative structure of his epic.



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general division between personal and impersonal experience. I am interested in where this overlaps with the internal and external elements of the sleep experience. Looking beyond the dream episodes for articulations of the obvious dichotomy between elegy and epic -- that of subjective narration versus objective narration -- we find that the representations of sleep and sleeping figures in these contexts are equally rich sources for information about the division between external and internal phenomena in the Roman conception of sleep and dreams.

Authors: Propertius and Statius

Propertius and Statius provide some of the most interesting material on sleep, dreams, and insomnia in all of Latin literature. Of the Latin elegists, Propertius displays the greatest variety in his representations of dreams; among epic poets, Statius creates for sleep, sometimes personified as the deity Somnus, the most intricate narrative role.[37]

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[37] See Bouquet (1996) for a comparative study of night and dreams in the Latin love poets. There are dreams in the poetry of Tibullus and Ovid, but neither of these authors presents a range of experience as diverse as what we see in Propertius. For an interesting treatment of the contradictory themes of Tibullus' poems as dreamlike, see Miller (1999). One could say that Tibullus 1.5, for example, contains a dream, but here the "dream" is simply a metaphor for a wish (*vota*), which reflects the narrator's fantasy of a happier situation (*haec mihi fingebam*, line 35). On the other hand, *Amores* 3.5, whether or not it was actually written by Ovid (for this debate see McKeown (2002)), is an overly-literal, one-dimensional account of a symbolic dream followed by a blunt interpretation. The poem is almost a parody of the role of the interpreter and his facile interpretation of a dream's allegory, and thus lacks the subtlety of any of Propertius' dream accounts. *Amores* 1.5, the account of a midday tryst between lovers, is more in line with the Propertian sensibility because of its dreamlike qualities and its setting in the bedroom as the narrator is falling asleep (see Nicoll (1977) 45 n. 13 for mention of similarity between vision and dream in this poem). Of the Latin epic poets, the dreams of Virgil's *Aeneid* and Ovid's *Metamorphoses* have already been the subjects of various studies (see Berlin (1994) and Walde (2001) for recent treatments and assessments of earlier work). The personified Somnus appears in both the *Aeneid* and the *Metamorphoses*; Statius' depiction of Somnus in the *Thebaid* responds to and develops elements from both of these accounts (see Delarue (1988) and Tissol (1997) 72 ff. for studies of the house of Somnus in Ovid and Statius). Despite the fact that Lucan's *Pharsalia* has wonderfully vivid dream episodes, Somnus plays a very small role in the epic; in the *Punica* of Silius Italicus, Somnus is summoned by Juno to put Hannibal to sleep in book 10 in a manner reminiscent of Iris' entreaty to Somnus in Ovid's *Metamorphoses* 11 (see



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Indeed the best known poems of each author, Propertius 1.3 and Statius *Silvae* 5.4, although very different, center on the theme of sleep. While the former is a meditation inspired by the narrator's observation of his sleeping mistress, and the latter is an appeal for the attention of Somnus himself told from the point of view of one who is unable to sleep, both poems use sleep as a mode for exploring ideas about desirability and frustration. This observation alone presents an interesting point of intersection between the two authors, but Propertius 1.3 and *Silvae* 5.4 need renewed attention for additional reasons. While scholars have tried to show how each poem fits in with its respective corpus as a whole, the particular connection between these poems and other references to sleep and dreaming within the works of each author has been neglected. By pointing out similarities between the dream of 2.26a and the voyeurism of 1.3, for example, I am able to extrapolate from this comparison some important features of the dynamics of viewership in Propertius' poetry. This approach also allows me to point out different ways that Propertius evokes imagery from artistic representation to create the visually intense environments of his poems. Furthermore, no attempt has been made to link the depiction of Somnus in *Silvae* 5.4 with his depiction in the *Thebaid;* this is an exercise that I have found valuable for the discussion of negative sleep experiences in both contexts, as well as for thinking more broadly about the characteristics of Statius' style.

Propertius and Statius also complement one another in that they both display a prominent visual style in their poetry. Jean-Paul Boucher referred to Propertius'

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Wilson (2004) for an analysis of Silius' use of Ovidian precedent). Aside from these examples, the role of Somnus (and of disturbed sleep in general) in earlier Latin epic is less developed than in Statius.



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"imagination visuelle,"[38] a phrase which Margaret Hubbard echoed in claiming that "the imagination of Propertius...was more liberally nourished by acquaintance with, and indeed knowledge of, painting and sculpture than that of any other Augustan poet..."[39] These sentiments, in turn, have been reaffirmed in much of the recent scholarship on elegy 1.3.[40] The recent work of Bettina Bergmann and Carole Newlands has likewise demonstrated the importance of the visual in Statius *Silvae,* in particular with regard to his extensive use of ekphrasis.[41] The detailed and powerful ekphrases of the *Silvae* undoubtedly betray Statius' familiarity with and sensitivity to works of visual art and architecture, while they also reveal his awareness of the powerful impact of visually evocative description.

A lot of attention has been paid to Propertius' use of the visual arts in his poetic descriptions, but criticism has generally been limited to a certain kind of identification of parallels between his imagery and parallel imagery in extant works of art. My work seeks to understand the implications of Propertius' visual sensibility for other aspects of his poems. By moving away from the literal parallels between the subjects in Propertius' mythological analogies and the mythological scenes popular in artistic representation, I

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[38] Boucher (1965) 63.

[39] Hubbard (1974) 164.

[40] See in particular Breed (2003) and Valladares (2004) for the most recent treatments of the visual in this poem.

[41] See Bergmann (1991) 51, where she claims that Statius "expresses a primarily visual aesthetic, stressing transitory, illusionistic effects and enlivening his narrative with images of mythological figures and distant places." Bodel (1997) 16 also writes that for Statius "ecphrases were a specialty." Newlands (2002) is largely a study of the complex function of ecphrasis in the *Silvae.* Newlands cites Szelest (1966) 186-88, on Statius' innovative use of ekphrasis. See also Duncan (1914) and Taisne (1994).



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open up ways for discussing the visual quality of Propertius' poetry, which is under-represented in scholarship on his dream poems. Likewise I hope to expand discussion of the visual in Statius' poetry beyond ekphrasis to include consideration of other particularly visual qualities in his work. By including an analysis of the iconography of Somnus in Roman art, for example, I show visual parallels for Statius' characterization of Somnus in the *Thebaid.* These broaden our understanding of this figure's complex representation in the epic.

**Internal and external dynamics in the poetry of Propertius and Statius**

Propertius makes productive use of both the internal and external types of dreams in his elegies. I begin my study of Propertius (section I) with his three dream poems, 2.26a, 3.3, and 4.7, considering each dream narrative separately and noting the points at which the internal (psychological) dream and the external (visitation) dream diverge and overlap. I focus upon the narrator's use of the internal/external dichotomy in his subjective and objective perspectives on the content of his dreams. In presenting his dreams thus, he deliberately calls attention to the challenges of presenting the dream as internal experience and external phenomenon by emphasizing the perspective of the dreamer as a viewer, who both participates in the dream and then assesses his experience after he wakes up.

One feature that unites the three dream poems is their shared emphasis on visual experience. The similarity between dreaming and looking, which Propertius articulates in poem 3.8, is borne out by his consistent emphasis upon the power of sight in his relationship with Cynthia, and by his ability to evoke the visual arts in his dream poems



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in a way that mirrors their function in other contexts. These facets of Propertius' interest in the visual lead the way to a discussion of two other types of visual experience, which are not actually dreams, but are dreamlike. The first is the viewership of Second Style wall-painting, whose illusionism is analogous to that which we see at work in the representation of dreams in Propertius' poetry. The other involves a close study of the externalization of the sleeper and the relationship between sleeper and viewer in both poetic and artistic contexts.

The degree to which the characters in Propertius' dream poems speak directly helps to define whether the dream is external or internal in origin. The dream that seems the most internal, that of 2.26a, blurs the lines between internal and external by shifting from the participant's perspective to that of the commentator in the narrator's retelling. Elegy 4.7, which has the structure of a visitation dream, is intensely personal in its detail of the speech of the dream figure. While it reveals for the reader new information about the lovers' relationship, it also captures some part of the dynamic between the lovers that has been so familiar. 4.7 is reminiscent of the epic dream-vision exemplified by Aeneas' dream of Hector in *Aeneid* 2.270 ff. or his vision of Creusa's ghost in 2.771 ff., although it lacks the spur to action or message about the future that the episodes in Virgil contain. In this sense it is a "subjective" dream, for it has no explicit narrative function and seems to reflect the narrator's own preoccupations. In fact, as if to flout the seriousness of the visitation dream as anything other than a poetic mode of expression, Cynthia reappears alive in the very next elegy.



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The dream visit by Apollo in 3.3 falls somewhere between the two. Apollo visits the dreamer in his dream and conveys important information about his poetry, but the dreamer himself is a character in the dream. Furthermore, the dream has a narrative and is set in a remote locale, distinct from the physical surroundings of the narrator's bedroom. In fact, description of the dream's location and material details are given as much attention as the speeches of Apollo and Calliope. The illusionism of this poem in terms of its setting and authenticity for the dreamer belie its somewhat formulaic content.

Propertius' elegy 1.3 offers a counterpoint to the dream poems discussed above precisely because it is not really a dream per se, but it incorporates some of the elements familiar from the dream poems. In this poem the narrator describes a visual experience which he makes more vivid for the reader by recourse to mythological analogy (as in 2.26a); he is a participant in the scenario, and his reaction to what he sees is recounted as an important part of the narrative (as in 3.3); finally, Cynthia speaks angrily to the narrator (as in 4.7). The poem is also connected to the dream poems because Cynthia herself is asleep while the narrator describes her from his external vantage point. The intimate but ultimately limited experience of the external viewer is underscored by the very interior experience of the dream, which the viewer imagines his lover to be experiencing. This detachment reminds us of the privileged perspective of the dreamer from the earlier dream narratives. It is the observation of the sleeper, as we see in poem 1.3, that actually defines the sleeper, for sleep is a state of being of which only those who are awake can be aware.



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Examination of the viewer's observation of the inanimate, sleeping figure in poem 1.3 paves the way for a discussion of the similarities between a dreamer's viewing of a dream image, and a viewer's experience looking at a work of art. Keeping in mind the division between external and internal perspective, I show that the viewer's curiosity about his sleeping girlfriend in poem 1.3 plays upon a dynamic familiar from the interaction between viewer and sleeping figure in various artistic exempla, the waking viewer's curiosity about the sleeper's dream. My analysis moves from the relationship of interrogation between the external viewer and the solitary sleeping figure, epitomized by the sculpted figure of the hermaphrodite, to that between sleeper and internal viewer depicted together. This type of composition is at its most intricate in depictions of Mars approaching the sleeping Rhea Silvia at the moment just before the rape, the prelude to the conception of the twins Romulus and Remus. For a viewer who was familiar with this story from literary and other artistic contexts, the excitement of viewing these depictions would have been heightened by his knowledge of the narrative hinted at by the imminent union of the couple shown. Furthermore, if the viewer was familiar with the story of Rhea Silvia as recounted by Ennius or Ovid, in which Rhea Silvia wakes up after her rape remembering only a symbolic dream, he might have in mind the very images and significance implied by the dream. As the viewer watched the scene, he might bring Rhea Silvia's dream to the foreground by imagining it himself. This confluence of expectation, viewership, and extrapolation sheds new light on the dichotomy between internal and external in representations of dreams and sleep. Although, in general, the disparity between the external perspective of the viewer and



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the internal experience of the sleeper in artistic representation is so pronounced, in representations of Rhea Silvia, it is to some degree diminished.

Moving on from the sleeping figure, my interest in externalization shifts to the personification of sleep itself. In the second half of the dissertation, I am particularly interested in how the personal anxieties of the characters in Statius' *Thebaid* are deflected onto the sinister character of sleep. This anxiety is also manifested by their inability to sleep well. My inquiry into the nature of sleep in the *Thebaid* concentrates mostly upon the intervention of Somnus himself in the war between the Thebans and Argives, but it also touches upon passages in the narrative that are sleep-like, and bouts with nightmare and insomnia. Just as a binding sleep is somewhat paradoxical, so too is a deep sleep that bestows or facilitates destruction. Statius' *Thebaid* is a tale whose very existence is rooted in the perversion of normal, acceptable behavior, as the sons of Oedipus, born from incest, are doomed from their own father's curse to engage in a war that is fated to end in double fratricide. The sinister aspect of Somnus in the *Thebaid* reflects the general inversion of norms that permeates the narrative.

In the first book of the *Thebaid,* as he arrays the circumstances for his epic's horrific plot, Statius establishes inversion as integral to the narrative. Three examples that exhibit abnormal features of the night or distortions of the sleep experience follow. The entire narrative of the *Thebaid* is introduced as though it were the gloomy nightmare of the blind Oedipus. In line 46 Oedipus' blindness, itself the result of self-inflicted violence, is described as an *aeterna nox,* permeated only by light of the *saeva dies animi* (line 52), his violent imagination. Thus the unnatural circumstances of his blindness



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lead to the state of nightmarish semi-consciousness in which he lives. Because he exists in a liminal state -- he is blind, but yet has the "vision" to predict the outcome of his curse, he is not dead, but is isolated from the rest of humanity -- Oedipus mediates between the Underworld and the world of the living. It is this ability to navigate between worlds that exemplifies the perversions of normal behavior that permeate this grim tale. Oedipus' withdrawal from the world and his inability to see are, somewhat paradoxically, the preconditions for his power to initiate the war between brothers. From the abyss into which he has retreated, he calls on the aid of the fury Tisiphone to enact his curse upon his despised sons, Eteocles and Polynices.

When Tisiphone heeds Oedipus' call, she is sitting beside the river Cocytus in the Underworld. Thus the first divine figure evoked in the narrative to intervene in the lives of its mortal characters resides in the world of the dead and is called upwards from below, an obvious inversion of the normal flow of traffic between the two realms. Furthermore, when Tisiphone leaves behind Taenarus' Gate, she imposes night's pitch blackness upon the gleaming white of day, thus impeding the regular progress of the sun across the sky: *sensit adesse Dies, piceo Nox obvia nimbo / lucentes turbavit equos...* (lines 97-98). The immediate presence of night actually blocks (*obvia)* the path of the day's course. This usurpation is indicative of the disruption of norms that will characterize the story of an unnatural war between brothers.

Later in book 1 Jupiter sends Mercury to the Underworld with a special mission, to raise the shade of Laius, Oedipus' murdered father, and accompany him from the Underworld up to the world of mortals (lines 292-302). As we see in book 2, Laius will



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appear in Eteocles' dream as a goad to action against his exiled brother. As we saw with Tisiphone's ascent, Mercury's action of retrieving a shade from the Underworld is also an inversion of the normal flow between the realms. The greater majority of shades, we must imagine, once they are conducted to the Underworld by Mercury, are never summoned to visit the realm of the living.[42] But just a few lines later, the power of Mercury's wand (*virga)* is described by Statius as follows, *tum dextrae virgam inseruit, qua pellere dulces / aut suadere iterum somnos, qua nigra subire / Tartara et exanguis animare adsueverat umbras* (lines 306-08). We learn from this characterization, however, that Mercury is accustomed to penetrating the realms of the Underworld in order to reanimate the dead, rather than simply to deliver them there. Furthermore, he has the ability to bring or withhold sleep, just as Somnus himself does. Indeed Statius' description of Mercury's powers conflates his ability to put to sleep or keep awake with his capacity for destroying or preserving life. This combination is significant as a precedent for Statius' characterization of Somnus.

These scenes of distortion serve as previews of the abnormalities that occur throughout the epic's narrative. The example of Mercury is relevant for examining the aberrant connection between sleep and death in the epic, particularly in book 10. Chapter 3 presents a study of the role of sleep in the *Thebaid,* which is often disrupted or plagued with nightmares -- quite the opposite of the *dulcis somnus* alluded to above. I have found it helpful to turn to the visual record for representing the personification of

[42] See Plutarch *Moralia* 758B for a description of Hermes as ψυχοπομπὸς εἰς Πλούτωνος, where the implication is that he cares for the dead by escorting them to the Underworld rather than abandon them in the world of the living.



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Somnus in order to see which aspects of his physical characterization have been exploited by Statius and given a narrative function. Because the figure of sleep has a rich and well-documented history of representation from Greek vase-painting of the sixth century B.C. (where he is sometimes paired with his brother, death) to Roman sarcophagi of the third century A.D. (where his presence has obvious funereal connections), it is possible to make productive comparisons between the representations of sleep and death in both visual and textual contexts.

The final chapter of the dissertation elaborates upon the theme of externalized sleep by looking at the absence of sleep in three types of reference to insomnia in Statius' writing. The insomnia experienced by the characters in the *Thebaid* is connected to the abnormally sinister quality of sleep in the epic and is indicative of the tension that runs through the epic. This is an insomnia inflicted upon the epic's characters and particularly noticeable among kings, for example, the Argive king Adrastus, and Thoas, the Lemnian ruler, whose kingdoms are normally peaceful and whose sleep is usually undisturbed. Their inability to sleep during outbreaks of violence is indicative of the toll of the war upon the familiar stability of their realms.

In *Silvae* 3.5 and in his epilogue to the *Thebaid,* Statius speaks about writing his epic as a difficult labor, whose accomplishment required periods of sleepless attention. Here we see a different type of insomnia, one that is productive if not entirely voluntary, which has its roots in the tradition of Hellenistic epigram and Latin love poetry. In a third and certainly more enigmatic instance, there is Statius' ode to Somnus in *Silvae* 5.4, a lament told from the perspective of an unhappy insomniac. This poem dwells



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upon the feeling of isolation caused by insomnia, and the insomniac's acute awareness of Somnus' interaction with others. The insomniac's imagination of the rest of the world indulged by Somnus' attention underscores his own bereft state, as he envisions a pair of lovers squandering Somnus' gift. It is possible that by singling them out, Statius calls attention to the themes of love poetry and the role of insomnia therein as a way to contrast his own plight in composing a long, violent epic.

While it is productive to think of the dream as an analogue for literary or artistic creation, it is equally worth inquiring into poetic claims of insomnia as a condition for creativity. And what of the sleeping figure, who is a physical embodiment of the mystery of the dream, the process that occurs behind the sleeper's closed eyes? In some cases the sleeper's opacity inspires a viewer to imagine his own fantasy about the sleeper's dreams; this itself is a process akin to creating literary narrative. Finally, there is sleep, the state of being that causes the passivity of the sleeping figure and thus enables the dream. I unite the discussions of dreams, sleep, and insomnia in the four chapters of this dissertation by keeping in mind the role of visual experience and the interplay between internal and external perspectives as modes for poetic expression in the work of Propertius and Statius.



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# Part I: Propertius

## Chapter 1: Dreams

ἑκάστη γὰρ τῶν ἡμετέρων ἡμερῶν,
ὡσαύτως δὲ νυκτῶν, ἔχει συγγραφὴν
-Aelius Aristides, *Sacred Tales*, 1.3

The mind has so many pictures;
why can't I sleep with my eyes open?
-Rufus Wainwright, "The One You Love" (2004)

### Introduction: A Study of Dreams in Propertius

For the elegiac lover, night is an active time. While the rest of society lies asleep, night provides the context for the amorous encounters that will become the subject of the lover's poetry.[43] The character of night is defined in the first poem of the first book of Propertius' corpus, where the narrator reveals that Venus is responsible for his nightly torture: *in me nostra Venus noctes exercet amaras, / et nullo vacuus tempore defit Amor* (1.1.33-34). This line undoubtedly includes in its meaning the notion that the lover is kept awake by bouts with his mistress and by spells without her, both subjects that will recur in Propertius' elegies.[44] Both ideas are linked by the lover's nighttime vigil; the

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[43] Poem 3.20 provides a succinct example of the division between night and day for the elegiac lover. In anticipation of the first night with a new mistress, the narrator calls out to the sun and the moon as follows,

*tu quoque, qui aestivos spatiosius exigis ignis,*
*Phoebe, moraturae contrahe lucis iter.*
*Nox mihi prima venit! primae data tempora noctis!*
*Longius in primo, Luna, morare toro.* (lines 11-14)

In this example, the contrast between night and day implies that lovers take advantage of night because of its dark cover (as opposed to the brightness of the day time, note the emphasis upon light in *ignis* and *lucis).* There may also be an implicit contrast between night and day in terms of societal expectation: the activities of the forum and the battle field take place during the day, while lovers conduct the business of love in contrast to the workings of their peers. For a discussion of the interconnection between night, sleep, dream, and subjectivity ("l'intuition du nocturne") in the Latin elegists, see Bouquet (1996).

[44] The phrase *noctes amaras* reappears in poem 4.3, where Arethusa uses it to refer to nights spent alone and awake without her lover Lycotas: *at mihi cum noctes induxit vesper amaras, / si qua relicta iacent,*



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lover does not sleep because either longing for an absent lover or his lover's irresistible presence causes him to stay awake.

Towards the end of the corpus, in poem 4.7, which will be discussed in detail later in this chapter, the ghost of Cynthia makes an explicit contrast between sleep and the activities of lovers that used to occupy the sleeper's nights: *Perfide.../in te iam vires somnus habere potest?/ iamne tibi exciderant vigilacis furta Suburae / et mea nocturnis trita fenestra dolis* (lines 13-16). Propertius' sleep is placed in direct opposition to the erotic escapades which used to occupy his nights and keep him awake. Furthermore, the contrast between the living Cynthia and the dead Cynthia is mapped onto the division between the love-making of sleepless nights and dream-filled sleep. Perhaps the passivity of sleep and the vital occupation of love-making are anathema, but where does dreaming, which is at once active and passive for the dreamer, fit in to the elegiac discourse of night and sleep? It is this facet of the elegiac narrator's experience, the dream-filled sleep, rather than the lover's passionate or anguished vigil that I will examine in the chapter which follows. In looking at the dream poems of Propertius, 2.26a, 3.3, and 4.7, I will show how they bring to the fore certain themes and modes of representation which are crucial to understanding Propertian poetics.

Sleep's detachment provides an analogue for the liminal state of the elegiac poet, as the sleeper is inherently marginal and withdrawn from interaction with others. But the dreamscape is also a fitting metaphor for the subjectivity of the elegiac first-person

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*osculor arma tua* (lines 29-30). In this case, the pangs of longing are felt most acutely at night when the lover is unable to sleep.



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narrator. While he dreams, the dreamer sees a manifestation of himself, who shares the characteristics, personal connections, and concerns of the person dreaming, yet this person lies asleep motionless, while the persona of the dream performs actions that have varying degrees of correlation to his waking activities. In some sense, this resembles the process of writing elegy.[45] The intersection between a sleeper's detachment, the erotic encounter of two lovers, and the "activity" of dreaming is encapsulated by the figure of Endymion, whose nighttime encounters with his lover Selene (the moon) make him an apt counterpart for the elegiac lover. Endymion's encounter with Selene brings together the paradox of the dream as both active and passive, for Endymion lies passively waiting for the arrival of his lover, but, when she arrives, he is physically engaged with her, rather than simply watching himself interact in a dream.

Propertius makes reference to the plight of Endymion in poem 2.15, where he uses the story of the sleeping lover to convey the effects of Cynthia's power over him.[46] The reference comes in a passage that describes the power of desire spurred by vision. *Oculi sunt in amore duces,* declares the narrator in line 12, before presenting two exempla from mythology to support this statement. In lines 15 and 16 he offers the

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[45] Lev Kenaan (2004) 267 has made this argument for reading the character of Lucius in Apuleius' *Metamorphoses*. She observes that "by equating the actor with the author he [Apuleius] establishes a dreamlike basis for his autobiographical fiction."

[46] 2.15, which begins *O me felicem! nox o mihi candida!*, contains four uses of the noun *nox*, more than in any other individual poem. The poem calls attention to the importance of night for lovers and also connects night time to death, a theme which is recovered by the popular use of Endymion in sarcophagus reliefs from later periods. One couplet in particular blurs the lines between night, erotic love, and immortality: *quod mihi si <in>te<r>dum talis concedere noctes / illa velit, vitae longus et annus erit. / si dabit et multas, fiam immortalis in illis* (lines 37-39). For more on the overtones of mortality in the poem see Stahl (1985) chapter 9.



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following interpretation of the story of Enydmion: *nudus et Endymion Phoebi cepisse sororem / dicitur et nudus concubuisse deae.* Aside from the fact that this line inverts the power dynamic between Selene and Endymion, as it casts him in the role of captor, and thus assigns the mistress a male analogue and the narrator a female one, this statement links the emphasis upon visual experience and mythological analogy -- both hallmarks of Propertius' poetic style. Furthermore, the delineation between sleep and erotic play is blurred if we imagine Endymion's dream-like state of perpetual sleep as the precondition for Selene's lust. Thus in Propertius' hands, visual experience, sleep, and the interaction of lovers all converge in the mythological tale of Endymion's nightly dream. Just as Endymion dreams himself awake at the arrival of his lover, we might say that the elegiac narrator encounters in his dreams the material inspiration for his work.[47]

**Propertian poetics: Visuality in the elegies**

The importance of the visual in the elegies is well-established in Propertian scholarship. The study of Jean-Paul Boucher, for example, concentrates upon the link between the subjects of artistic representation and the mythological imagery of Propertius' poems,[48] while Thomas K. Hubbard looks at the dynamics of vision in Propertius' poetry by aligning the function of artistic representation with the effects of

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[47] In fact, 2.15 could be read as the narration of a dream, for the narrator admits that, prior to his mistress' arrival, he has fallen asleep (*illa meos somno lapsos patefecit ocellos,* line 7), only to be awoken by her chiding, *sicine, lente, iaces?* (line 8). A very similar interaction occurs in poem 4.7, where the ghost of Cynthia appears to the narrator, accusing him of succumbing to sleep and forgetfulness (lines 13-14).

[48] Boucher (1965) is particularly interested in illustrating Propertius' knowledge of Roman painting, which he sees as a strong influence upon his inclusion of mythological references in his works which, in his view, have analogues in actual paintings that he might have seen.



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other types of visual experience, such as looking at Cynthia.[49] D. Thomas Benediktson, in his discussion of Propertius' "imagism", argues for the influence of Lucretius' Epicurean ideas upon Propertius. He connects the acts of reading and writing poetry, looking at art, and dreaming in Propertius' poetry.[50] It is this concatenation of ideas that will be paramount in the body of this chapter.

Propertius establishes the importance of the visual moment, that is, one in which sight plays a crucial role in an elegy's narrative, in the first poem of his corpus, where the narrator laments, *Cynthia prima suis miserum me cepit ocellis* (1.1.1), and thus introduces the reader to the imbalance of power between the lovers, a theme which will reappear in many of the later elegies.[51] This line constructs a visual relationship between the poem's narrator and Cynthia in two ways. First, the eyes become the weapon with which Cynthia ensnares her lover, whether this is by means of an intense stare, or because of the sheer beauty of her eyes,[52] and second, because it implies that the narrator

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[49] Hubbard (1984) presents this approach in his argument for the unity of poem 2.31/32. In fact, it is the connection between "vision, love, and art," 281, that establishes, in his analysis, the poem's coherence as a single poem. Hubbard's discussion of the role of vision in 2.31/32 is generally helpful for thinking about "the ambiguous notion of vision," 286, in Propertius as both subjective/ active/ empowering, and objective/ disarming. His scheme for the alternating perception of the narrator within the poem is also useful for understanding the shifts between the narration of experience and commentary upon it in other poems.

[50] In his discussion of Lucretius' explanation of the movement of *imagines* and its connection to dream visions, Benediktson (1989) 105 writes, "Lucretius does not explain what happens when one reads or writes poetry or even what happens when one sees a painting or statue. But I suspect that he would view all three activities as essentially similar processes and perhaps would compare them to the imaginative free play of dreams. Certainly Propertius would have done so."

[51] See, for example, 1.5, 1.12, 2.3, 2.4, where the elegiac narrator laments his subservience to his lover, Cynthia.

[52] See Richardson (1977) 146 and Stahl (1985) 26 ff., e.g., for different interpretations of this line.



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of the poem was engaged in looking at Cynthia, perhaps from a detached perspective, when he was, in turn, caught by her, thus shifting the balance of power in her favor.[53] But this is not to be the permanent state of affairs, for in poem 1.3, as he looks upon the sleeping Cynthia, the narrator reclaims visual authority with his own eyes, thus repositioning the power dynamic: *sed sic intentis haerebam fixus ocellis, / Argus ut ignotis cornibus Inachidos* (lines 19-20).[54] But in neither case is it explicit who really has the power, for the narrator is immobilized either way, arrested by the visual encounter with his mistress (note *cepit* in 1.1.1 and *fixus* in 1.3.19).[55] Consideration of the visual is an integral part of understanding Propertius' dream poems, since the dream is experienced by the dreamer visually -- a feature partially obscured by its communication in textual or verbal form. Furthermore, the power dynamic of a dream -- in which the viewer/dreamer is subject to his vision while he is dreaming, but capable of exerting control over this in his retelling and commentary on it -- is similar to that foregrounded in poems 1.1 and 1.3. In this case, while Cynthia controls the narrator either with her vision or as a vision, within the scope of poetic description, as the subject of a poem, she is subject to the poet's creativity.

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[53] In fact, in lines 3 and 4, the narrator claims that Amor forced his eyes downward (*deiecit lumina*), the literal manifestation of his gaze's inferiority. Stahl (1985) 29 reminds us that "it does not simply mean that , being captive, he is no longer his own master; he is humiliated as well." Cf. 1.19.5-6: *non adeo leviter nostris puer haesit ocellis, / ut meus oblito pulvis amore vacet.*

[54] This poem will be discussed in detail in chapter 2.

[55] Of course, Propertius chooses a dubious exemplum in Argus, for Argus will eventually lose his visual superiority when he is put to sleep and slain by Mercury (see Ovid's account in *Metamorphoses* 1). Perhaps by choosing this story Propertius encourages the reader to ponder the instability of visual supremacy.



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Does the visual quality of Propertius' poems, most obvious in his references to the eyes and the power of visual experience, have any real connection to the actual experience of viewership? Perhaps we can look for an answer to this question by turning briefly to a poem which links Cynthia, the visual arts, and vision itself. In poem 3.21, the narrator is preparing for a trip to Greece, where he will have a respite from love's torment: *magnum iter ad doctas proficisci cogor Athenas / ut me longa gravi solvat amore via. / crescit enim assidue spectando cura puellae* (lines 1-3). He draws a specific link between his intense love, his growing anxiety about his mistress, and his looking upon her (*assidue spectando).* In Greece, however, Cynthia will be as far from his eyes as love is from his mind (*unum erit auxilium: mutatis Cynthia terris / quantum oculis, animo tam procul ibit amor,* lines 9-10), a notion that provides him a sense of relief. Later in the poem, however, the narrator admits that Cynthia's control of his eyes will only be replaced by the power of works of art: *aut certe tabulae capient mea lumina pictae, / sive ebore exactae, seu magis aere, manus* (lines 29-30). This poem's commentary on viewership provides a template for understanding the power of the visual experience more generally in Propertius' poetry.

The dream poems, with their emphasis upon sight, provide analogues to the experience described here. Another way in which Propertius also alludes to visual experience, particularly that of looking at art, is with his combination of mythological analogies and vivid descriptions -- techniques which evoke artistic representation. Many have argued that mythological examples could evoke for the Roman reader of an elegy much more than is accessible for the modern reader because the Roman reader would



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have had at his disposal paintings from both public and private contexts, whose larger significance would be called forth by the mere mention of their subjects' names.[56] I would also add that mythological references, when used in connection with descriptions of images seen in dreams, as in 2.26a, help the dreamer to describe and define the elusive experience of dreaming. This will be another focus of the following chapter.

**Dreamscape as Tableau: representing visual experience in the dream poems**

Writing about the disguised ardor of a lover in elegy 3.8, Propertius cites various behaviors which reveal a girl's attempt to disguise her passion, and claims he has the power to interpret these (lines 11-20):

*quae mulier rabida iactat convicia lingua,*
*haec Veneris magnae volvitur ante pedes.*
*custodum gregibus circa se stipat euntem,*
*seu sequitur medias, Maenas ut icta vias,*
***seu timidam crebro dementia somnia terrent,***
***seu miseram in tabula picta puella movet,***
*his ego tormentis animi sum verus haruspex,*
*has didici certo saepe in amore notas.*
*non est certa fides, quam non in iurgia vertas:*
*hostibus eveniat lenta puella meis!*

the same woman who hurls insults with a vicious tongue
abases herself at the feet of powerful Venus.
She may surround herself with an entourage when she goes out
or rave in the middle of the street like a frenzied maenad,
**whether disturbing dreams frequently frighten her,**
**or the painted image of another girl makes her miserable,**
I am the qualified interpreter of this kind of mental anguish,
I've learned that these are the signs of true love.
Her devotion is insincere, if you don't get into fights:
May all my enemies have easy-going mistresses!

[56] See, for example, Boucher (1965) 41 et passim.



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In lines 15 and 16 of this passage Propertius establishes the connection between the visual experiences of dreaming and looking at art by emphasizing the similar potency of both types of experience for the girl involved, whether she is a dreamer or a viewer.[57] The fact that the dreams are described with the adjective *dementia* (the phrase is translated by G. P. Goold (1990) with the term "nightmares") is itself significant, because it underscores the dream's ability to torment the dreamer with images that lack the coherence familiar from the dreamer's waking life. The similarity between the visual experiences of dreaming and looking at art is developed by its counterpart in the next line, where the adjective *picta* describes the agent (*puella)* of a pitiful girl's sorrow.

The adjectives *dementia* and *picta,* whose parallel placement and function[58] in their respective lines emphasize their connection, mark their referents as removed from reality. The former implies a vision which distorts the dreaming girl's familiar waking reality, while the latter refers to the artistic depiction of the familiar, which is necessarily removed from reality through its imitation of it. Each line describes a phenomenon which is abstracted from reality through representation. The deranged dreams of the first girl terrify her with their distortion of reality-- perhaps in her dreams she succumbs to her lover's demands, while in her waking life she tries to maintain indifference towards or disdain for him. The representation of a human female figure is enough to distress the forlorn girl, who, we imagine, feels taunted by the predicament of a painted

[57] Cf. Virgil *Eclogue* 8.108: *an, qui amant, ipsi sibi somnis fingunt?* Here the connection is made between the intensity of love and the dreams a lover experiences.

[58] Each line begins with the correlative *seu* followed by an adverbial phrase, an adjective, a noun, and a verb. Furthermore, each adjective appears directly after the metrical caesura of its line. The parallel between these lines is made stronger by their contrast with the *seu* clause in line 14.



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mythological heroine.[59] But Propertius offers no information about the content of either the dream or the painting, for mention of specifics would only serve to diminish the universality which the poet claims for this type of behavior. Rather he forges a connection between the responses he describes, because it is the comparable effect of these visual experiences which is relevant for his poem.

In its context, this couplet constitutes the third pair of opposites in a group of six lines. In the preceding sets (lines 11-14), the contrast is more obvious: the girl who shouts insults most vehemently is also the one who abases herself at the feet of Venus. Her verbal assault belies her servitude to the goddess of love, but her active *iactat* reverts to a passive *volvitur* as the cause for her behavior is acknowledged. The second couplet reveals that a girl whose behavior shifts from one extreme to its opposite is similarly afflicted by love. Whether she desires to be disguised by an entourage or runs freely down the street in a frenzied state, this girl's curious behavior is motivated by the same factor. The contrast in the third couplet, which highlights the inherent similarity between the acts of dreaming and looking at a painting, is more subtle.

Although lines 15 and 16 are structurally nearly identical, the first example reflects an internal experience--terror from a series of images which occur for the viewership of the dreamer alone--while the latter describes an experience in which the girl is subject to the influence of an external source, a painting which exerts its power

[59] This is partially suggested by Richardson (1977) 347; he writes in his commentary that "the picture might have been in a shop or gallery whither the poet had pursued her and her tears be tears of rage and frustration as much as anything. The Roman fondness for pictures of tragic heroines was extraordinary; it led Rostovtzeff once to observe: 'there is no house in Pompeii without an Ariadne.'" See Fedeli (1985) 289 for criticism of the assumption that the "girl" is Cynthia and the poet is referring to his own experience here.



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from the outside. In both instances the girl is subject to the effects of a visual experience, and her reaction to each is marked by undesirable behavior. In the case of the dream, the girl's internal vision is affected by her affliction, while the work of art from line 16 remains unchanged, it is merely the girl's reaction to it that is influenced by her altered state. This distinction becomes an important aspect of Propertius' dream poems, where the shift between interior and exterior viewing is integral to poetic structure.

The narrator's role as an interpreter (*haruspex,* line 17) resonates on different levels within the poem.[60] The narrator's ability to decipher the behavior of his lover is analogous to that of an interpreter of visual signs and this in turn echoes the role of the dream interpreter and even the reader of a poem: things are often not as they seem, and the potential for deception is prevalent. These lines make it clear that Propertius considered the dream a type of representation, in this case a context for the poet's attempt to render with words his visual experience. In my discussion of two of Propertius' dream poems (2.26a[61] and 3.3), which, although they contain dreams

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[60] *Haruspex* is not the usual term for an interpreter of dreams; in this instance Propertius expands the definition of the word to include interpretation of the outward behavior of this girl's temporary madness. By contrast, the author of *Amores* 3.5 (possibly Ovid) uses *imaginis augur* (line 31) and *interpres* (line 45) to refer to the interpreter summoned by the narrator after his dream of the heifer and the bull. Propertius uses the word *haruspex* figuratively in poem 3.13.59 (the only other example of the word in his elegies), so its non-literal usage is not unusual for him. In 3.8, however, its adapted usage has particular relevance, as it reminds us specifically of the role of the *haruspex* as a reader of external *visual* signs, such as the marks on entrails. This feature is, of course, implied by the meaning of the suffix *-spex* (from the verb *specio,* to see). Dream interpretation is not so different from the *ars haruspicina* if one imagines that the interpreter of dreams also relied heavily upon visual symbols from dreams in order to uncover their meaning.

[61] I will treat only the first 20 lines of poem 2.26 (henceforth 2.26a) in my analysis, for the 58 lines as we have received them offer minimal coherence as one poem. The poem appears as a single elegy in all



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generated by different poetic impulses, display a prominent visual quality, I attempt to answer the following questions: What accounts for the visual nature of Propertius' dream poems? Was there a common concern among artists and poets in the Augustan age about the nature of viewership and readership which Propertius exploited when creating poetic dream texts? Why are dreams in particular conducive to conveying visual experience? What does the role of the viewer of a work of art share with the role of the dreamer "watching" his dream unfold?

Poem 3.8 is a meditation upon the nature of deception: an investigation into the easily misread *veri...signa caloris* (line 9) reveals that outward behavior frequently manifests itself in a manner that seems to oppose its impulse; a girl in love, for example, will try to injure her lover in a fight.[62] The greater her passion, the more violent her behavior. This contradiction is echoed by the abnormal behavior exhibited by a girl when she is apart from her lover. Even her private dreams are invaded by the torment of desire, and familiar works of art have the power to reduce her to tears. How do these

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manuscripts but one. Although there is some degree of thematic unity throughout the poem's 58 lines, I believe that lines 1-20, which are contained by the beginning and end of the narrator's dream stand sensibly as an individual poem. For discussions in favor of the unity of the poem see Richardson (1977) 286, Wiggers (1980), and Rambaux (2001) 152. Fedeli's Teubner edition, which I have used principally in this section of the dissertation, prints 2.26 as one poem of 58 lines, while Goold's (1990) Loeb edition divides the poem into three sections, 2.26A, B, and C. Others (Butler and Barber (1933), e.g.) have argued that the poem should be divided in two after line 21. For sensible and brief accounts of the poem's thematic unity and structural disharmony, see Papanghelis (1987) 80ff. and Newman (1997) 165.

[62] Later in the poem the narrator refers to the unspoken code between lovers in lines 25-26: *tecta superciliis si quando verba remittis,/ aut tua cum digitis scripta silenda notas.* One lover's secretive behavior is in need of constant interpretation by the other. Just before the tone of the poem shifts to the realm of mythological analogy and a final taunt at his rival, the narrator comments that he prefers disturbed sleep to peaceful rest, presumably because this is an indication of the strength of his ardor (*odi ego quos numquam pungunt suspiria somnos,* line 27). This line reinforces the notion that sleep interrupted, whether by dreams or "sighs," is unexceptional as part of the lover's regimen of discomfort and deviance from an untroubled life.



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incidents in particular exert their influence over a susceptible lover? Both dreams and works of art represent a familiar reality, but deviate from this necessarily by their very attempt to represent it; this accounts for their shared impact upon the person experiencing them. In the case of the dream this manifests itself as a disturbing incoherence.

Visual Incoherence: Dream and Commentary in Propertius 2.26a

Poem 2.26a has been the subject of two predominant critical approaches. Scholars such as Kenneth Quinn have seen in it a departure from "poetry built around incidents in the poet's affair with his mistress according to the recipe given in the opening poem of Book II".[63] His commentary groups the poem with two others in book II as examples of "the 'poetry of the intellect'",[64] a term which separates them as anomalous for Propertius' poetry. No dreams are so "persuasively inconsequential as those of 3.3 and 2.26," writes Margaret Hubbard, questioning the resonance of these poems within the entire corpus.[65] Alternatively, commentary has focused upon the features this poem shares with works of art, particularly painting, which, for some, offers an explanation for its disjointedness and its brevity. As Hubbard asserts, "the elements of this picture *derive* from representations of the drowning of Helle."[66] Jean-Paul

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[63] Quinn (1963) 167.

[64] Ibid., 168.

[65] Hubbard (1974) 166. Newman (1997) 145 goes so far as to call the poem "quite inexplicable unless we fit it into the whole network of sea imagery in the poetry."

[66] Hubbard (1974) 167.



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Boucher speculates that Propertius had a painting in mind as a model for his poetic dream-descriptions,[67] attributing this to the proliferation of painted and sculpted images in the public and private spaces of Rome during the early Augustan period. In a recent treatment of this poem, Christine Walde claims that the poem's sea-myth imagery shares qualities with Roman wall-painting, although she concedes a difference between the wall-painting and the dream-image.[68]

In the 20 lines of poem 2.26a, Propertius both describes a dream and offers commentary upon his memory of the dream. The narrator lurches between description of a nightmare and commentary upon it, as though the images he reports are too disturbing to recount uninterrupted. Propertius begins his poem with the word *vidi* (line 1). This declaration provides the reader with vital information, but is at the same time potentially misleading. This is one of a very select group of poems which begins with an active, finite verb in the first person.[69] In this case, the specific meaning of the verb is unclear until it is qualified by the phrase *in somnis* which follows. Precise understanding is postponed further, as the verb is followed immediately by the pronoun *te,* which the reader is tempted to take as the simple object of the verb. It is only upon reaching line 2 that the reader recognizes the pronoun as the accusative subject of the infinitive *ducere.*

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[67] Boucher (1965) 62: "On a l'impression que le poète suit un modèle pictural, le tableau d'un Mouséion."

[68] Walde (2001) 241: "Sie haben durch das Aufrufen von Motiven römischer Wandmalerei eine eigene Bildnatur..."

[69] In book 2, for example, there are only 4 poems that begin with active verbs; in each of these (2.1, 2.22a, 2.31, 2.33b), the verb is second person. There are no other poems in book 2 that begin with a verb in the first person; in the rest of the corpus, only 3 poems begin with first person verbs (1.9, 3.3, 3.10). The prominent position of *vidi* in 2.26a emphasizes the subjectivity of the dream experience.



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After reading the first distich the reader realizes this is the narration of a dream's action, and not merely a glimpse at a static Cynthia. This is the initial indication of the disjunction between fixed image and narration of events which characterizes this poem.

Lines 3 and 4 follow with two infinitives describing Cynthia's actions. In these four lines Cynthia's condition worsens; in line 2 she was at least able to move her arms although exhausted, but by line 3 she resorts to confessing her lies, perhaps in anticipation of forgiveness. In line 4 the narrator claims she is unable even to lift her hair because of the water's weight. Thus far, Propertius has confronted the reader with a series of frightening looks at what could be Cynthia's hopeless last moments. What saves Cynthia from death by drowning in this dream? We never actually read that she is saved; rather we are given the hope that she will be rescued in line 17. But what saves the reader from horror at her misfortune is the poet's creation of an alternate realm consisting of mythological analogies for aspects of Cynthia's predicament, in the form of a vivid, visually evocative commentary on the images from his dream.

These interruptions in the sequential narrative create a disjointed reading experience which not only produces a feeling familiar from the experience of dreaming,[70] but also confuses the reader's navigation of the narrator's primary and secondary observations. The poet's simile sections (lines 5-8 and 13-16) are interspersed among the events of the poem at intervals of four lines, providing a measure of predictability with their detachment from the diachronic narration of Cynthia's

[70] In their commentary Butler and Barber (1933) 234 [note p. 40 Lefèvre] write, "those who object to the sequence or non-sequence of thought might do well to remember that P. is describing a dream!"



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drowning. In the poem's penultimate couplet Propertius fuses the poem's parallel realms and leaves the reader to wake up abruptly with the narrator.

The first of two striking departures from the narration of his dream occurs in lines 5 and 6, where the narrator compares Cynthia to Helle. He proceeds in the next couplet to imagine the consequences of her transformation into Helle--the renaming of the sea after her and the mourning of the sailors who journey through her waters (lines 7 and 8), a euphemism for death at sea. Propertius chooses an obscure mythological reference to illustrate his point that, while Cynthia is in life-threatening danger, there is some notoriety to be gained from her predicament. This has significant implications for a reading of the poem as a metaphor for Propertius' poetic program. If, as critics such as Maria Wyke have argued,[71] Cynthia represents the personification of Propertius' poetic material, regardless of her status as an acquaintance of the poet himself, then her name is her enduring legacy in the corpus of poems. Just as Helle imbues the Ionian sea with her own name, Cynthia's name swims through four books of Propertius' poetry as a reminder of his source of poetic anguish and fame. But the poet's choice of Helle has additional implications for his fixation on the visual.

Propertius' depiction of Helle has frequently been noted for its similarity to an artistic representation of the same subject. Commentators whose central interests in poem 2.26a are as diverse as those of Boucher (1965, visuality), Hubbard (1974, Propertius' style) and Walde (2001, dreams in literature) all mention this feature of the

[71] See, for example, Wyke (1987).



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poem in their analyses. Of these, however, only Hubbard admits after surveying the extant examples of Roman art depicting Helle that there is but one--a mosaic in Naples -- which features all of the elements of the story present in Propertius' telling.[72] I will discuss this mosaic in more detail below. It is not possible to determine how many depictions of this composition existed while Propertius was writing, but the majority of surviving pieces, which should serve as an indication of the most popular artistic types, boast a simpler composition. In all of the depictions cited in the *Lexicon Iconographicum Mythologiae Classicae*, Helle appears with her brother, Phrixus (in fact, there is no separate entry in the *LIMC* for 'Helle'; to find depictions of Helle, one must search under the heading 'Phrixos et Helle'). In these representations, Helle either rides beside her brother on the back of the ram, or has already slipped off the animal's back and into the sea. It is not surprising that Phrixus is the focal point of these depictions; Apollonius of Rhodes, for example, in his tale of Jason's quest for the golden fleece mentions the history of the fleece in passing, alluding only to Phrixus' journey to Colchis on the back of the ram (1.251-59, 2.1140-1156). Helle's plight is mentioned only briefly, because it is incidental to the arrival of Phrixus and the fleece in Colchis.

If, therefore, Propertius is alluding to or even modeling his account of Helle's tale upon a wall-painting or a mosaic, he is deliberately shifting its emphasis from the journey of Phrixus and the golden ram to the sacrifice of Helle.[73] By referring to a

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[72] Hubbard (1974) 167. For an image of the mosaic, see Bruneau, *LIMC*, vol. VII.2 (1994) 337, no. 38.

[73] Keyssner (1938) 281 also noted the absence of Phrixus, familiar from artistic representation, positing an "emotional connection" between Phrixus and the poet in the poem.



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familiar painting type through the elimination of its central character, Propertius is able both to evoke a recognizable setting and to refocus the sympathy of his readers. The purpose of this, I believe, is to draw attention to the depth of Cynthia's misfortune and its similarity to the tragic but fame-enhancing death of Helle. So to claim that Propertius "models" his poem on a work of art is not only to over-simplify his poetic approach, but to miss the point of the explicit evocation of a work of art by a poem. Mythological subjects in both painting and poetry play similar roles: both the artist and the poet use the image from one moment in a story to recall the longer, linear narrative. This phenomenon is further enhanced by its presence in the dreamscape of poem 2.26a, because the dream is also a realm in which the visual moment dominates, and linear narrative can be disrupted or appear fragmentary.

Propertius inserts his second detour from the account of Cynthia's shipwreck in lines 13-16. Here the narrator imagines that if Glaucus--a character not usually associated with the story of Helle and Phrixus--were to witness Cynthia during her metamorphosis into a sea creature, his desire would ensure that she complete the transformation by making her a *Ionii...puella maris* (line 14). In an addition which Christine Walde brands "comic relief",[74] the narrator imagines that this will provoke the jealousy of the Nereids, who appear in the next couplet boasting the variegated colors of a work of art (*candida* and *caerula,* line 16). But Glaucus' lust is described in terms which have specific relevance for the poem's visual penchant. Propertius writes that

[74] Walde (2001) 240-41 writes "Dieses Bild der zänkischen Nereiden hat in seiner nicht abzuleugnenden Komik, die auf dem Kontrast von erhabener Heroine und scheltendem Hausweib basiert, wiederum entlastende Funktion."



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Glaucus would have wanted to possess Cynthia if he had seen her eyes (*quod si forte tuos vidisset Glaucus ocellos*, line 13). This image not only reminds the reader of the poem's preoccupation with sight, but also alludes to the first line of poem 1.1, in which the narrator claims that Cynthia first captured him with these very eyes (*Cynthia prima suis miserum me cepit ocellis).* We imagine that Cynthia has sunk so far below the water that her eyes are no longer visible; if she had stayed afloat, she would have maintained visual authority and made Glaucus suffer in love as the narrator of Propertius' poems had. Glaucus, through his brief appearance in the poem, becomes a foil for the narrator himself, whose distance from the drowning woman inhibits his ability to see. In his desire for Cynthia, Glaucus echoes the narrator's familiar loss of control and subservience to his lover.

One need only to compare 2.26a briefly with another poem to observe its terse disjointedness. Poem 1.17 contains the narrative of a shipwreck whose victim is the narrator himself. Both poems contain imagined situations, and, although it is not stated explicitly, 1.17 could be convincingly interpreted as Propertius' nightmare-like vision of his own desperation.[75] The narrative structures of the poems, however, are strikingly different. In poem 1.17, rather than shifting between vision and interpretation, the narrator's contemplation reaches a logical climax: he envisions his death, and then surges forward with a final plea for salvation. Whereas poem 2.26a offers an episodic view of Cynthia's demise and her viewer's hypothetical assessment of her predicament,

[75] In his commentary, Richardson (1977) 194 hints at this by calling the poem "delicate, a dreamy, insubstantial tissue."



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the movement of 1.17 is diachronic. The latter is strikingly devoid of comparisons to mythological subjects, and is explicitly focused upon the relationship between the narrator and Cynthia through its frequent alternating use of the personal pronouns *me* and *te,* and possessive adjectives *meus* and *tuus.*[76] The repetition of these words defines the central concern of the poem: the tension between the narrator and Cynthia which manifests itself in his insecurity about her response to his death. In 2.26a Propertius hints at the relationship between the lovers through Cynthia's words, which are implied by the verbs *fateri* (line 3) and *vocas* (line 12), but her male counterpart remains absent until the poem's end.

In poem 1.17 the narrator lets the reader know in the first line the reason for his misfortune at sea: he has left Cynthia, and shipwrecked solitude is the punishment for his departure (*et merito, quoniam potui fugisse puellam,* line 1). Although both poems contain vividly imagined scenarios in which Cynthia demonstrates the remorse and respect desired by the narrator, and each poem is addressed to Cynthia, 1.17 progresses through its narrative without recourse to the mythological exempla which feature in 2.26a. Within the poem, as the narrator describes his misfortune, questions his fate, and imagines an alternative death in Rome and a funeral at which Cynthia displays the appropriate grief, the reader is never encouraged to doubt the underlying conceit that Cynthia is responsible from afar for his punishment. The poem contains discrete sections: the first depicts the narrator adrift, the second questions his fate and the third

[76] For example see lines 8-11, where the personal referents appear in chiastic order: *haecine parva* ***meum*** *funus harena teget?/* ***Tu*** *tamen in melius saevas converte querelas:/ sat* ***tibi*** *sit poenae nox et iniqua vada./ An poteris siccis* ***mea*** *fata reponere ocellis.*



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envisions his funeral in Rome. In the final four lines of the poem, the narrator returns to his desperation with renewed determination to escape. There is no evidence here of the dreamy distraction that both narrator and reader experience in 2.26a; the poem follows a logic that does not permit mythological commentary.

Perhaps the differences between the poems are best exemplified through a comparison of features they share. In each poem the narrator mentions the Nereids (*aequoreae Formosa Doride natae,* 1.17.25 and *Nereides,* 2.26a.15); whereas in the earlier poem, he appeals to them directly to help him at sea, in 2.26a he includes speculation about their envy of Cynthia. This difference illustrates the deliberate rupture in the diachronic progress of 2.26a. The later vision of the Nereids, to which Quinn attributes a "realistic, everyday note,"[77] falls in the middle of one of the narrator's remarks upon what he sees in his dream. Their role is further detached from the action of the dream, because it is stylized in a manner reminiscent of a painting. As the narrator presents a contrast between the colors *candida* and *caerula* (line 16), he is, as Margaret Hubbard observes, "underlining its [the poem's] pictorial quality."[78] The word *candida* also appears at the same position in the line following his mention of the Nereids in 1.17; in this instance, however, applied to the sails and lacking the color contrast, its descriptive quality is diminished. This difference emphasizes the double effect of the mythological asides in 2.26a: they at once create a visual image and draw an analogy with their referent.

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[77] Quinn (1963) 194.

[78] Hubbard (1974) 167.



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The reader realizes the physical marginality of the narrator in the final four lines of poem 2.26a when the narrator appears *summo saxo* (line 19), perched at a lofty distance from his suffering mistress. His position in the context of the dream is not unlike that of a dreamer in his sleep: he is at once present at and detached from the dream's events, while he is entirely isolated from the waking world around him. It is from this vantage point that he sees a dolphin swimming to Cynthia's rescue (*sed tibi subsidio delphinum currere vidi,* line 17). In the following line he surmises that this is the same creature who bore Arion, associated with the evolution of lyric poetry according to tradition. The narrator's assumption is indicated by the parenthetical '*puto*' (line 18). This diction is unusual for Propertius: it provides the sole example of his use of this verb in a parenthetical statement, and is one of only two examples of the use of this verb in the first person singular in the entire corpus.[79] Here the narrator underscores the subjective nature of his commentary on what he sees.

As I have discussed above, analysis of this poem often centers around its derivation from or ability to evoke a wall-painting, but comparison to an artistic representation with like content, such as Hubbard's mosaic depiction of Helle, Phrixus, and the ram, has limited application. The mosaic in Naples, likely the very piece to which Hubbard alludes, shows that Phrixus and the ram dominate the center of the image, while Helle with her arm outstretched is seen disappearing into the sea at the mosaic's lower border (see note 72). Although the poem and the mosaic share a number of features, including the rocky crags and the dolphin, Helle becomes the central

[79] The other example is in poem 2.24c.40.



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character in the poetic account. As I have pointed out, it is equally compelling to demonstrate where poetic description deviates from the precedent of an artistic counterpart.

This divergence has further applications in poem 2.26a, for Propertius takes advantage of his readers' familiarity with artistic representation by evoking depictions which boast compositional similarities, but differ in subject matter. Propertius deliberately reinterprets the scene familiar from numerous painted depictions of Ariadne in which she lies on the shore asleep or having just woken up as Theseus' ship departs in order to underscore his dreaming narrator's marginality.[80] Propertius highlights his narrator's predicament as outsider in his own dream as he calls to mind the familiar image of Ariadne abandoned. Ariadne is the focal point of such representations, caught in a moment between desertion by Theseus and rescue by Dionysus. Often Theseus' ship can be seen in the distance slipping off to sea. In poem 2.26a, the focus has shifted from the shore to the open sea, and Propertius casts the narrator and Cynthia in inverse roles. I propose that this deliberate relegation of the sleeping figure to the side lines of both the poem and the landscape emphasizes the narrator's liminal position as a spectator. Furthermore, the male narrator occupies the role of Ariadne, lying passively on the shore, while his (female) lover is at sea. This gender reversal also contributes to the narrator's subsidiary status as an actor in the poem. His powerlessness in the face of

[80] See, for example, a painting of Ariadne abandoned by Theseus from the House of Meleager in Pompeii now in the Naples Archaeological Museum in Bernhard, *LIMC*, vol. III.2 (1986) 731, no. 80. For detailed discussions of the sleeping Ariadne in Roman wall-painting, see McNally (1985) and Fredrick (1995). For an interesting discussion of the "metaphoric frame" of the dream in French literature as a device for "invoking liminality", see Porter in Conner (1995) 107 ff.



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Cynthia's imminent death is subtly conveyed through his turn in a traditionally female role.[81]

The narrator of 2.26a characterizes his awakening from the dream with the following words: *cum mihi discussit talia* ***visa*** *metus* (line 20). The use of the substantive *visum* here accounts for one of three uses of this word in Propertius' entire corpus. In an early instance the word is used to refer to the dream which the narrator of poem 1.3 imagines Cynthia is experiencing while he gazes upon her asleep: *ne qua tibi insolitos portarent* ***visa*** *timores,* (line 29). In this example, however, the dream's images are the *cause* of fear rather than that which fear forces from the sleeper's eyes. The word appears a third time in poem 2.6, Propertius' lament about the lewdness of painting and its potentially harmful effects. Here he rails against *quae manus obscenas depinxit prima tabellas et posuit casta turpia* ***visa*** *domo* (lines 27-28). That Propertius uses

[81] The narrator's marginal status is further emphasized by the different roles played by mention of Cynthia's name and his own in the context of the poem. The fact that Cynthia calls out her lover's name in a moment of great desperation (*saepe meum nomen iam peritura vocas,* line 12) serves two possible functions--perhaps it simply emphasizes that thoughts of him occupy her final moments, and that her confessions and apologies are merely punctuated by guilty shouts of his name. This reading reflects the analysis of Goold (1990) 179, for example, who writes in his note on this line that Cynthia calls his name "not for succour, but in remorse (cf. Virgil, *Aen.* 4.382ff)." Once we account for the end of the poem and our realization that the narrator himself is present in his own dream, as Dido would not be in the scenario cited by Goold above, this invocation of the narrator by name acquires new significance. Perhaps he does imagine that Cynthia spies him on land and calls to him directly for aid. If we follow this interpretation, line 12 would then provide the reader's first indication that the narrator of the poem is at the scene, while foreshadowing his inability to act. Whereas Cynthia's name promises to endure in his poetry as long as it would were she to drown and give her name to the sea in line 6 (*quam timui, ne forte tuum mare nomen haberet*), the narrator's name reverberates off of the cliffs from the mouth of a dying woman. Fear motivates both references to the noun *nomen.* In the first instance, it results from the narrator's fear that his mistress will drown, an event to which he alludes through reference to Helle's fate; in the second, it reflects her own terror at drowning and an attempt to save herself. If we interpret Cynthia as a metaphor for Propertius' poetry (cf. Holleman (1970) 179-80), then this scene could represent both the threat of Cynthia's death and the demise of Propertius' poetic reputation, that is, his 'name.' But I suggest that the invocation of both Cynthia's and the narrator's names is also reflective of the narrator's anxiety about exclusion.



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*visum* exclusively of dreams and paintings reinforces the importance of visuality in his dream images.

2.26a in context: reading back to 2.25

It is useful to end the discussion of 2.26a with a look back at the end of poem 2.25, a poem which Margaret Hubbard calls "one of the most perfect in book II."[82] This poem contains themes common in Propertius' poetry: the tortures of his love for Cynthia, the determination to love her and exalt her in his poetry despite this pain, and advice to a friend recently smitten to learn from his experience.[83] Although the poems may appear unrelated at first glance, I have identified elements of this poem that provide thematic and structural segues into the next, a stylistic feature which has hitherto been ignored. I am convinced that Propertius cleverly alludes to themes from 2.25 in the subsequent poem, and that, like a dreamer, he mingles the narrator's daily concerns with the visions of his dream. I propose that if the reader encountered these poems in order, his impressions from 2.25 could help him negotiate the incoherence of 2.26a.

One example of the connection between the two poems can be seen in poem 2.25, lines 23-24, in which the narrator questions whether the person shipwrecked is

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[82] Hubbard (1974) 63-64. She makes this claim on the grounds of the poem's "strongly articulated architecture." This contrasts with 2.26a, whose unity is a source of controversy, as I have shown above.

[83] In their attempt to impose strophic order upon the sprawling patchwork of book 2, Damon and Helmbold (1952) 234 ask with regard to 2.25, "what, for example, have 39-48 to do with the rest of the poem?" By contrast, Richardson (1977) 286 writes in his note on line 48, "note how this verse echoes the first line of the poem." I have no difficulty believing that these lines serve as a coda to the poem. This poem is analogous to 1.9 (to Ponticus) or 1.10 (to Gallus), for example, in which the narrator begins the poem with a lament for his own situation and finishes by addressing another in a similar situation. But what is of greater interest, I believe, and is missing from the conservative, quatrain-driven analysis of critics like Damon and Helmbold, is the attempt to justify the inclusion or exclusion of certain lines based upon their allusive connection to *other* poems in the corpus. The case is more compelling for 2.25 and 2.26 because of their close proximity.



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likely to fulfill the vows he makes to save himself from destruction (*an quisquam in mediis persolvit vota procellis, / cum saepe in portu fracta carina natet?*). He uses this as evidence that people in dire circumstances and driven by self-preservation will resort to false oaths. This advice is to be applied to the addressee's situation with his mistress, in which, because of his new-found love, he is supposed to suspect her vows of devotion because, like the sailor, she is driven by desperation to swear them. What implications does this have, then, for poem 2.26a in which the poet conflates the image of the shipwreck in line 1 (*fracta carina* again, here in the ablative) with that of the near-drowning mistress who acknowledges her lies to her lover in the moments before rescue? Even J. K. Newman in his thorough analysis of references to sea-faring in Propertius' elegies, although he claims he will "fit it [2.26a] into the whole network of sea imagery in the poetry,"[84] in his discussion of 2.25, comments only on the use of the word *natet* ("float") in the poem, rather than picking up on the repetition of *fracta carina*.[85] In his recent commentary on the elegies, Claude Rambaux disregards the connection between the poems by stating briefly that, the poet is more "appealing" in 2.26 than in 2.25, where he is submissive and ready to endure Cynthia's mistreatment.[86]

It is of equal importance that lines 39-48 of 2.25 offer insight into the poet's interest in visual representation, as discussed above. The quadruple anaphora of *vidistis*

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[84] Newman (1997) 145.

[85] Ibid., 167, "clearly here the allusion is to the unstable movement of some storm-struck hulk."

[86] Rambaux (2001) 154-55, "le poète...se montre ici beaucoup plus séduisant que dans l'élégie précédente où il apparaissait seulement comme un homme prêt à supporter les mauvais traitements que sa belle pourrait lui infliger."



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in lines 41-44 insists that the reader become a viewer upon encountering his catalogue of types of alluring women.[87] The fact that this portion of the poem continues with the vocative address, but switches to the plural strengthens the universal appeal of these women. Like works of art, they can be viewed by many viewers (readers) and their charms are not exclusive. The contrast between the pairs of women also contributes to the visual quality of the poem. This is most evident in lines 41-42, *vidistis pleno teneram candore puellam, / vidistis fusca<m>: ducit uterque color,* in which the stark opposition between dark and light looks forward to 2.26a where the Nereid sisters are depicted with similar hues. This visual vividness is reemphasized with the use of the adjective *sandycis* in line 45.

Finally, the last two lines of 2.25, if kept in mind as one reads the opening of 2.26a, enhance the reader's understanding of the latter. The couplet in lines 47-48, *cum satis una tuis insomnia portet ocellis, / una sat e<s>t cuivis femina multa mala,* has direct relevance for the experience of the poem which follows it. This is the sole example in the elegies of Propertius of the noun *insomnium*, which can mean "dream" or "inability to sleep."[88] In their translations, both A. E. Watts (1961) and G. P. Goold (1990) choose the latter meaning. In this case, the reader understands that a man's

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[87] Fedeli (1984; 1994) preserves *vidistis*, the reading of the manuscript tradition, while Camps (1967) emends to *vidisti.* Camps prefers the singular because it makes better sense with *tuis* of line 47. He claims that *vidisti* "has the value of our impersonal 'one'," 175; thus in his reading its meaning is closer to that of the plural of *vidistis*. Goold (1990) follows Camps.

[88] The *OLD* provides two definitions for the noun *insomnium.* Each depends on the different connotations of the prefix *in-*. Definition 1a is "wakefulness, sleeplessness". Line 47 from 2.25 is cited in this context. Definition 2a, on analogy with the Greek ἐνύπνιον, is "an apparition seen in a trance or dream, a vision, dream." In this sense, the word often has negative associations, as in the following citations: *insomnia falsa, insomnia terrent,* or *insomnia turbulenta.*



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preoccupation with his lover deprives him of sleep because he can think of nothing else; the result of his insomnia is nothing but bad news for the man thus afflicted. I think that we should understand both of the noun's nuances when reading this line, particularly in light of what follows in 2.26a.[89] If the reader understands that one woman has enough power to bring disturbing *dreams* to a man's eyes, then this might explain the terror and fear expressed by the narrator of 2.26a. Thus the reader learns that Cynthia's dominance does not force the narrator to go without sleep, but rather to be tormented by dreams, perhaps those in which she is in danger and in view of him, while he is unable to offer help, as described in the poem which follows.

Kenneth Quinn was baffled by the role of fear in 2.26a asking, "Was it fear for his mistress in peril? Or was he afraid because plunging from the rock looked like tricky business?"[90] These questions underscore the fundamental dichotomy in the narrator's stance in the poem. Is he reacting to what he sees of Cynthia, or what he feels about himself as a viewer and a helpless non-participant in the action? I believe that the end of

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[89] M. Hubbard (1974) also translates *insomnia* in a way that connotes sleeplessness. By contrast, Vincent Katz (2004) 183 renders lines 46-47 as follows: "Since one woman brings dreams enough to your eyes, one woman is enough for endless pain." His translation implies that the dreams themselves are nightmarish or disturbing, while it maintains emphasis upon the negative effects of the dream (and possible resulting insomnia) upon the dreamer. This interpretation also reinforces the visual quality of the dream, accounting for the literal use of *ocellis*, as the means for experiencing a dream. Hubbard (1984) 285 renders *insomnia portet ocellis* as "carrying *insomnia* to the eyes". He elaborates as follows, "the object keeps the eyes perpetually open, and thus always under its control; the lingering image of the beloved is another common amatory motif." But this interpretation leaves us with an ambiguous understanding of the noun *insomnia*. Are the eyes of the afflicted literally open, or does he witness the action of his dreams *as though* with open eyes, in the sense that the dreamer cannot rid himself of the impression of his beloved even as he escapes into sleep? Hubbard then connects this notion to Lucretius' ideas about visual perception and the films that emanate from the surfaces of objects perceived by the eyes.

[90] Quinn (1963) 196.



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2.25 contributes significantly to the reader's comprehension of the source of the narrator's powerful fear. The whole experience of watching the dream, because of its unfamiliar images, is both a premonition and a source of fear for the dreamer. A comparison between poems 2.25 and 2.26a underscores some interesting similarities in their representations of visuality while drawing attention to the connection between dreams and statements about Propertius' poetic program. Bad dreams are indicative of trouble with a lover; the dream itself manifests this anxiety in visual form, and thus forges an explicit connection between visual experience, dreaming, and love in its advice to readers and other lovers. I will now turn to poem 3.3, which combines visual experience and admonition about poetic program in the context of a dream.

Propertius 3.3: Dreams of Helicon

Christine Walde has observed that Propertius uses similar approaches in elegies 3.3 and 2.26a; in each poem he borrows imagery from an unrelated realm to communicate to the reader the images from his dream. In 2.26a this manifests itself in the mythological similes with which the narrator of the poem comments upon his dream visions. In 3.3, however, as Walde points out, Propertius borrows the images, which in this case compose the dream itself rather than the narrator's critique, from the world of the plastic arts and architecture.[91] Scholarly focus upon this aspect of the poem has generally been secondary to an interest in the established theme of the poetic dream

[91]Walde (2001) 247-48.



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initiation, which provides the poem's narrative framework.[92] In this section I will show that in this poem, as in poem 2.26a, Propertius creates a visual dreamscape which exploits the similarities between dreaming and looking at art as a means of forging a connection between dreaming and creating poetry.

That Propertius specifically evokes the initiation scenes recounted in the works of his predecessors, Hesiod, Callimachus and Ennius[93] is of paramount importance in this poem, both because it confirms Propertius' alternative poetic lineage and because it highlights Propertius' deviation from the established parameters of this experience. A close reading of the influential passages in question reveals that their authors seemed to privilege the communication between poet and divinity over the description of the environment in which this occurred.[94] Each example has features particular to it: Hesiod and Callimachus both claim initiation on Mt. Helicon, although neither claims explicitly that his encounter occurred during sleep; Ennius, the closest to Propertius chronologically, experiences initiation through incarnation. Homer appears to Ennius in place of the Muses or Apollo, and his account of the experience most likely concentrated upon the interchange between poets rather than their surroundings.

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[92] See, for example, Kambylis (1965). The entire book is a comparative study of the *Dichterweihe* (poetic initiation) in Hesiod, Callimachus, Propertius and Ennius, with a particular concentration on the function of water as a symbol in these episodes.

[93] The relevant passages: Hesiod, *Theogony*, lines 1-34; Callimachus, *Aitia*, Prologue and reference in *Ant. Pal.* 7.42.1; Ennius, *Annales* Book I, fragments 1-3, 9 (Skutsch (1985)). Other related passages include Lucretius, *De Rerum Natura*, 1.117-126 and Ovid, *Amores* 1.1.

[94] This comparison is inhibited, of course, by the fact that the works of both Callimachus and Ennius are fragmentary.



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In Propertius' poem the scene in which the exchange occurs is also part of a dream; poem and dream begin before his encounter with Apollo and end after he has been initiated by the Muses. The poet does not write of his waking up; rather the events of the dream are contained by the structure of the poem, and the implications of its programmatic statements for the remaining poems in the corpus are to be inferred by the reader.[95] Propertius' innovation in recounting his dream lies in the attention he devotes to the setting of his encounter. In this way, Propertius is able to allude to the already familiar scene of Helicon and the desired approval of the Muses and Apollo without forfeiting the individual relevance of the dream as a context for his poem.

Poem 3.3 begins with the verb *visus eram* (line 1), a standard term for describing a dream.[96] Propertius' line 1 recasts Ennius' vision of his epic mentor (*visus Homerus adesse poeta* (Skutsch 1.3 [Cic., *Ac.* 2.51]) as a poet's dream of himself.[97] This is significant because it reflects the mechanism at work in Propertius' poem; by borrowing elements from the different accounts of his predecessors, he converts the already established theme of poetic initiation into a distinctly Propertian experience. In poem 3.3, Propertius is unmistakably aware of his inheritance of a poetic legacy, yet his poem

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[95] Walde (2001) 244 claims that because 3.3 is not the first poem in book 3, its programmatic impact is diminished. See Richardson (1977) 318 ff. for a convincing discussion of 3.1-3.3 as a tripartite introduction to book 3. The name 'Philetas', for example, appears in 3.1.1 and 3.3.52 (the last line of the poem) as a signal of the boundaries of Propertius' programmatic declaration.

[96] Cf., for example, poem 4.7: *Cynthia namque meo visa est incumbere fulcro* (line 3). This poem will be analyzed in detail later in this chapter.

[97] For more on the use of *video* in the passive to describe a dream experience, see the discussion below.



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unfolds in a dreamscape which elaborates upon the pre-established rites of poetic initiation.

Propertius'[98] dream opens with an image of himself *molli recubans Heliconis in umbra* (line 1). The mention of Helicon introduces the setting as one appropriate for poetic inspiration. But this poem immediately departs from its predecessors by creating a meta-dream-- a scene in which the dreamer sees himself lying still, *recubans,*[99] under the gaze of an onlooker, Phoebus, whose appearance is deferred until line 13. The verb may simply imply that the narrator is reclining, rather than in a state of sleep, but it is important to recognize that he is in the supine position of a sleeper.[100] The implication of sleep is reinforced by Propertius' choice of the verb *speculor* to describe Phoebus' observation of the poet (*speculans ex arbore*, line 13).[101] These present participles, conspicuous among the finite forms in the rest of the passage, are allied because they occupy the same position within their respective lines and precede prepositional phrases. Furthermore, by using a verb of seeing, as opposed to writing that Apollo merely "came

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[98] I will refer to the narrator of this poem as Propertius in my analysis, since Apollo uses this name to address him in line 17.

[99] This is the only use of the verb *recubo* in all of Propertius' poetry. Contrast this with Hesiod, who writes that he encountered the Muses on Helicon while tending his sheep, ἄρνας ποιμαίνονθ' ' Ελικῶνος ὑπὸ ζαθέοιο (*Theogony* line 23), a mundane activity during which he did not anticipate a divine encounter. The participle *recubans* has a bucolic precedent in Virgil's Eclogue 1.1 (*Tityre, tu patulae recubans sub tegmine fagi)*, in which poem the noun *umbra* also appears in the final line (*et iam summa procul villarum culmina fumant / maioresque cadunt altis de montibus umbrae*, lines 82-83). This shared vocabulary suggests a strong connection between the dreamscape of poem 3.3 and the elements of fantasy in the poetic conception of the bucolic landscape.

[100] Compare, for example, poem 1.3 (discussed at length in chapter 2), in which the narrator spies on Cynthia asleep, and even goes so far as to imagine her dreams and manipulate her as she lies unconscious.

[101] It is worth noting that this line contains the sole instance of the verb *speculor* in Propertius' corpus. I observe in the longer version of this section that Propertius' exclusive use of certain verbs in the dream poems contributes to their distinctive nature.



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upon" or "interrupted" him while lying beside the stream, Propertius reinforces the importance of the visual aspect of dreaming already familiar from poems such as 2.26a. Apollo, at this point in the poem, assumes the position of the reader, who has hitherto observed the poet beside the stream about to drink from inappropriate waters.

The narrator of the poem recounts that Apollo spies him about to drink from the Hippocrene, whose importance for epic poetry is revealed by the subsequent parenthetical list of historical subjects from Ennius' *Annales*.[102] He is poised to sip from his reclining position, *parvaque iam magnis admoram fontibus ora* (line 5), when Apollo intervenes. It is only at this point in the poem's narrative that the reader realizes that the narrator is not sleeping, but is reclining as though at a banquet, ready to imbibe the inspiration suited for poets such as Ennius. Propertius, whose initial appearance in the dream had been static, as though he were part of a tableau, is frozen again in mid-action (he had moved his lips *to* the stream, but had not yet tasted its water) by the reproach of Apollo. From this point on, the poet is inactive; he retreats from the scene to a position of observer.[103] Although the reader is to presume that he moves from the area of the

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[102] As Goold (1990) 226-27 points out, there is a problem with Propertius' catalogue: he seems to have conflated the victory of Aemilius Regillus from *Annales* 14 "with the triumphal return of L. Aemilius Paullus up the Tiber in 167, by which time Ennius was dead". Perhaps this anachronistic discrepancy is an attempt by the poet to represent the dreamer's confusion or condensation of events. In the line following the catalogue, Phoebus spies Propertius *Castalia...ex arbore* (line 13). Goold is quick to mention the geographical impossibility of this, for "Castalia is on Parnassus in Phocis, while the poet's dream takes place on Helicon in Boeotia," 227. I would argue that this type of inconsistency is permissible in the context of a dream because of the nature of a dream to blur chronology and location.

[103] This is underscored by the fact that there are no more first person verbs in the rest of the poem with the exception of the aside *(ut) reor* (line 38), which is discussed later in this section.



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Hippocrene to the Muses' grotto, Propertius does not mention the transition between spaces.

In the first line of his admonition, Apollo addresses Propertius as *demens* (line 15). Propertius' selection of this word is designed to emphasize for the reader the madness of the poet's attempt to drink directly from the Hippocrene. But rather than simply calling attention to the error of his ways, Apollo points him in the direction of the source of inspiration appropriate for elegiac poets--water from the grove of the Muses from which Philetas of Cos drank. Apollo, in a sense, wakes Propertius up, and, although Propertius is still dreaming, Apollo teaches him about the function of his writing in the waking world--namely, that it will serve the girl who sits idly on a bench waiting for her lover. Propertius' dementia is akin to the experience of a dreamer in a dream, in which the dreamer acts deviously. This behavior is sanctioned within the confines of a dream, but it is temporary; eventually the dreamer wakes up and returns to his senses, and this is presumably accompanied by a return to his normal activity.

The madness which Propertius experiences as a dreamer in poem 3.3 is similar to that experienced by the female lover of poem 3.8, discussed above, who is tormented by *dementia somnia* (line 15) in that it is recognizable as deviant but temporary. In both cases the dreamer is allowed episodic insanity, and sleep provides a space in which this is permissible. As we recall, the correlatives *seu* and *seu* in 3.8 imply that deranged dreams frighten a girl in the same way that a painted image can upset her. The similarity between the experiences of dreaming and looking at works of art, already familiar from



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poem 2.26a, is also relevant for the analysis of poem 3.3, as this poem, while it takes place in a dream, has the form of a painted diptych showing two scenes of landscape.

Poem 3.3 has the quality of a tableau, a static image whose continuity is only interrupted by the speeches of Apollo and Calliope.[104] The focus on the rustic landscape in this poem serves to distinguish it from others of its genre by shifting emphasis from the rites of initiation to the setting in which this occurs. The mention of the Muses' grotto, for instance, would have been sufficient for Propertius to evoke the prologues of Hesiod and Callimachus, but by elaborating upon their dwelling in a poetic ekphrasis, this initiation scene becomes, in the words of Jean-Paul Boucher, "la version propertienne"[105] of an already familiar trope. Christine Walde uses the following terms to describe the setting of this poem: "szenischen Gestaltung" (scene-like arrangement), "artifiziell" (artificial) and "'Kunstraum'" (art-space).[106] That Propertius' poetic description has pictorial qualities is an observation that many have shared, but it is particularly interesting in the case of poem 3.3, because this poem describes a dream and, as with poem 2.26a, the visual quality of the dream is maintained to underscore the difficulty of communicating such images in textual terms.

Propertius begins his description of the Muses' grotto (*spelunca,* line 27) with a reference to its decoration. The first impression he conveys is that its natural setting has

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[104] Hubbard (1974) 79 notes that "scene replaces scene rapidly and completely, and an air of inconsequence is convincingly created." The lack of connection between the images certainly tempts their dismissal as the illogical creations of a dreaming mind. I assume that Hubbard means by "inconsequence" the dream's picturesque quality; it is merely an image which flees as the dreamer wakes up.

[105] Boucher (1965) 175.

[106] Walde (2001) 244.



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been enhanced by mosaic work (*affixis lapillis,* line 27) and that drums hang from the cave's natural pumice (line 28). The next line offers the first hint that the dreamer has entered the home of the Muses, as the drums are called *orgia Musarum* (line 29). At this point the dreamer and the reader have moved along the new path (the *nova semita* of line 26) and into the entrance of the cave. Referring to the decoration of the grotto, Christine Walde notes that this passage evokes the atmosphere and design of Roman villas.[107] She echoes Margaret Hubbard's comment that, "probably it all seems more strange and wonderful to us than to a Roman, who saw many such things in the gardens of civilized villas and townhouses."[108] What both of these authors neglect to point out, however, is the strangeness of this civilized, villa setting in the midst of the dreamscape of Mount Helicon. Propertius' poetry is the poetry of the civilized, so it is logical that its source of inspiration should reside in such an abode; his ekphrasis is not merely an elaborate veneer, but rather reflects an element of the Muses' advice to him about his poetic material.

The dreamer begins to focus upon the details of the Muses' home in the subsequent lines. He observes two objects: *...Sileni patris imago / fictilis et calami, Pan Tegeaee, tui* (lines 29-30). Of these it is particularly striking that in the middle of this dream-image of a luxuriant grotto lies a clay image of Silenus; this grotto still life itself contains a work of art. The placement of the word *imago* in the description of this

[107] Walde (2001) 246: "evoziert Properz die Atmosphäre und Ausgestaltung römischer Villen".

[108] Hubbard (1974) 79-80.



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constructed landscape is surely meant to suggest the artificiality of the setting.[109] Propertius then observes Venus' doves drinking from the pool whose waters will anoint him at the dream's end: *et Veneris dominae volucres, mea turba, columbae/ tingunt Gorgoneo punica rostra lacu* (lines 31-32). This image "belongs to art," as Hubbard writes, "but is no less dreamlike for that."[110] Indeed it is more familiar as a dream because of its stylization, and it is not by chance that this image, undoubtedly recognizable from artistic representation,[111] is the first mention of any living creature within the Muses' abode. The vivid purple color of the doves' beaks adds to the

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[109] The word *imago* can connote the realistic deceptiveness of an image such as one sees in a dream. It is used by Ovid, for example, to refer to the power of a dream image (*imagine somni)* in book 8 of the *Metamorphoses,* where the starving Erysichthon imitates the act of eating in his sleep: *...petit ille dapes sub imagine somni, / oraque vana movet dentemque in dente fatigat / exercetque cibo delusum guttur inani* (lines 824-26). The dreamer believes he is eating, while, from a viewer's perspective, it would be obvious that he was gulping air and gnashing his teeth in vain (see also Ovid's description of the appearance of Isis and her retinue in the dream of Telethusa, *sub imagine somni, Met.* 9.686). Statius uses the word to describe the image of Mors in the cave of Somnus in book 10.105 of the *Thebaid,* a setting that also boasts a combination of refinement and naturalism in its description. The artifice of these images is pointed out to the reader as Statius warns not to confuse these representations with the real inhabitant of the cave. This passage will be discussed in detail in chapter 3. Both this cave and the cave of the Muses are places where refined art objects have a home, and where artistic illusionism reminds the reader of the artifice of a dream image.

[110] Hubbard (1974) 80. The only example I have found of artistic representation of the Muses in their grotto is a late third to early second century B.C. relief by Archelaos found at Bovillae in Italy, which is reproduced in Pollitt (1986) 15, no. 4. In this image, the Muses occupy a middle register where they serve as intermediaries between the realm of Zeus and that of mortals (Pollitt (1986) 16). Apollo is also pictured among them holding his *kithara* as he does in poem 3.3. The cave in the relief appears simple and rustic when compared with Propertius' description in 3.3. As was the case with 2.26a, it is unlikely that Propertius was merely trying to "translate" a visual image into words in this instance. If he used an artistic model such as this for his poem, his embellishments are significant for their deviation.

[111] There is a well-known example from Hadrian's Villa at Tivoli, now in the Capitoline Museum, done in such fine *opus vermiculatum* mosaic work that the water seems to shimmer in the basin (see McDonald, W. and J. Pinto (1995) *Hadrian's Villa and its Legacy.* Yale University Press: New Haven., 164, fig. 209). For a discussion of this mosaic in connection with the image of the doves drinking in poem 3.3, see Guillemin (1940) 107. See also Herter (1976), who discusses specifically the iconographic symbolism of the dove in connection with Propertius' description.



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pictorial quality of the scene. Their drinking from the pool is a prelude to Propertius' drinking from the same water at the poem's end.

When Propertius actually sees the inhabitants of the grotto, he notices them busy at work: *haec hederas legit in thyrsos, haec carmina nervis/ aptat, at illa manu texit utraque rosam* (lines 36-37). Each of the Muses is engaged in an activity which involves composition; the verb *texo* carries the secondary meaning of "write," while *apto* and *lego* could be read metaphorically as references to the poet's craft. The Muses are observed busy at a poet's work--that which should occupy Propertius when he is roused from his dream.[112] When one of the Muses addresses her guest, Propertius identifies her as Calliope: *ut reor a facie, Calliopea fuit* (line 38). In his commentary, Lawrence Richardson, jr. points out that this is a pun on the etymology of her name, which means in Greek "of beautiful voice," but is misinterpreted by Propertius to refer to her "beautiful face."[113] Perhaps this is simply an instance of Propertius' fixation on female beauty, but I think that it reflects more upon his desire to foreground the visual quality of the dreamer's experience in the dream and to remind the reader of the function of looking in this dream narrative. Furthermore, the use of the phrase *ut reor* in this parenthetical statement (reminiscent of the parenthetical *puto* in 2.26a.18), the only

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[112] The Muses' occupations in their cave are similar to those Cynthia claimed kept her busy in poem 1.3, as she waited in vain for her lover to return after a night of drinking: *nam modo purpureo fallebam stamine somnum,/ rursus et Orpheae carmine, fessa, lyrae;/ interdum leviter mecum deserta querebar/ externo longas saepe in amore moras* (lines 41-44). If, as Walde suggests (2001) 244, Propertius uses poem 3.3 as a vehicle for announcing that Cynthia has been replaced by the Muses as his source for poetic inspiration then the similarity between these passages represents a physical transfer of duty from one party to the other.

[113] Richardson (1977) 329.



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example of this verb in its finite form in the poems of Propertius, reminds the reader that the dreamer is reporting this after the experience and is commenting upon what he has seen. As was evident in poem 2.26a, a dreamer's commentary on his own dream is one means for underscoring the artifice of a dream, which in poem 3.3 is also manifested by its picturesque setting.

In lines 47 and 48, just before she gives Propertius a drink from the grotto's pool, Calliope gives him his poetic orders; he is to eschew writing about warfare in favor of writing love elegy: *quippe coronatos alienum ad limen amantes/ nocturnaeque canes ebria signa fugae.*[114] The phrase "drunken tokens of a nighttime escape" could have numerous referents, and most likely Calliope refers to props taken from parties such as garlands, torches, and fruit--the very objects which Propertius brought home to the sleeping Cynthia in poem 1.3. The tokens could also refer to the physical remains of the lovers' trysts themselves, namely the love bites and bruises which the narrator of poem 3.8, for example, reminisces about the next day (lines 5-8). I propose that we include dreams, the mind's nighttime escapades, among the *nocturnae fugae*. Of course the Muse encourages the poet to write about subjects antithetical to the theme of war, primarily lovers waiting on thresholds (as opposed to soldiers waiting for battle) and

[114] It is worth noting that Propertius receives the instruction to write elegy in the manner and setting (respectively) of Ennius and Hesiod, poets who wrote in hexameter as opposed to elegiac verse. Fedeli (1985) 119-22, 142 comments upon the overlap of elegiac and epic markers in the poem, namely in lines 3-12, where epic subject matter is given such prominence, yet is described in elegiac couplets. He draws attention to this confluence again in his discussion of the connection between the *lacus Gorgoneus* and the Hippocrene. He is convinced that the water which the doves drink has its source in the Hippocrene, acknowledging the mythological origin of Pegasus from the blood of the Gorgon Medusa. He sees in this relationship metaphors for the derivation of elegiac meter from the hexameter and for the levels of diction in each type of poetry. Perhaps the juxtaposition of rustic and civilized, seen in the elegant cave atop Mount Helicon, is meant to contribute to this blurring.



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"torches with which the lover signals to his mistress by waving them,"[115] as Richardson suggests (rather than brandishing a soldier's weapons, the domain of epic poetry). But writing about the dreams of lovers (also a part of the poet's nightscape) figures prominently in Propertius' corpus of poems. As the dream setting of 3.3 provides the context for Propertius' instruction as an elegiac poet, the link between dreaming and the creation of love elegy in this poem is explicit. The elegist's dreams--both those he has of his lover and those in which his writing is the subject--are now sanctioned by the Muses as the fabric of his poems.

The search for a link between Propertius' use of mythological references, the influence of artistic representation upon his imagery, and the role of visual experience in his poetry, has been a favorite subject of Propertian criticism. The general tendency of critics like Jean-Paul Boucher and Margaret Hubbard has been to imagine that Propertius had certain models in mind--wall-paintings, mosaics, or sculptures--whose subject matter matched that of a reference in a specific poem. The failure to identify in an extant work of art a source for a particular Propertian image results in a declaration that the poet must refer to a work that is now lost to us.[116] My intention in the discussion above was to gain insight into the visual quality of Propertius' dream poems and to understand where the themes of these poems intersect with those of his other poems.

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[115] Ibid., 329.

[116] See Boucher (1965) 54, where, in order to explain why the reference to Andromeda sleeping in elegy 1.3 is jarring to the modern reader (whereas there are known depictions of other parts of her story, for example, her rescue by Perseus), Boucher explains that Propertius must be referring to a depiction that is lost to us. I will return to this example in the following chapter.



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Taking as my cue Propertius' own analogies between dreaming and viewership, and between looking at art and looking at Cynthia, I have proposed ideas about the connection between Propertius' poetry and the visual arts and have speculated about how the elegist's understanding of visual aesthetics might have influenced his dream poems. Because dreaming is primarily a visual event, the poet faces a challenge in trying to translate the experience of 'watching' a dream into textual narrative; one way that Propertius responds to this is by acknowledging the similarity between dreams and art as likely vehicles for a realism which is illusionistic and thus deceptively true to life.

**Parallels between non-figural painting and the dream experience**

While my analysis hitherto has focused upon Propertius' possible evocations and manipulations of figural imagery in his dream poems, in this section I will briefly identify some potential similarities between the techniques of representation popular in non-figural wall-painting in the late first century B.C. and those employed by Propertius in the dream poems discussed above. For I am convinced that, along with his sensitivity to and familiarity with the representation of mythological characters in various visual media, the poet also took advantage of his readers' familiarity with the complex representational techniques used by painters of non-figural representation in the visual tableaux of his own dreamscapes.[117] Perhaps his awareness of the possibilities for deception inherent in artistic representation was, in part, informed by the illusionism of

[117] The connection between the advent of elegiac poetry and the changes in wall-painting styles witnessed by the Augustan age is explored in Andreas Grüner's very recent study (2004). Grüner is interested in the specific parallels between the erotic subjectivity of the elegiac narrator and the advent of mythological themes in the "framed" paintings of the Third Style (see in particular part B). Grüner's analysis, which concentrates upon the poetry of Tibullus, makes reference to ideas of madness (266, e.g.) but does not overtly connect this to dreaming.



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the architectural vistas of the style popular for most of his life (the so-called Second Style) and the compositional modes which emerged in Rome at the height of his career (the transitional period between the Second and Third Styles). Thus to the already well-established discourse on Propertius' use of the visual in his poetry, I would like to add a discussion of the similarities between the effects of illusionism in literary dreams and in the wall-painting of the mid-late first century B.C. My analysis in this section does not attempt to be comprehensive; I will use one example each to represent the two painting styles addressed in my analysis. Rather than exploring the possible political or social dimensions of the evolution in painting styles, my chief concern here is to illustrate a possible connection between modes of representation in painting and poetry and to open up an avenue for future work on Roman attitudes toward dreaming and viewership.[118]

Propertius comments upon the illusionism of painted depictions obliquely in poem 1.2. In this poem he contrasts Cynthia's false adornment with women from literature and myth who, according to his claim, did not need the help of ornament *(cultus),* false glamour *(falso candore),* gems *(gemmis),* or rouge *(fuco)* to entice their lovers. He ends his complaint by comparing the appearance *(facies)* of these women to the color used by the painter Apelles: *sed facies aderat nullis obnoxia gemmis, / qualis Apelleis est color in tabullis* (lines 21-22). We must assume that the painter's color appears independent of adornment because of its apparent naturalism. This startling statement is very revealing about Propertius' attitude towards painted representation: the

[118] For a thorough treatment of the political influences upon the evolution of the painting styles, see Grüner (2004) section I.4.



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more illusionistic it is, the more it appears pure; the richer its hues, the greater its illusion of being unembellished and closer to nature. What I would like to explore in the section that follows is the relationship between the intentional illusionism of complex wall-painting and the viewer's perception of this type of painted image with the deception of a dreamer by images which seem similarly real. Furthermore, I will show that Propertius, who was obviously influenced by the visual imagery of his day, could have acknowledged this similarity in his re-creation of the dream experience in his poetry.

Walls painted in the so-called Second Style, popular throughout most of the first century B.C., as well as those done in the transitional style that bridged this and the Third Style, traditionally dated to a period between 30 and 10 B.C., would have no doubt been familiar to Propertius.[119] Familiarity with the evolution of the styles provided Propertius with two paradigms from which to draw in his attempts to convey visual experience in his poems: The Second Style provided an illusionism which showed realistic vistas receding -- somewhat unrealistically -- away from the flat planes of walls, while the Third Style reasserted the wall's integrity and boasted smaller, picture-like images, which were themselves like portals to a fantastical world outside the room. The transition between these styles retained some elements of the former, while introducing new elements and hinting at the features that would come to dominate the Third Style. In one such example, the paintings from the so-called tablinum of the House of Livia on

[119] Mau (1882) developed this classification system. Beyen (1938) revised it to include two phases of the Second Style: early (ca. 80-40 B.C.) and late/transitional (ca. 40-15 B.C.).



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the Palatine, the juxtaposition of interior and external spaces redefines the illusionism of its predecessor by restoring to the wall its inherent solidity.[120]

Taking cubiculum M from the villa at Boscoreale as my paradigm for the pinnacle of the Second Style, I will look in particular at the ways in which the natural and architectural elements of the scenes depicted in the frescoes, although perhaps realistic individually, presented to their viewers vistas that were at once harmonious and incongruous.[121] Considering both the content and technique of the representations, I will make a broad comparison between these elements and certain features of Propertius' dream poems. This type of analysis provides us with another avenue for understanding the relationship between artistic and textual representation and the ways in which artists and poets anticipated and manipulated the experience of their audiences. By looking at the changes that occurred as the Second Style gave way to the Third, I will show that this transitional style also contained compositional elements that could also have been evoked by the mechanisms of Propertius' dream poems, or, perhaps, which played upon the same issues and points of fascination with visual representation of the early Augustan age.

Regardless of its precise dates, the so-called Second Style is marked most distinctly by a movement away from the emphasis upon the construction and physicality of the wall to the complete denial of the wall as a surface for depiction. In her lengthy

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[120] For a view of the room as it looks today, see Clarke (1990) 51, fig. 16.

[121] For Plan of villa and view of the cubiculum reconstructed at the Metropolitan Museum of Art in New York, see Lehmann (1953) 4 (fig. 1) and plate 10.



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treatment of the Second Style wall-paintings in cubiculum M of the Villa at Boscoreale, Phyllis Williams Lehmann writes that the "most significant tendency" of this style was that "it moved toward a decorative negation of the structural function of the wall which was opened up, or rather painted away..."[122] In the rooms where the Second Style is thought to have reached its height, such as cubiculum M at Boscoreale, likely painted between 50 and 40 B.C. and now on display in the Metropolitan Museum in New York, and in rooms 14 and 15 of the Villa at Oplontis,[123] we see the obliteration of the wall realized in various ways. The appearance of multiple layers of depth beyond the plane of the wall and the variety of structural types represented upon the plane of the wall foreground the artist's ability to defy the limitations of a room's structure as they contribute to the room's successful illusionism. While much of the discussion of the scenes from cubiculum M has centered upon their representation of structures from the "real" world, whether theatrical set buildings, the residences of wealthy Hellenistic kings, or, conversely, those of local Italian aristocrats, what I would like to focus on in my analysis is the viewer's experience of looking at these, and the effect of their illusionism and their juxtaposition within the room.[124]

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[122] Lehmann (1953) 134. See also Leach (1982) for discussion of the Boscoreale paintings. Also helpful are Borda (1958) 30-38 and Baldassare et al. (2002) 92 ff.

[123] See de Franciscis (1975) and Clarke (1991) for extensive treatment of the wall-paintings at this villa. The cubiculum at Boscoreale is unusually ornate, but the quality and subject matter of the Second Style rooms at the Villa from Oplontis furnish proof that this kind of elaborate decoration was not unique among the wealthy villa owners around the Bay of Naples.

[124] In her staunch rejection of the theories that the architectural panels reflected either stage decoration or the palaces of Hellenistic kings, Lehmann (1953) chapter 3 concludes that the structures represented are meant to evoke the *pars urbana* of a country villa, which would have included porticoes, rustic sanctuaries, and storage buildings. I think that she is unnecessarily dismissive of the possibility that these



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Cubiculum M of the villa at Boscoreale, although perhaps exceptional in its combination of motifs, is paradigmatic for the features of the Second Style, as it demonstrates multiple modes for "painting away" the walls of the room with illusionistic images.[125] As is typical for Second Style depictions of this type, the cubiculum presents mirror images on its side walls. As the viewer entered the room he would have seen on either side a series of four panels. The first three form a triptych, which contains a series of two scenes of urban architecture flanking a sacro-idyllic shrine seemingly set back into the wall.[126] The final panel on each side shows a tholos with receding colonnades.[127] The tranquility offered by this strolling area appears enticingly close by, as though it lies just behind a low wall and a curtain. In an alcove at the back of the room, where the viewer's gaze would have been directed upon entering,[128] we see a rustic scene of a grotto, trees, a pergola, and a fountain, all of which are arranged to accommodate the room's only window.[129] All of the room's represented views of the world outside are linked by matching ornately-decorated columns and pilasters, which also serve to

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represent cityscapes because she is determined to see the lateral walls as part of a cohesive whole. Kuttner (1998) and Ling (1991) 30-31 leave open the possibility that the "windows" created by these elaborate paintings "looked out" onto settings that could not have been physically contiguous and may have drawn upon diverse sources.

[125] The term "illusionism" is borrowed from Lehmann (1953) 6, where, in describing the villa's decoration, she writes, "...the Second Pompeian style was at its height. Illusionism was its keynote. Walls were no longer conceived as structural members whose function of enclosure and support demanded decorative expression."

[126] See Lehmann (1953) plate 11.

[127] See Ling (1990) 31, figure 27.

[128] See Scagliarini (1974-76) for a discussion of the orientation of the viewer within the room.

[129] See Lehmann (1953) 116-118 and n. 141 for the originality of the window in the design of the room.



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demarcate the individual scenes. A low podium that continues around the room and supports the columns adds some uniformity to the scenes by making it appear as though they all exist beyond this boundary. These elements contribute to the illusion of depth of space in the vistas by making it look as though the views themselves are already set back at one remove from the viewer's standpoint. But these features also remind the viewer of the parameters of the visual experience, as they frame the images and recall the physical structure of the room. Likewise, the narrator of a dream creates certain parameters to delineate the experience of his dream. Signposts such as the phrase *visus eram* in line 1 of 3.3, or the mention of waking, as we see in 2.26a.20, qualify the visual experience as a dream. Thus the reader is reminded of the mechanism at work at the beginning and end of the poem while he or she is encouraged by the vividness of the description to forget its narrative frame.

As Ann Kuttner has observed, "the owner of the Boscoreale villa seated in his small salon could pass at will, with a flick of the eye, from the jumbled cliffs of a multi-story townscape to portico precinct to villa *hortus* and grotto, each the stage for a different *persona.*"[130] With the "stage" set in such a way, the villa owner or his guest had only to imagine himself an actor upon it, in whichever scene he chose. Within the space of the room, one was free to cast himself in a role, just as he might in a dream.

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[130] Kuttner (1998) 106. Kuttner's description of the townscape, which makes it sound somewhat wild and rustic in its precarious stacking, also reminds us of its 'larger than life' quality (Ling's term (1991) 31). From the suggestion of the few buildings perched here, perhaps the viewer is meant to imagine the expanse of a city beyond. This type of extrapolation from a hint is also, according to Aristotle, a feature of the dream experience. In section 463a3 of his *De Divinatione per Somnum,* Aristotle claims that in sleep slight movements seem to be big (καὶ γὰρ αἱ μικραὶ μεγάλαι δοκοῦσιν εἶναι). This seems to affect the senses other than vision; people who hear faint echoes, for example, translate these into thunder and lightning in their dreams.



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Although the modern viewer is only able to indulge this fantasy from a fixed point at the doorway, it is still possible to appreciate the symmetry of the lateral walls and the function of the back wall as a balance between them. Taken individually each of the room's vistas provides the illusion of increased space, thus creating an opportunity for the viewer to envision realms beyond the room, while remaining firmly planted within its confines. Like a dreamer who is confined physically to his bed, but in a dream is seemingly able to interact in contexts unbound by the limitations of physical reality, so too is the viewer in this room able to transcend space.[131] Just as a dreamer is able to characterize what he has seen as a dream upon waking and to recognize his credulity while he was asleep, I believe the same would apply to the viewer of such a room. He would be able to appreciate the skilled artifice of the room's intricate vistas while allowing himself to succumb to its intended effects.

Another way in which the experience of viewing in cubiculum M is like that of dreaming derives from the incongruity of the room's images. There is nothing inherently strange about the concurrence of urban and rustic elements; in fact, the combination occurs in a reference by Lucretius to the lifestyle of an affluent Roman,

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[131] Lucretius (4.453-61) comments upon this paradox at some length, contrasting the fettering of sleep with the movement experienced in dreams. In particular, he refers to the contrast between the sleeper's confined physical space and his seeming ability to travel: *conclusoque loco caelum, mare, flumina, montis / mutare et campos pedibus transire videmur* (lines 458-59). The dreamer believes that what he sees in his dream is reality at the time that he experiences it, and it is only upon waking that he establishes the difference between what he has seen in a dream and what he sees in reality. This is, of course, one of the points that Cicero makes in *Academica* 2.51-52, a passage discussed below. Perhaps viewing the vistas of the cubiculum at Boscoreale would have fostered this type of paradoxical experience of seeming to depart from the space while simultaneously being confined by it.



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where the two are specifically juxtaposed to emphasize their contrast.[132] In this case, neither of the opposites can satisfy a tormented soul.[133] Likewise, in the case of the cubiculum, neither the city nor the country is privileged, as both coexist in a state of similarly realistic false representation.[134] But what does their proximity represent in the wall-paintings of a room such as this? If, as it has been argued, the combination of urban, rustic, and sacro-idyllic landscapes symbolizes the different facets of a villa owner's fantasy of himself, the skill with which their escapist illusionism is executed

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[132] Lucretius writes in 3.1060-67:

> *exit saepe foras magnis ex aedibus ille,*
> *esse domi quem pertaesumst, subitoque <revertit>,*
> *quippe foris nihilo melius qui sentiat esse*
> *currit agens mannos ad villam praecipitanter,*
> *auxilium tectis quasi ferre ardentibus instans:*
> *oscitat extemplo, tetigit cum limina villae,*
> *aut abit in somnum gravis atque oblivia quaerit,*
> *aut etiam properans urbem petit atque revisit.*

Kuttner (1998) 106 mentions this passage in conjunction with the images from the Boscoreale cubiculum in her conclusion about the mixing of urban and rural motifs in the paintings of the second style. Kuttner is convinced that the prominence of architectural motifs on the walls of a country villa served to unite the public/private, city/country allegiances of the villa's owner. In her critique of Lehmann (1953), Leach (1982) 146 describes her [Lehmann's] response to the established theory that second style wall-paintings reflected motifs from stage decoration as follows: "[she] argues instead that the scenes are illusionary views of the grounds of a Roman villa, a villa not unlike this Boscoreale residence yet somewhat grander in keeping with the owner's *dream* of what an ideal villa might be" [my emphasis]. Leach's choice of vocabulary is telling here: according to Lehmann the villa owner's dream is, of course, not literal, but rather refers to the owner's desire to collect all of the elements of his imagined ideal villa into one room, as though one room's perspective could offer a view of all of the desired components of a villa complex. Regardless of what the buildings actually represent, a dream offers a solution to what is in reality impossible.

[133] It is worth noting that this is mentioned just following a reference to dreams (lines 1047-48). As Lucretius has it, the person leading an unfulfilled life, one out of step with the principles of Epicureanism, may as well be asleep and dreaming since he is unconscious of the cause of his depression and inability to be self-satisfied.

[134] The architectural vistas cover more of the wall's surface area, but the rustic grotto scene is the focal point of the room as it lies on axis with the room's entryway, as discussed above.



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also highlights their owner's cultivation to an equal degree.[135] Perhaps, then, we can read the panels and their details as symbols of cultivation to which the villa's owner might have wished to draw attention.

This has a parallel, then, in what the narrator of 3.3 is doing as he draws attention to the subject matter of his poetry through the representation of pastoral open space in the first half of the poem and the cultivated grotto of the Muses in the second half. The poet-narrator envisions the locus for his inspiration as a place far away from the urban setting in which and about which he will write his poetry. The open space of Helicon and the flow of the Hippocrene are equated with the past through their association with other poets who had received inspiration there and through the epic themes which the location first inspires the narrator to write. By contrast, the Muses' cave reminds the reader of the refined and urbane subjects which the poet should be treating in his elegies.

Rather than dwell upon the incongruity between the subjects for representation, we can compare the ways in which the paintings of the cubiculum call attention to their artifice in the same way that the imagery of the Muses' dwelling in 3.3 does. Taking the grotto panel in the alcove of the cubiculum as an example,[136] we could say that this feature is enhanced by the fact that the view towards which the visitor to the room is most directly oriented is the one which also has the least architectural detail and is, therefore, the least reminiscent of the construction of the room itself. Furthermore, the

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[135] Kuttner (1998) 106-07 et passim argues that the design was arranged to reflect the owner's self-identity as a "builder," hence the combination of elements from public and private architecture.

[136] See Lehmann (1953) plate 20.



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fact that it boasted a window through which one could possibly look out to see the real rustic scene outside of the physical building drew greater attention to the very artifice of the images depicted on the inside of the wall. As Phyllis Williams Lehmann observes, "nowhere is its [the Second Style's] conscious juxtaposition and equation of the real and the painted more striking" than in the grotto panel.[137] The empty space of the cave with its gaping black hollow is the largest section of negative space in the room. This creates an inverted parallel to the window beside it, which presumably would have offered a view onto the scene outside of the room in addition to increasing the sense of depth in the room. Conversely, the cave merely alludes to depth with its hint of a recess beyond what is visible to the viewer, but it does not provide a view.

When the viewer's eyes focus on the details of the cave,[138] the image of a god standing on the cave's floor emerges from the darkness. Just as the *imago* of Silenus made of clay appeared in the Muses' cave as a self-referential reminder of the dream's artifice, thus an illusionistic representation of a natural setting appears adjacent to a view of the outdoors. Furthermore, there is a bird in the cave shown drinking from the fountain. Like Venus' doves, which drink from a pool in the Muses' cave, this bird reminds the viewer of the illusionism of the scene; the presence of a living creature interacting within this scene of represented nature enhances its credibility as a living reality. Its proximity to the open window and the possibility that through the open window would waft sounds of running water and chirping birds, as Phyllis Williams

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[137] Lehmann (1953) 118.

[138] See Lehmann (1953) plate 21 for detail.



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Lehmann suggests, would have further blurred the distinction between fantasy and reality.[139] The simultaneous awareness of construct and reality seems typical of the experience of dreaming and waking to describe the dream.

It is likely that Propertius' visually-evocative description of the Muses' civilized but still rustic dwelling in 3.3 had greater effect upon his readers because this type of scene had visual parallels in the compositions of specific Second Style wall-paintings. The grotto depicted on the back wall of cubiculum M at Boscoreale is also significant because of its contrast with the architecturally intricate compositions leading to it on either side of the room; in poem 3.3, Apollo serves the function of arresting and guiding the dreamer to the cave of the Muses after he has spoken with him about important elements from his waking life. As I showed earlier, the intrusion of the Muses' dwelling in 3.3, which reminds the reader of the dream's physical setting as it provides a descriptive interlude between Apollo's monologue and that of Calliope, was significant for its conspicuous refinement among the rustic environs of Mount Helicon. The decorative attributes of the Muses' cave, emblems of human artifice and reminders of the poet's refinement, disrupt the otherwise naturalistic setting of the poem. Let us compare this to the content of the complex second style wall-painting type exemplified by cubiculum M of the villa at Boscoreale. Just as Propertius created a variegated landscape in his poem, shifting from a large vista, which included the Hippocrene and the Castalian wood, to the refined decorative detail of the cave, which thereby lent some elements of the familiar to the fantastic realm of the dream, the painter of cubiculum M

[139] See Lehmann (1953) 130-31.



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used imagery derived from familiar urban and rustic settings to "break through" the walls with his illusionistic juxtapositions and views. Thus we see an analogy between the concerns of the elegist and those of the painter by examining their modes of representing imagined space. Both the painter of the cubiculum and Propertius in his dream poem create variegated landscapes that defy the parameters through which they are viewed. In both cases, the realism with which the vistas are presented challenges the context and medium through which they are seen.

In his treatise *De Architectura*, the Roman military engineer and architect Vitruvius expresses his disapproval of the recent trend in fresco painting with the following terms, "monstrosities are now depicted in frescoes rather than reliable images from definite things" (*nam pinguntur tectoriis monstra potius quam ex rebus finitis imagines certae* 7.5.3).[140] Vitruvius' complaint may be understood as a reaction to the perceived rejection of the Second Style, which embraced realistic representations of objects and structures from daily life. As a sign of the new aesthetic, Vitruvius claims, the columns of architectural structures are being replaced by elements such as reeds and spindly candelabras, which are depicted to function in ways that deviate from reality.[141]

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[140] This passage has been cited in various attempts to connect Vitruvius' observations with either literary descriptions of art or with contemporary examples of wall-painting from both Rome and Pompeii; see, for example, Leach (1988) 6, 242; Bryson (1990) 43; Wallace-Hadrill (1994) 29; Yerkes (2000). Also relevant here is Lucretius' statement (4.732 ff., discussed in the Introduction) explaining the origin of hybrid forms such as centaurs and mermaids. He accounts for these by explaining the mingling of films from different entities in creating them. Like "phantoms of the dead" (*simulacra*, lines 733-34), which are typical in dream imagery, these hybrids are not formed from life, since such creatures do not exist in life. The *ex vivo* of his explanation is comparable to the *ex rebus finitis* of Vitruvius' statement about the incongruity of *monstra*.

[141] As Paul Zanker (1988) 280, among others, observes, this shift actually represents a movement away from certain illusionistic tendencies of the Second Style: "the illusion of breaking through the wall is no



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The House of Livia on the Palatine boasts examples of this type of depiction. In the so-called tablinum, griffins perch atop cornices and winged caryatids support architraves with the points of their hats. Observers have seen in this type of imagery the very changes that Vitruvius lamented,[142] as these forms appear to replace standard architectural features, and thus present structural impossibilities.[143] Continuing my discussion of non-figural painting, however, I will concentrate upon the features of the tablinum that represent continuity with the Second Style imagery exemplified by cubiculum M from Boscoreale, rather than simply on the striking innovation of the

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longer sought--rather its integrity is emphasized--and the viewer is meant to focus on the meaning of just a few images that dominate the room." For similar opinions, see Knell (1985) 161-165; Clarke (1991) 49-54; Ling (1991) 41-42. Bernard Frischer (1990) 77 notes that the narrator's reaction (lines 5-7) to the monstrosities he describes in lines 1-4 of Horace's *Ars Poetica* reveals a pedantry and conservatism reminiscent of Vitruvius' own reaction to the changes in artistic style. The lines follow:

> *humano capiti cervicem pictor equinam*
> *iungere si velit et varias inducere plumas*
> *undique collatis membris, ut turpiter atrum*
> *desinat in piscem mulier formosa superne,*
> *spectatum admissi risum teneatis, amici?*
> *credite, Pisones, isti tabulae fore librum*
> *persimilem cuius, velut aegri somnia...*

Horace's comparison of the hybrid forms to images from a sick (mad) man's dreams in lines 6-7 recalls the link between a love-sick girl's reaction to a painted image or to a nightmare as manifestations of her madness in poem 3.8, as discussed above. For a later example of this parallel, see Sextus Empiricus, Πρὸς Λογικοῦς 1.88, in which he claims that two philosophers have abolished the criterion for truth because they equated τὰ ὄντα (existing things) with σκηνογραφίᾳ.... τοῖς τε κατὰ ὕπνους ἢ μανίαν προσπίπτουσι (scene painting and impressions experienced in sleep or madness). One could make an interesting connection between this reference to scene painting and the possible influence of scene-painting upon Second Style wall-painting, with its imitation of the scaenae frons and its illusion of depth. See Beyen (1938) for the idea that Second Style painting had its origins in stage decoration.

[141] Clarke (1991) 51-52.

[142] E.g. Clarke (1991) 50 and Ling (1991) 38.

[143] There are more examples of this phenomenon elsewhere in the House of Livia. In the room adjacent to the so-called tablinum, for example, we see victory-topped vegetal candelabras and floral scrolls with griffins, certainly worthy of being called "dream-like", as a prominent decorative feature.



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details. For, while the vistas in the tablinum are, perhaps, less obviously dream-like, they are no less evocative of the dream experience than their earlier counterparts. Let us keep this sentiment in mind as we turn back to Propertius' dream poems.

I have by now established that the visual quality of Propertius' poetic style is not simply a feature of his shared interest in the subject matter favored by wall-painters; rather it arises from an awareness of the ability of images to mimic or deviate from reality in specific ways. The transition between the Second and Third Styles of wall painting, in which the aesthetic of "breaking through" cedes to the reassertion of the wall's integrity, provides a good context for exploring the shift between exteriority (transforming the wall into a series of vistas) and interiority (focusing the viewer's attention upon a central painted panel), which is also familiar from Propertius' dream poems, particularly 2.26a. As I have already mentioned, the paintings from the so-called tablinum from the House of Livia on the Palatine mark an important point in the transition between styles.

Standing in the tablinum today, the visitor notices on the two preserved walls that each one has its own point of focus, this time a central painted panel housed in an aedicula. As John Clarke observes, " this late Second-Style approach shifted the viewer's attention from the perspective system designed for the whole room to a single axial focus for each wall, with the perspectives resolved on that axis."[144] Thus around the same time that Propertius was composing his elegies, the painters of decorative frescoes were beginning to re-establish the authority of the wall by using it to emphasize

[144] Clarke (1991) 51-52.



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different types of display for figural painting. This is demonstrated by the pinakes in the third register of the wall, which rest between horizontal moldings, and in the large central panels of the aediculae. Rather than simply demarcating individual scenes, the columns in this room support the internal structure of the wall. On the back wall, columns support the entablature of the aedicula; on the lateral wall, columns support the projecting entablature while others in the foreground appear to support the ceiling of the room. Furthermore, large red panels draw attention to the solidity and flatness of the wall itself. In two visible instances, to the right of the aedicula on the back wall and to the left of the aedicula on the lateral wall, the solid red plane of the wall is interrupted by the pinakes. Above these we see the tops of structures looming outside the room. The contrast here is stark, for the pinakes, depicting people engaged in domestic activity and framed by their half-closed shutters, are obviously meant for private internal viewing, while the appearance of a world beyond the room offers a contrasting viewing experience.

Elsewhere in the room, the shift from external viewing to internal viewing is also pronounced; where external architecture is visible, it is made to seem as though glimpsed through an opening in the wall or behind the wall of the room itself, rather than giving the illusion that the wall does not exist. Let us focus on the lateral wall of the room,[145] where the distinctly architectural features of a cityscape are seen through a rectangular opening to the viewer's left. At the far left of the aedicula and almost at the corner of the room, we see a cityscape through and above a rectangular opening. Here

[145] See watercolor by G. Mariani in Rizzo (1936) 16, figure 11.



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we see a view of houses rising vertically; narrow doorways are detailed with door jambs and architraves, while windows, upper stories and balconies also catch the eye. Rizzo likens the scene to a colossal but temporary wooden structure.[146] By contrast with the architectural scenes from cubiculum M at Boscoreale, these scenes feature human figures, thus adding a dimension of realism that was absent from its predecessor. Here we seem to look out onto a world that is oblivious to the activity going on inside the room itself, while at Boscoreale, the vistas created in the room seemed to be for the exclusive delectation of the room's viewer, a sort of stage on which he was invited to "dream" his own relationship to the space. There is a tension between the outwardly disposed view on the left of the wall and the inwardly-oriented pinakes whose shutters facing into the room are almost the mirror opposite of the borders of the rectangular window that give the illusion of perspective onto the buildings outside. This tension is -- to some extent -- resolved by the images in the aediculae,

The pastoral vistas of the mythological scenes featured in the "windows" created by the aediculae are an ambiguous middle ground between the internal and external views.[147] By contrast with the view from the rectangular window, these figures are immediately identifiable as characters from mythology and they occupy the foreground of their scenes. In the scene on the lateral wall, Io, Argus, and Hermes are caught in a moment of triangulated viewership, with Argus staring intently at his charge, Io, and

[146] Rizzo (1936) 21.

[147] See Rizzo (1936) 22-23, where he discusses his belief that these images are meant to be views rather than "paintings" occupying the niches of the aediculae. He includes a brief summary of the history of opinions on this topic.



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Mercury keeping an eye on Argus, soon to be his victim. Even if this is a view through the space carved by the aedicula, it is different from the architectural vistas in that it does not encourage the viewer to multiply the space in his mind. The focus is now upon the dynamic within the scene rather than the contemplation of the scene's extension beyond the room. If the view through the window looks out onto an anonymous scene to which the viewer, if he so desires, can import his own narrative, the scene painted in and framed by the aedicula is meant to be recognized as a familiar narrative. Attention to these images, which is encouraged by their centrality and size, inevitably leads to contemplation of the wall itself as a wall, as the image is framed by features that partake directly of the wall's structure.[148] The focused contemplation that any one of these images would inspire certainly moves away from the illusionistic fantasy of the Boscoreale paintings. Perhaps they inspire reflection rather than projection.

The contrast between the vistas is made explicit by the matching heights of the rectangular window and the top of painted panel, which also complements the tops of the pinakes. This is further accentuated by the complimentary socles below each frame, which serve as borders between the images and the floor. The contrasting subject matter of these vistas mimics the contrast between their modes of representation, as the cityscape is made definitively to seem as though it exists in reality outside of the decorative realm of the room embodied by the delicate pinakes. The mythological

[148] The attention to vision and to Io's metamorphosis into a cow (note the horns on her head) in the image perhaps comments upon the visual features and hybrid creatures which feature elsewhere in the room. Thus the image, while it has a physical function in replicating the experience of looking out of a window, also has a hermeneutic function as a key to viewership in the room's interior.



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panels lie somewhere between the two. By contrast with the cityscape, the mythological panel depicts a world which could not possible exist outside this room, yet it features aspects of the landscape which, as we recall from the back wall of cubiculum M at Boscoreale, were appropriate for the imitation of outdoor space.

Returning to the interplay between interior and exterior space in this room, which replaces the dynamic between urban and rural that was prominent in the Boscoreale room, we can make some analogies to the dream descriptions of Propertius' poems. Subjectivity is a hallmark of the elegiac style.[149] In his dream poems, Propertius emphasizes the subjectivity of the narrator's dream experience through the narrator's intermittent commentary upon what he sees. In poem 2.26a, for example, the first-person account of the dream establishes its subjectivity. But this aspect is expanded as the narrator draws back from the account of the dream in order to comment upon what he has seen. This is at its most blatant in the phrases in which the narrator interjects his own opinion (however tentatively) with a first person verb, such as *puto* in 2.26a.18.[150] These asides serve as signposts of the shift between the dreamer's description of the dream as though it is playing out before him and his preliminary interpretation of its symbolism. This dichotomy plays upon the difference between the dream as a reflection of the dreamer's individual situation and the possibility that it was implanted into his mind externally. Thus the transition between the narrator's description of the dream's

[149] Grüner (2004) chapter 4.1 discusses elegiac subjectivity and wall-painting of the late Second - Third Styles in connection with the mythological panels. He traces the evolution from 'Illusionsarchitektur' to 'Illusionsperson', 216, claiming that the elegiac 'Ich' projects himself onto the characters (often lovers) in the painted panels.

[150] Cf. the function of *ut reor* in 3.3.38.



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events, his commentary upon the dream via mythological analogy, and his interjections of opinion all contribute to a shifting perspective within the scope of poem 2.26a. This structure contributes to the dream's dream-like quality in the retelling. As the poet relies upon the shift between the dreamer's interior perspective on his dream's narrative and the viewer's external perspective upon the dream's events to create incoherence in his dream poems, the painters of the transitional period, whose painted "views" to the space outside the room compete with centralized panel paintings that mediate between internal and external space are decidedly dream-like. This is manifested by their illusionism, their dimension of fantasy, and their shift between the view outward and the view inward, which acknowledges the fundamental paradox of dreaming.

Artistic illusionism is apparent in both the Second Style and the Third Styles of wall painting, and its different modes are captured by the imagery of the period of transition between the two. As I hope I have shown, the interplay between illusionism and incoherence is a feature of Propertius' dream poems. I do not aim to forge a connection between the attitudes of Propertius and Vitruvius towards painting, but rather to show that both Propertius and Vitruvius are aware of the potential for distortion and incoherence inherent in painted representation, which in Vitruvius' account results from the artist's willful abstraction of reality. Propertius, on the other hand, armed with an awareness of this phenomenon and undoubtedly also familiar with numerous examples of wall painting, imbues his dream poems with an artistic sensibility.

Poems 2.26a and 3.3, although they share certain features, represent different types of dream experience. In poem 3.3, Propertius presents a more objective



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perspective on the dream experience by making clear that it is a visitation-dream with a message for the dreamer and by connecting the experience to the inspiration of the narrator's literary predecessors. Conversely, the dream of 2.26a is more psychological and reflective of the personal situation of the narrator. These differences are reflected in other discourses form antiquity. For example, they conform to the categories proposed by Artemidorus in his *Oneirocritica* of the second century A.D. According to his dream-rubrics of *oneiros* and *enhypnion*, where the former "indicates a future state of affairs, while the other indicates a present state of affairs."[151] Where the former extends outward and forward, the latter turns inward and is contained by the moment. Another way of understanding the difference between the types of dreams reported in poems 2.26a and 3.3 comes from mapping this difference onto the changes we observe in the styles of Roman wall-painting in the first century B.C., and comparing the experience of viewership in each case. These differences, as I hope to have shown, have parallels in the external perspective and internal focus of the rooms decorated in the two phases of the Second Style.

The observations above may lead us to some conclusions about why actual dreams are seldom represented in the visual arts. It is certainly not the case that artists lacked the means or ability to represent such imagery. Dream-like images such as hybrid forms and modes of representation such as illusionism, all of which share certain features of the dream experience were the common currency of wall-painting of the

[151] Translation, R. White (1975). See Artemidorus *Oneirocritica*, Book 1, sections 1-2, for further definition of these categories.



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second half of the first century B.C. In fact, some of the tension inherent in relaying the dreamer's memory of a dream, which lies in the shift between narration of and commentary upon the dream, has parallels in the delicate calibration of external views and internal space as depicted upon the walls of houses painted with the styles of this period. Thus perhaps the mechanism of the dream and its ability to seem real to the dreamer viewing it had particular resonance for the painter who sought to achieve the same experience for the viewer of his illusionistic paintings. In the next chapter, I will return to the curious lack of representation of actual dreams, when I take up the popularity of the representation of sleeping figures in the visual arts as a possible answer to this question. I now turn to the final dream of Propertius' corpus.

**Cynthia as revenant: poem 4.7**

No study of dreams in Propertius' poems would be complete without some discussion of poem 4.7, in which Cynthia appears at the bedside of the narrator as an indignant ghost with stories to tell. Rather than recount or summarize her speech in retrospect, Propertius cedes the role of first-person narrator to Cynthia, who leads the reader through accusations, reminiscences, apologies, defenses, and predictions before disappearing out of sight. The poet's sole action in this poem comes not in the context of the dream, but, rather after the dream has vanished. For the duration of the dream it seems as though the poet is frozen; it is only when he has emerged from his reverie that he is able to spring to action as he attempts to embrace the insubstantial ghost (lines 95-96). The rest of the dream presents itself as a nexus, uniting memory, the circumstances of the present, and an enforced vision of the future. Although this poem is structurally



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quite different from the others treated at length in the first part of this chapter, consideration of the dream of 4.7 as a visual experience enhances the discussion of visuality in Propertius' dream poems.[152]

Whereas the external setting for the narrator's experience of his dreams in 2.26a and 3.3 does not feature in either poem's structure, thereby giving prominence to the images and the landscapes of the dream itself, the reader learns at the beginning of 4.7 that the action of the poem unfolds at night while the narrator lies in bed. The description of the bed and what it symbolizes of the lovers' relationship is an important precedent for the narration of the dream. While in poem 3.3, the narrator begins by recounting how he has seen himself in the context of a dream, in 4.7 he recounts the vision of Cynthia at his bedside (*meo fulcro,* line 3). By providing a physical location for the vision, the narrator foreshadows the poem's mix of concrete and ethereal elements.[153] The episode depicted in poem 4.7 is more akin to the epic visitation dream -- one might think of the encounter between Achilles and the ghost of Patroclus in *Iliad* book 23.66 ff.[154] or Aeneas and the ghosts of Hector and Creusa in *Aeneid* book 2[155] as

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[152] Major studies of this poem include those of Warden (1980), Papanghelis (1987) ch. 8, Dimundo (1990), Janan (2001) ch. 6, Walde (2001) section 2.2.3. Analyses of this poem tend to focus upon Cynthia's words and their implications for the poet's characterization of their relationship in the earlier elegies, rather than upon the structure of the poem as a dream or dream-like experience.

[153] 4.7 is a poem of apparent contrasts, some of which are challenged within the context of the poem. The most prominent, that between the living and the dead, which is, of course, blurred by the apparent animation of the dead figure, has parallels in other polarities: dreaming/dreamed, mute/speaking, bodily/immaterial, seeing/seen, forgetfulness/memory, present/past, and cold/warm. This last pair presents another inversion: we learn that the living sleeper is cold (*lecti frigida regna mei,* line 6), while the dead Cynthia still displays markings from the warmth of the pyre (*...lateri vestis adusta fuit, / et solitum digito beryllon adederat ignis,* lines 8-9).

[154] See Walde (2001) 251 for discussion of the parallels between these dream scenes.



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important precedents -- and this feature distinguishes it from the earlier poems. But the dream episode of poem 4.7 does share certain features with its predecessors. Poem 4.7 recalls poem 2.26a in that both poems present Cynthia physically altered and showing signs of physical suffering. In both poems she speaks, although her words are reported in 2.26a, and presented as direct quotation in 4.7. One could call poem 3.3 a visitation dream because the narrator describes in it a visit (and a speech) from Apollo, which is also described as an intrusion upon the dreamer's activity, in this case, preparing to drink from the Hippocrene.[156] But the initiation dream of 3.3, because it is set in a fantastic realm and involves the narrator's participation so integrally, seems as much like the scene from 2.26a as it does the verbal tirade from 4.7.

*video* and *videor:* "seeing" a dream

One can outline the distinctions between Propertius' dream poems by studying the use of the verb *video* in each poem. Poem 2.26a opens with the verb *vidi,* which is, as I have already mentioned, potentially misleading, for, until the reader sees that it is qualified by the phrase *in somnis,* it is unclear that the narrator is describing a dream.

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[155] See Allison (1980) for discussion of the Virgilian precedents for the dream-visit of 4.7.

[156] The vocative *Properti* in line 49 reminds us of Apollo's injunction against Propertius' drinking from the wrong stream in 3.3, line 17. As Warden (1980) 122-23 n. 4 notes, Propertius' "name occurs on seven other occasions in his poetry. Each of these passages has something solemn or formal or 'public' about it." The proper noun is used in the vocative case in two other contexts that have thematic connections to poem 4.7. In 2.8.17 the narrator addresses himself in the context of imagining his own funeral. He envisions Cynthia vandalizing his grave (in a manner similar to the disrespect she claims from him in 4.7) and he alludes to the double suicide of Haemon and Antigone, whose bones mix in a way recalled by Cynthia's prediction of the similar mingling of her bones and Propertius' after his death. In 2.24.35 we get closer to the example of 4.7 because Propertius' name is uttered by Cynthia herself, albeit filtered through the narrator's imagination of his own funeral. Contrast this with Cynthia's garbled, inaudible cry for help in 2.26a.12, in which she apparently invoked the narrator's name. This is only reported, however, with no quotation either direct or indirect of the specific words.



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But this choice is also of interest because it differs from the usual phrasing for the description of a dream, the passive form of the verb *video*. Both 3.3 and 4.7 use the passive of *video* to describe the scenes which they see in their sleep. In 3.3 the narrator recalls seeing himself at the outset of his description, *visus eram...recubans* (line 1). This description informs the reader that the narrator was himself a participant in the dream while it also prepares the reader for the narrator's retelling of his interaction with Apollo, who first spies the narrator as he has described himself lying beside the Hippocrene.

In poem 4.7, where the narrator recounts that *Cynthia visast incumbere,* the passive use of the verb has a different effect. Here it conveys the dreamer's sense of uncertainty about trusting what he is seeing, and it establishes the externality of the vision itself. Cynthia both "appears" to him and "seems" to lean over his bed.[157] Therefore he establishes the experience he is about to describe as visual while isolating the appearance of Cynthia's ghost as a vision with an external origin. His interaction with the ghost of Cynthia will be limited to his initial vision of her and his final attempt to defy what he knows as limited to the visual -- his endeavor to embrace her in the

[157] In his comparison of the use of *visa* in poems 1.3, 2.29b, and 4.7, Warden (1980) 76 describes the bivalence of this form as it evokes both the narrator's subjective reaction and his objective description in 4.7 as follows, "the *visa est* which in 1.3 and 2.29b refers to the poet's subjective reaction here refers to the event itself. There is no description of the poet's subjective reaction, no probing of his emotions as in 1.3.11 ff. or (briefly) in 2.29b.30. And yet in a sense the *visa est* subjectivizes the entire narrative; it is all at one level the projection of the emotions of the sleeping poet; the dream is as much an illusion as the tender imaginings of the poet in 1.3.21 ff." Poem 1.3 will be analyzed in detail in the subsequent chapter, where the similarity between 1.3 and 2.29b and the significance of *visa est* to connote a dream or dream-like experience will also be discussed.



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poem's final couplet. This visualization of Cynthia serves to support his initial statement about the existence of ghosts of the dead.[158]

The difference between the two voices of the verb is well-illustrated by a passage from Cicero's *Academica* (II.51-52), in which one speaker claims that the distinction between describing reality and something witnessed in a dream can be seen in the choice of the passive form of *video*. He uses Ennius as an example, thus preserving the evidence for Ennius' dream-vision of Homer:

> Quis enim, cum sibi fingit aliquid et cogitatione depingit, non simul ac se ipse commovit atque ad se revocavit sentit quid intersit inter perspicua et inania? Eadem ratio est somniorum. Num censes Ennium cum in hortis cum Servio Galba vicino suo ambulavisset dixisse: 'Visus sum mihi cum Galba ambulare'? At cum somniavit, ita narravit: *visus homerus adesse poeta*
> Idem in Epicharmo: *Nam videbar somniare med ego esse mortuom*
> Itaque simul ut experecti sumus visa illa contemnimus neque ita habemus ut ea quae in foro gessimus.
> 52. "at enim dum **videntur** eadem est in somnis species eorumque quae vigilantes **videmus**!"
>
> For who, when he creates something for himself and paints this in his imagination, does not, right when he snaps himself out of it and recalls himself, perceive the difference between clear and illusory visions? The same reasoning applies to dreams. Do you believe that Ennius, when he had been for a walk with his neighbor Servius Galba, said: "I seemed (appeared) to walk with Galba."? However, when he had a dream, he described it as follows: "The poet Homer seemed to stand beside me." The same is true for the *Epicharmus*: "For I seemed (appeared) to dream that I myself was dead." And thus as soon as we wake up, we disparage those visions and we do not equate them with the things we have done in the forum.
> 52. (Response): But while they are being seen in dreams, the appearance of these images is the same as those we see while we are awake.[159]

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[158] Papanghelis (1987) 149 writes, "she [Cynthia] enters the poem in order to confirm the possibility envisioned in the opening couplet and takes her position on the borderline of Propertius' consciousness". The fact that she is a ghost establishes her externalization, thus making it more believable that she would enter his dream independently, rather than be conjured by his imagination.

[159] Translation my own, after Rackham (1933).



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According to the speaker's reasoning, Ennius would not describe what he had experienced earlier in terms of something seen; he would not need to qualify the experience as visual, as he is certain that it has actually occurred.[160] The use of the verb *video* then seems to serve two functions. On the one hand, it connotes a sense of uncertainty or even mistrust of the authenticity of the event (after all, this does follow a discussion of the difference between *perspicua* and *inania);* on the other it reinforces the notion that the person describing the event is the passive recipient of the visual information. Active seeing is distinct from passive seeing in the sense that it is used to describe what the speaker trusts has actually happened; because one cannot *really* have seen himself dead or have been visited by Homer, himself long deceased, one must qualify the experience by claiming that something seemed to have happened -- an assertion that can only be made upon returning to one's rational perspective, in this case, by waking.[161] In the second quotation, from the *Epicharmus*, the experience is at twice the distance from the dreamer's rational mind: the dubious experience implied by *somniare* is further called into question by the use of *videbar;* it is not simply that the

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[160] This distinction is reinforced in the final line of section 52, where seeing (contained in the participle *visa)* is contrasted with doing (*gessimus).* Thus the opposition between vision and action reflects that between untrustworthy and reliable experience.

[161] There is a clear example of this usage in Ovid *Metamorphoses* 9.687-88. In this passage, Ovid recounts Telethusa's dream-vision of Isis as follows: *Inachis ante torum, pompa comitata suorum, / aut stetit aut visa est...* The distinction between the active *stetit* and the passive *visa est* makes apparent the diffculty in distinguishing between vision and dream, what is happening and what seems to happen. This ambiguity is reinforced later when Isis begins to speak. The goddess addresses the sleeping Telethusa, who is described as *tum velut excussam somno et manifesta videntem* (line 695). The active form of the participle (*videntem)* is used to express the act of seeing as though awake; that is, without the ambiguity of something seen in a dream.



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dreamer dreamt something, but that he appears to have dreamt it, so that he is not even sure of the actual act of dreaming.

The predicted response given in section 52 is also revealing of the difference between the usages of the active and passive voices. The subordinate clause *dum videntur* contrasts with the relative clause *quae vigilantes videmus* while they share the implied subject *visa*. Although the dreamer will claim that, when he was experiencing them, the visions appeared the same as they would to someone awake, the verbs with which he chooses to point out this difference are telling of the way in which visual phenomena are experienced. In the first instance, they occur to the viewer/dreamer (the phrase *dum videntur* actually indicates the duration of the dream, as though the whole experience of dreaming is one of extended passive viewership) while in the second they are the objects of his active vision (*videmus*). Thus passive and active forms distinguish between the realms in which the visions are seen as well as how they are to be understood after the experience. Furthermore, there is a distinction which hinges upon the word *species*. It is the *appearance* of the things seen in dreams that seems the same as what one might see while awake and actually experiencing them. This experience, however, is not something the dreamer can recreate after he has woken up; rather, he can only recall the feeling of being convinced of the realistic appearance of his dream's images. Therefore, the use of the passive also conveys the dreamer's utter conviction that what he is experiencing and seeing in his sleep is real; the dreamer has no control over the images before him, nor does he have any sense that they are false. For this reason, the narrator's declaration that he saw Cynthia in his dreams in the active voice



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(*vidi te in somnis*...2.26a.1) is so striking, for he draws attention, albeit from the perspective of one awake, to the fact that while he was dreaming, what he saw and experienced seemed to him real. The use of the active form of the verb reminds the reader of the power of a dreamer's indelible conviction about what he has seen.

The lover's dream-vision

Most commentators agree that 4.7 is emblematic of the relationship between the narrator and Cynthia.[162] Cynthia's speech encapsulates the volatile passion and distrust that the lovers have endured in their relationship, to which the reader has borne witness in the earlier books of the elegies.[163] Thus some have seen a continuity across the boundary of death: even from beyond the grave Cynthia still has the same complaints as she did when alive. More recent readings see a continuity between Cynthia as a metaphor for the poet's poetic material in the earlier poems and the reappearance of this in her role as a revenant.[164] Barbara Flaschenriem abstracts the ghost of Cynthia specifically to signify "the existence of an autonomous, though largely unrepresented,

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[162] See Warden (1980) 78-81 for a summary of some biographical approaches.

[163] Griffin (1985) 159-60 observes "their union will differ from that of the model married couple in death, exactly as it differed in life." Richardson (1977) 454 warns, however, that poem 4.7 "tells us a number of things about Cynthia we are not told elsewhere, some of which are sharply at variance with other things we have been told." Looking at its function within its book alone, Janan (2001) 104 claims that "[elegy 4.7] serves, in fact, a pivotal summarizing function for all of book IV."

[164] Papanghelis (1987) 149 calls Cynthia the "visual 'embodiment' as well as the exponent of the poem's aesthetics", thereby seeing a connection between her base, disfigured form and the coarseness of her words. Dimundo (1990) 45 characterizes the appearance of Cynthia as a material metaphor for Propertius' poetic aspirations: "l'apparizione della *puella* si configurebbe come una materializzazione delle aspirazioni di Properzio." Walde (2001) 250 ff. reads Cynthia as the ghost of his poetic subject matter and its inspiration. She sees the dream as a confrontation between the poet and his own literary creation.



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female point of view" come to haunt the poet.[165] This kind of analysis has rendered the traditional biographical interpretation of the poem obsolete, thus diminishing the need to reconcile the death of Cynthia in 4.7 with her obvious and jarring vitality in the poem that follows. So, rather than attempt to contextualize 4.7 within the body of book 4, I will focus on two specific features of the poem: Cynthia's externality in this poem and the dynamic between dreamer and dreamed subject. In 4.7 Propertius alters the dream's subjective expression by externalizing the figure of the dream itself.

The first couplet of the poem, lines 1-2, establishes the existence of Cynthia outside of the imagination of the dreaming narrator. She is defined as a ghost and a shade, *Manes* first and *umbra* second; only in line 3, when she "appears," does she become a visitor to a dream. Her deft escape from the consumption of the pyre is no less impressive than her ability to enter the room and the dream of her sleeping former lover; she may be immaterial but she is still physical. The connection between the dead and the realm of dreams is made explicit by the juxtaposition of the subjects of lines 2 and 3 (*umbra* and *Cynthia,* respectively). The function of *visast,* as discussed above, is significant here, for it identifies Cynthia as visible and immediately alerts the reader to the onset of a dream description.[166] The meaning of the infinitive *incumbere* underscores the implied hesitancy of *visast.* Cynthia is neither standing in defiance of nor lying

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[165] Flaschenriem (1998) 63.

[166] Warden (1996) 119 refers to the detailed description of Cynthia's appearance in lines 3-12 as "an 'ecphrasis,' a self-contained passage of description". The ekphrastic static vision of Cynthia charred and scarred from the funeral rites reminds the reader of a description of a work of art; this association is encouraged by the poet's use of the verb *visast.* At this point, the reader might assume that this dream will include the elements familiar from the earlier poems. After this point, however, the form of the poem changes as description gives way to direct speech.



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beside the prone narrator. She appears to perform an action that only a vision is capable of, to lean without physically oppressing, to hover visibly above without intruding upon the space of the sleeper. Either Cynthia has arrived at his bedside to prevent him from succumbing to sleep's complacency, or she is there to wrest him from it. Either way, she is both dependent upon sleep's power to immobilize the narrator and determined to subvert the usual effects of a restful sleep. The verb *incumbere* also contrasts forcefully with the participle *humata* which appears in the following line to inform the reader of what has actually happened to her physical body -- recently placed below the earth, she is now inclining above it not bound by weight.

Moving down to line 5, we can compare *incumbere* and *penderet,* which appears in the same position as the infinitive two lines below. While the ghost of Cynthia is observed leaning in over the sleeper, somnus itself, the very force which should exert itself over this scene, has a tentative presence.[167] What exactly does *cum mihi somnus ab exsequiis penderet amoris* mean?[168] However one interprets the *cum* clause, it is obvious that the line implies, at least, a disturbed sleep. If the narrator is not actually sleeping, exhaustion is near enough that he is off-guard and vulnerable to the ghost's visit. Let us

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[167] Cf. lines 17-18, *per quam demisso quotiens tibi fune pependi, / alterna veniens in tua colla manu!* In this instance, Cynthia describes herself as "suspended" above the narrator, about to lower herself to him. Here we get the sense of both physical tentativeness and erotic teasing as we appreciate the emphasis upon the anticipation between the lovers and their physical distance as they are about to meet.

[168] If we compare the almost contemporaneous translations of Papanghelis (1987) 149 and Goold (1990) 357, we get different senses for the meaning of the *cum* clause. Papanghelis renders the line as follows, "while sleep for me was hung up on love's funeral..."; Goold understands, "when after my love's interment sleep hovered over me..." Both translations convey the idea that sleep is not performing its expected role, that of making contact with the sleeper and putting him to sleep. Richardson (1977) 456 translates the clause as follows, "when sleep for me hung upon the funeral of love..." He claims that Propertius is deliberately ambiguous about whether or not the narrator is dreaming of the funeral, or whether thoughts of the funeral are keeping him from sleeping (and dreaming).



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compare the role of sleep in an earlier poem. In poem 1.10 (discussed in chapter 4) the narrator describes himself excitedly staving off sleep, despite the fact that sleep is pressing upon his drooping eyes (*quamvis labentis premeret mihi somnus ocellos,* line 7). This indicates a physical connection between sleep and sleeper, in which the process of falling asleep is described in terms of sleep enacting its power over the sleeper through interference with the sleeper's body. If sleep eludes the narrator, then, as a result of his insomnia, Cynthia is able to appear as a vision in lieu of sleep, as a dream would to a sleeper. The switch from *visast incumbere,* which describes Cynthia's action, to *penderet,* which describes the narrator's pre-existing condition, is significant in that it shows the reader the circumstances under which sleep's distance is replaced by Cynthia's proximity. This ambiguity about the narrator's state of sleep and Cynthia's role as a dream distinguishes this poem from the dreams in 2.26a and 3.3.

Regardless of the ambiguity surrounding the circumstances of the narrator's sleep, the use of *visast,* the familiar signal for a dream narration, demonstrates that the narrator retells this experience as though it were a dream. A few lines later, the reader is given another indication that the narrator actually sleeps in the form of Cynthia's accusation of the narrator losing himself in forgetful sleep in line 14 (*in te iam vires somnus habere potest?).* Considering the implications of *somnus penderet* for sleep's tenuous power over the sleeper, this question has an ironic tone; it is Cynthia, rather, who will hold him in her grip as the night wears on. The questions in lines 13-16 clearly imply a connection between sleep and forgetfulness, by emphasizing the short amount of time that has elapsed between the end of their affair and his new dalliances, her funeral



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and her appearance at his bedside, his falling asleep and her arrival.[169] The accusation of sleep is here as much meant to draw attention to the lover's inattentive forgetfulness as it is to rouse him from slumber.

Just as Cynthia's accusation of sleep diminishes some of the ambiguity of the narrator's actual state, Cynthia towards the end of the poem adds further definition to the experience as she declares herself a dream. Just as her appearance as a dream followed upon a description of her recent burial at the poem's beginning (lines 1-5), her self-definition as a dream comes at the poem's end, just after she has described her epitaph. The inscription she envisions on the pillar to be erected above her tomb reads *hic Tiburtina iacet aurea Cynthia terra:/ accessit ripae laus, Aniene, tuae* (lines 85-86). In addition to vaunting Cynthia's worth and restoring her dignity, the very thing she feels Propertius has begrudged her, the epitaph emphasizes the physical distance of Cynthia's burial place from Rome. Furthermore, it draws attention to her immobility *(iacet)* and it locates her physically beneath the earth. Both of these features make the contrast with her presence in Propertius' dream significant, for, as a ghost she is entirely mobile and, as a dream, although she issues forth from a specific point, she is equally free from physical constraints. In a manner reminiscent of Cynthia's warning of sleep's power to make a sleeper forget (*in te iam vires somnus habere potest?,* line 14), Cynthia threatens Propertius with the power of a dream -- in this case both to remind the dreamer of the past which he is on the verge of forgetting, and also to hint at the future which awaits

[169] The contrast between wakefulness and sleep is further emphasized by the opposition between sleep's power over him now and the restlessness of their love-making in the past, transferred to the Subura itself in the phrase *vigilacis Suburae* (line 15).



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him after his own death. With the lines *nec tu sperne piis venientia somnia portis: / cum pia venerunt somnia, pondus habent* (lines 87-88), Cynthia underscores the importance of everything she has already said to the paralyzed Propertius and adds austerity to what she is about to say in lines 93-94, where she predicts the mingling of their bones after death, thus belittling his current romantic liaisons.[170] By commenting upon her own nature as a dream, Cynthia, the dreamed figure, self-reflexively calls attention to the fact that she is not real. She thereby challenges the utterly realistic portrait of her physical features at the poem's beginning and the detailed description of her death, funeral, and burial, which occupy the rest of the poem's body, and thus undermines the illusion of her power.

But the dichotomy between Cynthia's insubstantiality and the impact of her presence is underscored by her ironic choice of words to describe the importance of such dreams: despite their lack of physical constraint, they have weight (*pondus habent,* line 88). The word *pondus* implies both physical weight and the gravity of a spoken message.[171] A dream figure insisting on its own reality is an interesting foreshadowing of the sleeper's own credulity about the physical substance of the dreamed image. And

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[170] Numerous commentators have drawn attention to this line as reflective of Homer's *Odyssey* 19.562 ff. and Virgil's *Aeneid* 6.894 ff. Goold (1990) 363 writes that, in spite of the echoes, "Propertius signifies only that Cynthia abides with the righteous." Of course the concept of the *piis portis* is distinctly Propertian, but the notion that the type of dream is connected to its place of issuance has its precedent in the earlier passages. I think that this reference also includes a meditation upon the possible deception of dreams. Why should this dreamer believe the dream's own self-characterization? A dream's announcement of its own trustworthiness is the ultimate manifestation of a dream's deception. Perhaps this passage reinforces the dreamer's inability to identify the illusionism of a dream while he is dreaming it.

[171] Cf. *OLD* sub-section 6 for *pondus:* 6a) "claim to consideration, importance, value, weight, influence, etc. 6b) Claim to belief, authority, convincingness." Propertius 4.7.88 is cited in support of this definition.



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indeed, the figure's insistence upon its *pondus* looks forward to the narrator's final gesture of the poem. At the end of the poem, the dreamer, will try to embrace the dream the moment that she stops talking, as though her existence before him is specifically connected to her speech (*haec postquam querula mecum sub lite peregit, / inter complexus excidit umbra meos,* lines 95-96). Thus it seems that her claim to have weight has eclipsed her obvious insubstantiality as a dream-vision.

In their analyses of Cynthia's imagined epitaph, both John Warden and Barbara Flaschenriem emphasize the way in which the words of the epitaph are metaphorical for the words of Propertius' poetry: both feature Cynthia as their subjects, and both become the property of the public domain through a sort of publication and circulation.[172] We might say the same about Cynthia's existence as a ghostly visitor in Propertius' dream, for here she is the physical instantiation of the poet's creation with "an existence independent of her creator," to use Flaschenriem's term. Cynthia's imagination and articulation of her own epitaph, which is to contain no mention of her connection to Propertius, is similar to her self-definition as a dream with an origin and place of residence outside of the poet's mind. This is not the dreamed Cynthia of poem 2.26a, nor the divine visitor to the narrator's dream of himself in 3.3. Rather this is Cynthia as author and as self-conscious dream-image. The internal dream image familiar from 2.26a has now, in 4.7, become externalized in a way that mirrors the poet's relinquishment of control over the very poetic material towards which Apollo steered him in the oneiric initiation of poem 3.3.

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[172] Warden (1980) 56, Flaschenriem (1998) 61.



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In this chapter I have tried to account for the different ways that the dreamer in Propertius' dream poems experiences his dream as a viewer. Poem 4.7 differs from those discussed earlier in that it presents the dream as a phenomenon external to the sleeper, an image from which the dreamer is to some extent alienated. In his analysis of 4.7, Jasper Griffin observed that "an angry and eloquent Cynthia awaits him [Propertius], filled with grievances as she was in life (the end of 1.3 shows programmatically that their relationship was always to be like that)."[173] A comparison between these particular poems, however, should stretch beyond the similarities in Cynthia's speech and temperament. Poems 1.3 and 4.7 form a ring composition for the confrontation between the lover as viewer and his mistress as an externalized vision. In the chapter that follows I will return to the first book from the last, effectively removing the parentheses from Griffin's statement, in order to show how poem 1.3 is programmatic for certain aspects of the dream poems just discussed. I will leave behind explicit dream narratives for a discussion of sleep in the absence of dreams. This does not mean, however, that dreams will not form an important part of the subsequent material; rather, in the pages which follow, I turn my attention to the sleeping figure, as observed from the outside, and the viewer's curiosity about and imagination of the sleeper's dreams.

[173] Griffin (1985) 159.



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# Chapter 2 : The Sleeper

How can one speak of a sleeping body?
What power can we give language to express
something that is apparently powerless?
-Louis Marin, "Awakening Metamorphoses" (1999)

## Introduction: Sleeper's Dream / Viewer's Image

In his recent work on viewership in Hellenistic poetry and art, Graham Zanker compares issues of viewership in both contexts.[174] He both mines literary ekphraseis for their clues to expected modes of viewing works of art and also interprets works of sculpture in terms of the visual cues that artists incorporate into them. One of his central concerns in comparing viewership in both art and text is the work that the reader or viewer (whether internal to the context of the representation or external to it) must do to extrapolate narrative from the images he sees. My study is akin to Zanker's in that it takes into account both textual and artistic representation in an attempt to establish some commonalities between them which shed light on larger cultural ideas about viewership. In dealing exclusively with the representation of sleepers, moreover, it concentrates upon a type to which narrative must by necessity be applied, for the sleeping figures themselves are opaque, motionless, and reticent about themselves. The viewer of these figures, reassured that the sleeper (unlike a dead person) will wake up and transform from passive to active, imagines the internal world of the sleeper's dream and imports an

[174] Zanker (2004). He describes the value of taking into account literary descriptions of viewing in his analysis of viewership in Hellenistic art as follows in his analysis on the ekphrasis in Theocritus' *Idyll* 1, "his [the narrator's] description puts into words modes of viewing, expectations, and responses which cannot be expressed anywhere near so directly in actual representational art, and thus helps us define certain Hellenistic viewing practices with a precision that is not otherwise open to us" 16. Thus Zanker's work sets a precedent for considering in close connection viewership as it is expressed in text and implied in art and for allowing each to inform the interpretation of the other.



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identity to the sleeper which can reflect the viewer's fantasy as much as the sleeper's reality.

Many assessments of Propertius 1.3 characterize the narrator's interaction with his sleeping lover as a dream-like experience. Undoubtedly some of the similarity can be attributed to the narrator's drunkenness (*talis visa mihi...Cynthia...ebria cum multo traherem vestigia Baccho,* lines 7-9); nevertheless, when Daniel Harmon writes in his analysis of these lines that the drunken Propertius "is overcome by a seizure of hyper-imagination,"[175] or S. J. Harrison, also interested in the narrator's state of inebriation, describes the narrator's "irrationally fearful mind,"[176] they could just as easily be commenting upon the altered perception of a dreamer. Cicero, as we know from the *Academica,* for example, considered the mental state of the dreamer similar to that of a drunk person.[177] The similarity between the states of dreaming and drunkenness lies in their distortion of perception. This distortion, particularly evident in the narrator's perception of boundaries between himself and his sleeping girlfriend in poem 1.3, manifests itself in two ways: first in his analogies between Cynthia and various sleeping mythological characters (lines 1-6), and second, in his attempts to manipulate Cynthia in her sleep (lines 21-26). While it is not the explicit aim of the commentators cited above to compare the drunken narrator to a dreamer, the analogy between the two is further

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[175] Harmon (1974) 153.

[176] Harrison (1994) 20.

[177] Cicero *Academica* 2.51, where he also includes the insane among those with distorted perception (*omnium deinde inanium visorum una depulsio est, sive illa cogitatione informantur, quod fieri solere concedimus, sive in quiete sive per vinum sive per insaniam).* See also Lucretius book 3.1045-1052 for a comparison between one living in a dream state and one in a drunken stupor.



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supported by the similarities between the structure and technique of this poem and 2.26a, for example, in which the poet describes the contents of a dream. In each instance, the poem's narrator recounts and comments upon a visual experience through analogies to mythological tales which bear some resemblance to artistic representations of these scenes.[178] By making these connections to artistic representation in both poems, regardless of whether the context of viewing is the dreamscape or the bedroom, Propertius draws attention to the importance of visual perception to his poetics.

The poet's attention to the visual in 1.3 is confirmed by the use of the passive form of the verb *video* in line 7 to mark the transition between the narrator's use of analogy and the description of his experience (*talis visa mihi mollem spirare quietem / Cynthia consertis nixa caput minibus*, lines 7-8). As was the case with his dream-vision of Cynthia in 4.7 (*visast incumbere*, line 3) or his dream of himself in 3.3 (*visus eram...recubans*, line 1), here, too, the narrator describes his first encounter with the

[178] This device, which enables the narrator to slip between participation in the dream and observation of its events in 2.26a, is also featured in 1.3, where the observations/commentary precede the narrator's interaction with his lover in the structure of the poem, but seem to have implications for both Cynthia's appearance to him and his role as a participant in the narrative to which he alludes. Poem 1.3 could be read, in fact, as an intersection of the two dream-representations of Cynthia: in 2.26a, the narrator observes her silent in a dream; in 4.7, she visits and speaks to the narrator in his dream. Although in 2.26a the narrator recounts the experience after *he* has woken up, while in 1.3 he recounts his memories after *Cynthia* has woken up, the effects of the comparisons are similar. In comparing poems 1.3 and 2.26 (which he reads as an entire poem of 58 lines), Benediktson (1989) 100 appeals to Pound's notion of "superposition of narrative on image" to explain the phenomena we see at work in both poems. In both cases, he argues, the poems' second halves (narrative) comment upon the first halves which contain the references to mythological exempla (image). But I would argue that there is an equal amount of image applied to the narrative, and that, just as a dream requires commentary in order to explain it, references to painted myths provide a certain amount of explication of the intangible feelings and visions one has in a dream.



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sleeping Cynthia as an experience of sight.[179] The meaning of *visa est* in poem 1.3 is ambiguous; it could mean simply that Cynthia sleeping appeared to him in the sense that she "seemed to" him thus *(talis)* as the aforementioned sleeping women *(qualis)* would, rather than referring to the situation of his own dream, in which a figure might "appear" suddenly. But the point of similarity with the dream poems is that the experience is described as visual and is retold with some detachment, as though the narrator were not entirely in control of his vision.[180]

The point in 1.3 at which the narrator looks at his sleeping girlfriend and imagines the content of her dream (lines 27-30) is particularly important for my reading of the poem in connection with dreaming. Archibald Allen describes this moment as a "subordination of feeling," which the viewer feels with the viewed subject and which results in identification of feeling between the two. Allen articulates this transition, furthermore, as one in which the narrator "has passed from the place of present reality and has become a figure in a dream, an unsubstantial shadow."[181] This episode, I will

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[179] Furthermore, in each of the examples discussed in the previous section, the vision involves seeing a figure who is reclining (3.3) or hovering (4.7); in both cases the figure is immobile. cf. *Cynthia...nixa* in line 8 of 1.3.

[180] Recall Cicero's *Academica* 2.52 (discussed in chapter 1) for the use of *videor* for dream descriptions and *video* for actual sight. The active *vidi* of 2.26a.1, where the narrator is both in active control of his vision and sees the dreamed image of Cynthia in motion (*...ducere rore manus... ),* provides a contrast.

[181] Allen (1962) 133. In his discussion of the moment of the narrator's curiosity about Cynthia's dream, Harrison (1994) 22 contends that "this thought is stimulated by nothing in particular, and is presented as lying at the back of the poet's mind as a possibility in the real world." This, of course, serves his argument about the comic features of the poem, namely the allusions to Cynthia's infidelity which he detects throughout the poem. I disagree, however, and would argue that the events of the poem up to this point present this as the inevitable result of his curiosity. The narrator's inquisitive interaction with the sleeping figure, as I shall discuss below, is consistently thwarted by his realization that she is entirely unfamiliar to him in the isolation of sleep.



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argue, is one that is very informative about the interaction between the viewer and a sleeping figure. As is apparent from Allen's observation, it is unclear at this point in the poem which figure is dreaming, and whose dream (his lover's or his own) the narrator inhabits as a shadow. Curiosity about what a sleeper is dreaming, and the attempt to access the sleeper's dreams is one of the key features of interaction between a waking viewer and a sleeping figure; this is valid for representation in both artistic and poetic contexts. In the three sections of this chapter, I will explore how Propertius describes this curiosity in 1.3, and how Hellenistic and Roman artists prompt it through their compositions.

Concentrating in the first section upon Propertius poem 1.3, I extend my discussion of the difference between internal and external perspectives by analyzing the waking viewer's confrontation with the detachment of the sleeper. Thus I deal more with the sleeper's inaccessibility than with the sleeper's explication of his experience. I also suggest a method for using the dynamic of interaction between the narrator and his sleeping girlfriend in the poem as a template for understanding this dynamic in other contexts. In the second section, I explore the interaction between the live viewer and solitary sculpted sleeping figures, such as the hermaphrodite, in the absence of explicit narrative content. The final section looks at depictions of the sleeping Rhea Silvia in narrative contexts, many of which include the depiction of Mars as an internal viewer. Here I am interested in the appeal to the external viewer's response to such scenes, in which the 'snapshot' tableau hints at elements from a continuous narrative, the subsequent parts of which the viewer is encouraged to reconstruct. This comparative



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approach enables me to categorize some larger Roman notions about sleep both as a barrier between the waking world and the world of dreams, and as a mysterious state of existence which excites a viewer's curiosity and encourages him to create narratives around the sleeper's disguised thoughts.

**Representing the sleeper in text: the case of Propertius 1.3**

Elegy 1.3, one of Propertius' most beloved poems, has been the subject of extensive criticism and fascination. The poem's mix of references to mythological figures, likely allusions to artistic representation of these figures, and its depiction of the relationship between the narrator and Cynthia are all exemplary. But the poem's emphasis upon the intrigue of sleep, the circumstance around which the poem is structured, is also significant for the reader's appreciation of the poem's interplay between subjectivity and exteriority. By arguing that the poem casts the relationship between a waking viewer and sleeping figure specifically in terms of the viewer's confrontation with something at once familiar and unfamiliar, I propose a new reading of this poem as a particular type of visual experience. The narrator's attempt to contextualize the experience of viewing his sleeping girlfriend through recourse to the realm of myth, his manipulation of the sleeping figure, and his imagination of her dream, provide a paradigm for interaction across the divide between sleep and waking.

When he wrote his comparative study of Propertius 1.3 and the marble sculpture of a sleeping female figure known as the Vatican Ariadne (a Hellenistic sculpture



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type)[182] in 1895, Theodor Birt set the tone for subsequent analyses of the poem, many of which concentrate upon the connection between artistic representation and the images of Propertius' poetry.[183] By arguing for the Vatican Ariadne as Propertius' primary visual model for the restless sleep of Cynthia, Birt established a model for assigning an artistic precedent to Propertius' textual description of the sleeping figure.[184] By way of introduction to my analysis of Propertius 1.3, I will reassess Birt's insistence on naming the Vatican Ariadne as the model for the sleeping Cynthia as Propertius describes her; I do this not because I agree with him, but because I think his analysis points out a feature of the relationship between viewer and sleeping figure, one in which he himself participates as he tries to identify it in Propertius' poem.

I have already shown that the hunt for Propertius' artistic models is misguided in that it ultimately limits our analysis of the poet's use of the visual; Propertius' poetry is equally interesting when it diverges from possible models, or comments upon familiar types. In the case of 1.3, Birt's monolithic analysis ignores the multiplicity of associations which the poetic description evokes, most blatantly by avoiding discussion of Propertius' analogies to Andromeda and the bacchant.[185] But Birt's observations

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[182] Vatican Museums 548. See McNally (1985) plate XIII, or Koortbojian (1995) figure 72, for a cast of the sculpture.

[183] I will discuss representative examples of this approach to the poem later in the analysis.

[184] See Wolfgang Hering (1972) 45, e.g., where he disagrees with Birt's conclusion but cites his approach as seminal.

[185] In his early analysis, Keyssner (1938, rep.1975) 275-76 tried to deal with the seeming incongruity of the analogy with Andromeda and Perseus by asserting that, because no known depiction of Perseus gazing upon the sleeping Andromeda exists, the poet must have imported the image of the lover gazing at his sleeping beloved from other painted pairs of lovers onto the story of Perseus and Andromeda. In other



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about the live viewer's relationship to the sculpted sleeping figure, as well as the difficulties inherent both in representing and describing the sleeping figure, are themselves illuminating for my discussion of Propertius' visual style and, ultimately, for highlighting the differences between representing sleep in art and in text. In his attempt to establish a basic iconography of the sleeping figure, and to distinguish the sleeper from, for example, a representation of a dead figure, Birt identifies some of the criteria for the relationship between the solitary sleeping figure and its viewer. Finally, Birt's analysis of the poem in connection with its purported sculpted precedent introduces the viewer's application of narrative to a static image. Birt's analysis mimics certain features of Propertius' poem, two of which are relevant to my discussion. The first is the power of sleep over a sleeper as observed from the outside; the second is the viewer's fascination with the internal mysteries of the sleep experience.

In his analysis of the statue, in which he attempts to link the sleeper's awkward and restless pose with that of the sleeping Cynthia about to wake in Propertius' poem, Birt reveals the viewer's process of demystifying the sleeper.[186] Like the narrator in the

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words, Keyssner allows that Propertius may have created this analogy without using pictorial precedent, but that his characterization was based upon known images of Ariadne and a bacchant lying asleep and discovered by another figure. That Birt's model had persistent influence is obvious from the work of Jean-Paul Boucher (1965) 54 who, in analyzing this poem more than 50 years later, wrote that the reason Propertius' analogy with the sleeping Andromeda is so jarring to us is that it refers directly to a work which is now lost to us. Boucher does not allow that Propertius might have deviated from a paradigm or created a visual image which suited the needs of the poem. For Boucher, Propertius' obvious attention to visuality is not inventive but merely evocative.

[186] In a more recent study of the representation of Ariadne in Greek and Roman art, McNally (1985) 172 comments that the Vatican Ariadne, because of its combination of traits familiar from different sleeping figures, such as the position of the right arm over her head and the left arm bent to support the head, creates a sense of "deep slumber permeated with deep unease." This sense of unease intrigued Birt and inspired him to claim that Propertius saw a model for Cynthia's restless sleep precipitated by grief.



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poem, he takes advantage of the figure's immobility to scrutinize her sleeping body.[187] In moving between his observations of the sculpture in the Vatican and those of Propertius' narrator as he makes his argument, Birt himself engages in the same activity as the narrator of Propertius 1.3, as he imagines that the Vatican Ariadne is herself caught in sleep the moment after Theseus has abandoned her. Birt imagines that he can see her chest heaving and even hear her breath, "wir einen ihren Busen wogen zu sehen, ihr tiefes Athmen zu hören...,"[188] just as the narrator of Propertius 1.3 observes his lover breathing (line 7) and imagines that she is shifting restlessly in a worried sleep (line 27). Birt confirms the relationship between the text's narrator and the live viewer as follows, "mit derselben Scheu stand Properz vor seiner Cynthia...Sein Gedicht erscheint wie ein Commentar zu unserem Bilde."[189] He can easily imagine that this Ariadne suffers from tormenting dreams as Cynthia does in the poem (lines 29-30).[190]

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[187] See, for example, p. 38, where he devotes the entire page to a description of the sculpture's head and its relationship to its left hand. Birt deduces her state of restlessness from the fact that her head is not actually resting upon her hand, but rather hovering slightly above it, as though she were shifting positions agitatedly during a light sleep.

[188] Birt (1895) 43.

[189] Ibid., 43-44. Even the adjectives "sein" and "unser" underscore the similarities between the two types of viewer. Birt's connection between the Vatican Ariadne and Propertius' description of Cynthia hinges upon the viewer's reaction to the sleeper as much as upon any direct "iconographical" link. In other words, it is not simply the tension in the sculpture's pose which sets a precedent for Propertius' depiction of Cynthia's uneasy sleep, but just as important is his reaction to it as a viewer, which he links to Propertius' response of intimidation and trepidation in the context of the poem.

[190] Ibid., 48 and 55. One critical difference between the "dreams" of the Vatican Ariadne and those of Cynthia, both imagined by the viewer, of course, is that, as Birt claims, Ariadne dreams of the faithlessness of her lover Theseus, while Cynthia, as Propertius imagines it, dreams of her own unfaithfulness to Propertius. This presents a crucial divide between the viewer of a work of art, who imports a background of knowledge to the image he sees, and the lover, who invests the sleeper he knows intimately with a psychology that betrays a (more obvious) projection of his own fears onto the sleeper.



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In trying to link sleeping figures from both poetic and artistic modes of representation, Birt assumes the role of the poetic narrator and provides for the viewer (or reader) to which he appeals, a model for viewing the sleeping figure. Standing before the sculpture of the sleeping female figure in the Vatican, he is fascinated by the sleeper's mystery and is determined to solve it before she wakes. Birt's link between the Vatican Ariadne and the Cynthia of poem 1.3 hinges upon imagining the narrative leading up to (and following) the moment at which the sculpted Ariadne has been captured, and then inserting into this recreation of a familiar myth the individual circumstances of Cynthia abandoned and rediscovered in the context of the poem. This desire to secure the narrative of the mysterious sleeper, whether it focuses on what has preceded her sleep, what will follow this moment, or even what the figure itself is dreaming are of central importance to the question of how artists chose modes for representing sleeping figures.

Components of the interaction between sleeper and waking viewer include the inscrutability of the sleeper, the viewer's attempt to understand what the sleeper is dreaming, and the perception of the sleep experience as a nexus for the passage of time. These dynamics arise from a tension between the external (manifest) and internal (hidden) aspects of the sleeper. As Herica Valladares shows in a forthcoming essay on the dynamics of viewing in poem 1.3 with regard to artistic representations of Ariadne, "fascination, not possession, is the true subject of these images;"[191] I would add that the

[191] Valladares (2004) 11. It is not my goal to prove that Propertius' description of a lover's observations of his beloved asleep have universal application, or to claim that every viewer approaches a sleeping figure



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viewer's "enthrallment" (her term) results directly from the fact that the object of his gaze is asleep, and that sleep excites fascination as much for its vulnerability as for its inherent intrigue. This feature has received little attention in analyses of the poem.

One could say that all figures represented in art are, in a sense, "sleeping," in that they are made by their creators available to viewing and are unable to alter their position of immobility. But when specifically characterizing this immobility as sleep, the artist challenges the very notion of immobility. The sleeper at once embodies the representation of a sustained state and defies it, since the state of sleep (as opposed to that of death) implies an eventual awaking and, by a return to consciousness, the end of its inertness. When Birt exclaims with regard to the Vatican Ariadne, "wie afficirend, wie Mitleid und Furcht erregend, diese Unruhe und Friedlosigkeit einer Schlafenden!,"[192] he is almost impatient for her to wake up abruptly just as Cynthia does in 1.3. Sleep enforces the sleeper's physical passivity, while it inspires a sort of mental activity in the viewer that contrasts with the sleeper's mysterious interior activity as imagined by the viewer. It is this tension, exploited by both the sculptor of the Vatican Ariadne and by Propertius in his description of Cynthia in 1.3, on which Birt's reaction and analysis focuses us.

Studies of Propertius 1.3 over the past century have consistently focused upon the division between the passive, sleeping Cynthia of the beginning of the poem and her

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as a lover might approach his beloved. Rather, because there is an obvious parallel between the poetic description of Cynthia asleep and the artistic representations of the sleeping figures to whom she is compared, it is productive to look for the features of the poem which comment on the sleep experience that transcend the erotic dynamic between two lovers.

[192] Birt (1895) 56.



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verbally hostile, waking counterpart who emerges toward the poem's end.[193] The contrast between the poem's two Cynthias does not simply revolve around her marked transformation from mute object of focus to speaking critic, rather it indicates the divide between myth and mundane, visual and verbal, static and moving. Wolfgang Hering gives a typical analysis of the depiction of rival Cynthias as follows, "man fühlt sich aber 35 ff. eher in das Rom des Alltags versetzt, als dass man sich an die Welt des

[193] The attention given to the dichotomy between the two Cynthias is rivaled by that surrounding the author's motivation for introducing mythological exempla at the beginning of the poem to create analogies for the sleeping lover. The discussion of the use of myth generally breaks down into two types of criticism: on the one hand, critics are interested in the use of mythological exempla as a means of elevating or abstracting Propertius' poetry; on the other, they are interested in allying the mythological examples with artistic representation in an attempt to establish the criteria for Propertius' striking visual style. In a seminal article, Allen (1962) developed the former approach by questioning the role of mythology in the poem, rather than simply accepting it as an idealized foil for the nagging "realistic" Cynthia of the poem's end. Allen concludes that the mythological exempla in fact, elevate the poet's own personal situation to the level of the universal; he writes, "realism provides terms for describing what is temporary, mythology for describing what is permanent," 134. Allen de-emphasizes the traditional but abstract connection to pictorial imagery to which earlier critics had adhered and reclaims the use of myth as a way to understand the poet's attempt to add the depth of universality to his personal account. Leo Curran (1966) followed Allen's article four years later with an argument that established an allegiance between the worlds of myth and art in Propertius' poem. His approach represents a reunion of myth and art not guided by a search for the poem's specific artistic models. By calling the mythological exempla at the poem's beginning a "vision of the heroic world" 191, Curran succeeds in separating these from the rest of the poem, while he reminds the reader of the particularly visual qualities of the mythological images themselves. He argues that Cynthia "mediates between the immobile, artificial world of myth and art and the real world," 195 thereby solidifying the connection between myth and art on the one hand, and everything else, reality and all its harshness, on the other. In an attempt to point out Propertius' modernist tendencies, and to emphasize his influence upon Ezra Pound, Benediktson (1989) devotes an entire chapter in his study to the "imagism" of Propertius. This argument centers upon the "associative" (rather than "internally logical") quality of Propertius' images. In his opinion, Propertius' use of imagery suggests an interactive component, in that it urges the reader of the poetry to use his own imagination to "fill in the details," 86, that the reference to painted images suggests. This interpretation allows us to think about the poem as something on which the reader reflects, and around which he creates a narrative which is not stated explicitly in the poem; this reading underscores for us the idea that a description of a picture inspires the viewer to extrapolate further and to create connections between what is stated and what he associates with this. This is particularly significant in the case of poem 1.3, as the narrator extrapolates by using mythological exempla from his initial visual image of the sleeper.



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Mythos erinnern möchte."[194] Here the contrast is one between the realm of myth and that of familiar, daily reality divided across a moment of abrupt, line-specific transition.

R.O.A.M. Lyne made a particularly succinct and evocative assessment of the structure of 1.3, in which he described the waking Cynthia as, "the woman of reality who inevitably reveals herself, and breaks in upon the eggshell world of dreams."[195] This statement draws attention directly to the role of sleep in establishing the dichotomy between the poem's two Cynthias. In general, the discussion of the two Cynthias has tended to underestimate the importance of sleep as a factor in the division of Cynthia across the two parts of the poem. Lyne's statement, while it draws attention to the second Cynthia--the waking Cynthia--as an interruption, also leaves some ambiguity as to which world is the world of dreams. Is it the case that Cynthia shatters her own tentative and indiscernible dreams by waking? Or does Lyne refer to the world of myth and fantasy, in which the narrator himself is absorbed, that is abandoned as Cynthia

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[194] Hering (1972) 55. Hering echoes the sentiment of Curran (1966), who characterizes the split as follows, "the initial vision, with its romantic dignity and its augury of success, has been almost completely destroyed...At the end of the poem Cynthia herself is made to recall the vision, only to contradict it" 206. This analysis acknowledges the connection between the two Cynthias particularly in terms of the vocabulary used to describe her in each half of the poem (for example, the use of the adjective *fessa* in lines 5 and 42), but it diminishes the connection by asserting that her jarring behavior at the end of the poem negates the seeming similarity between them. Commentators have shown other ways to bridge the divide between the two Cynthias and thus the two sections of the poem. Wlosok (1967) 347-48, for example, links Cynthia's outburst and tirade against the narrator with the image of the frenzied maenad from lines 5-6 of the poem's beginning. Her behavior at the end of the poem recalls and even explains the inclusion of the maenad among the introductory analogies. Wlosok associates the qualities of "Leidenschaftlichkeit" and "Wildheit" with both the maenad and Cynthia as she appears at the poem's end. This comparison allays Wlosok's worry that the analogy with the maenad at the beginning lacked an erotic connection, as was the case with Ariadne and Andromeda (340). By linking the maenad with the real Cynthia, the missing eroticism is retrieved.

[195] Lyne (1970) 61.



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begins to speak and intrude upon the mute sanctity of his reverie? It is this ambiguity to which I would like to draw attention in my analysis.

Responding to criticism which centered upon Cynthia's "split-personality," or the shock of her "shrewish" behavior at the poem's end, feminist scholarship of the late 1980's and early 1990's challenged the strict division between Cynthias by questioning the notion of a 'real' Cynthia. As Maria Wyke argued persuasively, for example, the 'real' Cynthia of the end of the poem was as much a poetic construct as the mythologized, sleeping Cynthia of the poem's beginning; therefore, neither should be privileged as more representative of a contemporary Roman woman.[196] A. R. Sharrock, in an article with an acknowledged debt to the work of Wyke, extends her analysis to include speculation about Propertius' motivation for presenting Cynthia as a "nag" on the other side of the divide of sleeping and waking, by suggesting that this is a "more subtle form of wish-fulfillment, for her complaint displays the fidelity and devotion to

[196] See Wyke (1987) 47, where she takes on the many critics for whom, "faced with a poem presenting elegy's heroine as a physical and active presence which breathes, sleeps, wakes and even speaks, the written woman lives beyond the poetic world as flesh and blood." Her critique focuses primarily on book 2, where she sees a greater conflation of references to Cynthia and references to his poetic technique and debt to Callimachean poetics. She hopes to do away with the entire notion of a real woman behind the 'real' woman portrayed at the end of the poem. Ellen Greene (1995) 306 reads the Cynthia of the poem's end as a particular type of construct when she declares that her aim is "to show how 'the woman in the text' is a projection of male fantasy and male desire and, moreover, reflects male stereotypes about women that deny them agency and autonomy." Greene thus levels the distinction between the two Cynthias by demonstrating that the same force of objectification is at work in evoking both types of woman. She begins her feminist analysis of the poem with the declaration that "Propertius presents his mistress as a pictorial object," 304, and proceeds from the paradigms of the mythological heroines to the sleeping Cynthia 'herself.' Thus she locates Propertius' decision to depict Cynthia as he does in this poem within a more general framework of male "specularization."



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her lover which is the elegiac poet's professed desire."[197] More recently, Shelley Kaufhold, through a detailed analysis of the facets of the poem which purport to represent the 'realistic' features of the Cynthia of 1.3, concludes that Cynthia is portrayed as an elegiac lover, the typically male role, thereby reversing the roles of lover and beloved, which the reader understands only by scratching away the veneer of reality which the poet suggests with his portrayal of Cynthia at the end.[198]

The most recent scholarship on the poem has sought to emphasize other dualities within the poem. Reacting to her critical predecessors, Gail Tatham, for example, attempts to move away from a focus on the dichotomous Cynthia by favoring an analysis which takes pleasure in the poem's "satisfyingly circular structure or ring composition" as the poem "begins and ends at the same point, the moment when Cynthia is asleep."[199] She sees the poem unified by the motif of sleeping and wakeful figures. But even her analysis relies ultimately upon the establishment of a divide between appearance and reality within the context of the poem, as she argues for a subversive reading of the self-

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[197] Sharrock (1991) 42. In this analysis, the nagging Cynthia is not simply the poet's construct, but a complement to the obvious wish-fulfilling qualities of her rival from the poem's beginning, and therefore lies less starkly in opposition to her.

[198] See Kaufhold (1997). Unfortunately, Kaufhold's argument is rather simplistic in its assessment of the role reversal, as it fails to account for the significance of the slippage of roles played both by the narrator and his lover in the poem. Her conclusion that Cynthia is more loving than angry, and therefore a model of "the ideal mistress", ultimately diminishes the complexity of Cynthia's portrait. But Kaufhold's insight that the Cynthia of the second half of the poem is fashioned by Propertius the poet as a surprise to the narrator's (and the reader's) expectations (see pp. 96-97) will be important for my later discussion.

[199] Tatham (2000) 45.



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righteous Cynthia of the poem's end.[200] To her credit, however, Tatham, in her interest in the opacity of the sleeper in the poem and Cynthia's reinvention of her story upon waking, draws attention to an interesting but underdeveloped facet of the poem.

In his 2003 article, Brian Breed attempts to align the two Cynthias by claiming that through the technique of ekphrasis Propertius "collapses" the distinction between the two portraits of Cynthia. Propertius achieves this, Breed argues, by using a mode of representation which blurs the distinction between picture and word (ekphrasis), and, therefore, in the context of this poem, between mythic lover and realistic lover. Hence Breed's analysis acknowledges the distinction between the representations of the narrator's girlfriend, but elides the difference by appealing to the point at which they connect. Breed reduces Cynthia's "reality" to a textual reality, which derives its 'real' qualities from an intertextual relationship with Catullus 64, an obvious model for the mythological play of 1.3, and, for Breed, of particular importance because of the earlier poem's prominent ekphrasis.

For Herica Valladares, Breed's closest contemporary, the poem's mythological analogies provide templates for the moment of erotic enthrallment which is created by the visual interaction of the lovers depicted in the myths, in the static moments captured by the artistic representations of these myths, and through the interplay between the narrator and his lover across the boundary of consciousness in the dim light of the

[200] According to Tatham, the peaceful mythological allusions at the poem's beginning serve not to contrast simply with the enraged Cynthia of the poem's end, but with the duplicitous Cynthia, who, contrary to her claims of chaste solitary activity, has come home and fallen asleep after a night of drunken carousing which might have rivaled even the narrator's own. In her reading, the notions of 'myth' and 'reality' are not simply removed, but the 'reality' as it is presented is itself disguising another set of events.



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bedroom. In Valladares' reading, the cubiculum becomes the pinacoteca, and the relationship of visual exchange between the painted lovers is imitated by the lovers of the poem. The recent emphasis in scholarship upon the role of visuality in poem 1.3 is a productive development, I believe, since it draws attention away from a focus on Cynthia's representation alone, and redirects it towards the relationship between viewer and viewed within the context of the poem. From this encounter, we are better able to understand Roman notions of viewership, and thus, apply these to viewership in an artistic context.

Propertius' emphasis upon sleep in poem 1.3 is evident first at the level of vocabulary. In the poem's 46 lines, the word *somnus* occurs three times (in lines 3, 25, and 41); *Sopor,* the personification of sleep, once (in line 45), and *quies* twice (in lines 7 and 17).[201] This observation also underscores the diversity of the representation and function of sleep within the poem's lines. In addition to the words which appear in the introductory analogies indicating the *state* of sleep, such as *fessa, languida,* and the verbs *iacuit* and *accubuit,* many of which are pointedly repeated in Cynthia's own words at the poem's end, the different words for sleep itself are significant indicators of sleep's *function* throughout the poem. The three words for sleep, used specifically to describe aspects of Cynthia's sleep experience within the poem, become significant for our understanding of her transformation within the poem. I will show that sleep begins as a

[201] See section on "vocabulary of sleep" in chapter 3 for further discussion of these three terms in Statius' poetry.



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state defined by the observing narrator, evolves into an interactive mode, and, in its final representation, is an all-powerful force, which dominates the sleeper from the outside.

It is striking that the noun *somnus* first appears in the poem in the context of an analogy for which we have no literary or artistic parallel, namely the sleep of Andromeda after her rescue by Perseus. While the Ariadne of the first analogy (lines 1-2) is described as lying exhausted on the shore (*iacuit...languida),* and the bacchant of the third analogy (lines 5-6) has fallen to the grass out of exhaustion (*fessa...concidit),* Andromeda is described as *accubuit primo...somno,* lying stretched out in her first sleep (line 3), where the state of sleep itself rather than her physical exhaustion is emphasized.[202] In the next line, she is described as *libera iam duris cotibus,* thus implying that her restful sleep is contingent upon her freedom from captivity. But while Andromeda is free from her physical chains, the state of sleep binds her in immobility; in a certain sense, sleep deprives her of the freedom to move and to act.[203] The juxtaposition of the words *somno* and *libera,* separated by the line break, creates an interesting image of Andromeda's situation. On the one hand, she is both free from imprisonment and able to sleep for the first time since her capture; on the other hand, she has been freed *by* sleep, as her sleep constitutes the first phase of her freedom from the danger that she risked when she was bound to the rock.[204] But the proximity of these

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[202] The phrase *primo...somno* surely implies sleep after an extended period of deprivation, and thus its connotation of exhaustion implicitly links Andromeda to Ariadne and the bacchant. Propertius keeps her situation distinct by not using an adjective in the nominative singular to describe her state.

[203] See Lucretius 4.944-953 on sleep as a physically binding and weakening force.



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words also suggests the false freedom that sleep offers to the sleeper, as she becomes bound, this time to the gaze and manipulation of her viewer.

In his first mention of Cynthia's sleep Propertius uses the term *quies*. He describes Cynthia breathing out *quies* in line 7: *talis visa mihi mollem spirare quietem.* This line is significant for its implication that sleep pervades the sleeper, while it also establishes the relationship between sleeper and waking figure in terms of their physical states: we learn here that the narrator is aware of the sleeper's subtlest movement.[205] The narrator's comment on the movement of Cynthia's breath contrasts immediately with the static tableaux of the analogies which open the poem. The unobtrusive but fluid passage of breath from inside her body connects her to the outside realm of the viewer.[206] A comparison of this observation with Cynthia's description of the moment of falling asleep at the poem's end reveals a facet of sleep's duality. For Cynthia speaks of sleep as the external force which imposes slumber and then pervades the sleeping body. As we learn in line 45, Sopor has pressed upon her with his sweet wings (*iucundis lapsam*

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[204] In Andromeda's case more than in the others, the plane of her representation changes from vertical to horizontal. We imagine her chained to the rock in a standing position, while the horizontality of her sleep is obvious.

[205] The second use of the noun *quies* comes in line 17, where the narrator describes his hesitancy at rousing Cynthia: *non tamen ausus eram dominae turbare quietem.* Here again the noun refers to her sleep as she experiences it coursing through her. The narrator feels tempted to steal kisses, as his drunkenness and desire urge him on, but dares not go further, for he knows the fragility of the state of sleep and that its end will bring the return of anger. He remains immobile, preferring to look rather than act.

[206] We are reminded of sleep's motion again at lines 27-28, when the narrator claims to be inspired to irrational thoughts by the motion of his girlfriend's breathing: *et quotiens raro duxti suspiria motu, / obstupui vano credulus auspicio.* The noun *suspiria* recalls the verb *spirare* from line 7; Cynthia's sleep-infused breath in both instances inspires the narrator to create narratives around her. The former instance (line 7), the narrator's first glimpse of Cynthia, presumably generated the analogies which preceded it in the narrative, while the latter fosters fantasies about Cynthia's dreams. In the latter example, the juxtaposition of *motu* and *opstupui* across the line break is striking in that it transfers the bodily motionlessness of the sleeper to the onlooker, while it invests sleep with powerful motion.



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*Sopor impulit alis).* Thus the power of sleep is transferred from the outside to the inside as the initial force of sleep--exerted from the outside--insinuates itself and is combined with the breath of the sleeper while she is held in its power.

This final description of *Sopor* (line 45) contrasts with the poet's first use of *somnus* to describe Cynthia's soporific state in the poem (line 25). In this shift, the adjectives used to describe sleep's effects (*ingratus* and *iucundus* respectively) highlight the mutable nature of sleep in the poem. The embrace of Sopor's *iucundis alis* in line 45 seems incongruous with the unreceptive *ingrato somno* of line 25. But the dichotomous images work as complements split across the boundary between sleeper and interlocutor: for the sleeper, sleep's relief is welcome; for the waking figure, it furthers inscrutability. The narrator has just described his thwarted attempts to place his wreath upon Cynthia's head, to arrange her hair, and to place apples in her hands (lines 21-24). Thus the phrase *ingrato somno* refers specifically to the inhospitable nature of the sleeping figure from the waking viewer's perspective. Sleep is ungrateful not simply because it refuses to retain the objects of the waking and, thus, to mimic a waking state, but also because it refuses to allow the waking viewer to establish his familiarity with the sleeper. In a waking state, the narrator imagines, his girlfriend would gladly accept these gifts (*munera)* and, furthermore, would react perhaps by being more compliant with his wishes. *Somnus* is here presented as the boundary which prevents the narrator from achieving the reaction he desires from his girlfriend. Like the door in a



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paraclausithyron, which causes the lover to imagine his girlfriend's activities on the other side, sleep becomes the boundary which prevents interaction and manipulation.[207]

This brings us to the notion of the sleeper as both unfamiliar and familiar, a theme which is of central importance to the relationship between sleeping figure and viewer. For this we must turn back to the mythological analogy (lines 19-20) which precedes the gift-giving incident. As I have mentioned above, the narrator becomes frustrated when his gifts are rejected by the slack and unresponsive limbs of his sleeping girlfriend (lines 21-24). The narrator's frustration gives way to indictment of sleep as the agent of his inability to get what he wants (line 25). This episode is followed by his waking fantasy about Cynthia's dreams, a form of visual manipulation, through which the narrator tries to access the distant Cynthia by way of his imagination. But prior to these attempts at interaction, which culminate in Cynthia's awakening, the narrator has ascribed his reluctance to disturb her sleep to his fear of *expertae...iurgia saevitiae* (line 18); his previous experience and familiarity with his girlfriend's wrath forces him to resist the temptation to embrace her. This realization of impasse prompts comparison with another mythological scenario, one also possibly inspired by artistic representation, that of Argus watching over Io. This analogy, based upon a comparison between the narrator and Argus as viewers, marks a transition between the narrator's modes of interaction with his sleeping girlfriend. His hesitance gives way to engagement with Cynthia. As I will show, it is particularly relevant that this moment contains a revelation

[207] See poem 1.16, especially lines 33-34, for the image of the *exclusus amator* imagining his lover in the arms of another man. Of course, this trope is explicitly invoked at the poem's end, when Cynthia accuses the narrator of having returned from another lover's closed doors (line 36).



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of unfamiliarity, for it is this feeling of alienation from the familiar that motivates the narrator's actions in the lines which follow the analogy.

The poem's narrator compares himself to Argus staring intently at the unfamiliar horns of Io, daughter of Inachus, who has been transformed into a cow by the jealous Juno: *sed sic intentis haerebam fixus ocellis, / Argus ut ignotis cornibus Inachidos* (lines 19-20). The use of *sed* in line 19 establishes the narrator's resistance to the provocations of Amor and Liber -- rather than interact with Cynthia, he will watch. This description is interesting on its own, for it reveals the specular power of the viewer, who, in this case, like a guardsman, controls the movement of his charge, while he himself remains immobile (*fixus*).[208] It is also of interest because the poet returns to the use of the mythological and artistic references, this time utilizing the established mode of comparison for the narrator himself, and thereby inscribing him in the realm of myth. The use of the adjective *ignotis* reveals an important feature of the dynamic between viewer and sleeper.[209] It is possible that its usage simply comments upon the unfamiliarity of the horns to Io herself, as she becomes accustomed to her transformation at the hands of Juno. But in this case, since the analogy is told from the perspective of

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[208] See Greene (1995) and Valladares (2004) for discussions of specular authority in this poem The narrator is hesitant to relinquish visual control over his lover, although he does not yet dare to approach her physically. This represents a temporary reversal of the power dynamic from poem 1.1, where the narrator claimed that Cynthia captured him with her eyes (*me cepit ocellis*, line 1). The implication of both of these lines is that visual fascination transfixes the viewer and thus establishes a temporary power dynamic.

[209] The tension between familiar and unfamiliar, desire and resistance, viewer and sleeper, is also contained in the relationship between the adjectives *intentis* and *ignotis*. The adjectives share identical metrical positions in their respective lines. Moreover, they are linked by homoioteleuton (*-tis / -tis)* and initial near-rhyme (*in- / ig-).*



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the viewer, the element of unfamiliarity more probably reflects his observation of the mystery of the sleeping figure.[210] In sleep the narrator can approach his lover closely, but her thoughts remain inscrutable as she refuses to cooperate with him. Furthermore, the reference to Io's unfamiliar horns seems to challenge the narrator's familiarity with Cynthia's wrath which he has articulated in the preceding couplet. Daniel Harmon comments upon the placement of the adjective *ignotis* in the position before the caesura as "striking in the context of a simile which describes an encounter with the ominously familiar."[211] As with the first set of analogies, this one abstracts the relationship between lover and girlfriend by suggesting a visual relationship which matches their particular dynamic. But the sleep which characterized the women of the earlier analogies is here replaced by the image of Io not asleep, but instead projecting the simultaneous familiarity and mystery of the sleeper as she is locked under the narrator's gaze.

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[210] Brian Breed (2003) 46 claims that Io's unfamiliar horns "make her a *thauma*, and as an illustration of a viewer's ἔκπληξις the Argus exemplum signifies not only the stance of a watchman looking intently at his charge (a resonance the narrator surely intends with the choice of his image), but also the stance of looking specifically at art." This is bolstered by the fact that this was a known and documented subject for painted depictions, the best known being that in the house of Livia on the Palatine. Thus this analogy is doubly effective, since it evokes both the power of the arresting artistic image and the power of the enigmatic sleeping figure.

[211] Harmon (1974) 159. He goes on to say that, "this marks a point of transition: the figure of the Maenad, who had expressed all that was familiar about Cynthia, yields for a time to an analogue which represents the mystifying and distant." I agree that the figure of the Maenad is a close model for the enraged Cynthia, whose wrath the narrator takes measures to avoid, but I would argue that all of the mythological analogies at the beginning serve to abstract and, thereby, add mystery to, the figure of Cynthia, rather than to elucidate certain aspects of her personality, or her activity prior to falling asleep. What is particularly interesting in the Argus and Io analogy is that it represents the narrator's perspective on his relationship with the sleeper. Unlike the case with the Maenad, which purports, at least in Harmon's analysis, to forewarn the reader of Cynthia's rage and subsequent exhaustion from it, in the final mythological exemplum (that of Argus and Io) we learn only of the viewer's impression of the sleeper, rather than of her existence or emotions before falling asleep.



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As the viewer emerges from his transfixed state, he attempts to manipulate the sleeper; *fixus haerebam* gives way to *solvebam* as he moves out of reverie to action. As though he wishes to mask her protruding horns and return her to a more familiar state, his first act is to affix a *corolla* to her temples (line 21). This is followed by subsequent attempts to make her appear more animated and thus, more familiar. But his attempts are thwarted, as discussed above, by the obstinacy of *ingratus somnus,* which both invites manipulation with its semblance of passivity, and frustrates the attempt by its refusal to comply. The narrator's meditation upon sleep's lack of accommodation leads to his final effort to cross the threshold from waking into sleep. As I have already mentioned, the narrator's observation of the movement of Cynthia's breath reveals his own immobility (*duxti suspiria motu...obstupui,* lines 27-28). His frozen state allows him another moment to elaborate upon the narrative of the sleeper, as the narrator transforms the motion of her breath into a fantasy of her sexual dreams.[212]

At the very moment he creates his most unfounded fantasy about his sleeping girlfriend, one based not upon observation but upon an imagined narrative, the narrator

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[212] There is a parallel to this dynamic in poem 2.29, where the narrator describes spying on the sleeping Cynthia in similar terms (lines 25-28):

> *obstipui: non illa mihi formosior umquam*
> *visa, neque ostrina cum fuit in tunica,*
> *ibat et hinc castae narratum somnia Vestae,*
> *neu sibi neve mihi quae nocitura forent.*

This passage also unites the viewer's stupefaction (*obstipui*), the visual encounter with the sleeper (*visa*), and the viewer's imagination of the sleeper's potentially harmful dreams (*somnia*). In this poem, however, the narrator is inspired to think about Cynthia's dreams not as she is experiencing them at the moment of his observation; rather the comment is triggered by his memory of her in the dress she wore to the temple of Vesta to seek interpretation or purification of her dreams. Nevertheless, the speculation results from the act of viewership.



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of the poem calls himself *credulus* (line 28), as though to acknowledge the reader's suspicion that he has departed from simple fantasy to jealous paranoia. Daniel Harmon has observed that "the adjective offered the hint all along that he was half-aware of being taken in by his own imagination."[213] But the episode is conveyed with a sense of irony, since he admits that his credulity is influenced by a *vano...auspicio* (line 28). Thus the use of the adjective *vanus* is equally telling in that he knows Cynthia's sighs contain no clues to her dreams. What does the narrator achieve, then, by revealing to the reader the nature of his fantasy about her? The episode serves two important functions. First it demonstrates the strength of the viewer's desire to know what the sleeping figure is dreaming; it also provides a pivotal moment of manipulation in the poem, where the narrator attempts to breach the boundary of consciousness and enter into the sleeper's state, rather than settle for external manipulation as he has done up to this point.

It is this very moment which coincides with the entry of the moon's bright beam into the room and across the eyes of the sleeper, thereby ending the sleeper's (and the viewer's) reverie. As the narrator is transfixed and staring at his lover in fear, he imagines that her dreams (*visa,* line 29) are bringing terrors unusual for her, those which contain threats of being forced into something against her will (*ne qua tibi insolitos portarent visa timores, / neve quis invitam cogeret esse suam,* lines 29-30). By striving to erase the difference between them, the waking narrator actually underscores the impossibility of doing so. Thus the two are locked in a moment of simultaneous viewership, he of her and she of her dream's images, when their looking is interrupted

[213] Harmon (1974) 165.



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by the peeping of the moon.[214] The arrival of the moon with the movement of its rays (line 33) provides a direct contrast to the static montage created by the waking and sleeping figures at this juncture in the poem. The light of the moon's rays opens Cynthia's eyes, and thereby forces the two figures into a relationship of equality as they face each other awake. We could say that the narrator "wakes up" from his reverie as Cynthia does from hers; she is awakened by stray moonlight, while he is awakened by her awakening. Thus the tense dynamic between sleeper and waking figure is destroyed.

Towards the end of the poem, Propertius draws attention to the power of sleep by defining the split between the dreaming narrator and his waking counterpart as a boundary created by Cynthia's state of sleep. Whereas the narrator's experience of his sleeping lover has progressed in phases through his observation of her asleep, his interaction with her asleep, and her final, abrupt arousal from sleep, her own experience of that night consists of two periods of wakefulness interrupted by sleep. As I shall show, Cynthia's account of the evening's events appears jarring to the reader, who has witnessed and, in a sense, participated in, the narrator's progressive interaction with his lover. The sense of disconnection from the events of the evening which her story creates gives us insight into sleep's function in the poem. Cynthia's vivid memory of the evening's activities leading up to the narrator's entry into the room is striking, as is her immediate connection of these events to her present situation without a sense of her awareness of how long the narrator has interacted with her before her awakening. Her

[214] See Valladares (2004) on the moon as voyeur and alternative, female viewer.



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reaction emphasizes the gap between the experiences of the sleeper and the waking figure as presented in a narrative context told, until this point, from one perspective.

Despite the fact that Cynthia acknowledges in her speech to the narrator that some amount of time has elapsed since she fell asleep (*tandem,* line 35), it is obvious that she has neither any sense of how long the period was, nor of what happened during that time. She also refers to the night she has spent alone as *longa...tempora noctis* in line 37, which calls attention to her perception of the long duration of the night that she has spent alone and he has used up (*consumpsti,* 37). But neither of these terms conveys any accurate sense of how much time she has spent asleep, nor how much time she has spent in the presence of her lover since his return home. In fact, all of her references to the duration of the night betray a focus upon her suspicions about the narrator's activities before his return. It seems as though none of her accusations are based upon her immediate assessment of him, but rather upon her preconceived ideas about his behavior. The features of his behavior to which she draws attention (his affair with another woman and his expulsion from her house) contrast neatly with the picture she paints of her own behavior in the lines which follow. Because of this connection, Cynthia's accusations against her lover seem all the more likely to have been constructed for the purposes of contrast; the impact of the contrast is particularly strong since she claims to have fallen asleep thinking of his infidelity in contrast to her faithfulness (*querebar...*, lines 43-44). Since, from her perspective, the time she has spent asleep elapsed very quickly, this contrast is, of course, preeminent in her mind as she wakes up.



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The abruptness of Cynthia's commentary and its focus upon the concerns which preoccupied her while she was awake undoubtedly reflect the fact that the condensation of the lapse in time prevented any relief from her suspicions. Cynthia, then, is oblivious to the narrative lapse which we have witnessed as readers and which the narrator of the poem has used to his advantage; for the reader, the length of time in the narrative has been further expanded by the narrator's use of mythological analogies and other devices to describe the scene.[215] For the sleeper, on the contrary, there is no movement of time, save that which she imagines upon waking. Having fallen asleep against her will in a state of anguish, she recalls how much time and energy she expended worrying and thus converts this into a commensurate amount of time spent in undesired sleep. Regardless of the actual amount of time Cynthia has spent asleep as compared with how long she was awake and waiting, her lapse of awareness in sleep adds to the intensity of her anger about her lover's absence.

In a sense, Cynthia's acknowledgment of any time passed is undermined by her harsh response as her indignation resumes where it left off before she fell asleep. This sense of the condensation of time is reinforced by her designation of *lacrimis meis* (line

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[215] As Curran (1966) 202 points out in his analysis, "the impression of heavy, slowly passing time is achieved by the succession of ponderous, rhyming imperfects in 19-24 (*haerebam, solvebam, ponebam, gaudebam, poma dabam),* by anaphora (*et modo...et modo,* 21, 23), and especially by the repeated epanalepsis (*munera...munera,* 25-6 and *luna...luna,* 31-2)." These indications, in addition to the passing of the moon through the sky create for the reader a sense of the duration of the narrator's interaction with the sleeper. This emphasis contributes to the contrast between sleeper's and viewer's perceptions of the passage of time. Cynthia's retrospective account of her activity before falling asleep heightens the reader's sense that past and present have been collapsed. Cynthia's subjective presence in the poem consists of her retelling of events leading up to and ending with her falling asleep. This differs from the reader's experience of her in the poem, in which she is characterized by her sleep. Her "present" is still defined by her memories of what the reader thinks of as a past which existed outside the chronological border of the poem.



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46) as her final emotional condition (her *ultima cura)* before descent into sleep.[216] The same sense of worry and upset is conveyed by the words of her tirade against the narrator, thus reminding us of the continuity of her feeling in sleep. The act of weeping itself as a vocal expression of grief and worry also works as a way to transform her from active and possibly talking (*purpureo...stamine, carmine, querebar,* lines 41-43), to ultimately silenced by sleep. When she wakes up and speaks, her vocal dominance contrasts with the weeping of her last waking minutes. It is the sentiment of lamentation which characterizes her falling asleep and her waking up, while the transition through sleep has taken her from vocality to silence and back to vocal articulation.

This disconnect between the reader's understanding of narrative time and the sleeper's inability to account for the time elapsed is integral to the relationship between sleeping figures and their waking viewers. Propertius draws attention to this in the context of his poem in order to underscore the mystery of the sleeping figure as perceived from the exterior. The waking figure's inability to comprehend the sleeper's thoughts is compounded by the knowledge that the sleeper is oblivious to the progression of time which the viewer experiences. This is emphasized by Cynthia's residual anger; it appears as though her emotional state prior to her falling asleep has continued unabated through her sleep and into her waking. This testifies to the distinctly non-transformative quality of her sleep. In fact, Cynthia's entire transformation takes place in the mind and eyes of the viewer.

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[216] Cynthia's *ultima cura* also marks the end of her subjectivity. Her final concern was also her final moment of expression before the arrival of the narrator and his attempts to animate her.



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Cynthia's transition from waking to sleeping is defined in terms of her failed attempt to deceive sleep, as we read in lines 41-42: *nam modo purpureo **fallebam** stamina somnum, / rursus et Orpheae carmine, fessa, lyrae*. The force of Sopor (line 45) has not only robbed her of vigilance, but it has disabled her productivity. Her lyre playing and weaving have given way to a passivity which renders her vulnerable. Too little attention has been given to the connection between sleep and deception in this poem, and I would like to suggest that its effects are felt by both the sleeping and waking figures. Cynthia's attempts to ward off or deceive *(fallebam)* sleep wear her down so that, when she does finally fall asleep, she is exhausted *(lapsam*, line 45). What does *fallere* really signify in this context? Cynthia tries to ward off inactivity with activity, and thus to remain awake for the specific purpose of witnessing her lover's return. The futility of the exercise, as we learn in line 45, is of central importance to this poem. We learn by Cynthia's example that sleep cannot be deceived; a force which exists outside of the sleeper, sleep approaches and threatens her as she grows more tired. What ensues is a struggle in which the sleeper tries to persist in her activities while she becomes gradually inactive. Ultimately, sleep erases individuality despite individual protestations or circumstances. The analogies at the poem's beginning are a good example of this leveling: all three of the mythological characters mentioned are distinctly different and find themselves in very different circumstances, but asleep, their individual characters are leveled in order to create a basic analogy for Cynthia simply on the grounds that she sleeps. Sleep is thus revealed to be a force greater than the individual. This erasure of identity establishes an important circumstance for those who



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interact with the sleeper, for once she is subdued by sleep after a futile attempt at evasion, the sleeper, through her mystery, provides grounds for the deception of the viewer. The sleeper's ignorance of her condition creates an opportunity for the waking viewer to invent his own narrative about her. While sleep denies outward perception to the sleeper, the viewer's visual perception is enhanced by means of sleep's power to subdue.

Cynthia's avowed attempt to deceive sleep, particularly the use of the verb *fallere,* is also an obvious allusion to Catullus 64, a poem whose influence upon Propertius 1.3 is well-established.[217] In his ekphrasis of the coverlet which adorns the marriage bed of Peleus and Thetis, on which the story of Ariadne and Theseus is given prominence, Catullus describes Ariadne's awakening in terms of her having dispelled deceptive sleep, *necdum etiam sese quae visit visere credit, / utpote* ***fallaci*** *quae tunc primum excita* ***somno*** */ desertam in sola miseram se cernat harena,* (lines 55-57). Propertius' use of the verb *fallere* with *somnum* as its object recalls this line, thus reinforcing a connection between Cynthia and Ariadne as abandoned lovers.[218] But I

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[217] For the most recent treatment of the relationship between the two poems, see Breed (2003). See also earlier discussions by Curran (1966), Ross (1975), and Zetzel (1996).

[218] Harmon (1974) 163 identifies a later parallel with this phrase. In *Heroides* 19.37-38 Hero recounts her long wait for Leander as follows: *tortaque versato ducentes stamina fuso, / feminea tardas fallimus arte moras.* Adducing evidence from Homer with regard to Penelope, Helen and "even Circe", Harmon comments that Cynthia's weaving "enhances her likeness to the faithful, lamenting heroines," 162. He says nothing about the process of deceiving sleep, however. Perhaps a better parallel from the *Heroides* comes from poem 10, Ariadne's missive to Theseus. In this context, Ariadne "writes" to Theseus from the very site of her abandonment, the shore of Dia. In lines 5-6 she recalls the site of Theseus' betrayal as follows, *in quo me somnusque meus male prodidit et tu, / per facinus somnis insidiate meis.* Here *somnus* and Theseus are complicit in betraying Ariadne, as they are linked by the verb *prodidit.* This gives us a better indication of the nature of sleep's deception: it both disables the sleeper and then forces her into ignorance of the action going on around her. It is worth noting that *somnus* is twice defined as hers (*meus,*



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would add that they are further linked by the role that sleep plays in their tales. Whereas Ariadne is abandoned unknowingly while she sleeps, Cynthia is conscious of her state of abandonment while awake, only succumbing to sleep when she can no longer maintain her vigil. Both women acknowledge the deceptive quality of sleep as it alters or steals away perception. Cynthia cannot "deceive" sleep because deception is a feature of sleep's power. By acknowledging that she cannot thwart sleep herself by remaining active, she alludes to the deceptive power of sleep over the sleeper.

Allusion to the lines of Catullus helps to illustrate sleep's function as deceiver in Propertius 1.3. There is a direct correlation between the power of sleep and the change in perception which the sleeping figure experiences upon waking. The instant of awakening is characterized for Ariadne as a moment of disconnection between what she sees and what she believes (*necdum etiam sese quae visit visere credit,* line 55); the emphasis upon vision which the moment of awakening allows is underscored by the repetition of the verb *viso*. Sleep's deception involves deprivation of sight, and this, in

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*meis)*, thereby indicating its connection to her as well as its power over her, while Theseus is detached from her, able to depart independently as she is bound by *her* sleep. Sleep's deceit of Ariadne enables Theseus' deception of her during sleep, so it is both agent of deception as well as enabler of it. This duality is expressed twice: through its use first as the subject of a verb, and second in the dative with *insidior*. Later in the poem, when Ariadne addresses sleep, asking, *crudeles somni, quid me tenuistis inertem?* (line 111), we are reminded that the nature of sleep's treachery is to hold the sleeper, as though in an embrace, thereby preventing the sleeper from moving and acting; treachery is achieved by disabling. This is further emphasized in line 112, where Ariadne claims she would have preferred death, *aut semel aeterna nocte premenda fui* , thus comparing the states of sleep and death. This implies a permanent oppression, rather than a temporary state of immobility. This couplet is followed by a list of the forces which conspired to facilitate Theseus' departure, *in me iurarunt somnus ventusque fidesque; / prodita sum causis una puella tribus!* (lines 117-18) -- all of which are either his own acts, or facilitators of his action. Again sleep's inclusion in the list of factors (the winds, breezes, Theseus' right hand and his pledge of fidelity) demonstrates its importance in contributing to Ariadne's miserable fate, which is construed as a collaboration between natural forces such as the winds and sleep, and Theseus' lies. As we learn from lines 117-18, a couplet which echoes lines 5-6, in Ariadne's opinion, sleep is the hinge between Theseus' decision to break his pledge, and the favorable winds which enabled him to carry out his decision. By mentioning *somnus* first in the list, Ariadne gives its effects a prominent role in her abandonment.



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turn, prevents awareness of activity outside of the sleeper's frame of vision. The moment of Ariadne's awakening, *excita* (line 56), marks a transition from disbelief and lack of trust in vision to a self-awareness through perception in line 57 (*desertam...miseram se cernat...*).[219] When Cynthia wakes up, her comment on the inability to deceive sleep reflects her realization that sleep has instead deceived her by subduing her. As I have shown, the deception involved depriving her of the opportunity for lambasting her lover while displaying her faithfulness upon his return, as she had presumably hoped to do by remaining active and awake. Cynthia's inability to confront sleep with its own power marks the beginning of her loss of control. Her words upon waking allude to sleep's power to cheat the sleeper of self-sufficiency and individuality.

Conclusion: Ariadne in art and text

Brian Breed, whose 2003 article on the poem is one of the most recent, still struggles to explicate Propertius' evocation of the visual arts in the poem. He writes that, "the visual art which Propertius 1.3 very clearly evokes, whether painting or sculpture, may be taken to stand for any act of representation...he is drawing on a distinctively textual mode of engaging with and evoking the visual..."[220] Breed argues, furthermore, that, "ekphrasis itself as the conjunction of verbal and visual mimesis is a

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[219] Michael Putnam (1972 [1961]) 228 has written about this passage as follows: "so sudden is her disillusionment that her mind refuses to acknowledge what her eyes admit as fact. She is aroused from a sleep which is *fallax*, because it lulled her into a confidence as false as her lover." He concentrates upon the false confidence of a sleep which seemed benign until waking, whereupon it is revealed that the sleep facilitated deception. Therefore, the deception of the faithless lover, Theseus, is displaced onto the vehicle for its success, sleep itself. Putnam goes on to compare Ariadne's sudden awakening and its attendant clear perception of loss to the similar experience of Attis in poem 63.

[220] Breed (2003) 38.



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direct object of Propertius' allusions."[221] Thus analogy and ekphrasis are mingled--Breed's innovative reading allows us access to the complexity of the poem through Propertius' evocation of ekphrasis as a mode of representation. If we think of the dreamed image, that which one sees while asleep and from which one is detached when awake, as a form of representation, then we can posit the retelling of a dream in the context of a poem as a textual form of evoking the visual experience which is similar to ekphrasis. Just as an ekphrasis of a work of art is descriptive and can also create a narrative, so too does the retelling of a dream. Casting his interaction with the sleeping Cynthia as a dream-like experience, Propertius establishes the dream as a poetic device for communicating visuality. One of the hallmarks of the interior experience of the elegiac poet, the narrator's alternation between involvement and detachment, is shown in microcosm in this poem's dynamic of viewership and dreaming. Equally interesting will be the exploration of a situation which could be characterized as the live version of ekphrasis, namely that of looking at art without descriptive, textual clues to its interpretation.

When Breed claims that "Catullus' Ariadne is a prime example of an ecphrasis that exhibits many qualities impossible in a work of art,"[222] he is referring to the deceptive qualities of the representation of a work of art in literature, exploited by the author's ability to ascribe feelings and speech to a static representation of a figure. Can

[221] Ibid., 41.

[222] Breed (2003) 41. He also writes that "believing in something false becomes a trope of ecphrasis," 44-45. Ekphrasis is frequently not merely representative, but, rather, it expands upon the object it purports to describe and is thus, in a sense, deceptive; one trick of ekphrasis is to get a reader to believe that a figure in a work of art can speak, for example.



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we apply this to Propertius' Cynthia? As Breed reads 1.3, Propertius engages in this type of deception in his representation of the sleeping Cynthia, which is similar to ekphrasis in that it evokes similar elaborations on the part of the narrator of the poem and its reader. Of central importance to the role of description in each poem--whether through analogy or ekphrasis--is the representation of a viewer's reaction to what he sees. So how could these observations on the representation of looking be applied to the actual experience of viewing art? I would argue that the answer to this question lies somewhere between the representational realms of Catullus 64 and Propertius 1.3. In both poems viewership is essential to the extrapolation from the static form; indeed, it is the visual experience that cues the imagination of the viewer to extrapolate from what he sees.[223] How can we translate the experience of ekphrasis, that is, the impulse behind

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[223] At the end of his extensive ekphrasis in poem 64, Catullus informs us that *quae [pulvinar] postquam cupide spectando thessala pubes / expleta est, sanctis coepit decedere divis* (lines 267-68). Thus we are reminded that the information we have just learned as readers would have to have been generated by the visual observations of the wedding guests. I would also add that the importance of viewing is hinted at earlier in the poem, in the first phase of the ekphrasis. In lines 60-62 Ariadne is compared to a sculpture of a bacchant looking out at the departure of Theseus on his ship: *quem procul ex alga maestis Minois ocellis / saxea ut effigies bacchantis, prospicit, eheu, / prospicit et magnis curarum fluctuat undis.* Andrew Laird (1993) 21 cites this description of Ariadne in sculptural terms as an example of the metaliterary qualities of Catullus' poem. He writes, "the image of Ariadne is already embroidered on the *vestis*. Now this image is compared to a statue -- an impression of one form of visual representation is conveyed by actually describing another. It is not just that the embroidered figure has the posture of the statue -- *saxea* actually brings out the texture of the sculptural medium." This image both draws attention to Ariadne's status as a static representation, whose very status as such is being defied by the poet's ekphrastic description of her emotions, and as a viewer, someone who participates with the viewers of the coverlet in this activity. This feature is underscored by Catullus' use of *ocellis* and *prospicit*. Breed (2003) 45, n. 41 alludes to the conflation of Ariadne and the coverlet's "amazed" viewer by citing the earlier lines, 55-57, as evidence that "this characteristic of a viewer of an ekphrasis is perhaps transferred to Ariadne herself". Breed is referring here to line 55 (*necdum etiam sese quae visit videre cedit).* I would add that the use of *se cernat* in line 57 underscores Ariadne's role as viewer, although it is more indicative of Ariadne's self-awareness upon waking. Ariadne's statue-like state also reminds us of her status as passive and inert, as contrasted with Theseus' decisive action (*fugiens, pellit, linquens*, lines 58-59). Although she is shown awake on the coverlet, the comparison of her with a statue (and that of a bacchant, which Propertius will convert to a sleeper in his set of analogies) reminds the reader, at least, of the abandonment during sleep which rendered her incapable of action, an event which is not depicted on the



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the description of a work of art and its impression in text, to the experience of looking at art and desiring to extrapolate from it? What is the relationship between representations of the viewing experience and the actual viewing experience? In the case of viewership of art, which narrative cues are given to the viewer from the representation itself, and how is the viewer encouraged to create his own narrative by expanding from his background knowledge or his imagination? How does a sleeping figure either thwart or encourage this? I will address these questions in the subsequent sections of this chapter.

Before turning to a discussion of the artistic representation of sleeping figures, let us return to Theodor Birt for a moment. In his search for an artistic model for Propertius' description of Cynthia asleep, Birt defines this anonymous, decontextualized sculpted sleeper as Ariadne. By importing the narrative of Ariadne abandoned on Naxos to his reading of the sleeper's strained pose, he creates an appropriate model for Propertius' choice of Ariadne as an analogue for the sleeping Cynthia, and reads this back into the poem. His identification of the sleeping figure in visual art as a model for the text of Propertius is based as much upon his own reaction as a viewer as upon his imagination of the poetic viewer's experience. Most important for my discussion is that both involve the search for narratives to apply to the sleeping figure as analogies for the circumstances of their sleep. Because of his inclusion of personal reaction to the sculpture in his analysis, Birt's reactions and impulses provide insight into the live

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coverlet, but rather inferred by the narrator. The contrast between sleeper and actor is reinforced by the analogy between Ariadne and a sculpture. Furthermore, the image of the frozen bacchant, whose frenzied activity might be the first of her features to come to the mind of the reader or viewer, strengthens the notion that she is in a state of temporary immobility such as sleep, a departure from her regular activity.



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viewer's interaction with an artistic representation of a sleeping figure in a way that complements Propertius' example of this dynamic in a poetic text.

Birt takes advantage of the immobility of the sculpted sleeper for his sustained analysis of her pose. He deduces from this that hers is a restless sleep and he relies upon the precedent of the myth of Ariadne to supply a narrative about her past and her future which corresponds to the moment of agitated, grief-induced sleep in Ariadne's tale. This dream-like narrative expansion is analogous to that of the narrator of 1.3. Acknowledging the external force of sleep which has subdued this Ariadne, Birt concentrates upon the apparent inner torment of the sleeping sculpture in his attempt to identify her with a familiar figure. By claiming that the Vatican Ariadne "stirs before us" ("Die Schlafende regt sich vor uns," page 38), Birt confirms the paradox of the sleeping sculpture. Once she is invested with life, and, thus, the potential for awakening from sleep, she lacks only a narrative to begin the process of imagining what lies in store for her once she opens her eyes to the world as it has transformed during her slumber.

Ariadne, the figure who links Catullus 64 and Propertius 1.3, is one of the paradigmatic sleeping figures in ancient art. In her exhaustive, chronological study of representations of Ariadne asleep in Greek vase painting through Campanian wall painting, Sheila McNally has defined Ariadne's sleep as a "sleep of transformation... that brings sleepers into new relationships with others or with themselves". This has two sub-categories, "one in which the change comes from within and one in which it is



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imposed."[224] She places the Vatican Ariadne in the first category and the wall-paintings of Ariadne, in which she is typically being approached by Dionysus' retinue, in the latter. Thus the first type of change is psychological, internal, and not explicated by narrative; waking from this experience involves a change in self-perception. The second involves a change necessitated by external circumstance, usually the arrival of another figure on the scene.

How does a viewer interact with a lone sleeping figure when he has no visual cues to work with other than the sleeper itself (as in the case of the Vatican Ariadne)? How does this relationship change when there are other characters or elements added to the scene (as in the case of the painting from the House of the Citharist at Pompeii)?[225] In an attempt to answer these questions, my discussion will move away from Ariadne toward two well-known but less-discussed sleeping figures, the solitary sleeping hermaphrodite and Rhea Silvia, mother of Romulus and Remus, whose slumber attracts the god Mars. Rhea Silvia's transformative sleep contains both types of change described by McNally: if we consider literary accounts of her story, Rhea Silvia experiences internal change as she dreams of Mars' arrival and the results of their encounter, her pregnancy. But her sleep is also the circumstance which allows for Mars' approach and rape; this change, "imposed" from the outside, is most commonly evoked in artistic representation. Furthermore, there are compelling parallels between Cynthia

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[224] McNally (1985) 192. For other recent treatments of Ariadne in art, see Fredrick (1995) and Gallo (1988).

[225] For a fairly clear reproduction of this fresco, see Zanker (2004) 163, figure 148; for a more legible drawing of this image, see McNally (1985) figure 24, plate XXI.



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as she is discovered and observed by the narrator in 1.3 and Rhea Silvia as she is approached by Mars in textual and visual contexts. My analysis of the function of sleep and the role of the sleeper in Propertius 1.3 will serve as a template for the subsequent discussion of the role of the sleeping figure in Roman art.

**Representing the Solitary Sleeping Figure in the Visual Arts**

As I have discussed above with regard to Propertius 1.3, the viewer's desire to know the internal, psychological circumstances of a sleeper's repose, and even his or her dream, is an important part of their interaction. The narrator of Propertius 1.3 takes advantage of Cynthia's sleep to pose her with different props; when she stirs, his curiosity leads him to imagine her dream. A similar curiosity and sustained examination led Theodor Birt to identify a sleeping sculpture in the Vatican as a depiction of Ariadne tormented in sleep. But the representation of actual dreams is extremely scarce in ancient art. One exception to this might be seen in a relief panel from the late Hellenistic period, which depicts a sleeping male figure, possibly a shepherd, having sex in his sleep.[226] In this image we see a bearded man sprawled on the ground with his arms bent behind his head indicating abandonment in slumber. A winged female alights upon him just above his erect penis. Because of her wings and bird-like feet the viewer recognizes that she is not human; she could be a divine figure visiting the sleeper, or a

[226] For a reproduction of this relief see Johns (1982) 106, figure 87. Another series of images which may depict dreams are the so-called "kat'onar" inscriptions from Asclepius temples. Many of these were votives left by people who had been healed at the sanctuaries, depicting their visits from the healing god or from various temple attendants in dreams. Some appear to show the dream subjectively, from the point of view of the dreamer, while others provide an objective view of the scene. See van Straten (1976) for a catalogue and discussion of these.



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figure imagined by the sleeper in his erotic dream.[227] It is impossible to distinguish between what the viewer sees objectively and what the sleeper sees internally, or to decide whether this is one and the same. Perhaps the female figure is an outward, visual manifestation of the pleasure that the sleeper experiences. Regardless of the ambiguity of the scene, it is unusual to see a sleeping figure actually physically engaged as this figure is. In the representations of sleepers which follow, as is most often the case, the sleeper is either alone, or being approached by another figure. Thus the narrative of the circumstances of his or her sleep, as well as the substance of his or her dream, are left to the imagination of the viewer.[228]

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[227] As Sorabella (2000) suggests, "the picture recalls the *incubo* of Latin folklore, an erotic nightmare spirit that was supposed to land on men and smother them in their sleep," 186. See also Vermeule and Comstock (1976) 72, who call the winged female creature a "Lasa" (an Etruscan deity who guarded lovers and the dead). Other attempts to give this unfamiliar creature an identity through analogy include that of Johns (1982), who calls her a Siren, and Brendel (1970), who compares her to the medieval incubus. As they also point out, she holds a vessel in her left hand, from which some liquid pours past the sleeper's feet to the ground. If we can connect this with the soporific which Somnus is often shown pouring from a horn onto the sleeper (this is the subject of the following chapter), this may imply that she is also responsible for inducing and/or maintaining sleep for the duration of the dream.

[228] This image provides an interesting parallel for the scenario of elegy 4.7, discussed in chapter 1. The ambiguity surrounding whether the narrator is asleep or is just primed for sleep is of interest for understanding the ambiguous physicality of the dreamed image. Is she the exclusive property of the dreaming viewer, or is the figure seen by the dreamer something that can also be seen from the outside? Papanghelis (1987) 158, in his analysis of Propertius' mingling of the funereal and the erotic in this poem, writes that "it is important to remember that the Cynthia of 4.7 is a lustful incubus who stands half-way between Subura lewdness and sepulchral libido." It is helpful to think of this dream-vision of Cynthia as a mix of the living and the dead, the tangible and the intangible, for this gets at the central point of intrigue regarding the notion of the visitation dream. Just as this winged figure seems to ensure sleep with her poured potion while she also takes advantage of the shepherd's sleep to cause him pleasure or destruction, Cynthia in 4.7 imitates sleep in her leaning over the narrator's bed in place of the sleep which eludes the narrator. In this position of power, she shifts back and forth between erotic and destructive discourses. The overlap between eroticism and death is made explicit in the threatening and unmistakably erotic interaction between the shepherd and his visitor. While Cynthia conveys this overlay in words, the winged figure in the relief conveys this in her physical engagement with the sleeper, which, as I have stated, is very rare in artistic representations of sleepers. This makes sense, for Cynthia is known to the narrator, while the effectiveness of the figure depicted in the image lies in the fact that she is foreign, not human, and, presumably, unknown to the sleeper. This is one more way in which the familiarity of Cynthia



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The figure of the sleeping hermaphrodite, a sculptural type which likely dates in origin to the second century B.C., is undoubtedly one of the most recognizable sleeping figures from antiquity.[229] There are seven such figures extant and scattered around the museums of Europe. Consider the one in the Palazzo Massimo museum in Rome, which is just smaller than life size and has predominantly female characteristics, with the exception of its erect penis. The figure appears to sleep fitfully, as its right leg is taut and its clothing is pulled tightly and bunched around the lower and upper parts of its body, as though it has been tossing about and is poised to roll over into a new position. It is generally argued that this figure was meant to be approached from the back, where the buttocks and face would be visible to the viewer and the torsion of the sleeping body would lure the viewer around to the front.[230] Once the viewer had made this transition, he would see the juxtaposition of the figure's left breast and male genitals. In the analysis which follows I will concentrate less upon the explicit erotic appeal of this sculpture's surprise, or its ability to shift the power dynamics between sleeper and viewer, in favor of giving attention to the role of sleep in the appeal of this sculpture. Of course, these three facets are inter-dependent, but I am more interested in how the figure's sleep engenders surprise and vulnerability on the part of the viewer, by

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becomes distorted into unfamiliarity. By appropriating some of the qualities of the legendarily threatening female demon, she becomes believable as a figure who exists outside of the sleeper's consciousness and memory of her. This combination contributes to the effectiveness of her ambiguous stance as imagined and externalized.

[229] See Ajootian, *LIMC*, vol. V.2 (1990) 193, no 56c.

[230] See Sorabella (2000) ch. 5, for particular emphasis upon the figure's sleep, Clarke (1998), Stewart (1997), and Ajootian (1997), who posits the apotropaic qualities of the sculpture, for recent representative discussions of this figure and its function in space.



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concentrating upon two features of the viewer's interaction with the sleeping hermaphrodite. The first is the viewer's fascination with the mystery of the sleeping figure and his or her desire to question the sleeper visually, since he is unable to engage the sleeper with words. The second is the trickery and deceit of the sleeping figure, whose closed eyes create an opacity which masks their dreams.

Just as sleep created a boundary across which Cynthia transformed from mysterious figure accessible only through analogy with mythological scenes, back into animated girlfriend, we see a sort of metamorphosis in the case of the sleeping hermaphrodite figure. Here the figure itself morphs across the threshold of sleep, but not by waking up; instead, its sleep facilitates discovery of its duality by the viewer. As John Clarke writes, "Hermaphroditus remains a disquieting visual reminder that things are not always what they seem."[231] I will argue in this section that the gender ambiguity of the hermaphrodite is underscored and amplified by the figure's state of sleep. The thwarting of understanding which Clarke claims is fundamental to the representation of Hermaphroditus in art is also, I would argue, essential to the depiction of the sleeper in art. The fact that the two are combined in the late Hellenistic figure of the sleeping hermaphrodite will provide a good point of departure for my discussion of the representation of the sleeper in art and the interaction between sleeper and viewer in these contexts.

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[231] Clarke (1998) 54-55.



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Jean Sorabella has argued in a recent dissertation for reconnecting the sleeping hermaphrodite with the notion of metamorphosis; for, after all, Ovid told the tale of the origin of the bisexual Hermaphroditus as the result of metamorphosis involving the conjoining of two beings, one originally male and one originally female.[232] Sorabella speculates that "the hermaphrodite [sculpture] might not be a stable entity, but a woman becoming a man from the penis out, or a man becoming a woman in the other direction."[233] The figure itself is actually changing in the process of sleep. In this reading, sleep becomes essential to the story as the vehicle for significant change, albeit a change of which the one enduring it is itself unaware. This would heighten the viewer's surprise, as he or she would be experiencing a change in perception as the figure in flux underwent a physical shift. Perhaps the viewer would also feel a sense of privilege as he witnessed the transformation of the figure before him in advance of the figure's awareness of it.

While the sleeping hermaphrodite may be dreaming of and enacting a physical transformation, it is also possible that the viewer himself experiences something dream-like in his encounter with the sculpture. Sorabella suggests this when she writes that "[i]n ancient eyes or modern, discovering the hermaphrodite may feel like an awakening, if not to plain reality, then to a dream. The statue might represent a dream image or depict a creature transformed by a dream. Combined of both sexes, it is also split

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[232] Ovid's tale of Hermaphroditus and Salmacis appears in *Metamorphoses* book 4.285-388.

[233] Sorabella (2000) 152. A few lines earlier she had written, "for the hermaphrodite, sleep would be a natural response to the trauma of metamorphosis," implying that the body would become inanimate during the violent process of change and would wake up a new being.



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between possibility and fantasy."[234] As I proposed with regard to the role of narrator/viewer and the sleeping Cynthia earlier in this section, there is a degree to which the narrator's description of his impression of the sleeping figure before him and the transformation she undergoes in his presence are dream-like. Could it be the case that the viewer's interaction with the sleeping hermaphrodite, at once mysterious and monstrous in its hybridity, is like an image one might see in a dream? Just as the narrator of Propertius 1.3 challenged his expectations for his girlfriend's behavior by attempting to manipulate her in sleep, but then met her wrath when she awoke, the viewer of the sleeping hermaphrodite has his expectations inverted when he makes his circuit around it.

The hermaphrodite is, we might say, a metamorphosis arrested at the point of hybridity. The characterization of the sleeping hermaphrodite as a dream image is further bolstered by Lucretius' account of the origin of impossible hybrid images such as centaurs, mermaids and the equally unrealistic metamorphic re-animated phantoms of the dead in book 4.732-744 and 757-764.[235] While Lucretius does not say that hybrids such as centaurs are actually seen in dreams, he equates the perceptual flaw that creates such credible hybrids with that which animates the dead in sleep. Visions of the dead, common in the context of dreams, and hybrid forms, common misperceptions caused by the joining of flimsy films, deceive in similar ways the mind of the one who claims to

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[234] Sorabella (2000) 153.

[235] Cf. also book 5.878-881, where the existence of Centaurs and Scyllas is dismissed with a physical explanation of the incompatibility of species.



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see them.[236] Thus Lucretius' argument about hybridity and animation of the dead connects the acts of dreaming and viewing through the shared instances of the mind's unreliable perception. The sleeping hermaphrodite is also a hybrid form which shares anatomically impossible characteristics with the composites of a sleeper's misperception. As many have argued, the sculpted hermaphrodites do not resemble the biological condition of the hermaphrodite, whose existence was both known to and feared by the Romans. Thus, the hermaphrodite as depicted in art is a hybrid of an essentially female form with the male genitals appended, rather than a biological hermaphrodite which displayed a balance of both female and male characteristics. So beyond being a sleeper who may dream, the sleeping hermaphrodite is a sleeper who embodies the essence of a dream through its hint at metamorphosis and its embodiment of hybridity. This has interesting implications for the scenario of the viewer's interaction with the sculpture, as its pose was likely constructed to thwart expectation and to distort the viewer's perception of a seemingly familiar form.

The sleeping hermaphrodite is a perfect illustration of the sequence of viewer curiosity about the mystery of the sleeping figure and his desire to learn more about the sleeper. The element of viewer surprise, which is built into these figures, is reminiscent of the dynamic of interaction between the narrator of Propertius 1.3 and the sleeping Cynthia. In the case of the hermaphrodite, the immobility and reticence of the sleeper invites the viewer's movement, which, in turn, reveals the sleeper's surprise; in the

[236] While Lucretius' argument about hybrids reflects more his desire to explicate the nature of perception, than a general Roman attitude toward the nature of dream images, his theory is nonetheless helpful as it groups together the realms of myth, dream and imagined forms.



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context of Propertius' poem it is Cynthia who reveals her surprise--in the form of her change in temperament--to her lover upon waking. In each case desire motivates the viewer to engage with the sleeper, and in each case the seeming availability of the sleeper gives way to a revelation that shocks the viewer. The difference between the two is that in the poem, the narrator knows the sleeping figure, his lover Cynthia, and is drawn to her as she sleeps perhaps *because* her power seems diffused by the state of sleep. With the hermaphrodite, it is the curiosity of the unknown which lures the viewer, and the shock of the unfamiliar which completes the experience. For the poem's narrator, Cynthia's tirade at the poem's end can only be partially shocking, since it is likely this very scene which he has been trying to stave off by not waking her.

The chiastic sleeping hermaphrodite is undoubtedly designed to play a trick on its curious and lustful viewer. It is the vulnerability caused by sleep which allows for the viewer's lack of inhibition, and the ultimate identification of the sleeping "nymph's" ambiguous sex is thus an accident of the viewer's interaction with the sculpture. It is worth considering, however, that the viewer's curiosity is also prompted by the intrigue of the sleeper as an inscrutable figure. Thus the inherent allure of the sleeping form is exploited by the artist as it is combined with the accentuation of the naturally alluring young female buttocks as part of the seduction of the viewer. The viewer may be curious about what the sleeping hermaphrodite is dreaming. Andrew Stewart suggests that perhaps these creatures are "dreaming of the vanished Golden Age which they once



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inhabited."[237] But perhaps the viewer imagines that the sleeping girl dreams of sex and will awake to find her dream fulfilled by the arrival of the viewer. There is more to be gleaned from the study of this sculpture than simply figuring out and laughing about its joke. After all, the figure is still sleeping even after its potential violator has been surprised and thwarted; does that imply that his curiosity about the creature ends? Thus sleep is both a vehicle for seduction and a metaphor for inaccessibility. On the one hand, by solving its riddle, the viewer of the sleeping hermaphrodite comes closer to understanding the mystery of its sleep; on the other hand, once he has been tricked, the viewer is still without information about what the hermaphrodite is dreaming or the circumstances of its sleep.

The sleeping hermaphrodite mediates between the physical and the intangible, the state of sleep and the ephemera of the dream, the familiarity of the female form and the unfamiliar hybridity of a monstrum. Because it is a solitary figure, however, it offers no more than this to the viewer. Like the restless Vatican Ariadne, the hermaphrodite may have a story to tell, whether or not it is one familiar from mythology, as Birt supplies for the sleeping female sculpture. In the following section I will turn to images of sleepers whose sleep forms part of a narrative. The viewer of these images is not interactive with the sleepers, but rather imitative of the internal viewers of these scenes. The appeal of these images lies in imagining the sleeper's dream from a narrative already known by the viewer and inspired by prompts within the image itself.

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[237] Stewart (1997) 229-30. This is a reference to Plato's account in the *Symposium* of the bisexual creatures who inhabited the earth happily before the establishment of two sexes.



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**Narrating the Sleeping Figure: Rhea Silvia in Roman art**

In this section I will focus upon the dynamics of viewing the recumbent Rhea Silvia in a variety of artistic contexts. The images which I have chosen contain other characters, most notably the god Mars, whose interaction with Rhea Silvia establishes the scene as a narrative. The familiarity of this narrative would have been ensured by accounts in Roman literature of the circumstances of this encounter. Thus the wealth of representations Mars approaching the sleeping Rhea Silvia in Roman art and the textual accounts of her retelling of this experience as a dream work in tandem to focus the viewer's imagination upon the actual moment of her conception of Romulus and Remus and the subsequent growth of Rome's glory as a result. My discussion will focus upon the important role of the viewer's knowledge of the narrative progression of Rhea Silvia's story in looking at representations of her asleep.

The connection between Rhea Silvia's rape and her dream has early precedent in Ennius' *Annales* and later corroboration in Ovid's *Fasti*. In Ennius' account [Cicero, *De Div.*, 1.40-41; 1.34-50, Skutsch], Ilia's (Rhea Silvia's) reaction upon waking from her dream is to relay its narrative to her sister (lines 36-42):[238]

> *Eurydica prognata, pater quam noster amavit,*
> *Vires vitaque corpus meum nunc deserit omne.*
> *Nam me visus homo pulcer per amoena salicta*
> *Et ripas raptare locosque novos. ita sola*

[238] See Goldberg (1995) 95-101 for the suggestion that Ilia merely casts the terrifying events of her night as a dream as a better way to explain the unusual experience. See also Krevans (1993) and Connors (1994) for extensive discussion of this passage. Ennius' description of Ilia's dream likely set the tone for later incarnations of her story by Livy and Ovid (discussed below). In Ennius' account, Ilia's dream experience is a metaphor for her rape by Mars, while in Livy's it is a possible excuse for it. Ovid recasts the dream as a symbolic prophecy of the consequences of the rape.



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*postilla, germana soror, errare videbar*
*tardaque vestigare et quaerere te neque posse*
*corde capessere: semita nulla pedem stabilibat.*

Sister Eurydice, whom our father loved,
strength and life have now fled my every limb.
A handsome man seemed to steal me away through
pleasant willow groves and along river banks, strange places.
Thus I seemed afterwards to wander alone,
my sister, and to track you slowly and to seek you,
and I was unable to accomplish this though I longed to:
no path steadied my foot.[239]

Just as the reader of Ennius dwells upon the descriptive contents of Ilia's dream as she retells it, imagining the scene and her captor, the viewer visualizes her dream from representations of her surroundings and of Mars' visit to her in various contexts in Roman art. In the *Annales*, the importance with which Ilia invests her story of an encounter with an unknown man (line 38) and her unsure steps (line 42) evoke the qualities of a dream as it is experienced. This description gives the reader a sense of what Ilia may have seen and felt subjectively as the dreamer; while the artistic representations may also furnish this, it is possible that they depict an objective view, namely that which an outside viewer might have seen as Ilia lay asleep and dreaming.[240]

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[239] Translation my own, after Goldberg (1995).

[240] In his account of the story, Livy makes reference to the ambiguous patrimony of the twins by providing two options; either Rhea Silvia believed that Mars was actually their father, or she invented this story to add dignity to her transgression (*Vi compressa Vestalis cum geminum partum edidisset, seu ita rata seu quia deus auctor culpae honestior erat, Martem incertae stirpis patrem nuncupat,* 1.4.2). Although Livy does not mention the dream as a feature of Rhea Silvia's story, the dichotomy he presents underscores the problem inherent in relying on a dream narrative to convey an experience believed to be true: was the dreamer actually experiencing what she claims, or is this a metaphor for the magnitude of the incident in her mind? The phrase *seu ita rata* might remind us of the narrator's interjection *ut reor* in Propertius 3.3.38. In both cases the reader/listener is reminded of the persuasiveness of a narrator's or dreamer's conviction in what he or she has seen.



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Just as the reader infers from her account that the dream held a message about the outcome of the rape (lines 44-45), so too when the viewer looks at a visual representation of the prelude to the rape, is he meant to think of what it foreshadows of the future.

The images of Rhea Silvia asleep comprise part of an iconographic type, that of a sleeping figure being approached by a deity who dominates the vertical plane of the image. Images of Bacchus and Ariadne, and Selene and Endymion are also included in this type. In the majority of these representations the approach of the immortal figure and the apparent vulnerability and passivity of the sleeper reveals the scene's erotic potential.[241] In the case of Ariadne, as I have already discussed, her sleep provides a transition from bereavement to rescue, and thus, the amorous encounter which the scene hints at will occur after she wakes up. Sleep enables the exchange of a perfidious lover for a faithful husband. Endymion, another popular sleeping subject, and Rhea Silvia are different. Their encounters with their lovers, enjoyable and frightening respectively, are defined by the parameters of the night and enabled by their sleep. Therefore, their night time encounters, like that of the sleeping shepherd in the Boston frieze, could be

[241] See Propertius 2.15, for the eroticism of the Endymion story (discussed in chapter 1). Propertius writes *nudus et Endymion Phoebi cepisse sororem / dicitur et nudus concubuisse deae* (lines 15-16). These lines form part of the poet's praise of vision as a stimulus for love, *oculi sunt in amore duces* (line 12), so Endymion's nude body becomes an essential part of his allure, both for Selene and, in artistic representation, for the external viewer. Although his sleep is not mentioned, the repetition of the adjective *nudus* implies the vulnerability of Endymion both to the gaze and the approach of the goddess, which would also be facilitated by sleep. Endymion's nudity, often facilitated by Somnus removing his clothing, is a common feature of his depiction on sarcophagi.



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classified as dreams.[242] Endymion's nocturnal experience, however, has no lasting consequences (beyond its immediate pleasure), as he is fated to repeat this delight every night. In fact, his sleep is more like that of Ariadne in the sense that it is the vehicle for a long-lasting union between a mortal and a deity. The encounter between Rhea Silvia and Mars is a singular event, and it is the consequence of this decisive experience in which I locate the potency of the image's effect on the viewer.

As Michael Koortbojian has observed with regard to images of Rhea Silvia, "it is, [therefore] not the image that *we* see but the one that *she* sees that constitutes the truly significant image of the story and bears the fundamental content of the myth."[243] So viewers of these images see the content of her dream as they look upon her dreaming, and, in a sense, dream along with her. It is the viewer's privilege to share in the dream of the sleeping figure as the narrator of Propertius 1.3 had so longed to do. Regardless of the different compositional elements of these images that might have served as cues for thinking of the aftermath of the union of Mars and Rhea Silvia, I think that the viewer was meant to ponder the implications of their nocturnal encounter in every representation of her. Using a sample of different types of representation, this section aims to show how Roman artists achieved this, while it refers back to the features typical of the interaction between sleeper and waking viewer established in the earlier portions of this chapter.

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[242] See Koortbojian (1995) 105-06 on Endymion's experience as a dream and similarities to Rhea Silvia's experience in the context of their juxtaposition on a particular sarcophagus.

[243] Ibid., 103.



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Two wall-paintings from the first century B.C. contain depictions of Rhea Silvia's story.[244] The first, a portion of the fresco from the columbarium of the Statilii on the Esquiline, contains a narrative of the founding of Rome going back to Aeneas and the founding of Lavinium; its story is told chronologically from left to right.[245] In this image, we see the encounter between Mars and Rhea Silvia. In this example, Rhea Silvia is not asleep; rather, the figures stand facing one another, as though Mars has interrupted the vestal on her way to fill her water jug. The scene of her encounter is surrounded on either side by the related scenes of her becoming a vestal priestess and, afterwards, being punished for her transgression, so the emphasis here seems to be upon Rhea Silvia's deviance and condemnation, rather than upon the ambiguous circumstances of her own experience, or the dream and its outcome. This image is an exception to the great majority of images of Rhea Silvia in Roman art, but it still contains one element shared by the literary and other artistic accounts, namely the element of surprise which is implicit in the images of Rhea Silvia asleep and articulated in the confused dream narratives of Ennius and Ovid. This iconographic and narrative link is the water jug which lies on its side at Rhea Silvia's feet. The water jug here could be interpreted as a symbol of fecundity.[246] While the presence of the jug may also

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[244] There is a series of gems from the second c. B.C. which depicts Mars approaching Rhea Silvia asleep. These may be the earliest representations of the pair in Roman art. See Albertson (1987) 455 for mention of these.

[245] For the relevant portion of the fresco, see Carandini (2000) 161 or Alföldi (1950) 9, table III, figure 2, for a more legible drawing.

[246] In Ovid's account in *Fasti* 3 (which postdates this fresco), the image of the water jug bookends Rhea Silvia's encounter with Mars and has a direct correlation to her pregnancy. She places the empty jug on



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indicate the location of the encounter near the river (as Rhea Silvia was on her way to collect water when she was waylaid by Mars), I think it could also draw attention to the abrupt interruption of Mars' intervention and the element of surprise which reveals the unexpectedness of the god's arrival. The position of the jug dropped and left on its side hints at the suddenness of the encounter between the mismatched parents of Romulus and Remus. This element, however it is articulated, links this image with its counterparts in which Rhea Silvia is asleep during her strange encounter.

A second wall-painting known as the "origins of Rome" fresco from the house of Fabius Secundus at Pompeii, provides another early clue to the representation of Rhea Silvia's experience.[247] Christopher Dawson speculates that both motifs--the sleeping and the waking Rhea Silvia-- co-existed until the Augustan period, when the Ovidian version of Rhea Silvia's encounter with Mars during her sleep began to predominate and eventually replaced the other.[248] The "origins of Rome" fresco presents a synoptic view

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the ground as the first indication that she is growing tired and wishes to rest: *ponitur e summa fictilis urna coma / fessa resedit humo* (lines 14-15). When she has finished recounting her dream, she picks up the water jug which, as Ovid tells the reader, she has filled while recounting her dream: *dixerat et plenam non firmis viribus urnam / sustulit; inplorat, dum sua visa refert.* (lines 39-40). Thus the water in the jug becomes a metaphor for her pregnancy; the dream images of her offspring "fill" the jug as she relates them. Cf. the prominence of the water jug in a mosaic from Ostia, discussed in detail below.

[247] The original of this painting (in a poor state of preservation) with several images of details can be seen in Carandini (2000) 264; see 166 for a legible drawing.

[248] Dawson (1965, 1st ed. 1943) 169. Fred C. Albertson (1987) has also argued that the sleeping Rhea Silvia became more popular and began to dominate after the Augustan period. His argument hinges upon the dating of a sculpted frieze which shows lictors passing before a large temple to the Claudian period (see Alberston (1987) 442, figures 1 & 2). Arguing in part from the style of the lictors' clothing, he asserts that the temple in the background, whose pediment displays the sculpted figures of Rhea Silvia asleep and Mars approaching her, represents a major Augustan monument. He believes that the composition of this pediment influenced subsequent representations of the story. But Albertson's explanation does not investigate why in particular this image, that of the sleeping figure about to be impregnated by the god, came to dominate. Glenda Swan (2001) 69, in her speculation about the reasons



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of the story, rather than the elongated, diachronic panel version of the Esquiline fresco. Perhaps it was this synopsis which eventually lent itself to the single 'snapshot' image of Mars approaching Rhea Silvia as the marker for the entire tale. Thus we can imagine that the viewers of these "snapshot" images had the precedent of earlier narrative pieces such as these frescoes (in addition to literary material) to facilitate their imagination of the aftermath of this scene.

Let us look closely at the "origins of Rome" fresco. The landscape of this image presents a realm, somewhat like a dreamscape, in which elements of the temporal narrative could easily merge. Scholars have generally accepted that the painting presents a chronological progression in synoptic view. Reading the image from top to bottom, we see Mars approaching the sleeping Rhea Silvia in the top right; a group of men, possibly the priests of Mars, watching in awe on the left; a scene of Rhea Silvia being punished with death for violating her virginity below them (partially destroyed); and, at the bottom, Mercury showing a female figure the wolf suckling the twins. While the traditional focus of scholarship on this fresco has concentrated upon identifying the various figures in the panel, Glenda Swan presents an innovative argument in her dissertation, the most recent treatment of this fresco. She claims that, rather than presenting two scenes from Rhea Silvia's life, and another from her death, it shows the

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for the shift, writes that the "sleeping Rhea Silvia has much to recommend it...it allowed poets to combine Rhea Silvia's somnolent ravishment with her prodigious dream that predicts the greatness of Rome. It also makes her clearly innocent of any potential sacrilege, making her a more suitable mother figure." We could also apply Swan's first explanation of the opportunities created by representations of this scene in art for the viewer's extrapolation of narrative.



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contents of Rhea Silvia's dream.[249] Swan's interpretation hinges upon the function of the figure of Mercury, who appears to show Rhea Silvia her sons, Romulus and Remus at the bottom of the panel. According to Swan, Mercury plays the role of "conductor of dreams" rather than that of psychopomp, so that the viewer should imagine Rhea Silvia alive and dreaming this scene, rather than dead and watching her sons flourish from the underworld. Thus, if we follow Swan's argument, this depiction from the Augustan period translates the dreamer's experience into a narrative sequence with a literal representation of the fruit of her union with Mars. It is helpful to keep the composition of this panel in mind as we turn to subsequent images of the encounter between Mars and Rhea Silvia from which the viewer is meant to imagine the fruitful outcome of the rape.

Images of the sleeping Rhea Silvia in an extended narrative seem to disappear after the Augustan period, only to return in a serialized form, in the unique Ara Casali, discussion of which will end this chapter.[250] What we see in the meantime in examples from diverse media, are snapshot images of Mars in the vertical plane approaching Rhea

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[249] Swan (2001) argues against the traditional view held by Dawson (1965) and others that the painting depicts the chronological progression of the defining moments of Rhea Silvia's life: her rape by Mars, her punishment for pregnancy, and her "Nachleben", namely the survival of her young sons Romulus and Remus, shown to her after her death. O. Elia (1932) 84 writes, for example, that "la rappresentazione è distribuita in tre piani che costituiscono tre fasi e momenti del mito". Thus she interprets the painting as a progression of three vignettes from Rhea Silvia's narrative. See also Marconi (1929) for this idea and Dawson (1965) 104, who writes, "the continuous narrative style is fully developed in this painting". More recent scholarship on this topic, for example, the essay by Rosanna Cappelli in Carandini (2000) 167 in the catalogue to a show on Rome's foundation tales writes, "I singoli episodi del mito si svolgono in ordinata successione temporale su tre registri, dall'alto verso il basso". Swan also reads the youthful portrayal of Tiber at the bottom left of the image as an allusion to Rhea Silvia's marriage to the river god, another preview of the aftermath of her rape by Mars and subsequent banishment.

[250] Following the argumentation of Albertson (1990), the Ara Casali dates to the early fourth century A.D.



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Silvia as she lies horizontally.[251] The image of the approach of Mars is loaded with potential: the central figures are usually close enough that their future intimacy is suggested, while their lack of actual connection reinforces its distance from the present moment. The visible progress of Mars' movement (his bold stride is sometimes accentuated by his fluttering cape) also hints at the progress of the narrative into subsequent episodes beyond this isolated scene. As the viewer is prompted to envision the encounter alluded to by the approach, he may also be inspired to think beyond it to its outcome. Mars' aggressive approach and its connotations of futurity and imminent action seem to collapse present and future into one image. In the section which follows, I will concentrate upon three images of the approach of Mars to the sleeping Rhea Silvia, one relief panel from about the second century A.D., one mosaic from the Hadrianic period at Ostia, and one sarcophagus from the mid-third century A.D.[252]

In the Belvedere relief, we see Mars approaching Rhea Silvia from the right,[253] armed and with his cape billowing out behind him almost vertically.[254] In fact, his

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[251] This is consistent with Juvenal's description of Mars' approach in *Satire* 11.106-107: *...geminos sub rupe Quirinos, / ac nudam effigiem clipeo venientis et hasta.*

[252] There are other images which present the scene of the approach of Mars to the sleeping Rhea Silvia on gems, coins, and in other media. Examples include the lost painting from the ceiling of a corridor at the Domus Aurea and the rectangular limestone relief likely from the second century A.D. in the National Museum in Budapest. The examples discussed above are intended to be representative.

[253] See Andreae et al. (1998) 220, no. 36 (PN1). This composition is unusual. Mars is most often depicted approaching Rhea Silvia from the left, as in the "origins of Rome" fresco, e.g.

[254] Vermeule (1957) 294 dates the panel to the second century A.D. His dating is based upon his dating of the "lictors frieze" to the second century A.D. He argues that the temple in the background is the Hadrianic Temple of Venus and Roma. He writes "within the century of its execution the pedimental group of Hadrian's temple as interpreted in the Terme relief also inspired a copy of the composition in a



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verticality, while forced by the shape of the panel, is enhanced by the upward flow of his cape and the nearly full vertical extension of his right leg. This contrasts further with the emphatic horizontality of the sleeping Rhea Silvia, who stretches out on top of a rocky bed of segmented stones. Since we have no evidence for the context of this panel, we cannot say definitively whether there were representations of other scenes from the foundation of Rome depicted on other surfaces of the object it decorated. Carlo Pietrangeli reconstructed a plinth with a cast of this panel for the Mostra Augustea in 1937/1938, combining it with matching panels also in the Vatican Museums. From a photograph we see images of tropaea on one contiguous side; this motif was presumably repeated on the other side of the panel, too, but it is unclear whether the fourth panel would have displayed a figural scene.[255] But because we know from the panel's borders that it was marked off as a distinct scene, it is a good starting point for the discussion of the "snapshot" images of Mars and Rhea Silvia.

The image on the Belvedere relief hints at the unity between divine and earthly through its juxtaposition of vertical and horizontal protagonists. This union underscores the unusual circumstances of the birth of the twins from a one-time and unanticipated encounter between two figures unfamiliar to one another. The contrast between the horizontal immobility of the sleeping figure and the liveliness of Mars' vertical descent reinforces their disparity. As the story of Romulus and Remus is one of triumph over

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relief now walled up in the Vatican Belvedere." See Albertson (1987) for an earlier dating as discussed in note 67.

[255] Pietrangeli (1943) table V.



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seemingly insurmountable obstacles placed in the way of the twins' success,[256] the inscrutability of the sleeping figure, and the violation of her sleep provide the first indication of the mysterious and difficult circumstances under which the future founder of Rome will rise to power. Furthermore, the fact that their conception occurs during sleep and is recounted in a dream sets the tone for the secrecy that will surround their survival. Without having to depict the actual encounter between Mars and Rhea Silvia, the artist of the panel conveys the strange circumstances of the conception and early life of Rome's founder which, in the literary accounts, are transformed into the strangeness of a frightening dream. The tension between their opposing planes and their degree of movement reflects the difference between sleeper and waking figure: the sleeping Rhea Silvia is completely exposed to the advance of Mars, whose forward movement indicates their imminent encounter. Likewise, Mars' lofty suspension and Rhea Silvia's connection to the earth allude to the remainder of the tale. While Mars will continue to be ethereal, as his presence in the narrative is temporary, Rhea Silvia's fate will be connected to the natural world: childbirth, the river, the wolf and the shepherd.

We see a similar composition in a second century A.D. mosaic from Ostia, another self-contained "snapshot" of the moment of encounter between Mars and Rhea Silvia.[257] In this image, Mars approaches from the left (the more common direction) with a less severe degree of verticality. Rhea Silvia lies asleep with her arms enfolded

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[256] Livy's remarks on the establishment of Rome's greatness hint at their extraordinary circumstances. He writes *sed debebatur, ut opinor, fatis tantae origo urbis maximique secundum deorum opes imperii principium* (1.4.1) and *forte quadam divinitus super ripas Tiberis effusus lenibus stagnis...* (1.4.4).

[257] See Becatti (1961) table CV, no. 59.



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atop a jug of water, from which a seemingly inexhaustible stream of water appears to flow. The flow of water as it is captured and frozen in this image both reminds the viewer of the illusion of the mosaic and hints at the progression of the narrative beyond this frame. Whereas the dropped and forgotten water jug in the Esquiline fresco demonstrated that Rhea Silvia had been interrupted on her way to draw water by the arrival of Mars, in this example, the flow of the water from the jug implies that she was interrupted first by sleep just after filling the jug. Perhaps the flow of water from the jug in the mosaic hints at the continuity of Rhea Silvia's sleep and, beyond that, at the continuation of the narrative and implications of this encounter for the future beyond this scene.[258] In this image, we can imagine that Mars will not so much interrupt her sleep as he will insinuate himself into it, leaving her to continue sleeping as she was while the water continues to flow.

In his 1943 article on this mosaic, Carlo Pietrangeli argued that this image illustrates the scene set by Ovid in the *Fasti* for Rhea Silvia's rape, claiming that the trees framing the scene were the very *umbrosae salices* of Ovid's description.[259] But this

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[258] Perhaps, as Pietrangeli suggests (1943) 7, the jug merely represents the presence of the river from which Rhea Silvia drew the water. There are, however, other ways to interpret the presence of the overflowing jug. The water from jug could remind the viewer of Rhea Silvia's chastity, about to seep away, no longer to be contained. The water may also represent Rhea Silvia as a source both for her immediate offspring, and, ultimately, for the Roman race.

[259] Ibid., 5; cf. Ovid *Fasti* 3.17-18: *dum sedet, umbrosae salices volucresque canorae / fecerunt somnos et leve murmur acquae.* Following Pietrangeli's strict correlation between text and image, is it not also possible that the trees could just as easily correspond to Ovid's description of the content of Rhea Silvia's dream of her sons as growing trees (*duae...palmae)?* Cf. Ovid *Fasti* 3.31-34, *inde duae pariter, visu mirabile, palmae / surgunt; ex illis altera maior erat, / et gravibus ramis totum protexerat orbem / contigeratque sua sidera summa coma.* This interpretation would also reinforce the idea that the viewer is seeing simultaneously the external circumstances for Rhea Silvia's rape and the symbolic imagery of her internal dream. This desire to see representations of the symbolic content of Rhea Silvia's dream has



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assessment, in a manner reminiscent of Theodor Birt's approach to Propertius 1.3, pushes the search for a correlation between textual and artistic representation too far; to begin with, the trees are hardly identifiable as willows, but furthermore, this type of observation adds little to our understanding of their compositional function in this specific context. For the trees in the mosaic play an important role as boundary markers between the advancing Mars and the stationary sleeping Rhea Silvia. As Giovanni Becatti observed in his initial report about the mosaic, Mars in his descent forms a triangle with the left-leaning tree at the viewer's right, thus showing us the height of Mars' suspension and his relative proximity to Rhea Silvia; the "alberello" at the bottom left continues the line of Mars' body.[260] How does this link between Mars' body and the trees affect Rhea Silvia's space in the scene? The angle of the trees as they bend in towards the sleeper creates a sort of protected enclosure around her. Mars, in his

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parallels in the work of Alföldi (1950), who argues that some gems from the first century B.C. contain representations of Rhea Silvia's dream (see Alföldi (1950) 3, table I, figures 5 and 6, for representative examples). The figure of Mars is absent in nearly all of these representations, and in some the female figure appears to stand rather than lie recumbent in sleep. What is of interest here is that this figure appears to be surrounded by images of grain, animals and trees, all of which have been interpreted as symbols of fertility. So rather than use the approach of Mars to hint at the conception and birth of Romulus and Remus, these gems would indicate the fertility of the twins' mother and hint at the subsequent generations of Romans through symbolic forms. Using evidence from Ovid's account of Rhea Silvia's rape and dream narrative in the *Fasti* and other literary and artistic sources, Alföldi sought to identify these images definitively as representations of Rhea Silvia's dreams, thus creating and populating a unique category of representations of dream symbols in ancient art. His claims have since been disputed by Fears (1977) and Koortbojian (1995), among others. Erika Simon (1957) 17-20 had argued that the sleeping figure was Atia, mother of Octavian, who was thought to have been impregnated by a serpent while asleep in Apollo's temple. While some of the symbols may be difficult to connect to fertility -- for example, Alföldi associates the eagle with the future power of Roman kings, rather than simply with the birth of Romulus and Remus -- it is more easily believable that the stalks of grain and the foliage that appear in these images are visual metaphors for pregnancy and fertility. Thus these gems would seem to reveal exactly what we as viewers wish to learn from a sleeping figure, that is, the content of her dreams and their implication for the future. The fact that these images appear to float detached from their proper context might increase the viewer's temptation to associate them with the symbols of Rhea Silvia's dream.

[260] Becatti (1961) 36.



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alignment with the physical, natural world both defines and encroaches upon Rhea Silvia's space. As his body remains above the sleeper, his shield crosses the boundary created by the angle of the trees. Thus the interior world of the sleeper, initially represented by the enclosure of the secluded grove, is violated by the approach of Mars, who, now aligned with the trees, threatens to cross this boundary into this protected space. Again we see evidence for Mars' association with the ethereal, while Rhea Silvia, resting upon her jug, is connected to the earth. The water which pours forth from the jug onto the earth furthers this connection.

A second point of interest in this image is the depth created by the black lines which connect the taller tree with the lower frame of the composition. These jagged lines create an additional boundary to the scene, as they meet up at almost a right angle with the horizontal line running across the bottom of the image parallel to Rhea Silvia's sleeping body. It is difficult to define what they are meant to represent in the context of this image. It is possible to interpret the horizontal line as the bank of the river from which Rhea Silvia has just fetched the water, and along which she rests just after accomplishing her task, although neither Becatti nor Pietrangeli suggest this. While Becatti interprets the vertical lines as streams of water flowing from the base of the tree and mingling with the water from the jug,[261] Pietrangeli suggests that these might be shadows cast by the branches of the tree.[262] Whether we read the lines as shadows or as

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[261] Ibid., 37.

[262] Pietrangeli (1943) 7. He also suggests that the line going towards the right from the smaller tree may represent its shadow. If this is the case, then the shadows of the trees work in concert to delineate even



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streams of water, their presence creates the illusion of depth in the flat plane of the image. Thus it becomes easier to imagine that the area where Rhea Silvia lies is marked off and somewhat isolated, thereby contributing to her obliviousness of Mars' approach.

The progression in this composition begins with Mars, moves to Rhea Silvia, and passes from her jug, through its water, to the tree on the right, where it seems to mingle with the tree's shadow. Perhaps this indicates symbolically the way in which Mars' might will be passed on to the Roman race through the intermediary of Rhea Silvia as a type of vessel. The artist's representation of Rhea Silvia's space as framed and secluded by trees gives the viewer an impression of her seeming oblivion to her imminent rape. Her detachment is reinforced by the position of her body: she is turned away from Mars facing the viewer; a sense of inevitability is mirrored in the water, which flows copiously from her overturned jug as Mars makes his easy approach.

On a sarcophagus from about 100 years later, we see a different mode for representing the narrative of Mars and Rhea Silvia, for here they are not alone, but rather surrounded by personifications and deities.[263] The intimacy of their space, however, is still maintained by the triangular shape formed by the vertical Mars and half-recumbent Rhea Silvia. The personified Somnus, subject of the following chapter, serves as an intermediary between the two and thus fills out the hypotenuse of the triangle familiar from the Ostia mosaic. As Robert points out in his catalogue entry, the figures of Mars

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more boldly the space enclosing Rhea Silvia as she sleeps. If, as Pietrangeli surmises, the white patch in the middle of the vertical lines represents the reflections of the trees in a pool of water, then we must imagine that the water which has poured from the jug has flowed in two directions, thereby creating a small moat on two sides of the sleeper.

[263] See Zanker and Ewald (2004) 214, figure 193.



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and Rhea Silvia are portraits, presumably of the couple who commissioned the sarcophagus.[264] Thus, interpretation of the mythological figures would have been tempered by this level of resonance for viewers, particularly those with some connection to the dead. The fact that both Mars and Rhea Silvia are represented as portraits here raises the important question of the owners' identification with the myth. What kind of model was Rhea Silvia supposed to present for the woman whose portrait she bore? Both Koortbojian and Zanker analyze the development of the Rhea Silvia type of sarcophagus as a conflation of the erotic connotations of the Dionysus-approaching-Ariadne or Selene-approaching-Endymion compositions with the traditional, nationalistic aspects of the scenes of Mars approaching the sleeping Rhea Silvia.[265] But rather than simply look at it as a variation on the nightly erotic sleep of Endymion or the sleep of Ariadne that gave way to divine rescue, I will now show how certain aspects of the earlier composition, particularly the prompts to extrapolate the narrative of Rome's founding, are maintained in this new funerary context.

The verticality of the striding Mars contrasts with Rhea Silvia's horizontal pose. Rhea Silvia is turned away from Mars, as she was in the Ostia mosaic, thus reinforcing her distance from him. In this instance, however, we notice a difference: Rhea Silvia has her eyes open. This may be a feature of the artist's desire for detailed accuracy in a portrait, but, as Robert suggests, it could also indicate that she is falling asleep while

[264] Robert (1904) 229. Although this is not the focus of my current study, perhaps we can make a connection between the impulse for portraiture on sarcophagi and Propertius' use of mythological analogy in poem 1.3. In both cases, the traits of the personal are overlaid with aspects of the mythological in order to import certain characteristics from the myth to the mundane.

[265] For more on this, see Koortbojian (1995) ch. 6 and Zanker and Ewald (2004) 215.



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thinking with her eyes open. Since she holds her arms in a pose typical for the sleeper, she must, at least, be on the verge of sleep.[266] It is certainly possible that Somnus has just arrived, almost simultaneously with Mars, and is shown putting Rhea Silvia to sleep just before the god's arrival. This may also account for Somnus' nervous backwards glance at the approaching deity. It is also possible, however, that Rhea Silvia has opened her eyes in a dream, that she is dreaming of Mars' approach as much as this is actually happening before the eyes of the viewer. Perhaps she envisions a scene not represented for the viewer, one which we as viewers are meant also to imagine. As the viewer sees Mars approaching Rhea Silvia, perhaps she is at that very moment experiencing the event as a symbolic dream, akin to the one she describes in Ovid's *Fasti,* in which the birth of Romulus and Remus, their escape from death, and Romulus' eventual supremacy are hinted at through visual metaphors.

The viewer is assisted in imagining the aftermath of the rape of Rhea Silvia at least in part by recalling the alternative story of the divine descent of the Roman people of an earlier generation through Aeneas and Venus. Venus presides proudly over the scene as she anticipates the second union between divine and mortal progenitors of a Roman king.[267] Her sandal-clad left foot punctuates the diagonal line formed by Mars' right shoulder and tilted gaze, Somnus' right arm, and Rhea Silvia's bent left arm, thereby connecting her to the narrative of Rome's founding. Venus thus reminds the

[266] Robert (1904) 229, "Weiter rechts liegt unter einem kleinen Eichbaum Rhea Silvia deshalb obgleich sicher schlafend oder richtiger einschlafend zu denken mit offenen Augen..."

[267] See Aichholzer (1983) 73 for a description of Venus' noticeably large presence. Also Zanker and Ewald (2004) 215.



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viewer of Rome's glorious divine lineage through Aeneas in the past and Romulus in the future. In fact, the viewer does not have to look far to see a depiction of the results of the union featured in the central panel, for the sarcophagus also contained a side-panel showing Romulus and Remus being suckled by the she-wolf.[268] According to the analyses of both Robert and Amelung, two sarcophagus side-panels, once in the Palazzo Mattei and now embedded into the wall of the Belvedere courtyard at the Vatican Musuems, were originally part of the Palazzo Mattei sarcophagus.[269] In addition to the correlation in width and height between the side-panels and the central panel of the sarcophagus, there is a second element which verifies the join. As Robert and Amelung point out, a Cupid hovers just beside the throne of Venus, beneath her left arm. From the front we see only his torso, but if we align this with the side panel, as Robert has shown, we are able to match the torso with a pair of child's legs afloat and dismembered beside the wolf. These earlier observations have particular significance for my study, as the physical continuity between the sides supports the imagined relationship between the tales depicted -- a connection that the central scene prompts the viewer to make. Thus if the viewer were to walk around to the right, following the direction in which Mars himself is moving and the direction of Rhea Silvia's gaze, he would see articulated the very outcome he had been prompted to imagine by the "snapshot" of Mars approaching

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[268] See Andreae et al. (1998) 292, nos. 52B (PN32) and 37B (PN2).

[269] See Amelung (1908) v. II, 92-93, 130-131 and Robert (1904) 231-232. The second side-panel depicts a scene whose iconography is less clear. It appears to show a male figure, possibly Mars, leading a shrouded female figure, possibly Rhea Silvia, through a mountain pass to a river, both of which are shown as personifications. Perhaps this alludes to Rhea Silvia's punishment or to her abandonment of the twins after their birth.



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Rhea Silvia. As he changed his viewpoint, his physical movement would yield results which matched the movement of his thoughts.

Ara Casali: Return to narrative

The final representations of Rhea Silvia's tale which I will discuss are those on one side of the Ara Casali, whose serialized narrative style provides a new template for understanding the connection between Rhea Silvia's sleep and the remainder of her narrative.[270] Discussion of these images will also serve as a summary of the central issues of my analysis. This monument, likely an altar which was transformed into a statue base, could be the latest of the images of Rhea Silvia's rape I have discussed. In different analyses, scholars have dated the altar to the Hadrianic, Antonine, and Severan periods based upon issues of style and the popularity of its iconography.[271] Most recently Fred Albertson has claimed that this depiction displays characteristics of the early fourth century, arguing that it is consonant with the revival of the imagery of Romulus and Remus in the Maxentian period. While it is not my aim to revisit the question of the base's date in this brief analysis, I will return to one aspect of his argument later.

The first register of the altar's frieze presents a now familiar composition: Mars advances from the left towards the recumbent Rhea Silvia, asleep by the banks of the Tiber. The god's erect, vertical stance is again contrasted with the languid pose of the

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[270] See Andreae et al. (1998) 241, no. 87a (PN52A) for back side of altar and details of registers one and two.

[271] See Toynbee (1934) 235-36 for the Hadrianic date; Maynial (1903) for the Antonine date; Brilliant (1967) 104-05 for a Severan date.



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sleeping figure. To the left of Rhea Silvia sits a personification of a river (likely the Tiber), identifiable by the reeds he holds in his left arm. Thus the personification replaces the water jug as a location marker. In a manner similar to that of the Ostia mosaic, Rhea Silvia appears to prop herself up, this time on a rock, so that the upper half of her body is tilted vertically; instead of facing the viewer, however, only her torso remains frontal while her head is in profile as she faces the oncoming Mars. Directly behind Rhea Silvia looms a tree, which is presumably meant to indicate that she has fallen asleep in Mars' sacred grove.[272] But the tree, as I argued with regard to the Ostia mosaic, might also be representative of the content of Rhea Silvia's fertility dream. This association becomes clearer through comparison with the composition of the second register.

In the second register we see Rhea Silvia in the same position as in the register above: she sits (rather than reclining) between the seated personification of the Tiber and two male figures who stand to her left and appear to address her.[273] The order of seated and standing figures is transposed from the frieze above, but Rhea Silvia remains in the center of the tableau, seated upon a rocky outcropping similar to the one above, and the

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[272] See Maynial (1903) 46-47 for discussion of the type of tree represented. He imagines it is Ovid's willow (*salix*), explaining why it cannot be Livy's *ficus ruminalis*, where the she-wolf was said to suckle the twins. Perhaps this is taking the literary associations too closely as keys to the iconography.

[273] Compare with these figures the shepherds in the fourth/bottom most register of this series and on the side panel of the Palazzo Mattei sarcophagus. In each case, the shepherds are shown having just discovered the she wolf suckling the twins, and they look on amazed by what they see, thus encouraging the viewer to have a similarly astonished reaction to the circumstances of the twins' birth and survival. By directing visual (and possibly verbal) attention toward Rhea Silvia in the scene of the second register, these internal viewers create the same kind of focus upon the central figure as remarkable by providing a template for the external viewer's focus.



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focus of the attention of those who surround her. In place of the tree behind her, she is holding the twins Romulus and Remus, presumably just-born, in her lap. In fact the tree is the only topographical feature missing in the second register, as the personified river deity and Rhea Silvia's rocky seat reappear. The tree, a symbol of her fertility in the first scene, is replaced by the product of her fertility as the viewer reads along; the fact that she is shown in the same location in each frieze reinforces this association. Thus the upper register, while it depicts the chronological precedent of the birth of the twins, is also a metaphor for their birth. The union between the parents of the twins is not actually depicted, so the viewer must reconstruct the connection between its precedent and its consequence through other visual cues.

In Maynial's interpretation of the scene in the second register, the onlookers to the left of Rhea Silvia are not simply passers-by (like the shepherds below) who have happened upon the scene accidentally. Maynial identifies the figures to the left of Rhea Silvia as emissaries from Amulius, Rhea Silvia's uncle, who orders the children and their mother to be killed.[274] Their intervention would provide a convenient connection to the events shown in the third panel, in which the infants are abandoned beside the Tiber. But in Maynial's reading, the presence of these men also forges a connection with the scene in the first register. Their announcement from Amulius forces Rhea Silvia to entreat Mars to help her protect her children; thus, in looking up at him in the first register, she is both reminding him of his parentage and asking for his help in saving his

[274] Maynial (1903) 47 ff.



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children. When we see the third register, we realize that her prayer has been successful: Mars attends the abandonment of the children, assuring their safety from the periphery of the image.

In the abstract for the paper in which Albertson argues for dating the Ara Casali to the early fourth century A.D., he focuses upon Rhea Silvia's glance up to the first register from the second, claiming that "such a visual link defying a clearly defined spatial frame is common in late Roman art."[275] While this feature may be important for the dating of the piece, it is also significant for the discussion of visuality and continuity in the context of a dream narrative. For we can also read this spatially-defiant look as a glance backward in time, a visual mechanism for forging a connection between Rhea Silvia's sleep experience and the birth of her children. In both scenes, the angle of Rhea Silvia's head is similarly tilted in profile facing to her right. Whereas in the first register her head tips back in the repose of sleep, in the second register she makes an explicit visual connection to Mars as she turns to look above her. But what is she really looking at here? Is she simply breaking the barrier of spatial arrangement in order to entreat Mars in the very place where he was when he approached her, as Maynial argues? When she looks up at the approach of Mars in the second register, Rhea Silvia also violates the barrier of linear time. By acknowledging Mars' role in her fertility dream and by making explicit his connection to her children through her reflection upon the entire scene from the outside, Rhea Silvia's glance elicits a similar response from the altar's external viewers.

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[275] Albertson (1990) 313.



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Rhea Silvia connects the events of her rape (dream) with the birth of her children (reality) through visual experience: it is her line of sight which the viewer follows, and which enables the viewer to associate the figure of Mars above with the birth of the twins below. Thus while the viewer "reads" the narrative in registers, he is reminded of the connection between the first register and the second not simply through filling in the gaps of a chronological progression, but through its reverse, by bridging the gap, as Rhea Silvia does, between what was seen in a dream, and that which occurs in reality. Rhea Silvia's act of seeing in the second register reminds the viewer of her act of seeing in her dream, as it prompts the viewer to follow her gaze upward in space and backward in time.

Rhea Silvia's glance in the second register of the Ara Casali articulates in narrative the mental process of the viewer of the earlier representations I have discussed. While in the "snapshot" images, the prelude to the encounter between Mars and Rhea Silvia was meant to provoke thought about the outcome of the encounter, in the Ara Casali friezes, the connection is made by serializing the story in registers of the same visual plane where the basic elements of the narrative are explicit. This is reminiscent of the "origins of Rome" fresco from Pompeii, where various phases of the story of Rhea Silvia are told synoptically, on one visual plane, and culminate, in the lowest part of the image, with the discovery of the she-wolf suckling the twins. Glenda Swan has argued recently for reading the synopsis as a dream, where the viewer's gaze is guided toward the fate of the twins by the figure of Mercury who himself indicates this marvel to an internal viewer, possibly Rhea Silvia seeing herself in a dream (see discussion above).



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We see the reverse here, in a sense, as Rhea Silvia in the second register contemplates an earlier phase of her story from a later standpoint. Both compositions, however, specifically draw attention to the process of seeing in a dream.

The viewer of both the "origins of Rome" fresco and the Ara Casali reliefs is privileged to see the content of Rhea Silvia's dream in as much as he watches her as she dreams. In the case of the fresco, this is reinforced by the presence of three men near a temple on the left, who appear to point to the sky and marvel at the arrival of Mars.[276] Gesturing towards and marveling at the descent of Mars, it appears they can actually see the figure who will soon disrupt Rhea Silvia's sleep and precipitate the images of her dream. As her face is turned away from the approaching Mars and, thus toward the viewer, it is easier to imagine that she is dreaming of the outcome of their imminent encounter (perhaps the very scene of the twins suckling below, if we follow Swan's reading) while the painting's internal viewers are witnessing a different reality. The painting's external viewer, however, has the privilege of seeing both internal and external perspectives.

Keeping in mind this type of viewing experience, we can see a parallel in reading the Rhea Silvia episode in Ovid's *Fasti* book 3. The *Fasti* passage is similarly divided between objective and subjective perspectives upon Rhea Silvia's sleep experience. The episode begins with a description of the scene from the standpoint of an external viewer (lines 11- 24). Rhea Silvia becomes drowsy on her way to draw water and falls asleep,

[276] See Wiseman (1981) and Swan (2001) 63 ff. for arguments about the topographical references in this image and the identity of these figures who populate it.



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having laid aside her water jug. Mars sees her lying unguarded and indulges his desire for her. As we have observed in the artistic representations of this scene, the prelude to the union of Mars and Rhea Silvia is given much more attention than their actual encounter, which is confined to just one couplet (*Mars videt hanc visamque cupit potiturque cupita / et sua divina furta fefellit ope,* lines 21-22). *Somnus* gives way to *sonos* (these nouns bookend the four-line passage that marks the bridge between Mars' departure and Rhea Silvia's speech) as the narrative moves from third to first person, and Rhea Silvia begins to recount the contents of her dream to the reader (lines 27-38). From her words, the reader learns what she alone saw as Mars made love to her in her sleep. She conveys the highly subjective experience of dreaming by communicating the feelings of amazement (*visu mirabile!,* line 31) and terror (*terreor admonitu, corque timore micat,* line 36) which the dream's startling images fostered in her.[277] Ovid thus treats the reader to both the obvious and the hidden aspects of Rhea Silvia's dream. This comparison underscores the advantage of continuous narration, and the difficulty that artists had to grapple with in representing the surface level and internal aspects of narrative, in addition to hinting at the aftermath of this important encounter.

[277] In lines 27-28, Rhea Silvia expresses doubts about whether her experience was a dream or reality; she asks, *utile sit faustumque, precor, quod imagine somni / vidimus! an somno clarius illud erat?* There is a degree of irony in her question about the vividness of the dream, for what she claims to have seen (the symbolic imagery) is itself masking the reality of her rape, even though it has a prophetic value. So the adjective *clarius,* in referring to the vividness of the dream's violent and frightening imagery, is misleading in that the scene it describes is itself at one remove from the external reality of Rhea Silvia's rape.



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**Looking ahead to Somnus**

In this section, I have argued that artistic representations of the sleeping Rhea Silvia differ from those of other sleeping figures, for her sleep functions as a vehicle which enables the viewer to imagine the legendary birth of Rome's founder, the outcome of the scene depicted. In some cases, the aftermath of the encounter between Mars and Rhea Silvia is depicted, while the more predominant composition is a "snap-shot" of the moment just before the encounter. All of the depictions share an emphasis upon the potentiality of the encounter, whether this is expressed explicitly, or is the object of an allusion through dream imagery. The versatility of the story of Rhea Silvia and its unique place among the representation of sleeping figures is best illustrated by another example from the visual arts, in which her tale is juxtaposed with that of Endymion on a Roman sarcophagus of the mid-third century A.D.[278] Michael Koortbojian has argued convincingly that this example serves to assimilate the two disparate tales of nocturnal visitation through their compositional similarities.[279] But a close look at the role of Somnus in each of these vignettes reveals an important distinction between the nature of their stories.[280]

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[278] See Zanker and Ewald (2004) 215, figure 194.

[279] Koortbojian (1995) writes on the mixing of 'motifs' that "one of the effects of the standardization brought about by the use of types is the possibility of their displacement from their proper, typical context. In such cases, despite the exigencies of the particular narrative role the motif plays in its new context, the type retains the traces of its original sense," 101-02.

[280] The personification of Somnus and his interaction with sleeping figures in both art and text is the focus of the subsequent chapter. In the discussion which follows, I am particularly interested in Somnus as the outward manifestation of the internal state of sleep. The interaction between sleep and sleeper is fundamental to the artist's conception of sleep's power to bind the sleeper in a state of immobility and availability.



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On the right side of the panel we see an aged Somnus, aloof and staring out at the viewer from behind a stone wall. He has no contact with the figure of Endymion lying below, rather he seems to stand in attendance as Selene approaches her lover. Somnus observes the scene as one whose presence is necessary without interfering. In the scene at the left, by contrast, an aged Somnus stands directly above the prostrate Rhea Silvia, gazing down at her as he pours his soporific potion from a horn to ensure slumber. Somnus' contact with Rhea Silvia is both visual and tactile, thus underscoring the importance of her state of sleep on this particular night. But what is most striking is the gesture he makes with his left hand, as though he is pointing into the distance while remaining focused upon keeping Rhea Silvia under his power. While it is possible that this gesture simply establishes a connection between the two scenes, as Paul Zanker reads it, I imagine that Somnus points beyond the content of the panel and ahead to the future. In so doing, his raised hand communicates to the viewer that what Rhea Silvia is about to endure at the hands of Mars will have fortunate and significant consequences as the rape will be justified by her progeny.[281] Although neither of the panel's central characters can see this gesture, from the viewer's perspective it hints at something

[281] Neither Helbig (1963) nor Koortbojian (1995) comments upon this gesture. Zanker and Ewald (2004) 215-16 notice that the faces of Mars and Rhea Silvia are portraits of the deceased married couple for whom the sarcophagus was made. He also thinks it likely that the faces of Selene and Endymion would have been carved with the same portraits. Thus the gesture of Somnus could be one which hints at the eternal bliss that awaits the couple in death. Thus they make a transition from an existence marked by days to one not bound by time. Zanker suggests that the images present a balance between desire and devotion. Somnus, here standing in as a euphemism for his brother death, represents the state of unconsciousness which will carry this couple from life into death. Whether Somnus' gesture is meant to extend the narrative of Rhea Silvia only as far as the boundary of the sarcophagus, or it reaches beyond her story as a prompt for thoughts about the consequences of her encounter, the implication is that Rhea Silvia's story is to be taken as a beginning point for the progress of narrative.



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outside of the parameters of the scene itself. The relationship between Somnus and the sleeper in each half of the panel emphasizes their differences: whereas Endymion's sleep experience is to be repeated each night, Rhea Silvia's sleep defines the beginning of her role as mother and progenitor. Somnus must ensure that she sleeps deeply enough to be moved by vivid dreams, but does not wake.



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# Part II: Statius
## Chapter 3: Somnus

*...sed nec leti tibi ianua tristis;*
*quippe leves causae, nec segnis labe senili*
*exitus instanti praemisit membra sepulchro,*
*sed te torpor iners et* ***mors imitata quietem***
*explicuit* ***falso****que tulit sub Tartara* ***somno****.*
-Statius to his father after his death
(*Silvae* 5.3.257-61)

*perfugium videtur omnium laborum et sollicitudinum esse somnus.*
Cicero, *De Div.* 2.150

### Somnus in Latin Epic

The personification of sleep as a deity (Somnus or Hypnos) is familiar from both Greek and Latin epic. In a well-known passage from Homer's *Iliad,* he (as Hypnos) is summoned by Hera in book 14 to charm Zeus to sleep. Although Hera mentions his fraternal connection to death (ἔνθ' Ὕπνῳ ξύμβλητο κασιγνήτῳ Θανάτοιο, line 231), he is depicted as a jovial (if venal) character, able to negotiate with Hera for a reward suitable to the weight of his task (lines 242-76). One makes the connection between Hypnos and Thanatos only by seeing Zeus' slumber as the indirect cause of the slaughter which results from his inattentiveness. The deep sleep that Hypnos brings to Zeus (ἀτρέμας εὖδε πατὴρ, line 352) is the temporary means to Hera's desired end, but this episode also reveals Hypnos' impressive ability to subdue even the mightiest god. In fact, his power to debilitate with somnolence becomes an important feature of his characterization by later authors. Two significant post-Homeric antecedents to Statius' portrayal of Somnus are found in Virgil and Ovid. In the former we find



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precedent for Statius' depiction of Somnus' sinister qualities; in the latter we discover the paradigm for his description of Somnus' languid abode.

Somnus arrives unsolicited at the end of book 5 of Virgil's *Aeneid* with the specific purpose of lulling the steersman Palinurus into the sleep of death (lines 840-56). Neptune has already decreed that one of the Trojans will have to be sacrificed to ensure Venus' request for their safe arrival in Italy (lines 779-826). That it is Somnus who performs the sacrifice presents a paradox: those who sleep willingly are left in peace, while the one who initially refuses sleep is forced into the sleep of death. The Trojans have finally overcome the obstacles to their journey, but their tranquility is disturbed by the death of a comrade, visited upon him in the guise of peace (sleep). Their freedom from persecution on the seas comes in the form of freedom from cares, namely sleep, but their serenity becomes a time for loss. In a scene which conflates the nighttime visitation of a god to a mortal--a familiar epic convention for conveying a message--with the regular intervention of Somnus to induce sleep, the god of sleep arrives in disguise to deliver the message of death. This is no longer the jocular and deal-making Somnus of the *Iliad,* but a sinister agent, who causes death through his manipulation. This contradictory figure who brings a lethal peace is an important model for Statius' depiction of the deity.

Palinurus' response to Somnus exposes one of the central features of Somnus' power: his ability to deceive. In terms displaced onto the sea and the calm, both analogies for Somnus' lethal stillness, Palinurus claims to know about their potential for deception, as he hints at the connection between submitting to sleep and trusting the ship



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and its crew to the sea's tranquil appearance. He asks, *mene salis placidi vultum fluctusque quietos / ignorare iubes? mene huic confidere monstro?* (lines 848-49). All of the words he addresses to Somnus regarding the nature of the sea could easily be directed toward Somnus himself. Palinurus claims to know better than to allow himself to be deceived by the sea and the winds; a false sense of calm is never to be trusted, he has learned. The use of the word *vultum* (face) to refer to the surface of the water here is particularly charged, since Somnus appears to Palinurus in the guise of his companion Phorbas (*deus consedit...Phorbanti similis,* lines 841-42), thereby displaying the face of another in order to trick the steersman.[282] The juxtaposition of the noun and adjective *fluctus* and *quietos*, forming a mild paradox in line 848, refers to the deceptive calm of the waves: the seas can change abruptly, and a swell can rise from beneath the placid surface. The adjective *quietos* recalls *quies,* a synonym for sleep, and thus forges a stronger bond between the description of the sea and Somnus himself.

But the image of the calm billowing of the sea applies also to the unpredictability of sleep, for while those around him slumber in peace, Palinurus' sleep transforms into death. In fact, his protestations to Somnus about the nature of the sea become the seal of his death. Palinurus' final expression of concern about allowing Aeneas (and the ship) to sail along without his attentive watch is laden with references to deception: *Aeneam credam (quid enim?) fallacibus auris / et caelo, totiens deceptus fraude sereni?* (lines

[282] For similarities between this scene and that of *oneiros'* dream-visit to Agamemnon in the guise of Nestor in *Iliad* book 2.1-83, the earliest example of a dream in the epic tradition, see Walde (2001) 294. Of course, as Walde points out, Agamemnon is asleep and dreaming, while Palinurus is awake as he experiences this dream-like vision.



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850-51). Like the sea, the winds are capable of deception (*fallacibus auris);* the atmospheric calm (*fraude sereni)* is not to be trusted. Finally, Palinurus uses the participle *deceptus* to describe himself should he be deceived by these false appearances of calm. Somnus, the putative representation of calm, whose deception in the guise of Phorbas has failed to lull Palinurus, reverts to his true self (*ecce deus,* line 854) in order to dupe Palinurus with the trappings of sleep, namely the branch dipped in soporific liquid (*...ramum Lethaeo rore madentem / vique soporatum Stygia,* lines 855-56). But this is also misleading in its appearance. For the branch dispenses not simply sleep, but rather the elixir of death (*vique...Stygia).* So Palinurus' caution about resisting easy deception is dashed when Somnus, in this case bringer of death, performs the grandest deception of all by eliding the boundary between sleep and death.

In the Ceyx and Alcyone episode of Ovid's *Metamorphoses* book 11 we encounter Somnus in his own abode, rather than having traveled to the side of a sleeper. This Somnus does not speak directly; rather, his responses to Iris are communicated by Ovid in the third person. In fact, just as we shall see with Statius' Somnus, Ovid's god of sleep is characterized by the drowsy atmosphere of his setting and his soporific effects upon others. In a typically humorous description, Ovid refers to Somnus' power to subdue, but this time, with reference to the god himself: *summaque percutiens nutanti pectora mento, / excussit tandem sibi se cubitoque levatus* (lines 620-21). Somnus struggles, perhaps metaphysically, to release himself from his own bonds, thus



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demonstrating how intimately his power is bound with his mere existence.[283] But this statement underscores Somnus' paradoxical externality, by questioning whether the external power of Somnus can actually be extricated from its source. His narrative role in this episode of the *Metamorphoses* appears to be limited to rousing one of his sons to appear in a sleeper's dream, but the power which he exudes effortlessly is immediately disabling. Iris herself must flee before she falls asleep in the cave, from which the soporific effects of its inhabitant emanate: *Iris abit --neque enim ulterius tolerare soporis / vim poterat--, labique ut somnum sensit in artus* (lines 630-31). Rather than focus his attentions upon one select figure, Somnus is indiscriminate in lulling to sleep whoever enters his sphere.

When it comes to creating dreams, however, we learn that this is the responsibility of Somnus' sons. Unlike Virgil's god of sleep, Ovid's Somnus dispatches his shape-shifting sons to populate the dreams of sleepers, rather than leave his lair to intervene in the lives of men.[284] Ovid places great emphasis upon the deceptive powers of the sons of Somnus, thus attesting to their abilities as good dream impersonators. In Ovid's tale, sleep's deception comes in the form of a persuasive dream image which

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[283] Hardie (2002) 235 reads this line as a reference to Iris' behavior, i.e. that it is she who cannot stay awake, overcome by the effects of Somnus' proximity (this phenomenon is, in fact, described in detail 10 lines later). I think he is mistaken, perhaps hasty in his attempt to make this description fit into his discussion of Ovid's play with pronouns. I read the lines along with Bömer (1980) 404, as a description of Somnus' self-imposed drowsiness. The verb is used in the passive (with the force of the middle voice) to refer to shaking off sleep in Virgil's *Aeneid* 2.302, during Aeneas' retelling of the sack of Troy and his dream of Hector, *excutior somno summi fastigia tecti / ascensu supero...*

[284] As Netta Berlin (1994) 105 observes, "the passivity of Somnus [in Ovid] foregrounds the idea of sleep as a necessary condition for the occurrence of a dream rather than the deceptive and destructive forces that have attended the actions of Sleep in earlier epic."



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animates the dead when Morpheus appears to Alcyone as the drowned Ceyx. This differs from imposing a sleep which itself imitates death, as was the case in Virgil's Palinurus episode. Dreams share Somnus' penchant for napping, as they lie about the cave beside their father, but they are not simply languid, for they appear to take on shapes even as they relax: *hunc circa passim varias imitantia formas / Somnia vana iacent totidem...* (lines 613-14). The adjective *vana* alludes to their innate emptiness, while the participle *imitantia* demonstrates their capacity for filling the void with deceitful impersonations. The vocabulary which Ovid uses to describe the abilities of Somnus' sons evokes their talents as master deceivers: Morpheus is both *artificem* and *simulatorem figurae* (line 634), and his specialty is described as *homines imitatur* (line 638).[285] In fact, Ovid says that he is the best of all the sons at imitating the walk, appearance and speech of men (*exprimit incessus vultumque sonumque loquendi,* line 636).

Morpheus' ability to simulate the appearance of a human being is particularly deceptive, and Ovid's use of the word *vultum* here may remind us of Palinurus' mistrust of the deceitful "face" of the sea (*salis placidi vultum, Aen.* 5.848).[286] Ovid makes further reference to the appearance of a dream as a *vultus* in his description of the

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[285] Phantasos, whose particular skill is the imitation of things such as rocks and waves, is described by Ovid as an exercise in deceit: *fallaciter omnia transit,* line 642. Perhaps his talent is even more impressive than that of his brothers, as he is able to disguise his own living spirit in assuming inanimate forms.

[286] For the idea of Morpheus and his brothers as actors on the mind's stage, and that of the dream as a creative force independent of the dreamer's conscious creativity, see Walde (2001) 354-59. She also compares the appearance of Morpheus to Alcyone with that of Somnus to Palinurus in terms of the appearance of the figure in disguise as deceptively real.



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division of dreams between social classes: *regibus hi ducibusque suos ostendere vultus / nocte solent, populos alii plebemque pererrant* (lines 644-45). Thus the dream is something which has both a true form and a surface appearance which it dons and displays for the purpose of convincing a dreamer of its authenticity.[287] In the realm of sleep, dream images derive power from a false appearance which is life-like to the dreamer. Despite an awareness that this is so, the dreamer is nonetheless prone to deception.

Because of his superior mimetic ability and his residence in the cave of sleep, the primary incubator of dreams, Philip Hardie claims that Morpheus' power "is the power of the poet to work on the imagination of the reader through the suggestive force of *phantasia*."[288] As I will show, just as Morpheus' shape-shifting abilities provide a model for the metamorphic episodes throughout Ovid's work, and, ultimately, the poet's skill at creating these, the encounter with Somnus in the cave of sleep in Statius' *Thebaid* has significance for the narrative of the epic as it expands beyond the description of the cave. While the metamorphic quality of the dream figure and his illusionistic power provide close parallels for Ovid's poetics in the *Metamorphoses*, for Statius the power of Somnus to oppress or taunt the *Thebaid*'s sleepers and his collusion with his brother

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[287] The sons of Somnus are called dreams even when they are languishing about the cave and not in the process of visiting a sleeper. Ovid refers to Somnus' sons as dreams twice before they have actually assumed the form of any being. When Iris enters the cave she has to brush away dreams (*somnia)* blocking her path (*obstantia virgo / somnia dimovit*, lines 616-17); later when she asks Somnus to summon one of his army to visit Alcyone in her dream, Iris refers to them as *somnia, quae veras aequant imitantia formas*, line 626. This line echoes line 613 mentioned above, with the adjective *veras* replacing the earlier *varias*.

[288] Hardie (2002) 277 and note 38. This is an idea whose origin he credits to Garth Tissol.



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Mors (death), constitute an essential part of Statius' poetics of sleep. In the remainder of this chapter I will elucidate Statius' poetics of sleep by evaluating his characterization of Somnus as a sinister external force. I will argue that Somnus' intervention in the lives of the characters of the *Thebaid* via nightmare, insomnia, or fatal submersion underscores the tension and anxiety caused by an accursed and destructive fraternal war.

**Sleep's Guises: Statius' Vocabulary of Sleep *(somnus, sopor, quies)***

*somnus*

The word *somnus* first appears in book I of Statius' *Thebaid* as part of the phrase *inpacatis somnis* (line 147), an unusual and foreboding collocation. The description is embedded within an account of the contrast between the distant mythological past, during which time the sons of Oedipus fought for power uncorrupted by lust for material wealth (and its attendant paranoia), and the material trappings of rulers in a later time with noticeably Roman characteristics. Although Statius never explicitly mentions Rome as his point of comparison, specific references in his description recall details of contemporary life. The lines read as follows:

> *et nondum crasso laquearia fulva metallo,*
> *montibus aut alte Grais effulta nitebant* 145
> *atria, congestos satis explicitura clientis;*
> *non* ***inpacatis*** *regum advigilantia* ***somnis***
> *pila, nec alterna ferri statione gementes*
> *excubiae nec cura mero committere gemmas*
> *atque aurum violare cibis: sed nuda potestas* 150
> *armavit fratres, pugna est de paupere regno.*
>
> and the yellow-gold ceilings were not yet resplendent from solid metal, nor did atria shine supported by lofty [columns quarried from] Greek mountains in order to welcome throngs of



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> clients; nor did ever-wakeful spears guard the restless sleep
> of kings, and no guard groaned because he had to
> take up an armed watch, nor did they care to pour
> wine into jeweled cups or defile gold with food; rather,
> undisguised power brought the brothers to arms,
> and they fought over a humble kingdom.

By noting that the stone used to build this imagined structure was possibly quarried in and imported from Greece, Statius emphasizes the wealth of the builder. Furthermore, the fact that Statius refers to an *atrium* in which leaders can meet their *clientes,* two distinctly Roman terms, underscores the likelihood that he depicts a scene typical of Roman imperial architecture.[289] The rulers who sleep in these elaborate edifices are hardly convinced of their safety, and rely for protection upon *advigilantia pila,* a metonym for their palace guards. But Statius' line is ambiguous in that he leaves the reader uncertain of the time period to which he refers.

I believe that, in Statius' mind, the increased vigilance and sleeplessness of kings was associated with periods of heightened anxiety, and that by drawing attention to it in

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[289] Note the emphatic framing of line 146 with these two Roman words. Both Martial, in his description of Nero's Domus Aurea (*invidiosa feri radiabant atria Regis / unaque iam tota stabat in urbe domus* (Liber Spec. 2.3-4)) and his probable description of Domitian's Palatine residence in 8.36, and Statius in his description of Domitian's palace in *Silvae* 4.2, where he mentions the luster of different imported marbles (lines 26-9) and gilded ceiling coffers (line 31), emphasize the brilliance of these emperors' *atria.* There are three other instances in the *Silvae* where Statius offers a detailed account of the different types of marble in a particular structure. These are 1.2.148-153 (in a description of a Roman maiden's sumptuous villa); I.5.34-43 (in a description of the baths of Claudius Etruscus); and 2.2.85-94 (in a description of the seaside villa of Pollius Felix). Thus the Greek setting of the *Thebaid* shares this descriptive feature with his distinctly Roman *Silvae.* There is nothing in the *Thebaid* passage which points to a specifically Flavian context for this building, but it is likely that Statius is imagining the domicile of an emperor with great power and wealth, whose ostentation is commensurate with (and perhaps the cause of) his fear of assassination at night. For a comprehensive discussion of the Flavian architectural program, see Darwall-Smith (1996), esp. 193 ff.; for the Flavian reaction to Nero's building program, see pages 35-41 and 181-182. Statius' detailed architectural description evokes for the reader a concrete image of the structure he depicts.



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this passage, he is establishing this as an important theme in his narrative.[290] The contrast within line 147 alone between the vigilance of the guards (*advigilantia (pila)*) and the albeit disturbed slumber of the kings (*inpacatis somnis)* sets the tone for a dichotomy that will recur throughout the epic's narrative. Furthermore, the adjective *inpacatis,* which has its root in the noun *pax,* immediately connects the slumber of kings with the disruption of peace, a matter of great concern to any ruler.[291] The thoughts which preoccupy the rulers during the daytime seem to have invaded their sleep, thereby depriving them of night's customary escape from care. Finally, by placing his first reference to disrupted sleep in a context that would have been familiar to his readers, Statius also imbues his mythological tale with an acute contemporary relevance, beginning at the level of architectural description. This connection between Thebes and Argos in the distant mythological past and Rome of the early empire underscores the universality of the experience of the characters in his tale.[292]

Sleep personified as the god Somnus makes his first appearance about 200 lines later at 1.339-41: *iam pecudes volucresque tacent, iam Somnus avaris / inrepsit curis pronusque ex aethere nutat, / grata laboratae referens oblivia vitae.* Sleep has a distinct

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[290] There is a certain ambiguity in this passage. Statius could mean that the fight between Eteocles and Polynices predates the sleepless anxiety of kings, or rather that the nighttime anxiety of rulers is timeless, while the need for protection by vigilant armed guards is a recent development. Certainly later in the narrative, both of the brothers, as well as other rulers, suffer from insomnia and nightmares caused by anxiety surrounding the imminent war at Thebes.

[291] The *TLL* gives "*de rebus pace carentibus*" as its second definition for the adjective *impacatus.* This appears to be a specific usage, as the only other citation given is from Seneca. The same passages are cited in the *OLD* entry 2a, "(transf.) not made peaceful, restless." The more common meaning appears to be "not subdued or pacified" (cf. *OLD* 1a), for which Statius' *Silvae* 5.1.137 is cited (*quisnam impacata consanguinitate ligavit / Fortunam Invidiamque deus?...*, lines 137-38).

[292] For more on Thebes as a metaphor for imperial Rome see Ahl (1986) and Hardie (1990).



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personality here: this is the divine Somnus, counterpart to Phoebus, and companion of the moon (*Titanis,* line 337), a divinity who will later become a decisive figure in determining the action of the war. Here he is the subject of the active verbs *inrepsit* and *nutat* (line 340) and the bringer of *oblivia* (line 341). Statius gives us not just a description of the effects of sleep, but rather, an introduction to how these effects are enacted. This Somnus brings welcome relief and forgetfulness to men whose lives are characterized by toil. He appears to act in concert with the natural course of time: the sun retires, the moon rises and replaces him, and sleep comes to mortals in order to soothe them.[293]

The description of the animals asleep (line 339) is intended to contrast with Polynices' isolation among the creatures of the universe. But mention of Polynices' situation is delayed by the description of a violent storm. In fact, Somnus approaches and settles upon the world just after a lengthy narration of the topography of Polynices' journey from Thebes. The presence of Somnus provides a moment of respite, characterized by silence and calm, between the tumultuous and disruptive journey of Polynices (lines 328-35) and the fierce storm he endures on his path to Argos (lines 342-63). The transitions from description of sleep to the night's violent storm, and then from the furious motion of the storm to Polynices' desolation, are both marked by adversative words: *sed* in the first case (*grata laboratae referens oblivia vitae. / sed nec puniceo*

[293] This line has a precedent in book 4 of the *Aeneid,* where Virgil contrasts Dido's insomnia with the rest of the natural world asleep. Line 525 reads *cum tacet omnis ager, pecudes pictaeque volucres.* Compare also line 3 of Statius' *Silvae* 5.4, *...tacet omne pecus volucresque feraeque,* where Statius seeks to offset the narrator's aberrant insomniac experience. This passage is discussed in detail in the next chapter.



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*rediturum nubila caelo / promisere iubar...*, lines 341-43) and *(ille) tamen* (*...nullisque aspecta per aevum / solibus umbrosi patuere aestiva Lycaei. / ille tamen...*, lines 362-64) in the second. Polynices, who has labored excessively throughout his journey and continues to strive to protect himself from the storm, finds no share of Somnus' reputed relief from toil, and this serves to isolate him further from the rest of the world's living creatures.

The description of the dark and violent storm foreshadows, furthermore, the sinister aspects of Somnus as he is personified. The duality of Somnus is not explicit, but rather is suggested by the juxtaposition between his advent and the rise of a terrible storm. This association between Somnus and destructive violence will reappear in book 10, where Somnus receives his most complex characterization.[294] Nightfall marks the end of the final stretch of Polynices' passage in exile from his homeland to the unfamiliar kingdom of Adrastus, which is soon to become allied to him through marriage to the king's daughter. When the storm finally dissipates and allows for visibility, Polynices is almost at Argos and Adrastus' palace. This is where he is finally able to sleep, albeit fitfully (*invitat tenuis ad dura cubilia somnos,* line 389), having missed his opportunity to do so when Somnus held the world in peace the night before. Thus by making Somnus a pivot between past and present, Thebes and Argos, day and night, Statius calls attention to the power of the god. The role of Somnus as a figure

[294] As we shall see in book 10, the atmospheric effects of Somnus and of the storm are not dissimilar in that they both possess the power to alter nature; this becomes more apparent in the description of the House of Somnus in book 10, where, for example, rivers make no noise as they flow in proximity to Somnus' dwelling (lines 95-97). The storm which Polynices endures fills river beds which have been dry for long periods of time (lines 358-59). Both forces have distinct effects upon other living things: sleep subdues nature, while the storm unleashes its force.



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whose presence marks a transition between phases of the narrative as well as between topographical points will become important in later books of the epic. The fact that Somnus, bringer of relief from care, neglects Polynices, is our first inkling that sleep will not be restful for the characters of the *Thebaid.* We have entered a realm in which Somnus' normally comforting acts are negated and overpowered by an intense anxiety that prevents rest or escape. That Polynices' first sleep of the epic is fitful and fraught, as I shall discuss later, confirms this. Thus these early examples of the noun *somnus* in context establish the inversion of sleep's function as provider of rest, and point out its selectivity, thus providing a preview of the torment which awaits the characters of the *Thebaid.*

*sopor* and *quies*

The noun *sopor* is used by Statius with significantly less frequency than *somnus* throughout the narrative of the *Thebaid.* The first instance of its use, which comes in line 59 of book 2, as Mercury transports Laius from the Underworld in order to allow him to invade Eteocles' slumber, is noteworthy. Laius and Mercury encounter Sopor driving Night's horses across the sky: *...Sopor obvius illi / Noctis agebat equos, trepidusque adsurgit honori / numinis et recto decedit limite caeli* (lines 59-61). In this example both the Teubner editors, A. Klotz and T. C. Klinnert, have capitalized the noun, making it into a personification of sleep.[295] Guiding Night's horses is the exclusive responsibility of Sopor rather than that of the cave-dwelling Somnus, who, as I will show, acts when roused by one of the gods to act on his or her behalf. By

[295] J. H. Mozley, editor of the Loeb edition (first edition 1928), also capitalizes the noun.



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comparing the first mentions of Somnus and Sopor in the text, we understand the distinction between the two deified aspects of sleep: Somnus makes contact with the earth's sleepers, while Sopor is the more ethereal and generalized figure. Whereas Somnus descends to earth in order to touch individual sleepers, or to withhold his touch from the unfortunate, Sopor remains aloof in the upper realm.[296]

The noun *sopor*, sometimes modified by an adjective, refers to the experience of sleep rather than the active power of the god of sleep in the *Thebaid*. When it is used as the subject of an active verb, as is the case with Ismene's description of her dream in book 8.622-635, and with the sleep of the guards in book 12.449-50, it refers exclusively of the creation of dream images in the mind of the sleeper.[297] While it is often used as a generic term for sleep, these examples demonstrate a particular usage of the word: *sopor* is specifically the agent of the dream image. This observation adds significance to the events of 2.59, since Mercury and Laius appear to displace Sopor from his route, and thereby, from his duties of implanting a dream in the mind of Eteocles. This duty is then

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[296] The one other instance in which the editors of both editions agree that *sopor* is used as a personification comes in book 10. While Somnus steeps the Thebans in sleep (lines 146-155), there is no *Sopor* for the Argives (line 156); for them there is no equivalent immersion under the spell of sleep. While Somnus is exerting his power over one group, the transition to the other is marked by mention of their lack of sleep. In this instance, Sopor is Somnus' alternate; the fact that he is here characterized as a god emphasizes not so much the interchangeability between the names, but the limited occurrence of the personification of *Sopor* as a god. In both instances of capitalization, the noun Sopor could be easily replaced by Somnus, since he is described as withholding from the Argives the very power which Somnus bestows upon the Theban force. Although Statius prefers the name *Somnus* to refer to the god of sleep, he allows a substitution for *Sopor* in the event that, as is the case in 2.59, the reference is to sleep in general, as it is being distributed to all of the world, rather than to a specific group. In the instance in book 10, Statius features individual sleepers coming under the effects of Somnus, while Sopor is used to describe the effects of sleep upon a whole community. The Thebans will be assisted by Somnus to have dreams of death, while Sopor, in his chariot, will not fly over the Argives' camp.

[297] The editors of the Teubner text have chosen not to capitalize the noun in any of these instances.



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usurped by Laius in the guise of Tiresias, and the vision he creates for his grandson is a pivotal moment in the development of the antagonism between the brothers.

The noun *quies* is also used by Statius to connote sleep, although it more frequently describes rest, peace, or simply refraining from activity.[298] In the majority of its uses, regardless of case, it is modified by an adjective, usually a participle and usually with a negative connotation.[299] Because it is a fairly general term, the use of a modifier gives it a deeper shade of meaning. Two such examples include *rupta quies* (2.125), to express the disruption of Eteocles' sleep, and *exturbata quies* (3.693), in a description of Argia's inability to sleep well beside her anxious husband Polynices. The term *praesaga quies* is used in 10.324 to describe the prophetic sleep of one of the doomed Theban soldiers.[300] This particular collocation provides insight into the different aspects of the sleep experience, especially dreaming, rather than simply the repose necessary for it.

But the noun is also used by Statius to connote a state of peace which differs from sleep. This distinction is exemplified by the description of the enemy Argives who march determinedly to war after their sojourn in Nemea in book 7.398-401. Statius writes,

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[298] The *OLD* gives the primary definition of the noun as "the repose of sleep" (1a). The noun occurs 16 times in the *Thebaid;* of those instances it is used 6 times to connote sleep specifically.

[299] In 14 of its 16 usages in the *Thebaid,* the noun is modified by an adjective or participle. Of these modifiers, 9 have negative connotations.

[300] The line above has an interesting parallel in book 9.631, where Atalanta speculates about the significance of her nightmares in the phrase *praesagia mittit sopor...* Through this comparison, we see that *sopor* brings dream visions which may relate to the future, while *quies* is that which is imbued with these messages.



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*interea Danai noctemque diemque sub armis,*
*noctem iterum rursusque diem -- sic ira ferebat --*
*ingeminant: contempta* ***quies****, vix aut* ***sopor*** *illis* 400
*aut epulae fecere moram; properatur in hostem...*

Meanwhile day in, day out, the Argives doubled their armed march along the road, advancing both by night and by day-- thus their anger drove them on: rest was despised, they scarcely stopped for sleep or eating as they hastened on towards the enemy.

In this context Statius tells us that neither *quies* nor *sopor* is welcomed by the troops, as the latter seems to be a component of the former. Rest, which seems to include any kind of break in progress, is shunned, while sleep and meals have scarcely a chance to interrupt the Argives' progress.[301]

The sole personification of the noun *quies* appears in book 10 of the epic. *Quies* stands guard alongside *Oblivio* outside Somnus' cave in line 89, *limen opaca Quies et pigra Oblivio servant.* This is also the sole case in which the noun is used as the subject of a transitive verb, a usage which lends itself to personification. This characterization is important also because it demonstrates the nature of *quies,* even in other contexts. Quies is closely associated with sleep in that it establishes an environment in which sleep may thrive, but it is not often used as a substitute for sleep. Instead, it is given the role of setting up a context in which Somnus can easily cause others to sleep. Their relationship is represented by the image of Quies as guard before the home of Somnus ensuring the

[301] There are a few instances in which the noun *quies* simply refers to peace or rest, the absence of hurried activity, such as in the description of Bacchus' tigers, who have become docile in Thebes. Statius claims that they have a *vaga rure quies* in 7.576.



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conditions for peaceful sleep. Even in his role as a personification of calm, Quies is modified by an adjective, this time *opaca*.[302] This characterization is peculiar, since Statius seems to borrow the idea of darkness from the description of night and apply it to the circumstance of rest itself. The transfer works in this context, because the darkness of Quies obscures the doorway to Somnus' cave, while the laziness of Oblivio keeps him in place before the door; these qualities enhance the capabilities of both figures as guards.

By way of conclusion, it is helpful to turn to *Silvae* 1.6, where all three words for sleep are mentioned together in the same stanza.[303] The theme of *Silvae* 1.6 is the celebration of the Saturnalia from dawn until night on the Kalends of December. Statius describes the moment at which a flare goes up from the arena which is so brilliant that it prevents night from descending: *nihilque / obscurae patitur licere nocti* (lines 89-90). The end of the day is staged as a contest between the natural descent of darkness and the artificial fires and flares of the celebration. One effect of this extension of the day is the

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[302] This combination also appears in *Silvae* 5.3.17, where Statius uses *opaca quies* to contrast with the bustle of the Circus contests and the crowds at the theater in Rome.

[303] There is an interesting parallel for the combination of these three terms in Lucretius 4.453-54: *denique cum suavi devinxit membra sopore / somnus et in summa corpus iacet omne quiete.* In this passage Lucretius describes sleep as physically binding for the sleeper, despite the fact that the dreamer believes he is moving his limbs. In this example, *somnus* seems to refer to the agent of sleep, while *sopor* is the means by which sleep affects the sleeper. *Quies* is the state of rest that results from the action of *somnus*. This is generally consistent with Statius' distinctions. Catullus 63 also provides a good comparandum for this grouping. In lines 37-38, Attis and his band of Gallae fall asleep exhausted from their frenzied dancing: *piger his labante languore oculos sopor operit / abit in quiete molli rabidus furor animi.* This is a deep slumber precipitated by the intensity of their mad activities. It is also a transformative sleep, for, when Attis awakes, he realizes the gravity of his self-mutilation. *Sopor* is powerful enough to sedate these wild revelers, on the scene at the initiation of sleep, while *quies* simply describes their state of rest. Attis' awakening at dawn is described as follows (line 42): *ibi Somnus excitum Attin fugiens citus abiit.* Here we see Somnus flee from Attis, having played his role as preserver of sleep.



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escape of the personified Quies and Somnus, who are on hand to subdue the celebrants: *fugit pigra Quies inersque Somnus / haec cernens alias abit in urbes* (lines 91-92). Quies is again described by a negative adjective (*pigra),* in this case used ironically with the distinctly energetic verb *fugit.* In this context, Quies and Somnus represent the routine aspect of sleep, that which is expected every night. The missed opportunity for nightly sleep is described here as the absence of the god of sleep; in this case, he will have fled to another town which is not carrying on with celebration deep into the night. These personifications are given responsibility for altering the natural pattern of sleep; when they see (*cernens)* what is happening on this unusual day, they decide to leave and spread their bounty elsewhere. These personifications are contrasted with the noun *sopor* six lines later, when the poet claims he is succumbing to sleep and can no longer sing the praises of the feast: *iamiam deficio tuoque Baccho / in serum trahor ebrius soporem* (96-97). The different usages of the nouns are explicit here. Somnus and Quies are active, decisive gods, while *sopor* is a state which someone achieves as a result of extreme exhaustion or inebriation. Even though Somnus and Quies have fled the scene, *sopor* is still an option for the weary.[304] In this case, *sopor* is unnatural sleep,

[304] In his 1941 commentary on *Aeneid* 6.278 (*tum consanguineus Leti Sopor et mala mentis / Gaudia...),* Fletcher comments on Virgil's use of Sopor rather than Somnus in describing the entrance to the Underworld. He claims that "*sopor* suggests a swoon or lethargy rather than ordinary sleep..." (54). In his view, both *sopor* and *somnus* connote restful sleep, but it is *sopor* alone which carries the sense of weakness and unconsciousness associated with death. He does not offer examples of other usages for comparison. This distinction is corroborated by a passage in Pliny's *Nat. Hist.* (21.119), where he describes the potentially dangerous seeds of a specific type of *iuncus* (a plant). He writes *huius semine somnum allici, set modum servandum, ne sopor fiat,* thus indicating that deep sleep or (possibly) death could result from an overdose of the otherwise sleep-inducing seeds.



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or sleep induced by external forces. Its usage reinforces the contrast between natural and unnatural, expectation and surprise, which are the themes of the Saturnalia itself.

Statius' use of a diverse vocabulary of sleep, sometimes presented in juxtaposition to contrast the specific meanings of the terms, underscores the complexity of the role of sleep and its importance in the narrative of Statius' *Thebaid.* Sleep has an overarching role as subjugator in the guise of Somnus, while Sopor implants dream images -- often nightmares -- in the minds of sleepers. Quies, the basic principle of repose and refrain from activity, is often characterized by a negative epithet, thereby reinforcing the extent to which rest of any kind is scarce for the characters of an epic whose outcome is destined to be destructive for both sides of the conflict.

**The Iconography of Somnus**

In addition to its different names, the physical attributes of Somnus are important to his personification. Fortunately, the study of the god's appearance is greatly enhanced by a wealth of artistic representation from different time periods and in various media; familiarity with the iconography of Somnus and his interaction with sleeping figures in artistic contexts contributes considerably to our understanding of Statius' literary depiction of the god. A comparison between the textual and artistic representations of Somnus is fruitful, as it illuminates the ways in which artists and poets chose to express the intangible external power of Somnus over the sleeper through a depiction of their interaction. In this section I do not attempt to identify specific artistic precedents for Statius' descriptions. I am interested instead in showing that visual representations of Somnus as an independent being acting upon the body of a sleeper provide helpful



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illustrations of the Roman concept of sleep as an external force which exerts its power internally. Philip Hardie, in his discussion of the personification of Somnus in Ovid's *Metamorphoses,* refers to "the absurdity of personifying a condition that is one of depersonalization of the waking individual."[305] This "absurdity" is particularly well-illustrated by certain artistic representations, in which the interaction between Somnus and a sleeping figure is at once intimate and detached.

What is the nature of the connection between Sleep and Death personified as deities? Are not the differences between the two equally significant? To what degree is the one a foil for the other? When does sleep become a euphemism for death? Most obviously, the fact that a sleeper is able to wake up from and even avoid sleep reveals that the similarity in appearance between the brothers' effects is limited. Although the gods have in common an ability to affect the consciousness of their victims, sleep, because it is temporary and frequently restorative, is death's more benign counterpart.[306] The key to understanding their association as brothers is that the similarity between the two hinges upon the often ambiguous physical appearance of a prostrate body as it is observed from the outside.

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[305] Hardie (2002) 235; see also 232, where he says sleep "represents the nightly reduction in sleep of an individual to a non-person."

[306] Hesiod, in the *Theogony,* characterizes this difference in terms of the brothers' attributes; Hypnos is "kind to men" (μείλιχος ἀνθρώποισι, line 763), while Thanatos has a heart like bronze in his chest (χάλκεον δε οἱ ἦτορ / νηλεὲς ἐν στήθεσσιν, lines 764-65).



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Sleep (Hypnos or Somnus/Sopor) and Death (Thanatos or Mors) share a long history of characterization as brothers in the literary tradition.[307] Some of the earliest examples come from Homer's *Iliad,* as in an example I have already mentioned, where Hera addresses Hypnos as "brother of death" (κασιγνήτῳ Θανάτοιο, 14.231). In this instance, the mention of Hypnos' brother functions as a descriptive epithet, but the context evinces its power: despite the levity of the scene in which it is couched, the goddess's mention of his sinister brother may hint at the destruction which she hopes will result from Hypnos' action as Zeus is immobilized, and the Greeks are allowed to advance. At their rescue of Sarpedon's body in 16.672, the pair are called "twin brothers" (διδυμάοσιν), and their joint participation in transporting the Lycian's body is neither questioned nor explained; rather both are of equal importance in attending to the dead. Virgil, in *Aeneid,* 6.278, uses the phrase *consanguineus Leti* to describe Sopor (see note 304);[308] the brothers guard the entrance to the Underworld, where the connection between sleep and the realm of the dead is unequivocal. This is reinforced by the juxtaposition of the proper nouns *Leti* and *Sopor* within the line.

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[307] For a discussion of the personification of sleep in Greek and Latin literature, see Wöhrle (1995) 11-41. For the specific genealogy of sleep and death as brothers, the sons of Nyx (night), see Hesiod, *Theogony,* lines 756-66.

[308] Compare the similar usage in *Thebaid* 5.197-99, *cum consanguinei mixtus caligine Leti...Somnus.* Other non-epic examples include Seneca *Hercules Furens,* 1069, 1075-6, and Ovid *Amores,* 2.9.41 (*stulte, quid est somnus, gelidae nisi mortis imago!).* The latter, in its context, is a figurative statement. Sleep in this poem is experienced by those whom Cupid does not torment and, hence, those who lack the "heat" of love. Thus the life of someone without a lover is tantamount to a cold "death". The word *imago* reminds us of the visual similarity between the two, as though sleep were a replica of death.



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In *Silvae* 5.3, Statius' lament for his dead father, excerpted in the epigraph for this chapter, the connection between sleep and death exposes the easy slippage between the two through their mutual ability to deceive. In lines 260-61, Statius expresses his hope that his father's death was peaceful by commenting upon its ability to mimic rest (*mors imitata quietem,* line 260);[309] he then communicates his wish that his father's passage to the Underworld seemed no different from being asleep, albeit false sleep (*falsoque tulit sub Tartara somno,* line 261). These observations underscore an important conception of the role of sleep at the time of death, namely that it is a temporary substitute whose welcome rest eases the transition for the one dying and comforts those who remain alive to mourn. The notion of sleep as a counterpart to death, particularly during the passage from life into death, is the subject of visual representation in the select examples from Greek and Roman art which follow.

The Brothers: Hypnos and Thanatos in Greek art

Artistic representations of the interaction between the externalized personifications of Sleep and Death and sleeping or dead figures demonstrate the similarity in appearance between a sleeping figure and a corpse. The so-called 'New York crater', a late sixth century BC red-figure vase signed by the painter Euphronios, is one of the earliest and, perhaps, the most recognizable depiction of the relationship between the personified Sleep and Death and a human figure.[310] A favorite subject for

[309] This provides a contrast to the use of *quies* in the *Thebaid,* where it is usually used to connote disrupted rest or sleep.



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this painter, the removal of Sarpedon's body also appears on a kylix with similar composition, the so-called 'Hunt cup', which he painted at about the same time.[311] As a subject for artistic representation, according to Dietrich von Bothmer, "the removal of Sarpedon's body by Sleep and Death on the signed cup is totally novel."[312] The story of Sarpedon's death and the removal of his body endured as a motif but, as is evidenced by the surviving depictions of this scene from the sixth through fourth centuries B.C., there are few extant examples.[313]

In his essay on narrative technique in Euphronios' painting, Alan Shapiro speculates about the possible reason for Euphronios' interest in the death of Sarpedon as a motif, proposing that the subject matter for the Hunt cup may represent Euphronios' reaction to a performance of the newly canonized text of Homer's *Iliad*.[314] This raises some interesting questions about the connection between artistic and textual representation: if indeed the depiction on the cup was inspired by a passage from Homer's *Iliad* which the painter had heard recited, how literal is his "translation" from

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[310] See von Bothmer (1981) figure 66. The earliest depiction of the two deities as brothers would have been that on the chest of the Corinthian tyrant, Kypselos, which survives only in a description given by Pausanias in book 5.18.1. According to his account, the chest contained a depiction of Night "carrying a white boy asleep on her right arm: on her other arm she has a black boy who is like one that sleeps: the feet of the boys are turned different ways" (trans. J. G. Frazer, 1898). In this example, the crucial difference between sleep and death is expressed in visible terms through the skin color of the boys. The sinister figure of death, although he is "like one that sleeps", betrays his true character in his appearance.

[311] See von Bothmer, *LIMC* vol. VII.2 (1994) 520, no. 3.

[312] Von Bothmer (1992) 17.

[313] See *LIMC* vol. VII (1994) for a catalogue of examples.

[314] Shapiro (1990) 40. See also Nagy (2002).



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oral performance, or text, to image? The painter necessarily makes choices about how he is going to represent a scene; these could be governed by material concerns, such as the shape of the vessel, or by commercial concerns, involving the vase's appeal to prospective users. On the New York crater, for example, regardless of his possible inspiration by recitations of the *Iliad,* Euphronios has chosen to focus upon a scene which occupies fewer than twenty lines in Homer's narrative (16.666-683).

The painter also makes decisions concerning the setting for the scene, which may deviate from its antecedent, whether textual or oral.[315] On the New York crater, Euphronios chose to paint a Lycian and a Trojan onlooker, who frame the action on either side. These onlookers, writes von Bothmer, "do not participate, but have become honor guards, if not mere onlookers, that face each other and thus flank or frame the scene symmetrically."[316] These upright, mortal figures contrast with the winged and crouching figures of the gods Sleep and Death; their bent frames, in turn, guide the viewer's eye towards the central figures of the prostrate Sarpedon and the figure of Hermes caught in motion walking towards Death as his head turns in the opposite direction to face Sleep. The soldiers' lack of involvement in the scene serves to

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[315] One example of this is his inclusion of Hermes, who seems to direct the action, behind the figure of Sarpedon. In Homer's tale it is Apollo who is sent to rescue and wash the body of the slain hero. Furthermore, in Homer's account, Sleep and Death are charged with transporting the body to Lycia *after* it has been treated by Apollo; in the case of this depiction, the body is still in need of cleansing, and is being removed directly from the battlefield.

[316] Von Bothmer (1994) 698. This observation is a revision of his earlier comment in a 1981 essay, in which he describes the Lycian and Trojan onlookers as "if not...invisible, they are at least unseeing," 68. Earlier in the passage he had described them in the following terms, "they do not betray through expression or gesture that they are even aware of what goes on between them." This raises an interesting question: what is Euphronios trying to represent here, if not the literal transportation of a dead body by invisible divinities? And if the soldiers are 'unseeing', what is it that they do not see?



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emphasize their roles as observers and to provide a template for the external viewer of the vase. Their placement as boundaries for the action on this side of the vase also contains the scene and separates it from that on the reverse. This arrangement encourages focus not only upon the mutilated body of Sarpedon and his removal by Sleep and Death, but upon the act of *observing* the dead body and its removal. The viewership of these soldiers offers one possible interpretation for the pairing of Sleep and Death in this context, namely that the state of sleep is substituted for the state of death as a euphemism by the viewer. It is a likeness ascribed by an external viewer which forces an allegiance between the two states of being.[317]

On the Hunt cup Sleep and Death are disguised as soldiers, thereby further obscuring their distinction from the other soldiers on the field, one of whom is depicted turned away from them. If it were not for inscriptional evidence (their names are written beside each one), there would be no way to distinguish this from another scene in which soldiers remove the body of a comrade from the battlefield. Their 'absence' is emphasized here by the lack of onlookers; the soldier in the scene with them does not even glance in their direction. Despite this invisibility, however, their presence is embodied by the dead Sarpedon. His body has both the languidness of a sleeper, with the characteristic right arm flung over his head, and the conspicuous open chest wound

[317] Louis Marin (1999) 159, in an essay on Poussin's painting entitled "Awakening Metamorphoses," analyzes a painting in which Adonis is shown dead, while another man in the frame is shown asleep. He observes that the presence of this second figure reveals "the mysterious equivalence of sleep and death, the apprenticeship of the one by the repetition of the other, its happy daily announcement and thereby the most persuasive of consolations." This observation could be applied to the scene on the Euphronios crater, in which the similarity between the two states of being is expressed through the figures of the gods, rather than the bifurcation between sleeper and dead man. But we can appreciate Marin's distinction between sleep and death; repetition and permanence; rehearsal and finality.



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which marks him as dead. Why is Sleep a necessary participant in this scene? The immediate answer lies with Homer, since we attribute to him the original characterization of Sleep and Death as brothers and messengers to the underworld. But the presence of the figure of Sleep in artistic representation derives its power from an additional factor, namely the ability to remind the viewer of both a grim reality and its euphemism.[318]

The tension between the event illustrated and its perception by viewers, which is prominent on the New York crater, is consonant with the penchant for this type of visual play exhibited by painters of the late sixth century B.C., the so-called Pioneer group. According to Richard Neer, the Pioneers, among whom Euphronios was a major figure, exploited the "fund of concepts and techniques with which to practice their craft."[319] In a discussion which aims to debunk the popular notion that Euphronios and the other Pioneers of red-figure vase-painting were striving towards greater "realism" in their depictions, Neer argues that, rather than present "the reproduction of appearances...[the detail] only focuses the viewer's attention on the vast difference between depiction and

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[318] There is an obvious distinction between the states of sleep and death; in the case of Sarpedon on the New York crater, we know he is dead because he is bleeding from three spear wounds, so any similarity is merely conceptual here, not literal. One explanation for the presence of Sleep in this scene comes from the ultimate fate of Sarpedon's body. In Homer's account, Sleep and Death will transport the soldier's body to his home in Lycia after it has been washed by Apollo. Because Euphronius seems to have eliminated the washing of the body to render its condition ambiguous, the presence of Somnus is less explicable. Perhaps he serves as a reminder of the futile hope held by the Lycians and Sarpedon's fellow warriors for his survival before they learn the truth. Or perhaps it represents the hope, like Statius' for his father, that this young warrior, whose wounds bespeak a painful death, is now experiencing something as soothing as sleep as he is transported to his home and, eventually, to the Underworld.

[319] Neer (2002) 44.



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perception."[320] The presence of the soldiers on guard at the sides of the scene on the New York crater, and, particularly, their blank stares, suggest the possibility that Euphronios comments here as well upon the friction between depiction (what we see on the vase) and perception (what they see before them). For surely they do not see the body of a comrade being lifted off the ground by winged daemons; if that were the case, their expressions and gestures would certainly be more animated. Rather, there is a distinct difference between their perception of the scene and our perspective on it. This duality of representation is a suitable vehicle for reflection upon the ambiguity inherent in the dead or sleeping body; for just as the confusion between sleep and death is the concern of the external viewer, the role of the external viewer is challenged by the differing experiences of the viewers on Euphronios' crater.

Jan Bazant writes in his commentary on 'Hypnos' in *LIMC* that "Hypnos' role in ancient art was to visualize sleep."[321] Bazant refers here to the depiction of reclining figures who are merely asleep, so the presence of the personified Sleep is necessary to show that the central character is *not* dead. But this comment also underscores the difficulty inherent in distinguishing between the states of sleep and death from the point of view of an onlooker: what is gained by 'visualizing' sleep alongside death when the central character is dead? As exemplified by the New York crater, death is easily depicted by painting blood escaping from wounds, but the role of sleep is more elusive. The inclusion of Hypnos as a participant in such a scene must have a relevance beyond

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[320] Ibid., 46.

[321] Bazant (1997) 644.



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simply his association with Thanatos familiar from Homer's account of the story. Perhaps his presence in partnership with his brother is meant to serve as a reminder of the sinister aspects of sleep--the potentially deceptive quality of dreams or the encounters with the dead which are permissible across the boundary of sleep. By placing Hypnos at the scene of Sarpedon's death, rather than showing him merely assisting his brother with the transportation of the dead body after its removal, Euphronios has created an early predecessor for the interplay between the brothers at the moment of a soldier's death, an aspect which features prominently in book 10 of Statius' *Thebaid.*

Von Bothmer, in his *LIMC* article on representations of Sarpedon, remarks upon the removal of Sarpedon's body from the battle field by Sleep and Death as the enduring iconographic feature of Euphronios' sixth century vases.[322] In his opinion, this represents "a significant shift from the emphasis on valor in bloody battle to the more poignant reflection on the tragedy of war and the grief of parents that afflict even Zeus."[323] He is reacting to Euphronios' innovative choice for the focus of this image, the dead body of Sarpedon with no hint at Patroclus' aristeia or the subsequent fight over Sarpedon's body, which had both been the subjects of earlier depictions. The nearly nude, limp body of a young warrior who returns to his family only for his burial exposes the grim counterpart of the Homeric heroic code. The sense of despair over a young life lost is corroborated by the reaction of Sarpedon's father Zeus, who plots the demise of Patroclus, Sarpedon's

[322] Von Bothmer (1994) 699-700.

[323] Ibid., 700.



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murderer. But the complicity between Sleep and Death in this image also strikes us as an ironic joke: since, in the context of a war, peaceful and nourishing sleep is scarce, this image taunts the dead figure by allowing him peaceful sleep only at the price of death. This irony has a parallel in Homer's text. When Zeus orders Apollo to cleanse the soldier's body before it is returned to Lycia, he commands that Apollo also anoint and dress the body (χρῖσόν τ' ἀμβροσίῃ, περὶ δ'ἄμβροτα εἵματα ἕσσον, 670). The use of the words ἀμβροσίῃ and ἄμβροτα which refer to immortality and the negation of death are particularly ironic, since Sarpedon is dead. Presumably, Zeus orders that he be anointed and dressed this way, so that he will appear youthful, radiant and unharmed when he returns home. The only way he could achieve such harmony between life and death is to appear to be asleep. Thus sleep becomes the vehicle for deception because it is a compromise between the states of life and death.

There is another red-figure cup by the Nikosthenes painter, also a Pioneer, which depicts the prostrate body of the giant Alkyoneus.[324] Above him stand Herakles and Athena; a winged sleep figure hovers above the giant's torso, as though he could fly off at any moment. Without the presence of his brother Thanatos, Hypnos here is more like an early precedent for the interaction between Somnus and the sleepers in Roman art which I discuss below. But this scene is also an interesting conflation of the states of sleep and death, as tradition held that Herakles killed Alkyoneus while he was subdued in sleep. We could say his slumber is a "rehearsal" for his imminent death. In his *LIMC* article on Hypnos, Bazant speculates that vase painters introduced this winged figure

[324] See Trendall (1958) plate VIIa.



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"because they were not satisfied with the previous explanation of the monster's sleep as a consequence of his drunkenness."[325] But the presence of Hypnos seems only to draw more attention to the fact that the giant lies in sleep rather than death; the reason for his sleep is not explained, but he is not yet dead. The scene is further confused by the presence of a winged figure dressed as a soldier, who is turned away from the interaction among Herakles, Athena, and Alkyoneus. Could this be Thanatos waiting to enter the scene? The dichotomy between the figures of Athena and Herakles looking directly at the horizontal body, and the winged figure looking away in seeming oblivion underscores the different possibilities for viewing in this scene. The presence of the personification of sleep is surely only a visual clue for the outside viewer; so what is it that those present at the scene actually see or fail to see? It is not my goal here to answer these questions definitively, but rather to give an idea of the types of problems which these representations pose. Furthermore, it is helpful to have a sense of the precedent in Greek art before turning to the vocabulary of Roman depictions. The single figure of Hypnos on the Nikosthenes cup brings us closer to the paradigm typical in Roman art, where the single figure of Somnus interacts exclusively with the sleeper. But the figures of Somnus which I discuss below do not hover tentatively, instead they engage more directly with the sleeping figure.

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[325] Bazant (1994) 644.



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Somnus and the sleeper in Roman art

In the pages which follow, I am particularly interested in the representation and iconography of Somnus alone (without his brother) as he interacts with sleeping figures. The development in Roman art of the representation of Somnus administering sleep rather than tending to the dead with his brother, is important for my discussion of the role of Somnus in the *Thebaid,* where we see Somnus himself, independent of his brother, as a facilitator of death. Although the examples which I will cite postdate the writing of the *Thebaid* by more than one hundred years, I believe that they provide valuable visual parallels for Statius' characterization of Somnus as a physical entity in the *Thebaid.* I am working under the assumption that the scenes from sarcophagi, in particular, represent the development of iconography which was familiar from earlier periods.[326]

The method most common for dispensing sleep, both in the *Thebaid* and in images from Roman art, is from a horn, and Somnus' horn becomes a salient feature of his interaction with mortals in the *Thebaid.*[327] The conception of sleep as something

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[326] There are enough examples of Somnus with sleeping figures such as Ariadne and Endymion from Romano-Campanian wall-painting to support this. See Koortbojian (1994) 70-78, e.g., for a discussion of this.

[327] We do see examples in literature of sleep conveyed through other means, all of which involve dispensing liquid. When Somnus descends upon the Theban camp in book 10 of the *Thebaid,* Statius describes his wings as wet: *...cum vero umentibus alis incubuit* (148-49). This action is coincident with the immersion of the Theban camp in sleep, one feature of which is the closing of eyes and nodding of heads: *...errare oculi resolutaque colla* (150). Thus Somnus' wings seem to be the means for effecting sleep, rather than simply enablers of movement. This has many parallels in Roman art, where the figure of Somnus appears winged but not in flight. As we have seen in book 5 of Virgil's *Aeneid,* Aeneas' helmsman Palinurus is visited by Somnus and punished with the sleep of death. Palinurus resists the cajoling of Somnus, described here in the following terms: *...funditque has ore loquelas* (842), where it is interesting to note that the persuasive action of Somnus is described as a "pouring". As I will show later,



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poured may have its earliest literary precedent in book 14 of Homer's *Iliad,* where Hypnos recalls a time when he put Zeus to sleep at Hera's behest. In lines 252-53, he describes his actions as follows, ἤτοι ἐγὼ μὲν ἔλεξα Διὸς νόον αἰγιόχοιο / νήδυμος ἀμφιχυθείς. To subdue the god in sleep, Hypnos pours himself around Zeus' mind, literally infusing the king of the gods with himself, his power, from the outside. In this instance, Hypnos does not dispense sleep from a vessel, but, rather, fills the sleeper with his power, while remaining separate from him. Somnus' horn appears in artistic representations from various time periods and media. Let us consider two examples from different media and contexts. One is a free-standing Somnus made of bronze who advances and pours liquid from his horn.[328] He is captured just as the liquid flows out of the horn. Perhaps we are to imagine a sleeper below, ready to receive Somnus' gift, or perhaps this is a vision of Somnus high above the mortal world, spreading his potion over large portions of the earth's living beings. As Catherine Lochin mentions in her *LIMC* article on Hypnos/Somnus, the figure likely held a branch of poppies in his lowered left hand. In a relief image from a marble altar of the mid-first century A.D., whose central face contains an image of the marriage of Bacchus and

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sleep: *ecce deus ramum Lethaeo rore madentem / vique soporatum Stygia super utraque quassat / tempora...* (854-56). This image has a parallel in Ovid's *Metamorphoses* 11.605-07, where he describes Nox dispensing her soporific potion after it is culled from the plants outside the house of Somnus: *ante fores antri fecunda papvera florent / innumeraeque herbae, quarum de lacte soporem / Nox legit et spargit per opacas umida terras.* In *Silvae* 5.4, Statius uses the verb *spargit* to describe the action of Tithonia, who, pitying the insomniac narrator, sprinkles him with her cool whip (*...et totiens nostros Tithonia questus / praeterit et gelido spargit miserata flagello,* lines 9-10).

[328] See Lochin (1990) 409, no. 51.



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Ariadne, we see a more youthful Somnus, also in motion.[329] This Somnus, who also carries a horn and a branch of poppies, appears to have already dispensed his liquid. Perhaps the horn's emptiness can be explained by context, as the point of connection between faces of the altar. Somnus has enabled the meeting between Ariadne and Bacchus by means of his soporific liquid, as Ariadne's deep sleep spans the departure of Theseus and the arrival of Bacchus.

It is possible that the poppies are used to subdue the sleeper, while the horn of liquid is used to keep him asleep.[330] Or, perhaps, the liquid contained in the horn is derived from the poppies, and the fact that Somnus carries one in each hand is supposed to reflect this. In any case, represented alone, the viewer only imagines what effects either might produce on the sleeper. It is primarily on sarcophagi that we see the horn used to connect Somnus with a sleeper. Because this image became popular in the funereal context in the second and third centuries A.D., and we know from the frequent reference it receives in Statius that the union of Somnus and sleeper through the use of the horn was a familiar motif, perhaps we can speculate about its indication of a particularly heavy, ominous, sleep which immerses the sleeper.

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[329] Ibid., 416, no. 127.

[330] Incidentally, the poppies are not mentioned once in Statius as an attribute of the god. It seems as though poppies, which are a consistent feature of artistic representation, provide a visual cue for the power of the deity, undoubtedly because of the analogy between their soporific power and that of Somnus. In an artistic context, they are a physical manifestation of his power to subdue, but are unnecessary (or would be redundant) for his literary characterization. But the methods which Somnus uses to subdue sleepers in literature are paralleled by the use of poppies in artistic representation. Virgil alludes to the soporific quality of poppies in book 4 of the *Aeneid*. In this passage (lines 474-99) Dido tells her sister that she has been instructed by a priestess to erect a pyre on which to burn all reminders of Aeneas. This priestess, as Dido claims in an attempt to win her sister's confidence, was responsible for subduing the snake which guarded the apples of the Hesperides: *spargens umida mella soporiferumque papaver* (486). Here the poppy is linked explicitly with its sleep-bringing power as well as its use in magical practice.



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The most dire example of the power of Somnus' horn comes in book 5. In line 199 Somnus marks out the Lemnian men for sleep and then murder at the hands of the island's women. Somnus is first described as imbued with a deathly mist and then as embracing the city with a dousing of fatal liquid as he approaches the city's inhabitants in stages. In a passage reminiscent of the interaction between Palinurus and Somnus in *Aeneid* 5, Statius writes, *cum consanguinei mixtus caligine Leti / rore madens Stygio morituram amplectitur urbem / Somnus* (lines 197-99).[331] Once he moves on from the city at large to the individual men, Statius writes that he *...inplacido fundit gravia otia cornu* (199). The horn, described as *implacidum,* is the implement of a sleep which implies and ensures death for the Lemnian men. The *otia* which Somnus is usually thought to dispense is laden here; it is heavy *(gravia)* with the burden of an oppressiveness which guarantees death.

Personified sleep, in this case called Sopor, makes his second appearance in the narrative in book 2 as Mercury is delivering Laius from the Underworld. Sopor, used twice by Statius to connote sleep in its capacity as bringer of dreams to men, here has the added responsibility of driving the chariot of Nox, thereby reinforcing the natural collusion between night and sleep. When Sopor gives way out of deference to Mercury in the night sky (*...trepidusque adsurgit honori / numinis et recto decedit limite caeli,* lines 60-61), this represents a transfer of power from Sopor to Mercury and Laius. Furthermore, this interchange also serves to underscore the similarity between Sopor and

[331] Compare *Aeneid* 5.854-56, cited above, a precedent for this description, which reminds the reader of the murderous sleep of an undeserving victim.



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Mercury: both are winged, and both travel between the realms of the dead and the living with ease. In fact, the intersection between Sopor and Mercury and Laius ensures that the night becomes the domain of the dead. Whereas Sopor might have provided a peaceful or dream-filled sleep for Eteocles, by yielding the night's course to the messenger and his reluctant shade, he enables Laius' ghost to fulfill Jupiter's command. This is also our first indication of the complicity between sleep and death in the epic. As all of the other Thebans spend the night awake in drunken revelry (lines 73-75), Laius appears to Eteocles in his sleep in the guise of Tiresias and terrorizes him with a warning about his brother's allegiance to Argos and his imminent attack (lines 102-119).

In addition to simply taking advantage of sleep's absence, however, Laius actually usurps the power of Sopor later in the scene, in a sort of inverted impersonation of his physical communication with the sleeper. After he has conveyed his message to his grandson, Laius opens the wound on his neck, the physical reminder of the origins of the family curse, and allows it to gush. Statius writes *...dirique nepotis / incubuit stratis, iugulum mox caede patentem / nudat et undanti perfundit vulnere somnum* (lines 122-24).[332] As I shall demonstrate later, the image of sleep lying down in the manner of a sleeper (*incubuit,* line 123) recurs in book 10 as an indicator of sleep's oppressiveness, but the image of Laius' pouring blood into the sleep of Eteocles is more evocative of a feature typical of the iconography of Somnus. The conception of sleep's power as a

[332] Compare Hypsipyle's retelling of Polyxo's exhortation to the Lemnian women, in which she uses the murderous daughters of Danaus as analogy for the Lemnian women: *...potuitne ultricia Graius / virginibus dare tela pater laetusque dolorum / sanguine securos iuvenem perfundere somnos,* in book 5, lines 117-19. Just like Laius to Eteocles, the daughters are said to infuse their husbands' sleep with blood. Although they commit murder, while Laius simply terrifies his grandson, in each instance, sleep's power to infuse the dreaming sleeper is usurped.



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liquid which pervades and subdues the body of the sleeper is familiar from artistic representation. But the connection is further reinforced by the context of the epic's narrative, as Statius draws the reader's attention to Laius' appropriation of sleep's duty by describing the actual sleep of Polynices and Tydeus just 20 lines later. In this companion passage, Polynices and Tydeus sleep deeply after their fight, while Adrastus is left awake to worry about their arrival. Statius describes the scene as follows: *...illos post verbera fessos / exceptamque hiemem cornu perfuderat omni / Somnus; at Inachio tenuis sub pectore regi / tracta quies...* (lines 143-46). Statius' use of the verb *perfundo* to describe the effects of an outside force upon a sleeper recalls the interaction between Laius and Eteocles from earlier in the text. At Argos the bounty of sleep's entire horn ensures the sleep of the exhausted travelers, whereas the blood poured from the gaping wound of Laius' neck serves only to jolt Eteocles from his sleep.[333] Thus we see that Laius' impersonation of the god of sleep entails an inversion of the god's usual sleep-inducing effect. The transition between Thebes and Argos, and thus between Eteocles and Polynices, is described in terms of sleep: the brother at Thebes is awakened by a pseudo-sleep figure with a bath of blood; the brother at Argos is put to sleep awash in

[333] Somnus' horn reappears in the text at two other points, this time empty--its contents either used up or waiting to be replenished. Close to the beginning of book 6 of the *Thebaid* Tithonia arrives on earth to mark the beginning of day; her advent chases both Nox and Somnus from the scene (cf. Tithonia in *Silvae* 5.4.9-10). Somnus is said to leave with his horn empty: *et Nox et cornu fugiebat Somnus inani* (line 27). Presumably, Somnus spends the duration of the night emptying his horn into the bodies of sleepers, and thus, the horn's emptiness implies the end of Somnus' obligation. At another instance, when Somnus is described asleep in his cave in book 10, lines 110-11, Statius chooses to mention his horn lying empty beside him. The horn is described as though an extension of his body: *...manus haec fusos a tempore laevo / sustentat crinis, haec cornu oblita remisit.* While one hand is attentive to the god's disheveled hair, the other lets the horn fall slack in forgetfulness. Even though he is asleep, his horn lies by his side. Both of these references mark the horn as an important attribute of the god's power. The horn also appears as an attribute of Somnus in Silius Italicus' *Punica* 10.352, where Juno sends Somnus to visit Hannibal in a dream bearing *medicata papavera cornu.*



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sleep's liquid. Statius establishes the opposition between brothers and the commingling of death and sleep at this early point in the narrative through his jarring repetition of the verb *perfundere*.

That infusion is a typical feature of the god of sleep is again corroborated by a description of Tydeus asleep in book 3. This scene is similar to the former in that it sets up a distinction between sleepers and insomniacs which is centered around sleep's action of pouring. The passage begins with a description of night's power to subdue mortals and beasts. In a variation on the *"nox erat"* scene, night descends and calms the earth's creatures: *Nox subiit curasque hominum motusque ferarum / composuit nigroque polos involvit amictu, / illa quidem cunctis, sed non tibi mitis, Adraste, / Labdacioque duci* (lines 415-18). Statius then describes the hero asleep as follows, *nam Tydea largus habebat / **perfusum** magna virtutis imagine somnus* (lines 418-19). In this case, deep sleep holds Tydeus while, as we learn from the use of the ablative *magna...imagine,* his sleep is pervaded by dreams, namely visual images of his recent bravery. In this example, the (non-personified) *somnus* is engaged in holding the sleeper, while its effects are manifested in the influx of dreams. Tydeus' sleep serves as a point of contrast with the situation of Polynices and Adrastus (mentioned in lines 417-18), who are unable to sleep; rather than point out the solitude of one lonely figure, Nox binds Adrastus and his new son-in-law to one another in anxious insomnia. By contrast, Tydeus, who has achieved an early victory against Thebes, is rewarded with sleep and dreams. Recall lines 339-41 of book I: *iam pecudes volucresque tacent, iam Somnus avaris / inrepsit curis pronusque ex aethere nutat, / grata laboratae referens oblivia vitae.* In the epic's



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first scene of the *"nox erat"* type Somnus himself was responsible for subduing the worries of men by invading their cares and altering their state of mind from within. In the scene in book 3, the duty of subduing the sleeper's cares is transferred to Nox, while sleep, instead of making the sleeper's mind go blank with oblivion, delights the sleeper with pleasing dream-memories.

In some representations of Somnus, the god is shown standing behind or at the side of the sleeping figure and pouring his horn of soporific liquid over him or her. this is typical of sarcophagi, where we see Somnus depicted in direct interaction with his victim using a gesture which shows that the figure in question is at that moment under the spell of sleep and is infused by his power. In such instances, the fact that the horn overlaps with the body of the sleeper suggests a continuity between the figure of Somnus and the sleeper, a link of power which is sustained by Somnus' presence.[334] As I mentioned in chapter 2, the interaction among Mars, Somnus, and Rhea Silvia isolates them among the confusion of figures occupying the rest of the visual plane. Somnus' body is twisted between the two: turning his face towards Mars, his right hand touches Rhea Silvia's raised arm as he pours soporific liquid from his horn. He holds a bowl in his left hand, which presumably contains a reserve of his sleepy potion. Furthermore, the line of the horn and Somnus' arm forms a pathway from the immobile, sleeping Rhea Silvia to the approaching figure of Mars. Somnus is the conduit between the sleeper's internal state and the outside world; in this case, Somnus admits Mars into the

[334] Recall figure 25 from chapter 2 and see also Zanker and Ewald (2004) 108, figure 91 for a contemporary piece showing Selene and Endymion.



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realm of Rhea Silvia as though guiding him to her. This is confirmed by the strong visual connection between Mars and Somnus. Furthermore, the diagonal line created by the heads of Mars, Somnus and Rhea Silvia strengthens their interconnection. Somnus provides the mid-point between Mars and Rhea Silvia both in alignment along the axis of the line created by their heads, and in their placement in the visual field. Mars, still hovering above the ground, dominates the vertical plane; Rhea Silvia, elongated in repose, occupies the horizontal. Somnus, who stands (presumably) on the ground and leans forward with arm outstretched, is a compromise between the two as he mediates between wakefulness and sleep, external force and internal repose.

In the following section I will focus upon Statius' characterization of Somnus in book 10 of the *Thebaid* as a death-like figure who is also an enabler of death, as he works in collusion with his sibling Mors to allow the Argives' unbalanced slaughter of the Thebans as they sleep. Statius' sustained characterization of Somnus is unparalleled in earlier epic. But there is a context in Roman funerary art, which provides an interesting visual parallel for the figure of Somnus imbued with the qualities of death. The so-called Medea sarcophagus, of which there are beautifully preserved examples in the Pergamon Museum in Berlin and the Louvre in Paris, both from the mid-second century A.D., depicts the demise of Creusa, daughter of Creon, king of Corinth, and the escape of Medea after the murder of her children.[335] The sarcophagus is divided into halves which are distinctly composed. The left side is noticeably static and calm, as though its figures were captured in a moment of contemplation; the right side, by

[335] See Zanker and Ewald (2004) 82, figures 64 and 65 (detail).



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contrast, swirls with motion as Creusa, having donned her poisoned garment, thrusts herself forward in a dance of death, as Medea mounts her serpent-led chariot with the corpses of her children.

To a viewer familiar with the story, the left side of the frieze, on which we see Medea's children offering poisoned wedding gifts to Creusa, hints at the horror which lies in store for her.[336] But there is yet another clue to Creusa's pending doom. As she sits with her neck bent and looking away from the scene of her death to the right, the angle of her head is matched by that of the personified Somnus, who faces her with his arms crossed in front of him.[337] The symmetrical positions of their bent necks form a prominent link between them; their eyes are at the same level as she stares away from the depiction of her imminent death, and he meets her gaze as though keeping her to her promise. He holds two poppies in his left hand and an empty horn in his right (see detail), both signs, as I have shown, of immersion in sleep. But unlike figures such as Endymion, or Rhea Silvia, whose stories revolve around action which occurs during sleep, sleep plays no role in Creusa's story. And, in fact, here she is not asleep; rather the presence of Somnus is a harbinger of death, a cruel substitute for the violent, fiery

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[336] The tale of Jason's marriage to Creusa and Medea's wrathful revenge is, perhaps, best known from Euripides' *Medea* (lines 772-89 and 1197-1201), but see also Ovid, *Heroides* 12.53-54, for example.

[337] In her *LIMC* article (1992) 122, Gratia Berger-Doer remarks that this figure could be interpreted as either Hymenaeus, and therefore an allegory of marriage, or as the god of death or sleep. It seems obvious to me that, at least in the example of figure 8, the god holds a horn, rather than a torch (associated with weddings). The poppies, as I have shown, are unmistakably the attribute of Somnus and a symbol of his power to subdue a sleeper. See Zanker an Ewald (2004) 336-39 for a more recent treatment of the iconography of this sarcophagus. Zanker also identifies the figure as a marriage attendant, who coaxes the shy bride. Zanker mentions the poppies without commenting on their possible incongruity in a wedding scene and neglects to acknowledge the horn in the figure's right hand.



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end which awaits her. This composition perverts Somnus' usual role as a euphemistic substitute for death or a metaphor for the peaceful repose of the occupant of the sarcophagus. For the death which Creusa will experience will be the frenzied opposite of sleep, as is obvious even at the level of composition. Rather than being immersed in sleep's liquid, she will be infused with the poison from her new crown and garment. Somnus' foreboding presence on the left side of the panel seems to cast its effect upon the entire scene of the left side; all of the figures in this panel are motionless, as though subdued by the proximity of a figure whose presence is external to the narrative and possibly undetected by those around him. He is not actually going to put Creusa to sleep, rather his intense stare and implements of sleep foreshadow the immersion in death which awaits her, as is obvious to the viewer of the sarcophagus, but of which she is momentarily and peacefully unaware.

**The Sleep of Death: Somnus in *Thebaid* Book 10**

In book 10 of Statius' *Thebaid,* sleep and death act as counterparts who perform easy substitutions for one another. The brothers, while they do render their victims (the Theban soldiers) immobile and unresponsive in similar fashion, mostly play separate roles: Somnus functions as disabler, while Mors, inflicted by the weapons of the Argive soldiers, furnishes the their final destruction. As the epic progresses towards the inevitable conflict between Eteocles and Polynices in book 11, the link between sleep and death in book 10, the prelude to the double fratricide, is given extended treatment. Somnus and Mors, brothers whose partnership ensures the doom of countless Theban soldiers, provide a foil for the doomed but opposed fraternal enemies, Eteocles and



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Polynices. The theme of fraternal conflict, first expressed by the phrase *fraternas acies* in line 1 of book 1, is reinterpreted in the characters of Somnus and Mors, the brothers who draw a united front against the Theban camp.

Rousing Somnus

Book 10 of the *Thebaid* begins and ends with Jupiter. The first lines of the book inform us that the father of the gods has accelerated the approach of night in order to bring an end to the misery of the day before: *obruit Hesperia Phoebum Nox umida porta, / imperiis properata Iovis; nec castra Pelasgum / aut Tyrias miseratus opes...* (lines 1-3).[338] But Jupiter's decisiveness is limited; it is in fact his ambivalence (expressed in lines 2-3: *nec...aut...miseratus)* which characterizes the opening of the book and which sets the stage for Juno's destructive intervention. At line 49 we see a geographical shift from Thebes to Argos, where the Argive women pray to Juno for aid. As R. D. Williams points out in his commentary on Book 10, this episode recalls two passages from Homer's *Iliad*-- the first is in book 6.286 ff., where the Trojan women offer a robe to Athena to win favor, while Juno's subsequent entreaty to Somnus to intervene on her behalf uses the already-mentioned episode from book 14 as its example.[339] But Statius alludes to Hera's anger and validates Juno's by using the robe to link Hera's indignation and power, evident from the scene in *Iliad* 14, with Juno's outrage against Thebes as the scene of two incidents of Jupiter's infidelity. The robe

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[338] The book ends with his decisive punishment of the hubristic Argive hero Capaneus.

[339] See Williams (1972) 41 for elaboration. See also Juhnke (1972) 141-51 for the influence of Homer's *Iliad* on *Thebaid* 10. See note 391, p. 144, for a discussion of this scene in particular.



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offered by the Argive women, as Statius tells us in a mini-ekphrasis, depicts Juno as a naïve young bride, unsuspecting of the dalliances of her husband-to-be in the following lines: *expers conubii et timide positura sororem, / lumine demisso pueri Iovis oscula libat / simplex et nondum furtis offensa mariti* (62-64).[340] The Argive women then mention Jupiter's unfaithfulness with Semele in their entreaty (*Cadmeae paelicis,* line 67); this is, of course, designed to enrage the goddess. Finally, Juno herself refers to Jupiter's infidelities with the mothers of Hercules and Bacchus (*...non saevius arsit / Herculeae cum matris onus geminosque Tonantis / secubitus vacuis indignaretur in astris,* lines 76-78), as she vows to punish the Thebans with sleep, thus offering justification for her wrath.[341]

The entreaty by the Argive women and Juno's subsequent dispatch of Iris to rouse Somnus is also reminiscent of Alcyone's story in book 11 of Ovid's *Metamorphoses,* the episode which is the model also for Statius' description of Somnus' cave. In Ovid's tale of the despondent Alcyone desperate for the return of her husband Ceyx who is lost at sea, Juno intervenes to bring solace to her devotee. Alcyone prays to Juno to return her husband uninjured and faithful to her in lines 577-82. Moved by Alcyone's entreaty, Juno dispatches Iris to rouse Somnus so that he can order Morpheus to visit Alcyone in the form of her husband as she sleeps (lines 583-91, discussed above). Statius expands Ovid's model of personal entreaty to suit his new recasting of

[340] The reference to Jupiter's future infidelity brings to mind his own list of dalliances from *Iliad* 14 (lines 312-28), which precedes his falling into Hera's trap of love-making and subsequent slumber in that context.

[341] Compare this with line 323 of *Iliad* 14, where Homer includes the same pair in Zeus' list of former lovers: οὐδ' ὅτε περ Σεμέλης οὐδ' Ἀλκμήνης ἐνὶ Θήβῃ.



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Somnus as a direct force on the action of the war. Whereas in Ovid's tale, Juno enlists Somnus' help on behalf of the individual Alcyone, and Somnus' assistant assumes the form of an individual, Ceyx, in the *Thebaid,* Juno responds to the collective plaint of the Argive women to protect their men as a group, and Juno's response takes the form of an attack against another collective, the Theban men. The interaction between Somnus (via Morpheus) and the mortal realm in Ovid's account takes place solely at the level of the individual's sleep experience. Statius' Somnus, however, is summoned to intervene directly in shifting the war's balance of power, and his involvement paves the way for significant destruction.

In the *Iliad* Hera uses her power to dupe Zeus and lure him to sleep in the hopes that this will allow the Greeks to advance in the conflict. In the *Thebaid,* rather, Juno, whose hatred for the Thebans is directly connected to her husband's infidelity, as both the entreaty of the Argive women and her own response demonstrate, usurps Jupiter's power by calling on Somnus to intervene directly in the war in a way which discriminates heavily against her enemies. Her arrogation is particularly noticeable in light of Jupiter's ambivalent disdain for the war's opposing sides. In fact, Juno is urged by the Argive women very specifically. After imploring the goddess to destroy Semele's tomb, they exhort her as follows: *et in Thebas aliud -- potes -- excute fulmen* (69). This is, of course, a reference to the death of Semele, who, duped by Juno, asked to see Jupiter's true form. When he complied, the intensity of his thunderbolt burned her to a crisp, forcing the premature birth of Bacchus. But in this case, Juno is being challenged to wield the thunderbolt herself and hurl it upon Thebes with her own might.



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The Argive women have no doubt of her ability to do this (*potes*). Jupiter's voluntary absence thus enables other gods to become involved in the conflict. Once Juno throws her metaphorical thunderbolt, Somnus assumes a dominant position on the battlefield. Somnus is a reliable choice, for she knows he is easily won over, and his ability to incapacitate, as we have seen in the *Iliad*, is unfailingly powerful, even to subdue the mightiest of the gods. But her choice of Somnus is also a direct reaction to what she sees as an unfair discrepancy between the two camps; her deployment of Somnus will establish a direct contradiction to what she perceives as the Thebans' strength at this point in the conflict. When chance (*fors*, line 73) affords Juno a moment of clarity as she is deciding whether to intervene she notices the Argive camp besieged and secured by sleepless guards: *...tempus tamen obvia magni / fors dedit auxilii. videt alto ex aethere clusa / moenia et insomnia vallum stationi teneri* (72-74). Her decision to enlist Somnus' aid is a deliberate attempt to counteract the oppressive vigilance of the Theban sentries. The use of the adverb *ergo* in line 79 to explain her choice of Somnus establishes the connection between her outrage and her appeal for his help.[342]

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[342] Statius' Iris couches Juno's request in terms of an affront to Somnus' rule, while reconfirming that she is moved to action by her perception of the Thebans' vigilance (*tumefactus...pervigil)* as a distinct advantage (lines 126-31):

> *'Sidonios te Iuno duces, mitissime divum*[342]
> *Somne, iubet populumque trucis defigere Cadmi,*
> *qui nunc eventu belli* ***tumefactus*** *Achaeum*
> ***pervigil*** *adservat vallum et* ***tua iura recusat.***
> *da precibus tantis, rara est hoc posse facultas* 130
> *placatumque Iovem dextra Iunone mereri.'*

The fact that the Thebans remain awake while the Argives sleep provides the grounds for Juno's intervention; the Thebans' aggression towards the Argives is recast as hostility towards Somnus (*tua iura recusat*, 129). His entry into the war is sanctioned as a reaction to disrespect.



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The House of Somnus

By assigning Somnus a place to live with a specific topography, Statius confirms that Somnus' existence outside of sleeping bodies is an essential part of his character.[343] Statius is, of course, building upon the models set by Virgil's description of the entrance to the Underworld in *Aeneid* 6, and Ovid's description of the cave of Sleep in *Metamorphoses* 11, but his house of Somnus departs from these exempla in significant ways, just as his characterization of Somnus also differs from earlier literary incarnations. In keeping with his tendencies elsewhere in the epic's narrative, Statius diverts attention from the presence and function of shapeless dreams, the sons of Somnus whose deceptive abilities are so important to Ovid, for example, to that of Somnus himself.[344]

Statius' description of Somnus' abode shares with its predecessors the mingling of references to death and sleep. In book 6 of the *Aeneid,* Virgil tells us that Sopor and Letum are among the personified sentinels marking the transition to Orcus (line 278), as though they represent passage from one state of consciousness to the other across the boundary of the *vestibulum.* Furthermore, Virgil mentions dreams both as Aeneas enters and exits the Underworld, thereby forging a connection between features of sleep and

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[343] In her discussion of dreams in Ovid's *Metamorphoses,* Netta Berlin (1994) 113 comments upon Ovid's location of dreams, the personified sons of Somnus, in the house of sleep as an "expression of [the dreams'] externality." I would say that the same is true of Somnus himself in the *Thebaid.*

[344] See Delarue (1988-89) for a brief discussion of the influence of Ovid's description of Somnus' lair. He emphasizes, for example, that in Ovid's account, Somnus has to be awakened in order for him to act, whereas in Statius, he never wakes up. Thus the house of Somnus in Statius, with its emphasis upon obscurity and silence, resembles a dream world. This, for Delarue, is the central difference between the accounts.



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death.[345] Ovid also hints at the association between the brothers sleep and death by referring to the proximity of the river Lethe to the cave of Somnus, and the poppies which grow on its banks (*Metamorphoses,* 11.602-06). But the familial connection he really wishes to emphasize is that between father (Somnus) and sons (dreams). In Ovid, the focus of the interaction in Somnus' cave shifts from the god's own soporific effects to the ability of his sons to deceive through dreams; after he rouses Morpheus, Somnus fades back into oblivion and out of the narrative.

Statius' ekphrastic visit to Somnus' cave parallels the external effects of Somnus upon the narrative itself; as the ekphrasis slows narrative progression, Statius demonstrates Somnus' soporific power over all creatures in his proximity. His ability to dominate through debilitation is emblematic of his power as a disabler throughout the epic. Extending the metaphor of Somnus' power, I propose that Somnus' cave becomes a locus for sleepiness even for the author of the passage and its reader, that is, for all who come into contact with it. If we imagine that the cave's soporific effect upon the narrative causes a type of drowsiness to overcome its author, this is one way of explaining the haziness of his memory of the examples of his predecessors. In other words, the murkiness of Somnus' cave provides the optimal setting for blurring the

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[345] Dreams as entities which originate outside of the sleeping mind are a significant feature of Virgil's Underworld: false dreams hover under the leaves of the elm tree at the entrance to Underworld: *in medio ramos annosaque brachia pandit / ulmus opaca, ingens, quam sedem Somnia vulgo / vana tenere ferunt, foliisque sub omnibus haerent* (lines 282-84). When Aeneas leaves the realm of the dead through the gate of ivory, Virgil explains this aspect of Underworld topography as follows: *sunt geminae Somni portae, quarum altera fertur / cornea, qua veris facilis datur exitus umbris, / altera candenti perfecta nitens elephanto, / sed falsa ad caelum mittunt insomnia Manes* (lines 893-96). Finally, Aeneas and the Sibyl receive a stern warning from the ferryman that his realm is one where the living and conscious are unwelcome, using two words which define the Underworld as the domain of sleep as much as death: *umbrarum hic locus est, somni noctisque soporae* (line 390).



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poet's memory of his epic paradigms. The effects of this transformation are exemplified by the experience of Iris when she visits the house of Somnus. Her arrival is signaled by descriptions of her radiance: she is called *discolor* (line 119), and her effects upon the surroundings contrast with those of Somnus: *effulgent silvae* (line 119) and *zonis lucentibus icta / evigilat domus* (lines 120-21). But when she leaves the house after addressing Somnus himself, as Statius writes, *excedit gravior nigrantibus antris / Iris et obtusum multo iubar excitat imbri* (lines 135-36), her levity has been weighed down by the lugubriousness of the cave, and her natural radiance has been blunted by her stay. The adjective *obtusum* is particularly charged here, as I believe it connotes both physical and mental dullness.[346] If, as Gian Biagio Conte suggests, allusion and poetic memory are synonymous, what happens to an obvious allusion in the house of Somnus, a locus for oblivion?[347] Statius' sleepy approximation of the architectural ekphrases created by

[346] This use of the adjective *obtusus* is one of only two in the entire epic. It first occurs in book 7, in the catalogue of Theban allies as recounted by Phorbas to Antigone from the walls of Thebes. The teichoscopy is an epic convention which has established precedents going back to Homer. Thus it is a locus for generic memory, in that it recalls similar passages in other epic contexts, as well as a test of memory for the character at the textual level who recounts the names of those he sees. After Phorbas has listed almost the entire host of leaders and their origins, he falters suddenly and beigns to sob (*dicenti maduere genae, vultumque per omnem pallor / iit, vocisque repens singultus apertum intercepit iter...*, lines 359-61). When he refers to this interruption a few lines later, he calls it a *labor iners* (line 368). This emotional swoon which causes Phorbas' lapse is triggered by his response to a memory of Laius in the moments before he was murdered by his son. Invading memories of horrors past prevent him from recounting from memory the names of those who pass before him in the present. When he returns to his task, he is able to add the names of those who have gone by during his period of distraction. But upon finishing this list, Phorbas claims that now his eyes fail him: *et iam acies* ***obtunsa*** *negat, cunctique resistant* (line 372). Of course, the noun *acies* has significant resonance in the epic, as it recalls the *fraternas acies* of book 1, line1. In this context its meaning seems to shift, as it could initially be mistaken for a reference to the battle line of Thebans which the pair observes. The procession of troops has come to an end as his blurred vision lets him down. The resources of his flagging memory, overwhelmed by the emotional impact of certain images, give out as his vision becomes impaired. The participle *obtunsa*, while it indicates a condition of physical exhaustion, also refers obliquely to an old man's reluctance to recount painful memories, and an imposed pause of forgetfulness.



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Virgil and Ovid allows him to reinterpret these spaces in a way that privileges the power of Somnus and the relevance of his connection to Mors in the rest of the epic.

Statius creates skillful and varied ekphrases in both the *Silvae* and the *Thebaid.* His approach is particularly diverse in the corpus of *Silvae,* where descriptions of works of art and architecture create an immediate visual image and sense of presence before the object or building described. In some cases, the ekphrasis constitutes the entire poem. In an attempt to define the generic terms for the occasional poem, Alex Hardie looks to the influence of the epigrammatic tradition, particularly its epideictic branch, on Statius' ekphrastic poems.[348] Bettina Bergmann notes that in his villa poems in the *Silvae* Statius uses ekphrasis to comment upon the owner's social status by referring to the luxuriousness of the setting described, and the interplay between natural and man-made settings.[349] Finally, Carole Newlands has recently shown that Statius uses ekphrasis in the *Silvae* to showcase the experiential aspects of viewing, and that the viewer's impressions, conveyed by the poem's narrator, are of paramount importance. In her analysis, Statius uses ekphrasis as a way to "celebrate and explore" his own poetic art. [350] In the context of the *Thebaid,* however, ekphrasis contributes to narrative effect and contends with narrative progression, creating a commentary upon the events of the epic while focusing the reader's attention upon a physical construct. In a very recent study

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[347] Conte (1986). See particularly chapter 2.

[348] Hardie (1983) 119 ff.

[349] Bergmann (1991).

[350] Newlands (2002) 38 ff.; 40.



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on ekphrasis, Michael Putnam has claimed that Virgil's ekphrases in the *Aeneid* help the reader to understand "the larger poem for which they stand as synecdoches."[351] This way of thinking about ekphrasis is important for my analysis of the house of Somnus, for I will suggest that Statius uses the concrete forms of the house along with its powerful effects upon textual and extra-textual visitors to confirm the externalization of Somnus and to allude to his equal ability both to saturate with sleep and to withhold sleep from the unlucky.

Statius' ekphrasis on the house of sleep, with its obvious nod to ekphrases in the works of his epic predecessors, also recalls passages from within his own text, such as the house of Mars in book 7, and thus its resonances are both intra- and inter-textual. Statius' ekphrasis on the house of Somnus slows the progress of the narrative at a critical point just before the final series of battles which lead up to the showdown between enemy brothers. But this slowing also focuses the attention of the reader on the effect of the ekphrasis, which creates an inward rather than linear progression as the description spirals toward the inner sanctum of the god's home. This deceleration coupled with the drowsiness induced by proximity to the slumbering effects of Somnus himself distorts the allusive presence of earlier scenes. But the oblivion attendant upon any sleep experience, here literalized in the personification of Oblivio (line 89), who guards the entrance to the home, also provides ample time for constructive "misremembering."

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[351] Putnam (1998) 209.



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There are three important precedents in the *Thebaid* itself which inform Statius' description of the house of Somnus in book 10 and give it a specific internal relevance. In the instances which I will discuss below, Statius uses the description of a location to reflect the sinister circumstances of either what takes place there or the personalities of the characters who dwell in these spaces. The inaccessibility and darkness of Somnus' house recall both Oedipus' blind exile, described in terms of inhabitation in book 1, and the grove of Diana at Thebes, the site chosen for the necromancy of Laius in book 4. The dominance of silence at both the grove of Diana and the house of Somnus is another reminder of the link between death and sleep. But the house of Mars, described in an architectural ekphrasis at the beginning of book 7, provides the closest structural parallel to the house of Somnus. It is also inhospitable to light: *laeditur adversum Phoebi iubar, ipsaque sedem / lux timet, et durus contristat sidera fulgor* (lines 45-46). Among other features, Statius mentions the personifications which guard each god's structure as well as a series of sculpted forms which adorn the respective interiors. The innovation of the sculptural program is certainly remarkable, but the way in which Statius elaborates upon the model set in book 7 for his description in book 10 has particular significance for his characterization of Somnus. These textual relationships showcase connections of specific thematic importance in the epic: they ally Somnus to the realm of the dead (grove of Diana) and the living dead (Oedipus), as well as to the dominance and destructiveness of war itself (house of Mars). The provocation of Mars in book 7 yields the first physical confrontation between the Argives and Thebans, an end towards which Oedipus and Laius, from their liminal positions, have urged progress since the beginning



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of the tale. Architectural ekphrasis, therefore, links the human characters who exert their influence over narrative action with the divine and externalized motivators of confrontation, Mars and Somnus.

The ekphrasis of the house of Somnus, a self-contained passage framed by the uses of cognate words denoting drowsiness *occiduae* (line 84) and *succiduis* (line 117), during which the reader penetrates the home of the god before the arrival of Iris, has four distinct layers. The approach to the house establishes the atmosphere of immobility and silent drowsiness which characterizes Somnus' home. These qualities are emphasized by the use of the verb *stat* in primary position in the line which begins the description (line 84) and are echoed again in the description of the location as a *lucus iners* in line 86. The sentinels posted to guard the house are personifications of Somnus' side-effects and, therefore, emblematic of his power. There is an ironic paradox embodied by the sentinel who is never vigilant: *limen opaca Quies et pigra Oblivio servant / et numquam vigili torpens Ignavia voltu* (lines 89-90), Statius writes, as though advertising the god's power over all who come into contact with him, including the guards themselves. This theme receives tragic reincarnation later in the book, as Somnus subdues the Thebans in sleep despite the presence of their own sentinels at the Argive camp. The power of Somnus is confirmed by his silencing of natural activity in the vicinity of his house. Guardians Otia and Silentia are said (again ironically) to sit *muta* (line 92) while they prevent the birds and branches from making noise (lines 91-92); likewise the sounds of



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water and the sky are subdued (lines 94-97).[352] Finally, the blanketing silence is attended by the withering of activity in the natural world: the verbs *recubat, marcent,* and *inclinat* (lines 98-99), which refer to the (in-)action of the sheep, the buds, and the grasses in proximity to Somnus' home, are further reminders of his power to inhibit growth and effect a type of death.

At last the narrative enters Somnus' chamber at line 100 (*intus;* this continues the progression from *limen* (line 89) to *vestibulo* (line 91)), where the reader is immediately confronted by another ekphrasis, this time describing the sculptures which decorate Somnus' chamber (*mille simulacra,* line 100). Statius makes specific reference to five individual sculptures before Iris and the reader encounter the god himself. Statius deploys his ironic humor, for example, in his description of the sculpture of Labor, the embodiment of hard work, who is depicted with Somnus *in requiem vergens* (line 102), that is, acting contrary to his own nature. Finally, after witnessing the effects of Somnus on other beings, observing his cohort of personified guardian-avatars, and seeing his image multiplied in sculpted forms, Iris and the reader encounter the god himself, also asleep, exuding his soporific power from the deepest recess of his home. This is marked by Statius as a moment of awakening, in a sense, an experience distinct from the representations the reader has encountered up to this point: *haec species* in line 106 signifies a transition from the deceptive qualities of representation to the confrontation with what is real. This distinction is further emphasized by the description of the dreams

[352] With the humorously redundant *Silentia muta* Statius reminds us of the excessive (and unnatural) degree of silence in his grove.



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which crowd Somnus' inner chamber, where *vera simul falsis permixtaque...* (line 113), between which neither the visitor to the house, nor the unwitting sleeper whom one of these may visit, can distinguish.

The important connection between place and inhabitant in Statian ekphrasis, which is most intricate in the house of Somnus in book 10, has an early precedent in the self-fashioned, internal dwelling place of Oedipus, namely the space of his mind's darkness, from which realm he calls down the curse upon his sons that governs the events of the narrative. At the beginning of book 1, after establishing the theme for his epic and giving a brief synopsis of the story he is to tell (lines 1-45), Statius turns to Oedipus, progenitor of the central antagonists of his work. The former king's self-imposed blindness (*aeterna...nocte,* line 47) is described as an exile in the confines of his own mind, whose features are reminiscent of a home. Statius describes Oedipus' existence as follows:

> *illum indulgentem tenebris imaeque recessu*
> *sedis inaspectos caelo radiisque penates* 50
> *servantem tamen adsiduis circumvolat alis*
> *saeva dies animi, scelerumque in pectore Dirae.*
>
> Submitting to the shadows and the obscurity of his deep dwelling,
> tending to the penates unseen by the sky and the sun, nevertheless,
> the fierce daytime of his mind flew about with tireless wings
> and the Furies, punishing his crime, in his breast.



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In particular Statius evokes the image of a home by using the words *sedis* and *penates* in line 50 as metaphors for the liminal realm in which the blind Oedipus exists.[353] In describing his abode as a *recessus* (line 49), Statius emphasizes its distance from the populated world. Statius alludes to the darkness of Oedipus' existence with the word *tenebris* (line 49) and the phrase *inaspectos caelo radiisque* (line 50), which describes both its darkness and its inaccessibility. Oedipus' mind (*saeva dies animi,* line 52) is the only semblance of daytime and light for him, and he is constantly tortured by his thoughts. Thus we see a direct correlation between Oedipus' self-torture and his relegation to the confines of a blind existence detached from the rest of humanity and removed form happiness. But yet it is from this "home", the cave of his mind, that he calls down his curse upon his sons to fight one another to the death (lines 56-87), thereby setting in motion the events of the epic.[354]

There is a corollary to Oedipus' mental confinement in book 4 of the epic, but this is neither an enclosed dwelling, nor a metaphorical abode. Rather, Statius creates a detailed ekphrasis upon the grove of Diana/Hecate, the site chosen by Manto and Tiresias for their necromancy. It is in this scene that the ghost of Laius appears and predicts the mysterious "double crime" (*geminumque nefas,* line 643) which awaits the

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[353] The *penates* of Oedipus' "home" are picked up by Statius' use of the word *larem* (line 88) as a metonym for Somnus' home in book 10.

[354] Oedipus reappears in book 11, immediately after his sons have killed one another. His emergence from his "home" is described as follows: *at genitor sceleris conperto fine profundis / erupit tenebris, saevoque in limine profert / mortem inperfectam...*(lines 580-82). The shadowy confines of his tortured mind are said to contain a *limen* which the father must cross to rejoin the rest of the world. He crosses this boundary as if emerging from the Underworld, having experienced an incomplete death in the isolated exile of his mind.



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warring brothers. Laius ends his speech with the following prediction: *crudelis vincit pater* (line 644). This acknowledgment of Oedipus' power recalls the opening of book 1, where the blind father articulated the curse on his sons; thus Laius' reiteration of the curse one-third of the way into the narrative forms a bookend to the predictions of fraternal war. Statius tells us that the grove of Diana (*nemori Latonia cultrix / additur,* line 425-26) lies underneath (*subter,* line 423)[355] an overgrown wood which lets in no light (*silva capax aevi validaque incurva senecta, / aeternum intonsae frontis, stat pervia nullis / solibus,* line 419-21). The description of the wood as impenetrable by sunlight both recalls the chamber of Oedipus' blindness and anticipates the description of Somnus' home as ....*nulli penetrabilis astro / lucus iners* in lines 85-86 of book 10.[356] In all three locations, the lack of light indicates their remoteness and inaccessibility. Furthermore, Statius alludes to the darkness of the place using two words identical to those used to describe the obscurity of Oedipus' visionless realm: ...*hanc piceae cedrique et robore in omni / effictam sanctis occultat silva* ***tenebris.*** */ huius* ***inaspectae*** *luco stridere sagittae* (lines 426-28). Statius' mention of *tenebris* in line 427 to indicate the quality of darkness in the wood recalls the darkness that Oedipus is said to indulge in

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[355] Statius also marks the inaccessibility of the house of Somnus in book 10 with the adverb *subter: subterque cavis grave rupibus antrum / it vacuum in montem* (lines 86-87).

[356] This grove shares additional physical similarities with the house of Somnus. The space below the wood, in which awe protects silence, is actually first identified by the noun *quies* (*subter operta quies, vacuusque silentia servat / horror,* lines 423-24). Both *quies* and *silentia* are recast as personified sentries of the entrance to Somnus' cave. Furthermore, the grove is said to be Diana's resting place when she tires from the hunt: *aut ubi fessa iugis, dulcisque altissima somnos / lux movet, hic late iaculis circum undique fixis / effusam pharetra cervicem excepta quiescit* (lines 431-33). Because of its solitude, darkness, and quiet, this locus invites sleep. These are also the qualities which make it ideal for conjuring the dead. The connection between inaccessibility, sleep, and death will be exploited by Statius in book 10.



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book 1. Diana's arrows zip by unseen (*inaspectae...sagittae,* line 428), just as Oedipus' "home" was unseen by the sky or the light of the sun. The repetition of this adjective emphasizes the darkness of both realms as well as the inability of those inhabiting them to see.[357]

The most obvious precedent for architectural ekphrasis in the *Thebaid* is the poet's description of the house of Mars in book 7; these abodes have more in common than simply their remote settings. At the opening of book 7 Jupiter dispatches Mercury to bring Mars the message that the war god must rouse the Argives to attack. After describing Mercury's difficult approach to the house through storms of wind and hail (lines 34-39), and the predominance of iron in its construction (the words *ferrea, ferro* and *ferratis* are used in quick succession in lines 43-44), Statius then focuses the reader's attention upon the personifications posted to guard Mars' threshold. Like the personified sentries who guard Somnus' house, figures such as Nefas (line 48), Metus (line 49), and Discordia (line 50), embody the facets of human emotion which both enable and result from war. House and denizens are linked by the phrase *digna loco statio* (line 47). Poignantly, Virtus (courage) fends for itself in the midst of all other hostile entities (lines 51-52). We learn more about the inhabitant of this place, although Mars himself is absent, upon entering the space to see images of the spoils of wars which decorate it (lines 55-63). Of particular significance, as Smolenaars notes, is the manner in which

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[357] The adjective *inaspectus* is used sparingly by Statius. In fact, these examples account for two of only three usages of the adjective in the *Thebaid.* The third comes in book 8.241, where Statius describes Oedipus' reentry into the narrative as he joins the revelers at Thebes. His appearance contrasts with his usual obscurity: *semper* ***inaspectum*** *diraque in sede latentem.*



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Statius blurs the line between what is inscribed and what is three-dimensional by using verbs such as *caelata* and *insignibant* to describe what the visitor sees.[358]

Furthermore, Statius draws attention to the sculptures of Mars himself, which stand everywhere (*ubique,* line 60) in his home; this feature will be echoed and expanded by the thousand sculptures of Somnus (*mille...simulacra,* line 100), also created by Mulciber, which adorn his cave. It is in these decorative details, which appear to be a Statian invention, that the edifice most resembles the house of Somnus, rather than in the experiential qualities of visiting the house.[359] We get a sense thus that the god of war works alone, thriving upon human strife, rather than in tandem with another god, such as Mors (Death), to bring misery to mortals. In fact, Mors, who is the last personification to be mentioned in the list, appears like Mars himself, armed and smeared with gore. The fact that Mars is not to be found at home when Mercury arrives is significant, for this sets up a contrast with his counterpart Somnus. Mars, an active god, is not as intimately connected to the environment of his home, as is Somnus, who sleeps in (and pervades) his abode until he is disturbed.

I will now return briefly to a discussion of how Statius' passage deviates from its primary referent in book 11 of Ovid's *Metamorphoses.* Most significant is the decorative program of Statius' house of Somnus, an elaborately-woven meditation upon Somnus' exteriority, which establishes the existence of sleep outside of his connection to

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[358] Smolenaars (1994) 33-34.

[359] For the literary precedents for the house of Mars in other texts, especially Homer's palace of Alcinous in *Odyssey* 7 and Virgil's description of the palace of Latinus in *Aeneid* 7, see Smolenaars (1994) 22-24. Smolenaars sees Statius' use of additional negative models from Vergil, Seneca and Valerius Flaccus as motivated by a desire to "associate the god of war with crime and ruthless tyranny," 24.



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sleepers. The many incongruities throughout the house, Labor, product of Vulcan's own hard work struggling to stay awake, for example, or, Silentia rendered mute, underscore the paradox of the externalized force of sleep, a state which cannot exist without a body to inhabit. Statius distinguishes his account of the house of Somnus from Ovid's through his description of the house as a self-reflexively decorated space. While an armature for Somnus' dwelling is established by Ovid, the details of its decorative program yield to the importance of the personifications of dreams. Dreams, the thousand sons of Somnus in Ovid's tale, are replaced by the thousand images of Somnus which adorn Statius' rendering of the house. Just as Morpheus is praised by Ovid for his skills as *artificem simulatoremque figurae* (line 634), Statius pointedly contrasts the *simulacra dei* of Somnus' chamber with the presence of the slumbering Somnus himself, encouraging the reader to ponder the distinction between representation and reality. And, while we have learned that Mars' house in book 7 is adorned with innumerable sculpture, Statius refuses to describe any one in detail, for the distinction between image and reality is not important for his characterization of the god of war.

Giving corporeal form to the figure of Somnus coincides with the description of artifice in the sculpture which decorates his home. As Statius tells us, the sculptures of Somnus depict him interacting with other gods, presumably making them drowsy or putting them to sleep. I have described the ironic depiction of Labor above. We also encounter an image of Voluptas, for example, who is said to slouch around the god's side (*...hic haeret lateri redimita Voluptas,* line 101). Somnus' external force is given permanence in sculpted representations, where he exerts his power through contact with



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his victims, in this case, other gods. This device is most significant in the revelation of the hidden sculpture of the brothers Somnus and Mors together: *...interius tecti in penetralibus altis / et cum Morte iacet, nullique ea tristis imago / cernitur...*(lines 104-06). The fact that no one sees this image (except the reader, of course), a tantalizing reference to its disturbing subject matter, reminds the reader of the nexus between the brothers at the level of the outer narrative, whose manifestation is about to reach its pinnacle in the story of the war. It is helpful to think of the allusive relationship between these figures and their counterparts in the larger narrative as one of pendants, images which are "infused with new meaning", according to Elizabeth Bartman, when allied in a certain contextual juxtaposition.[360] The intimacy between Somnus and Mors captured by the sculpted image of the brothers gives the reader a glimpse at the sinister collaboration between the two forces that determine the events which will follow, while it hints at the intensity of their relationship.

Somnus on the battlefield: the sleep of death and dreams of destruction

In *Thebaid* book 10, sleep is not simply a euphemism for death, but is death's complicit partner.[361] As David Vessey notes, "the slumber which Somnus casts over the Theban camp is unnatural and portentous."[362] The examples in this book, I argue, reflect

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[360] Bartman (1991) 79.

[361] See Mace (2002) on Aeschylus' *Oresteia* for the most recent treatment of the link between sleep, death, and wakefulness as a reflection of the disturbing elements of its story, namely, "the destructive and self-perpetuating cycle of retaliatory violence" 36, with reference to Fraenkel's observation on the matter n. 61, p. 48: "the details [of the Herald's speech at 503 ff.] capture 'much the worst aspect of the almost unending war: scarcely ever a decent night's rest...'" See also Mace (2004).

[362] Vessey (1973) 305.



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a prominent feature of Statius' poetic technique, namely the prevalent inability of his characters to experience peaceful sleep. By repeatedly calling attention to his characters' failure to rest peacefully, Statius comments upon their anguish over the predicament of a war between brothers towards which his narrative progresses. The events of book 10, the final battles before the meeting of the brothers, perpetuate and amplify the dysfunction of sleep from earlier in the text by teaming sleep with death itself. This hideous collusion between sleep and death marks the culmination of a series of nightmares and tortured bouts with insomnia which have hitherto plagued the night lives of the *Thebaid's* characters. When the Thebans in book 10 do sleep, they experience a deep sleep from which they do not awaken, or from which they awaken only to die. This is the cruel crux of sleep's sinister persona--when the soldiers do sleep deeply, their rest costs them their lives.

The connection between sleep and death in book 10 of the *Thebaid* is particularly prominent because Somnus himself controls the central action of the book, while its beginning and end are demarcated by scenes of death. The book opens with a survey of limbs strewn from the preceding day's battle and ends with the smoldering death of the Argive hero Capaneus. Somnus' intervention towards the beginning ensures that the slaughter will continue through the rest of the book. Juno's plan for the Thebans' demise reveals the established collusion between sleep and death: sleep will render its victims vulnerable to the attack of their enemies, and their immobility will guarantee their death. Juno's plan does not fall short of its aim, and the Thebans suffer a horrific variety of deaths in their sleep.



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In lines 79 and 80, which summarize Juno's plot against the Thebans, Statius explicitly connects the experience of sleeping with that of death:

> *Ergo intempesta somni dulcedine captos*
> *destinat Aonios leto praebere, suamque* 80
> *orbibus accingi solitis iubet Irin et omne*
> *mandat opus....*
>
> Thus she plans to offer to death the Aonians captured
> in the unpropitious sweetness of sleep,
> she orders her Iris to be girded with her usual arcs and
> she dispatches the entire job to her.

Line 79, which echoes the weight of sleep upon the sleeper with its heavy spondees, characterizes sleep by its "unpropitious [time-less] sweetness" (*intempesta...dulcedine).* The adjective *intempesta* is significant for its shades of meaning. Statius' usage here exploits the word's negative connotations--a precedent familiar from the works of other authors. Virgil, for example, uses the term to describe *Nox*, personified mother of the Furies, at 12.846,[363] while the phrase *nocte intempesta* is used by Cicero to describe the dead of night as a time conducive to an act of insubordinate revolt, such as a slave gathering.[364] Statius borrows this word from its usual attachment to *nox* itself, and transfers it instead to the charms of sleep, night's defining activity. Its inherent reference

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[363] Virgil describes the birth of the Furies (*Dirae)* as follows, *dicuntur geminae pestes cognomina Dirae, / quas et Tartaream Nox intempesta Megaeram / uno eodemque tulit partu...* (845-47).

[364] Cicero writes, at *Verrines* 4.94, *repente nocte intempesta servorum armatorum fit concursus.* In this case *intempesta* underscores both the fact that the night is an unlikely time for a *concursus* and that a group of armed slaves could only stage their assembly--an unusual and subversive event--under the cover of deep night. Williams (1972), 44, prefers 'timeless' and writes, "others, less well, take it as 'untimely', 'fatal.'" He cites examples (different from those above), which he believes corroborate his claim. I find it difficult to ignore the negative connotations of the adjective in this context, however, where it forms an oxymoronic phrase with *dulcedine.*



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to the suspension of time evokes a point in the night at which everything is still--this is an environment in which chthonic forces such as the Furies are free to roam the upper world, for the static quality of this moment not bound by time enables their interference.[365] Because of its familiar association with the powers of the Underworld and the mystery of night's darkness, the stillness of the deep sleep which Juno imagines for her despised Thebans is already comparable to death's eternal calm. But Statius reemphasizes the complicity between the nouns *somnus* and *letum* by placing them in the same position, after the caesura, within their respective lines: *ergo intempesta* ***somni*** *dulcedine captos / destinat Aonios* ***leto*** *praebere, suamque....* Furthermore, the nouns are brought into closer alignment by their positions in a chiastic arrangement around the accusatives *captos...Aonios*. These lines convey through their word order the twofold doom in store for the Thebans; first they will fall prey to sleep and will then be given over to death. The nouns *somni* and *leto,* each at the beginning of a metrical colon in the same position after the line's caesura, thus surround the Thebans and create boundaries which their captivity will not permit them to cross. The words which represent the Thebans' fate are hemmed in from both sides by the dual threat of immobilizing sleep and his fraternal counterpart, death.

After Somnus subdues the Thebans en masse, the Argive seer Thiodamas--Amphiaraus' protégé and replacement as prophet--encourages his men to seize the

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[365] The adjective *intempestus* is formed from the inseparable particle *in-* meaning "without" or "not" and *tempus* meaning "time" (see Ernout-Meillet 682 "II. tempus"). For definitions in ancient sources, see Macrobius *Sat.* 1.3 (*non habet idoneum tempus rebus gerendis);* and Varro *LL* 6.7 (*inter vesperuginem et iubar).*



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opportunity for attack. His words echo the already established bond between sleep and death. He cries, *stupet obruta somno / Aonidum legio: tempus nunc funera regum / ulcisci miserumque diem,* in lines 194-96. Before they have been attacked, the Thebans are already dead, having been "buried" or "destroyed" (*obruta)* by sleep. The participle *obruta* refers not only to their submission to the power of sleep, but to their imminent death which will result from sleep's imprisonment.[366] The verb *stupeo* reinforces their immobility and helplessness. Their vulnerability is echoed in Thiodamas' subsequent incitement to the Argives: *bellum iacet* (line 214). As I will show, the verb *iaceo* recurs in descriptions of both sleeping and dead soldiers.

The stupefaction of the Thebans is contrasted with Thiodamas' agitated description of a fruitful nighttime visit from the shade of his predecessor Amphiaraus (lines 202 ff.). His vivid retelling of his master's visit is very effective. Like an orator conjuring the spirit of an ancestor, Thiodamas uses the realistic appearance of his mentor to sanction the attack he proposes. Whereas the dreams of the Thebans will produce nothing but images of their own death, Thiodamas' vision lends validation to the massacre that they are poised to commit. Thiodamas emphasizes the authenticity of his vision first by claiming that Amphiaraus stood before him unchanged: *ipse, ipse adsurgens iterum tellure soluta / qualis erat...* (lines 203-04), and second that the visit from his mentor was not a legitimate dream: *...non vanae monstra quietis, / nec somno*

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[366] Statius has already employed this phrase at book 8.267-70, where he contrasts Adrastus' insomnia on the night of the Theban revelry with the slumber of the Argive troops by using the simile of a lonely helmsman steering a ship and its sleeping crew as follows, *sic ubi per fluctus uno ratis* ***obruta*** *somno / conticuit.... solus stat puppe magister / pervigil...*



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*comperta loquor* (lines 205-06). The deceptively lifelike appearance of the seer, perhaps reminiscent of the deceptive realism of a dream visit from a dead figure, such as Ceyx's appearance to Alcyone in Ovid's *Metamorphoses* 11, is given validation by its viewer because of its lifelike qualities. Thiodamas' insistence upon its independence from the dream realm, however, creates a further distinction between his experience and that of the Theban soldiers who lie asleep and wait to dream their own deaths.

Thiodamas translates the incitement of his teacher into a succinct phrase in lines 213-14, *non comminus hostes / sternendi: bellum iacet, et saevire potestas.* He presents the opportunity before his companions in terms of the tension between opposing forces in the context of a fraternal war. The nouns *bellum* and *potestas* are linked across the chiasmus, as are the verbs *iacet* and *saevire.* Obviously, the verbs are more recognizable as opposites: although both are intransitive, the meaning of the second is distinctly active and hostile, while the first lends itself to various usages, but is used frequently to refer to the passive state of sleep. But the opposition between *bellum* and *potestas* is more telling. War between enemies challenges the power of either side over the other.[367] In this instance, the prostrate enemy is the one easier to overcome; there is no need to act as the normal circumstances of war dictate: *non comminus hostes sternendi,* cries Thiodamas to the Argives in lines 213-14. Furthermore, this statement works on two levels, since the verb *sterno* can refer, when used reflexively, to lying

[367] In his commentary on book 10, R. D. Williams (1972) 60 calls the clause *bellum iacet,* "a bold use of abstract for concrete, a form of metonymy much used by Statius and the other Silver Age poets." It is possible to read *bellum* as a metonym for 'enemy' in this context, but this limits the noun's effect. The phrase should also be understood as a comment upon the suspension of war, its protocols, and its attendant rivalry between sides.



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down or stretching out, as in sleep, while it can also denote throwing down violently or striking to the ground.[368] There is no need to lay the enemy low, since he is already in this position, Thiodamas points out, but, when understood in the context of Statius' repeated alignment between sleep and death in book 10, we can read the verb as an indication that the Thebans are already dead, because they lie fast asleep across the battlefield. This is at once a premonition of their imminent deaths, which they will meet lying in the same positions, and an admission that their sleep renders them already dead to their enemies, since their attackers will not have to exert great effort in killing them.

Making sure not to create the level of noise which would awaken the sleeping Thebans, the Argive troops descend upon their prey, *praecipitant saltu* (line 264), rather than force open the gates to the city--the expected method of entry for an antagonistic military force--which would likely emit a deep groan (*ne gravis exclamet portae mugitus aenae,* line 263). Of course both methods of entry would create noise, and we must as readers wonder why Statius draws a contrast between the two methods of approach in this passage.[369] I believe that he does this in order to call attention to the unnatural state of sleep which captivates the Thebans: this is not a sleep from which they will easily

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[368] See *OLD* 1a: to lay out on the ground (or other surfaces); spread; 5a: to stretch (a person, etc.) in a horizontal position (esp. oneself, one's limbs); (pass. in middle sense, often in pf. pple.) to lie or throw oneself prostrate (esp. as a suppliant); 7a: to strike down or stretch lifeless (a person, etc.) with a blow or weapon, lay low.

[369] Williams (1972) 66 comments that "the phrase is a very unusual one" in reference only to Statius' use of the verb *exclamare* with an inanimate subject. He neglects to remark upon the strange implications of this line in its context. The image of the loud doors that disturb sleep has precedent in Ovid's description of the cave of Somnus, where, Ovid claims, *ianua nec verso stridores cardine reddit* (11.608). In Ovid's account, the doors are absent so as not to disturb the inhabitants of Somnus' cave, namely Somnus and his sons. In Statius' account, the Argives' avoidance of the gates so as not to wake the sleeping enemy reminds the reader of the pervasiveness of Somnus' presence in the Theban camp. The Argives must not risk disturbing Somnus or his victims in any way.



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awaken, rather it is a prelude to the death from which they will only surface as they are about to die. Furthermore, it underscores the unnatural and subversive supremacy which the Argives will enjoy. The absence of noise in their movement also emphasizes the deceptive nature of Somnus in this episode. He is the bringer of peace who secretly portends death for his victims. The silence of the attacking Argives belies their aggressive stance and their imminent rampage. They too harbor evil intention in their false respect for their enemies' rest.

By attacking in this manner, the Argives imitate Somnus himself, whose own entry into Thebes was described 100 lines earlier in the narrative as follows:

> *primus adesse deum subita caligine sensit*
> *campus, et innumerae voces fremitusque virorum*
> *submisere sonum; cum vero umentibus alis*
> *incubuit piceaque haud umquam densior umbra*
> *castra subit, errare oculi resolutaque colla,* 150
> *et medio adfatu verba inperfecta relinqui.*
>
> The field first felt the presence of the god in the
> immediate mist, and countless voices and sounds of
> men fell silent; when he lay over the camp with his
> moist wings and swooped down in a
> a black cloud never more oppressive, eyes
> wandered and necks sagged, and unfinished words were
> left unspoken in mid-sentence.

Somnus swoops down into the camp with his *umentibus alis* (line 148), wings wet with soporific liquid. By describing the actions of the Argives as similar to those of Somnus himself, Statius compensates for and explains the suspension of reality we must display in order to believe that their descent created less noise than the opening of the Theban gates would have made. Furthermore, the attention to silence is paramount in



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each scenario. The Argives in their imitation of Somnus, here a sinister counterpart to Mors, are invested with his destructive potential by acting like him. It is important to note his effects upon the fighters he subdues. After his immediate presence is felt, all noise ceases: *et innumerae voces fremitusque virorum / submisere sonum* (lines 146-47). Somnus' silencing takes place at the level of general din--the noise of the crowd is checked by his intervention among the Thebans. But his silencing also occurs at the level of individual conversation containing discernible words. Statius writes, *et medio adfatu verba inperfecta relinqui* (line 151). The implication here is that Somnus' power takes effect immediately, allowing no opportunity even for completion of a statement already begun. In fact, the double elision in the line (in the second and fourth feet) enhances the effect of Somnus' force.[370] Just before the speakers are interrupted by sleep, they begin to slur their words; the triple spondee in the middle of the line contributes to the sense that their speech becomes slower as they fall asleep.[371] This example of his power is followed by a description of his ability to deactivate the mechanisms of war itself by deactivating the Thebans' shields and spears and rendering them limp (lines 152-53). That the chins of the soldiers droop onto their chests is a

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[370] This double elision is not unusual for Statius' composition; there is an instance less than 20 lines earlier, for example, in line 137 (*ipse quoque et volucrem gressum et ventosa citavit).* It is unique, however, in its context of the six lines cited above.

[371] There are two noteworthy instances in which death at the hands of Thiodamas forces an end to speech; one comes in lines 275-76, where voices die in helmets: *et galeis inclusa relinquit / murmura;* the second occurs in line 323, where the voice of a charioteer dies in a torrent of blood after he is stabbed to death: *fractumque perit in sanguine murmur.* Both of these descriptions emphasize the abruptness and surprise of the soldiers' deaths as well as their momentary attempts to rouse themselves from sleep only to be immediately cut down. In the latter case, the soldier is described as lying (*iacentis,* 321) while his sleep is agitated and bubbling: *accensusque mero sopor aestuat* (321). His sleep is animated yet he lies immobile and available for slaughter.



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premonition of the enemy spears which will land on those very spots after the Argives storm their camp. Somnus at once halts war and allows a doubly intense destruction to occur in its place.

After Somnus has overcome all of the individual soldiers with his soporific potency, his task is complete. The epilogue to Somnus' aristeia consists of the following statement, *et iam cuncta silent* (line 154). These lines imply that all is silent because all of the Theban soldiers, overcome by Somnus, lie still. This stillness is manifested, as Statius continues, by the immobility of the Theban horses, and the blackness which results when there is no one awake to tend the torch fires: *ipsi iam stare recusant / cornipedes, ipsos subitus cinis abstulit ignis* (lines 154-55). The proliferation of 's' sounds in these two lines (each word in line 155 has an 's' in at least one of its syllables) evokes the sound of sleep itself--the only thing audible in the absence of noise. The war between Thebans and Argives (and the battle between Eteocles and Polynices) has ground to a complete halt. Just as the words are drained from the mouths of talkative soldiers, the words of Statius' war narrative have fallen beside their course.[372] But the respite is temporary: what we have witnessed is the interruption of war but not of fighting.

The balance between the two sides has been tipped in favor of the Argives. Just as the Argives were waylaid at Nemea upon their journey to attack Thebes in books 4-6, the Thebans are now deprived of the ability to defend their city. The contrast between

[372] Compare with this Statius' description of Somnus' cave and its slumberous effects on the narrative, as discussed above.



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the positions of the cities is emphasized very clearly in lines 156-59, where Statius switches to the scene in the Argive camp:

> *at non et trepidis eadem Sopor otia Grais*
> *suadet, et adiunctis arcet sua nubila castris*
> *noctivagi vis blanda dei: stant undique in armis*
> *foedam indignantes noctem vigilesque superbos.*
>
> But Sopor did not offer the same relief to the fearful
> Argives, and the soothing power of the night-wandering god
> kept his clouds away from the adjoining camp: they stood
> everywhere in arms offended by the foul night and
> their enemies' haughty night watchmen.

The Argives are awake and anxious about their worsening situation, since they have lost four of their seven leaders to the Thebans. Their agitation is immediately apparent from Statius' use of the verb *stant* (line 158), especially as this is recalls *stare recusant* from Statius' description of the sleeping Theban horses in line 154. The immediacy of the juxtaposition between camps is further underscored by the naive reaction of the Argives to the situation at hand. They are said to be resentful of what they perceive to be the vigilance of their enemies. They are quick to resent the 'base night', just on the point of recognizing its benefits for their cause.

The fact that the Argives have yet to learn what the reader already knows adds a degree of irony to the sentiments expressed by these lines. Statius uses the word *otia* to describe the effects of sleep upon the Thebans. Relaxation is certainly what they experience, but since we are aware of the origin of Juno's command to Somnus, namely to provide the Argives with an easy chance for revenge, we already fear that one camp's leisure will afford the other an opportunity for havoc. The use of the verb *suadet*



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emphasizes the duality of the sleep experienced by the slumbering Theban soldiers and the ambivalent nature of sleep's gift. But the most poignant example of the ironic characterization of sleep is evident in the adjective *blanda* modifying *vis,* sleep's power. The god's soothing power keeps his cloud of rest away from the Argive camp, thereby depriving the attackers of its 'sweet' effect of inglorious death. I think that this phrase is also meant to evoke the *intempesta somni dulcedine* of line 79, the first allusion to the link between sleep and death which defines Juno's nefarious plan and which is so integral to the narrative of book 10.[373]

After the Argives have infiltrated the Theban camp, their initial impression of their opponents is one which yet again mingles the states of sleep and death. In a simile which uses the now familiar verb *iaceo,* the Thebans who lie en masse (*ingens,* line 264) before them look as though they are already dead from battle wounds. Statius writes that they appear not just *iam exanimes* but, more specifically, *multoque peracti / ense* (lines 264-65). The violent deaths of the Theban soldiers are foreshadowed in this description of their horizontal bodies. The contrast between the sleeping-dead Thebans and the vital Argives continues in the following lines, where Thiodamas urges on his men, telling them to go wherever lust for boundless slaughter should take them. Significantly, Statius uses the adjective *inexhaustae* to modify *caedis* (line 267), further illustrating the

[373] References to Somnus' "sweetness" are ironic in the *Thebaid,* as they refer to one's expectations of sleep as welcome, while undercutting this quality in their specific contexts. This is also the case in *Silvae* 5.4, where the epithet used by the narrator in the *captatio benevolentiae* of line 1, *placidissime divum,* is somewhat undermined by the god's refusal to grant the insomniac's request. Thus *placidissimus* is an ideal which is not always fulfilled by the god; it implies what one expects of him.



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wakeful greed of the Argive force. Slaughter for them will be inexhaustible, while for those whom they kill, it will be indiscernible from exhaustion.

Lines 300-03 offer another example of the juncture between sleep and death at both the narrative and structural levels. The result of the murders committed by Actor[374] and Agylleus, son of Hercules, is described in the following terms:

> *fumat humus, **somnique et mortis** anhelitus una* 300
> *volvitur; haut quisquam visus aut ora iacentum*
> *erexit: tali miseris deus aliger umbra*
> *incubat et tantum morientia lumina solvit.*
>
> The earth smoked, and one united breath of sleep
> and death rolled forth; scarcely any one of those sleeping
> lifted his face or head: the winged god lay with such
> an oppressive shadow upon the wretched
> and opened their eyes only as they died.

By putting the nouns *somni* and *mortis* in the genitive case and using the correlatives *-que* and *et* to link them, Statius encourages the reader to associate these words. Statius' use of the adverb *una* at the end of line 300 draws a further connection between the nouns. The elision in the third foot of line 300 between *-que* and *et* brings the words for sleep and death closer together in pronunciation while also articulating what Statius describes at the narrative level--that the two types of unconscious experience are exhaled in the same breath. The passive verb also underscores the Thebans' lack of control over their actions. The lugubrious quality of sleep is brought out again in the next line, where none of those "sleeping" (*iaceo,* again) is able to lift his eyes, let alone his entire head.

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[374] The first named Argive soldier after Thiodamas is Actor; cleverly his name itself reiterates the advantage of animation which the Argives hold over the Thebans in this battle.



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Their sluggishness is underlined by the weight of the spondees in the second through fourth feet of the line.

Employing a phrase which reminds us of the paradoxical nature of the god of sleep, Statius writes that the winged god hovers over the sleeping Thebans, shrouding them in his somnolent shadow. This recalls the scene in lines 148-49, where Somnus, described as having *umentibus alis,* is said to lie upon the Thebans spreading his *umbra* over their bodies. He is stationary while his effect lasts, but his wings are a reminder that his presence is temporary and that, when he leaves, he has the ability to change the fortunes of the war. By describing him in this manner, Statius characterizes the god of sleep as the bringer of sleep but also *as* a sleeper lying immobilized (*incubat).* Thus the oppressiveness of his physical presence combined with his identification as a sleeper, undoubtedly a metaphor for the effects of sleep from the perspective of the sleeper, underscores the duality of Somnus' external and internal power.

The rest of line 303, however, boasts another paradox whose implications are equally significant for a discussion of the bond between sleep and death in the *Thebaid.* Statius writes that the god of sleep only opens the eyes of those who are in the process of dying, *as they die.*[375] This is a strange image, for we are accustomed to think that the eyes *close* at the moment of death, never to reopen. But in fact, this remark serves to complete the contamination of sleep by death. The victims are roused from their death-

[375] The phrase *lumina solvit* (line 303) is not an unusual combination. It is used by Virgil to describe the death of Palinurus in *Aeneid* 5.856 (*deus* [Somnus, line 854]... *cunctantique natantia lumina solvit.* As Melville (1995) xl writes in the introduction to his translation of the *Thebaid,* "there is a reversal in sense [from Vergil's use], which points a paradox: eyes are not now 'closed' when life ends, but 'opened' merely for death itself."



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like sleep just as they are about to experience death itself; since they wake up only to die, they will remain with their eyes open as they pass into death. Their death will be like an awakening, while their life in sleep was a type of death. The Theban soldiers are cruelly awakened by death only to realize that they have been and continue to be powerless to combat it. As though dreaming with eyes open, the soldiers are allowed to see their deaths as they happen. The process of dying, then, is like the experience of dreaming, if the whole experience of sleep is analogous to that of death.[376]

This experience receives a more substantive treatment 20 lines later in the narrative, which is helpful to read with the earlier passage in mind. In lines 318-25, Statius describes the final moments in the life of a Theban charioteer named Calpetus. In line 321, his sleep is disturbed; in lines 324-25 Statius speculates that perhaps (*fors,* used adverbially) he has a terrifying vision of his city in blackness and of his killer, Thiodamas: *fors illi praesaga quies, nigrasque gravatus / per somnum Thebas et Thiodamanta videbat.* So his glimpse of the ruined city and his vicious attacker would be the equivalent of a nightmare whose events are a simultaneous reality for their viewer. Statius begins line 324 with an ironic description of sleep (*quies)* as *praesaga,* which reinforces a dream's potential for averting behavior through interpretation. This

[376] This has an earlier parallel in the experience of Elymus the Lemnian described by Hypsipyle in Book 5.210-15, where he surfaces from an inebriated sleep only to be murdered by his treacherous wife, ...*sed illum / infelix sopor admota sub morte refugit. / turbidus incertumque oculis vigilantibus hostem / occupat amplexu, nec segnius illa tenentis / pone adigit costas, donec sua pectora ferro / tangeret...*



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dream-vision does not simply foretell the future, but it reveals imminent events which the dreamer has no chance either to interpret or to prevent.[377]

**Sleep Tenuously Restored**

The conjoining of sleep and death, an important factor in the narrative of book 10, allows for the imbalanced slaughter of the Thebans by the Argive forces. This scene of massacre and the demise of the Argive hero Capaneus at the end of the book set the stage for the ultimate confrontation between the epic's antagonists, Eteocles and Polynices. The double fratricide towards which the story has progressed, casting a sense of dread over the entire epic, finally occurs in book 11. Although the aftermath of the slaughter is only tenuously peaceful, book 12, the final book of the *Thebaid,* offers some restoration of the elusive restful sleep sought by the fighters and families on both sides of the conflict.

Book 12 opens at night: *nondum cuncta polo vigil inclinaverat astra / ortus et instantem cornu tenuiore videbat / Luna diem...* (lines 1-3). The brothers Eteocles and Polynices have killed one another in battle the day before (11.572-73); night has fallen on a scene of intense lamentation and Creon's censure of Antigone at the end of the dreaded day preordained by Oedipus' curse. The last line of book 11 hints at the favorable change in the night's temperament, as the Argives retreat to Argos, defeated and obscured by darkness: *nox favet et grata profugos amplectitur umbra* (line 761).

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[377] Cf. Hypsipyle's description of her 'actual' dreams as *dura...praesagia somni* in book 5.620. She, however, refers to dreams she had long before, and whose content is revealed as significant only in retrospect. Although she had ample time to interpret their symbols, she failed to do so. We are left to wonder what she actually saw in her dream, and whether it was allegorical or literal.



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This marks a significant improvement upon Thiodamas' description of night in book 10, in which night's cover was favorable because it rendered a sleeping camp vulnerable to its enemies' murderous impulses: *nox fecunda operum pulchraeque accommoda fraudi / panditur* (lines 192-93). The change in the function of Nox reflects the recuperative aftermath of the war and hints at a possible return to normal sleeping patterns for the war's survivors. But as I shall show, this is only partially true. For as there is no final resolution to the tension between the brothers, there is also no full return to restful sleep, although the situation is improved.

In lines 6-8 of book 12 Statius reveals the dual nature of night as it persists for the Thebans after the war. The cover of night is at once a hindrance to their assessment of the aftermath of the war's destruction and a partially restorative experience. The night has imposed inactivity upon the Thebans; they have been unable to take stock of the war's devastation after the climax of the war: *agmina iam raris Dircaea penatibus errant, / noctis questa moras;...*(lines 5-6). The night which for the Argives marked the beginning of retreat, and thus an end to combat, for the Thebans meant a prevention from beginning their reconstruction after the war. The tension between sleep and rest is illuminated in the concessive clause of lines 7-8, where Statius offers the first evidence that sleep has been reinstated after the war, but that its restorative qualities are elusive: *et primus post bella sopor, tamen aegra quietem / pax fugat et saevi meminit victoria belli.* The disconnect between the presence of sleep (*sopor)* and its inability to benefit the sleepers through rest (*quietem)* is further emphasized by the paradox of *pax aegra,* the very cause of *sopor's* ineffectiveness. A weakened peace resulting from the war's



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unsatisfactory end prevents the external force of sleep from affecting those it would otherwise soothe. Furthermore the internal function of memory, which keeps alive the tensions of the war, overrides the natural function of sleep. This represents a transformation from the situation prior to and during the war, where insomnia was a response to upcoming tension, rather than reflection upon conflicts past.

The following night and subsequent three days are marked by a vigil for the unburied dead, during which the insomniac Theban mourners do not move from the battlefield, as they await the timber for funeral pyres: *...nec dulcibus astris / victa, nec adsiduo coierunt lumina fletu. / tertius Aurorae pugnabat Lucifer...* (lines 48-50). This is also the experience of Argia, who, as we learn, has traveled from Argos with a band of bereft Argive women to retrieve their dead. In an act of defiance, she has set off to confront Creon herself, while her companions have elected to travel to Athens to seek the help of Theseus. Her sorrow prevents her from distinguishing between day and night: *cum tamen illa gravem luctu fallente laborem / nescit abisse diem: nec caligantibus arvis / terretur,...* (lines 230-32). For those intent upon lamentation and the proper burial of their dead, night and day, without the punctuation of sleep, are indistinguishable. The refusal of the mourners to sleep hints at the resistance to closure manifested by book 12.[378] This is underscored by the intervention of Juno, who is on her way to aid the mission of the suppliant women in Athens, the result of which may bring

[378] Closure in literature has been a topic of recent debate among classicists. See, for example, *Classical Closure* (1997). For a discussion with particular relevance to Latin epic and the *Thebaid*, see the contribution to this volume by P. Hardie (1997a).



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peace to Thebes. She desists from her journey, a digression from her mission, to aid Argia in her search for Polynices' body. Narrative perspective shifts from Juno's ethereal context, characterized by night's sleep-bringing shadows (*...soporiferas caeli...per umbras,* line 291) to the unnatural wakefulness of the world below, where Argia labors despite her exhaustion (*...per campos errore fatiscere vano / inmeritam Argian supero respexit ab axe,* lines 295-96).

Juno's assistance of Argia takes two forms: the goddess first persuades the moon, Cynthia, to illuminate the battle field in order to enable Argia to locate her husband's body (lines 299-306). Juno then asks Cynthia to dispatch Sopor to subdue the Theban guards, so that they will not interfere with Argia's search (*hunc quoque, qui curru madidas tibi pronus habenas / ducit, in Aonios vigiles demitte Soporem,* lines 307-08). Thus the natural progression of the moon through the sky is temporarily stalled and her light diverted at Juno's behest. Sopor, this time in his capacity as charioteer, will abandon Cynthia's chariot while he tends to this command.[379] As the adjective *pronus* shows, Sopor is idle at the reins while Cynthia focuses her beams of light upon the battlefield at Thebes. This is an interesting inversion of the scene in book II, where Sopor, this time in his role as charioteer of Nox, was stopped in his tracks across the sky and his position usurped by Laius and Mercury, as I have discussed above. This scene represents his return to the conflict in his capacity as a soothing force. Not unlike the summoning of Somnus in book 10, here Sopor is called by being diverted (rather than

[379] Compare with this the first mention of Somnus in book I, line 339, where he accompanies Titanis (the moon) in the night sky, with no mention of the chariot, however.



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roused) to subdue Theban victims in a scheme to enable Juno's will to pass. As I shall show, this intervention by the force of sleep, although it distracts rather than disables the Theban victims, allows for the continued conflict between Eteocles and Polynices as their flames contend on the pyre.

We learn of Argia's foray onto the battlefield through the brightness of the moon's light as it enables her to find her husband's corpse. Cynthia shines with a brilliance more concentrated than usual, which is almost too much for even Juno to bear: *...vix ipsa tulit Saturnia flammas* (line 311).[380] Antigone's dash onto the field to uncover her brother's body is the direct result of Sopor's intervention, which, we learn, has overcome the guards whose constant vigil had hitherto inhibited her movement: *ut paulum inmisso cessit statio horrida somno, / erumpit muris,* (lines 355-56). While Cynthia uses the strength of her light to guide Argia, Sopor immobilizes the guards in order to facilitate Antigone's movement. The contrast between methods is complemented by that between the unnaturally sun-like brilliance of the moon and the simultaneous deep sleep of the guards. The abnormal setting for this scene is balanced by the events which follow the brave efforts of Antigone and Argia.

The women can only find one pyre with its embers still burning on which to lay the body of Polynices. They discover that the body already occupying the pyre is Eteocles', as the hostility between the brothers flares up once again, rekindled by their

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[380] Statius includes a striking number of references to the overpowering brightness of the moon's light. See also, *via ea, cum scissis magnum dea nubibus orbem / protulit; expavere umbrae, fulgorque recisus / sideribus* (lines 309-11). The moment of recognition is an almost instantaneous result of the illumination of the field: *primum per campos infuso lumine pallam / coniugis ipsa suos noscit miseranda labores* (lines 312-13).



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proximity on the pyre, literalized by the image of a split flame (lines 429-36). In contrast to the peace which has been forged between two women from the opposing sides, the brothers' hatred for one another endures.[381] The split flame of the funeral pyre undermines the women's attempt at peace and the reader's hope for resolution. The intensity of the flames threatens to split the pyre apart (lines 447-48), and this disruption awakens the guards, thus leading to the apprehension of Argia and Antigone. But Statius also develops this ambiguous non-resolution to the conflict in other ways. At lines 449-50 Statius describes the experience of the guards just before they are awakened: *et vigilum turbata quies, quibus ipse malorum / fingebat simulacra sopor.* The guards, who had been lulled to sleep by Sopor, are now reanimated by the commotion coming from the brothers' pyre. In the distinction between *quies* and *sopor* (this time printed with a lowercase 's' in the Teubner edition of the text), Statius informs us of the continued tension surrounding sleep in the *Thebaid,* even after the conclusion of violence. Although the guards have been asleep, they have not been at peace nor completely detached from the events going on around them. The active agent of sleep (*sopor)* has fashioned *malorum simulacra* for their dreams, leaving them unable to escape the nightmarish vision of the brothers' continued hostility. As long as the mutual hatred of Polynices and Eteocles endures, those in their periphery will be unable to experience restful sleep. It is significant that sleep, in its final reference in the epic, is invoked as an indicator of continued unrest between enemies.

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[381] This inability to find peace even in death reminds us of Polynices' threat to Eteocles at 11.568-69: *...vivisne an adhuc manet ira superstes, / perfide, nec sedes umquam meriture quietas?*



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Statius' epic does eventually come to a close with the arrival of Theseus, the destruction of Creon, and the resounding of female lamentation. The final reaction of the two sides is to unite in peace: *permiscentque manus* (line 783).[382] This is a notable departure from the persistent polarization of the sides, which reached its ultimate manifestation in the hostile flames of the brothers' shared pyre, the reader's final reminder of the un-restful rest characteristic of the epic and typified by the slippage between sleep and death. As Somnus was summoned by Juno to aid the destruction of Thebes in book 10, Theseus is employed by the goddess to achieve peace through the murder of their monarch. In each case, the power of an outside force, one that is specifically allied to neither of the sides in question, is deployed to assist in destruction.

The absence of restful sleep in the *Thebaid* has played a dominant role in indicating the unnatural and dangerous tension between warring members of the Theban royal family. After the sons of Oedipus exterminate one another, those left behind are faced with the restoration of peace and, with it, one hopes, peaceful sleep. But the theme of insomnia, we find, outlasts the conclusion of the epic's narrative proper. In his epilogue, Statius expresses his hopes for his poem's success, refering to the labor involved in writing it as follows, *durabisne procul dominoque legere superstes, / o mihi bissenos multum vigilata per annos / Thebai?* (12.810-12). Thus we learn that the writing of the poem deprived the author himself of sleep (*multum vigilata...Thebai),* as he withheld sleep from his characters as a way of expressing the futility of their conflict.

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[382] For discussion of the epic's drawn out or insufficient closure, see Markus (2004); McNelis (2000) 126-59 for a discussion of closural precedents in Homer's *Iliad*; Braund (1996); Hardie (1993) 48, who refers to "Statius' potentially endless subject matter", also (1997) 151-58.



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Thus Statius links his own experience of writing the *Thebaid,* and the anxieties which this entails for him, with the experiences of the *Thebaid*'s restless, sleepless kings and warriors. Statius' poetics of sleep extends beyond the fictional narrative of his epic and into his own programmatic statement about his work. Acknowledgment of this connection between method and content allows for an insight into the role of negative sleep experience which has hitherto been overlooked in studies of Statius' poetry.

Insomnia, the inability to sleep, or the deliberate rejection of it, provides an important counterpoint to the discussion of sleep and the characterization of Somnus' power. Thus the perversions of the sleep experience and the torture of its disruption in the context of the *Thebaid,* themes which I have explored in this chapter, will continue to be relevant as I turn to a study of insomnia in Statius' poetry in chapter 4. The following chapter considers the sphragis to the *Thebaid* and then looks back at some specific episodes of insomnia in the *Thebaid.* But it is really a detailed analysis of *Silvae* 5.4, Statius' ode to Somnus from the perspective of an insomniac, that comprises the greater part of the upcoming chapter. In my discussion of insomnia I contextualize Statius' characterization of this condition as a component of the poetic process in this and other of the *Silvae* within in the history of the theme as it appears in the work of earlier Hellenistic and Latin poets.



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# Chapter 4: Insomnia

A flock of sheep that leisurely passes by
One after one; the sound of rain, and bees
Murmuring; the fall of rivers, winds and seas,
Smooth fields, white sheets of water, and pure sky;
I thought of all by turns and yet do lie
Sleepless.
-William Wordsworth, "To Sleep" (1807)

## Elusive Sleep: Statius' poetics of insomnia

Statius' *Silvae* 5.4,[383] the shortest in his corpus of his occasional poems, and the penultimate poem of the collection, is a plea for the attention of Somnus, god of sleep, articulated through a meditation upon the agony caused by his absence. The narrator's desperation is evident in the poem's opening line, a question addressed to an anonymous god (the name Somnus does not appear until line 3), which is blurted out by the narrator before the specific context of the poem has been introduced. 5.4 is notably different from the other poems of the *Silvae,* particularly for its brevity and its dearth of biographical components and references to Statius' cultural milieu. The poem has a universalizing quality, which appears, like a hymn, to transcend time or personal circumstance. But rather than dismiss this poem as disconnected from Statius' life and poetry, we should consider its commentary upon the experience of insomnia essential for understanding the Statian poetics of sleep.

In the 19 lines of poem 5.4, Statius conveys the powerful effects of sleep by conceiving of it as an externalized force, in particular by describing expressively the

[383] See text of poem along with my translation in Appendix 1.



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god's selective kindness and his ability to torment those from whom he withholds his attention. This god, whom the poem's narrator begs to visit him after being driven from a pair of lovers who might shun his attentiveness (line 15), is depicted as all-powerful and yet discriminating with his gifts. But the emphasis in this poem is less upon courting Somnus than upon portraying the psychological torment of insomnia. This dichotomy, however, reveals the poet's skill at conveying the tension inherent in the internal and external facets of the sleep experience.[384] Furthermore, the insomnia described in this poem differs from the sleeplessness to which Statius refers elsewhere in his poetry, particularly in *Silvae* 3.5 and in the sphragis of the *Thebaid,* where he defines the writing of his epic as an insomniac experience. This observation is relevant for two reasons, which I hope to illuminate in the remainder of this chapter: insomnia is an important feature of Statius' poetic self-definition, to which he draws attention in both the *Silvae* and *Thebaid.* Furthermore, his representation of sleeplessness in both contexts reflects the anxiety and the horror of internecine war in the *Thebaid* itself and the similarly taxing experience of writing about this. These referents for insomnia in the poetry of Statius, while distinct, are united in the context of *Silvae* 5.4.

*Silvae* 5.4 connects my discussions of elegy and epic, as it contains elements familiar from elegiac discourse while it encapsulates some aspects of the role of Somnus

[384] The first part of the poem (lines 1-11), which presents a subjective reflection on the narrator's predicament, reminds us of the subjective stance of the elegiac narrator. The later portion of the poem (lines 14-19), which characterizes sleep as an external force, reminds us of the objective personification of the figure of Somnus in epic. Lines 11-13, the reference to the mythological tale of Argus and Io, function as an interlude between these two phases of the poem. Laguna Mariscal (1990) 125 notes a similar division in the poem, characterizing lines 1-13 as a "queja por el insomnio" (complaint/lament) and lines 14-19 as a "plegaria al dios Somnus: invocation clética" (prayer).



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in the *Thebaid*.[385] The narrator of *Silvae* 5.4 longs for Somnus' presence to such a degree that his desire for the absent god determines the tone of the poem; thus the figure of Somnus looms in the poem precisely because of his absence from it. By the end of the poem, the restless narrator will be content to have a mere encounter with Somnus: a simple, momentary interaction that he hopes will bring temporary relief from his insomnia. But the fact that Somnus does not visit the narrator even at the end of the poem makes his absence more striking. A. J. Pomeroy analyzes the poem by comparing the narrator to a lover longing for his absent partner, who is figured as Somnus.[386] This is the central feature on which Pomeroy hinges his argument about the parallels between this poem and the elegiac notion that insomnia is caused by the desire for a lover's presence. We see this, for example, in Propertius 1.3, where Cynthia claims to have stayed awake imagining her absent lover returning from the bed of another woman.[387] Furthermore, the poem's intensity, communicated in few lines, and its interior focus, which is underscored by the narrator's self-doubt and sense of isolation, help to create a recognizably lyric or elegiac atmosphere, which is distinctly different from the rest of the *Silvae*.[388]

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[385] Regardless of the chronology of the writing of *Silvae* book 5 and the completion of the *Thebaid,* and the question of which might have served as a model, it is obvious that Statius' characterization of Somnus in *Silvae* 5.4 shares distinct features with its counterpart in the *Thebaid.*

[386] Pomeroy (1986).

[387] See also Roland Barthes (1978) *A Lover's Discourse* for the discussion of the power of absence in the relationship between lovers.

[388] As early as 1932, in fact, Paul Friedländer wrote that this poem "das so viele Ströme antiken Geistes auffängt... doch ganz allein steht in der klassischen Dichtung...", 228. To him, the poem was not simply unique among the *Silvae,* but stood alone among all of classical poetry.



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The obvious elegiac sensibility of *Silvae* 5.4 makes it an appropriate focus for the final chapter of a dissertation that began with a discussion of elegy. But the poem's connection with the tradition of love poetry has a significance that has hitherto been overlooked in analyses of the poem and its place within the corpus. Statius emphasizes the distance between his own experience of insomnia and that of two excited lovers in the following lines, *si aliquis longa sub nocte puellae / bracchia nexa tenens ultro te, Somne, repellit, / inde veni...* (14-16). The manner in which the narrator casts the lovers in a position antithetical to his own is itself important. The poet's use of *aliquis* to describe the lover introduces his anonymity and thus his unfamiliarity to the narrator; the opposition in the verbs *repellit* and *veni* establishes a further resistance between them; the adverbs *ultro* and *inde* create a sense of distance in space between the narrator and his imagined lovers. Just as the narrator sets up a contrast between himself and this couple, thus the poet alludes to but then distances himself from the role of insomnia typical for the love poets.[389] Before turning to an analysis of *Silvae* 5.4, let us look more closely at some precedents for Statius' treatment of sleeplessness.

**Insomnia in Latin love poetry**

We see an early example of a poetics of insomnia in poems such as Catullus 50 and Propertius 1.10, which blur the lines between erotic longing, hard work, and poetic

[389] *Silvae* 5.4 inverts the model of Ovid's *Amores* 1.13, the hymn to Aurora. The earlier poem also presents a desperate plea to a personified deity, this time urging Aurora *not* to come, for he wishes to linger with his lover. The narrator of Ovid's poem confesses that he has wished for Aurora's course to be disrupted as follows: *optavi quotiens, aut ventus frangeret axum, / aut cadere spissa nube retentus equus!* (lines 29-30). Contrast the verbs of halting, *frangeret* and *cadere*, with the verbs of motion, *veni* (line 16) and *transi* (line 19), of *Silvae* 5.4.



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competition.[390] Working within a tradition that established insomnia as the side-effect of longing for an absent lover, these authors played with this notion by adding poetic rivalry as a cause for insomnia.[391] As Richard Thomas points out in his important study of this motif, the narrator's insomnia in Catullus' poem 50, for example, is caused not simply by the absence of Calvus, but by his excitement after taking turns at writing poetry with his friend (as described in lines 1-6 of the poem) and finally by creating his own agonistic poetic response to this experience, as we see in lines 7-17:

*atque illinc abii tuo lepore*
*incensus, Licini, facetiisque,*
*ut nec me miserum cibus iuvaret*
*nec somnus tegeret quiete ocellos,* 10
*sed toto indomitus furore lecto*
*versarer, cupiens videre lucem,*
*ut tecum loquerer simulque ut essem.*
*at defessa labore membra postquam*
*semimortua lectulo iacebant,* 15
*hoc, iucunde, tibi poema feci,*
*ex quo perspiceres meum dolorem.*

I left your house turned on by your charm,

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[390] This has its origins in a fragment of Callimachus (epigram 27 Pf.), in which he describes the excellent crafting of his friend Aratus' poetry as a σύμβολον ἀγρυπνίης. The term ἀγρυπνία is borrowed from the paraclausithyron scenes in other epigrammatic sources, and first applied here to refer not to an excluded lover's sleepless state, but to a poet composing poetry (for a longer discussion of the uses of this term, see Thomas (1979) 198-200). As Alessandro Barchiesi has recently pointed out to me, this phrase had a double meaning when applied to the work of Aratus: since he was writing about astronomy, he was compelled to work at night in order to collect material, so it could reflect both the circumstances and the intensity of his work. An earlier source for the sleepless vigil of the paraclausithyron is comedy. See for example, the opening of Menander's *Misoumenos*.

[391] Ovid's *Amores* give us a number of examples which echo the traditional association between love's torment, longing for an absent lover, and insomnia. In 1.2.3-4 the narrator laments *et vacuus somno noctem, quam longa, peregi, / lassaque versati corporis ossa dolent?;* in 2.9.39-40, he exclaims that a good night's sleep can only be enjoyed by one who lacks love, *infelix, tota quicumque quiescere nocte / sustinet et somnos praemia magna vocat!;* in 2.10.19-20, the narrator is willing to accept insomnia, so long as it means he has a lover, *at mihi saevus amor somnos abrumpat inertes, / simque mei lecti non ego solus onus!*



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Licinius, and your wit, so that when
I got home no food could help me in my wretched
state and no sleep blanketed my eyes with peace
instead I tossed about the whole bed
wild with madness, desperate to see the light,
so that I could talk and be with you again.
But after my half-dead limbs spent from work
lay about the bed, I wrote you this poem, my delight,
so that you might get a sense of my pain by reading it.

Here Catullus conflates the emotional state provoked by the longing to reunite with an absent lover with the excitement of poetic competition. Inspired by his friend's talent, Catullus is unable to sleep as he reacts to what he has read and heard; he translates his stimulation and consequent insomnia into an opportunity for creating his own poem, one which both acknowledges and incorporates that of his friend. As in *Silvae* 5.4 line 2, the narrator of this poem calls himself *miser* (*me miserum,* 9), using a typical elegiac epithet. This wretchedness, however, is skillfully converted into poetic productivity; it reflects not the state of being an insomniac, but rather the absence of his friend. This choice of adjective, with its connotations of erotic longing, bolsters the connection between the tone of *Silvae* 5.4 and the sensibility of love poetry.

Thomas reads Propertius' elegy 1.10 as a "deliberate reminiscence of" Catullus' poem.[392] The poet, mixing amatory and programmatic references, locates these within the narrator's bout with insomnia. The first 10 lines of the poem follow:

*O iucunda quies, primo cum testis amori*
*affueram vestris conscius in lacrimis!*
*o noctem meminisse mihi iucunda voluptas,*
*o quotiens votis illa vocanda meis,*

[392] Thomas (1979) 204.



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*cum te complexa morientem, Galle, puella*
*vidimus et longa ducere verba mora!*
*quamvis labentis premeret mihi somnus ocellos*
*et mediis caelo Luna ruberet equis,*
*non tamen a vestro potui secedere lusu:*
*tantus in alternis vocibus ardor erat.*

O sweet quiet, when I was present as a witness
to your first love and an observer of your tears!
O sweet delight for me to remember that night,
O how many times it must be recalled in my prayers,
when I saw you, Gallus, dying in her embrace and
creating long delay with your words! Although sleep
was pressing upon my drooping eyes and rosy Luna
was in the middle of her course across the sky,
I was still unable to slip away from your game:
There was such great passion in your conversation.

As in Catullus 50, this poem's narrator is inspired by what he has experienced earlier in the company of his friend.[393] After "watching" his friend's love-making, the narrator is inspired to share with his friend his own advice about love, and to impart the wisdom he has garnered from his relationship with Cynthia (this follows in lines 11-30). The narrator's insomnia results from his excitement about his friend's poetry/love-making, and this translates into an opportunity for demonstrating his own poetic wisdom. His deliberate shunning of sleep is indicative of his interest in his friend's experience.

[393] If we read these lines as Thomas (1979) does, we must accept two adjustments to the traditional view of the poem: first that Gallus is the late neoteric poet, Cornelius Gallus, not simply a friend of the narrator; and second, that the putative description of the narrator's voyeurism is a metaphor for *reading* Gallus' erotic poetry, rather than literally watching his love-making. It is not my goal to prove here that Thomas' reading is correct. Rather, I feel that it is sufficient to note that Propertius writes metaphorically of the experience of observing in some way (whether through viewing or reading) the erotic experience of a friend whose vivid style inspires admiration and rivalry. Propertius writes as though he were watching the subject matter of his own poetry, an amorous encounter between a poet and his lover, come to life before his eyes. The vividness of his description reveals the intensity of the lovers' encounter. For an agreement with and elaboration of this argument, see Janan (2001) chapter 2.



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Furthermore, this sparks his enthusiasm for sharing the information gained from similar poetic/erotic rounds with his own lover, Cynthia.[394] Just as in Catullus' poem, the narrator's insomnia becomes the hinge between reminiscing about his friend's erotic experience and discussing his own, both in poetic terms.[395] The fact that Propertius is inspired to write a poem about the experience of reading his friend's poetry gives sufficient evidence for the connection between reading another's work and writing one's own. This connection is reinforced at the level of subject matter as well, since the themes the narrator mentions are those that form the topics of Propertius' own poems, for example, Cynthia's annoyance and hurt.[396] His insomnia is synonymous with poetic and erotic excitement, and bridges the transition between admiration for his friend and the creation of his own new work.

As Thomas argues in the conclusion to his article, the link between poetic-erotic stimulation and creative competition is forged in Propertius 2.34, where these sets of poetic competitor-lovers (Catullus / Calvus and Gallus / Propertius) reappear as a group in the final four couplets (lines 87-94):

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[394] This is a lover/poet who repels sleep, unlike the narrator of *Silvae* 5.4, who craves it but is deprived. In fact, the lonely and uninspired narrator of *Silvae* 5.4 begs Somnus to flee from the thankless bedside of those like Catullus and Propertius in order to appease him.

[395] The narrator of Catullus' poem indicates that he felt no hint of exhaustion or desire to sleep (*nec **somnus**...**ocellos**,* line 10), just as food provided him no pleasure (line 9). This phrase is similar to that which Propertius uses in line 7 in a concessive statement (*quamvis...**somnus ocellos**)*. Although Propertius implies that his narrator is staving off sleep, while Catullus' is wide awake, the emphasis upon *somnus* closing the eyes of his victims provides another parallel between these two accounts.

[396] Thomas neglects to mention that Propertius' use of the noun *verba* in line 6 to describe Gallus' supposed "aroused utterances" (echoed by *verbis* in line 18 to describe the narrator's own words of advice) supports a reading of the "viewing" as a references to poetry. This usage extends the metaphor into the realm of writing and away from that of action.



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*haec quoque perfecto ludebat Iasone Varro,* 85
*Varro Leucadiae maxima flamma suae*
*haec quoque lascivi cantarunt scripta Catulli,*
*Lesbia quis ipsa notior est Helena;*
*haec etiam docti confessa est pagina Calvi,*
*cum caneret miserae funera Quintiliae.* 90
*et modo formosa quam multa Lycoride Gallus*
*mortuus inferna vulnera lavit aqua!*
*Cynthia *quin etiam* versu laudata Properti,*
*hos inter si me ponere Fama volet.*

Varro also played with these themes after he finished his Jason,
Varro the brilliant flame of his Leucadia
these themes the lines of cheeky Catullus also sang,
and because of these Lesbia is more famous than Helen herself;
these the pages of even learned Calvus recorded,
when he sang of the death of wretched Quintilia.
And because of beautiful Lycoris how many wounds did Gallus,
when he died, wash with the water of the underworld!
Cynthia, *...* praised in the poetry of Propertius,
if Fama wishes to place me among these examples.

This poem reinforces the close relationship between self-promotion, poetic program, and admiration for one's predecessors. Here Propertius establishes his own place in the lineage of Roman neoteric and elegiac poets. By including Varro and his poetic conversion at the head of his list and specifically linking him with those who follow in a forceful triple anaphora with *haec*, Propertius also recapitulates his aversion to epic poetry. By describing Varro as a poet who both abandoned epic poetry (*perfecto ludebat Iasone,* 85), and had a successful career as a love poet, Propertius exhorts the poem's addressee to do the same. Varro provides for Propertius a transition from the body of the



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poem, in which Propertius establishes the supremacy of elegiac poetry, into its conclusion, which features his selective list of love poets and their subjects.[397]

Although this poem makes no explicit reference to insomnia as part of the creative-competitive relationship between writers, it alludes to the overlap between eroticism and poetic ingenuity. By mentioning in particular Catullus, Calvus, Gallus, and himself in succession, Propertius recalls the connection between inspired poetic creativity and sleeplessness. As a declaration of his membership among the poetic heirs of Callimachus, this poem is striking because, while it clearly refers to the subject matter which links these poets--namely their mistresses--it also suggests that they share a poetic style capable of transforming erotic subject matter into poetic fame. But rather than elide the intervening Roman poets and boldly call himself the Roman Callimachus as he does later in poem 4.1, Propertius speculates here that his reputation (*Fama,* line 94) might align Cynthia with the lovers of the earlier poets, and thus place him among the pantheon of his predecessors, whose pedigree extends as far back as Callimachus.

**Insomniac's lament: *Silvae* 5.4**

Paul Friedländer compared the role of Somnus in *Silvae* 5.4 with the choral pleas for Somnus' attention in both Sophocles' *Philoctetes* (lines 828 ff.) and Seneca's

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[397] This explicit anti-epic statement is perhaps meant to ally Propertius further with Callimachus. Callimachus' *Aitia*, in which he makes his famous programmatic statement about the virtues of refined and well-honed writing over the well-worn themes and bombastic style of some of his predecessors (particularly Antimachus, author of the *Lyde)* would have already been in the reader's mind. By the time Catullus and Propertius are writing, however, this has been reconfigured more specifically as an antagonism between the genres of elegy and epic. Earlier in poem 2.34, Propertius had mentioned the dream-setting for Callimachus' poem in lines 31-32, where he advises his friend, the addressee of the poem, to abandon his bard and imitate instead *...musam leviorem...Philitae / et non inflati somnia Callimachi.*



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*Hercules Furens* (lines 1063 ff.).[398] The respective isolation and madness of the central characters in these tragedies is an interesting parallel for the similar conditions of the narrator of 5.4; in all three cases, Somnus is summoned to alleviate the misery of the protagonist, who because of his personal torment is unable to find peace even in sleep. In each of the examples from tragedy, however, the chorus is asking for Somnus to come on behalf of the central character, whereas in Statius the narrator begs for his own relief. This marks *Silvae* 5.4 as particularly elegiac: the insomniac narrator demonstrates a self-awareness typical of the elegiac narrator. He is able to articulate his own unhappy condition and comment upon it both internally (as he experiences it) and externally (as though he has an objective perspective upon his experience). He alone calls upon Somnus, because he realizes that this will benefit his own need. This is a departure from the tragic scenario, in which Somnus is invoked as a result of outside observation.

This slippage between internal and external awareness is also evident in the description of the insomniac's isolation vis-à-vis the rest of the sleeping world outside of his bed, a scene familiar from Virgil's description of the sleepless Dido's isolation in book 4 of the *Aeneid*.[399] What was in Virgil a third person narration, included to establish and indicate Dido's madness, becomes for Statius a first-person commentary

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[398] Friedländer (1932) 225-26.

[399] Virgil describes the sleepless Dido in *Aeneid* 4.522-27 as follows:

> *nox erat et placidum carpebant fessa soporem*
> *corpora per terras, silvaeque et saeva quierant*
> *aequora, cum medio volvuntur sidera lapsu,*
> *cum tacet omnis ager, pecudes pictaeque volucres,* 525
> *quaeque lacus late liquidos quaeque aspera dumis*
> *rura tenent, somno positae sub nocte silenti.*



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on his own desperation. The external world, unknowable from the perspective of one's own bed, become internalized and projected outwardly as an acknowledgment of the narrator's own desperation. As Gibson has noted, Statius' first-person manipulation of the omniscient epic narrator is reminiscent of the "lyric voice." He goes on to say that his adaptation of this device, "has great potential for irony; if Statius is lying in bed awaiting the onset of sleep, his knowledge of the external world can in fact only be limited."[400] But his comment fails to identify the play between external and internal as an important feature of elegiac discourse.

The shift between mythological allusion as commentary, and the return to the realism of description is typical of Propertius' dream descriptions, as I showed in chapter 1. Statius also uses these structural components in his short poem. As Pomeroy has observed, the connection between *Silvae* 5.4 and love elegy is bolstered by Statius' mention of Argus, which recalls but inverts the narrator's fantasy of playing Argus to Cynthia's Io, in Propertius' elegy 1.3.[401] Statius' narrator has had enough of his many-eyed vigilance, claiming that even if he could alternate wakeful and sleeping eyes, he would remain miserable (lines 11-13). But Pomeroy misses another Propertian feature of this poem--the transition between mythological allusion and narrative of the present. When the narrator exclaims, *at, nunc, heu,* in line 14, he makes a clear distinction between the hypothetical mention of Argus, an external referent for his vigilant suffering and the reality of his condition. It is of further significance that this is the hinge on

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[400] Gibson (1996) 461.

[401] Pomeroy (1986) 95.



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which the tone of the poem turns. First the narrator questions his suffering and casts his insomnia in terms familiar from epic as well as tragedy, then he refers to the subject matter of love elegy through the image of restless lovers and begins to make demands of Somnus.

Somnus is figured by Statius as an external force, albeit one which works in concert with feelings of personal guilt, anxiety, or grief. He has the ability to refuse sleep as easily as he dispenses it in *Silvae* 5.4, but he does not appear to withhold his bounty arbitrarily: if one suffers insomnia, it is merited. For this reason, commentators have speculated that *Silvae* 5.4 reflects Statius' personal distress and sorrow over the death of his father, the subject of the preceding poem, and the death of his adopted son, the subject of the poem that follows.[402] Although the chronology of publication would not prevent us from considering the poem a biographical statement about the insomnia experienced while writing the *Thebaid* any more than it would dissuade us from reading it as the poet's expression of grief for the death of a loved one, neither conclusion can be substantiated by any specific reference in the poem.[403] Without ascribing too much

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[402] See Vollmer (1898) 546 for this interpretation, and Gibson's (1996) 467-68 dissuasion from reading biographical elements into this poem in particular. In a paper delivered at the APA in January 2005, Anthony Augoustakis argued that the insomnia of *Silvae* 5.4 reflected Statius' loss of poetic inspiration after the death of his father, thus reviving the idea that 5.4 is a response to the situation described in 5.3. Biographical interpretation of the *Silvae* is hardly questioned, since many of the poems contain clearly personal information and indeed the poems are usually mined for information about Statius' life and the world of Flavian Rome. See, for example, McNelis (2002) on Statius' father, a grammarian, for which much of the author's evidence for his teaching is taken from *Silvae* 5.3. See also Newlands (2002).

[403] As Shackleton Bailey notes in his 2003 Loeb edition of the *Silvae* (4-5), the *Thebaid* was likely published in 92 A.D., while book 5 of the *Silvae* was probably published after the poet's death in 96. This is likely the case, as the poem lacks a full preface and its final poem is incomplete. We must also allow that the order of the poems in the book could have been decided after Statius' death.



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significance to the possible biographical factors that may have engendered this characterization of insomnia, it is more fruitful to explore the connection between intense personal agitation and insomnia as a literary topos, especially when one considers the importance of the personification of Somnus and his power in Statius' work. The connection between the relief-bringing but cruel figure of Somnus, a complex figure in both *Silvae* 5.4 and in the *Thebaid*, is significant for a larger discussion of Statius' poetic attitude towards this figure. Thus I am not interested in establishing a particular event in Statius' life as the biographical referent for this poem. In addition, my argument is in part a response to B. J. Gibson's charge that with *Silvae* 5.4 we fear the "prospect of a poem which deals with insomnia and nothing more."[404] This assertion, an overcompensation for an aversion to biographical reading, which denies the poem some of its complexity, is proven unsubstantiated when the poem is considered along with other examples of insomnia in Statius' poetry.

The trope of insomnia in the tradition of Latin love poetry is an important referent for *Silvae* 5.4, and it is through an exploration of its relationship to precedent that we can begin to access the poem's programmatic message. By hinting at the contrast between those who actively spurn sleep (the lovers mentioned in lines 14-15) and those who are denied his presence as punishment (the narrator of *Silvae* 5.4), Statius sets up an opposition between the elegiac attitude towards sleep, where Somnus is a bane to excited lovers, and the role of sleep in his poem, where Somnus' absence reflects the anxiety of its narrator. But there is another tension which I will explore in my

[404] Gibson (1996) 468.



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discussion: that between the desirability of a productive insomnia, and the torture of an insomnia which is unsolicited by a person seeking sleep. Productive insomnia, the sort which lovers practice, was a trope used by Statius' predecessors Catullus and Propertius, for example, to describe one context for poetic productivity. Statius places himself within this tradition by acknowledging the link between insomnia and productivity (as discussed in the passages above) but also by revealing its unpleasantness (as he does in *Silvae* 5.4).

The particular severity of the narrator's insomnia (as well as his subsequent unhappiness) is evident from context: Statius utilizes a scene familiar from Dido's insomnia (discussed above), in which the insomniac is described as a marginal figure in opposition to the world outside where other creatures appear to sleep peacefully:[405]

> *.....tacet omne pecus volucresque feraeque*
> *et simulant fessos curvata cacumina somnos,*
> *nec trucibus fluviis idem sonus; occidit horror* 5
> *aequoris et terris maria acclinata quiescunt.*
>
> ...all the cattle are silent, as are the birds and beasts,
> and even the curved tree tops seem to slump from exhaustion,
> There is not a sound from the coursing rivers; the sea's crests
> slumber and her waves curl up to sleep on the shores.

In Statius' poem, the narrator's solitude is emphasized by the fact that he does not mention any human counterparts in his description of the sleeping world. Perhaps he has already dismissed them as happily asleep and, thus, not worth comment. Statius adds pathos to the narrator's situation by claiming that even the beasts, birds and rivers--

[405] This scene, in turn, has a precedent in the description of Medea's sleeplessness in book 3.744 ff. of Apollonius of Rhodes' *Argonautica.*



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themselves not normally accustomed to sharing the sleep patterns of human beings--are able to rest. Of course, birds do not stop flying at night just because men and women have gone to sleep; rivers do not stop rushing nor do waves desist from curling back into themselves at night. That the insomniac imagines that all of this has happened underscores his feeling of isolation from the rest of the earth. He is not simply lonely, rather, he is almost delusional at this point. The reference to *curvata cacumina* in line 4, strikes the reader as strange because it is the sole mention of something that is neither a breathing, sleeping being (like beasts and birds) nor an ever-vigilant body of water (such as rivers and the ocean).[406] Furthermore, Statius includes three of the former (animals) and three of the latter (water ways) with the sleepy tree-tops nestled exactly in the middle as a seventh example, thereby drawing attention to their inclusion in particular.

Even more striking is that the tree tops are the only entity whose slumber must be noted visually. Presumably, the narrator hears no lowing or screeching, and thus knows the animals and birds are asleep; the same holds for the rivers and ocean--he fails to hear the gurgling and crashing waves. The drooping tree tops are a visual delusion; perhaps they have also ceased their rustling, but this is not what the narrator chooses to remark upon. They seem to hang their heads like guards who have fallen asleep standing up

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[406] This scene has a counterpart in *Thebaid* book 10, lines 141-45, where Statius offers a description of Somnus' effects on the natural world as he descends upon Thebes. The first to be affected by his presence (*illius...aura,* 141) are, as in the *Silvae* passage, *volucres pecudesque ferasque,* (141); they are the objects of the verb *explicat* in line 142, which underscores the power of Somnus to disengage those in his presence from activity. In line 144, Statius includes an unambiguous statement about the sleep of treetops: *...demittunt extrema cacumina silvae.* This is just one phase in the sleep-inducing, all-encompassing progress of Somnus across the sky and earth. In the *Thebaid,* not even the stars are able to keep from falling as Somnus passes (145)! In the context of book 10 this hints at the imminent massacre and the powerful finality of death. Perhaps this should also be on the mind of the reader of *Silvae* 5.4 as he reads the poet's description of the slumberous world.



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(this must be the sense of *curvata;* for if Statius had wanted to comment simply upon the stillness of the trees, he would have chosen another word). The use of the verb *simulant* shows that the narrator realizes that the sleeping tree top is an absurdity, and that sleep is just an illusion, but this revelation makes his observation more powerful as a delusional statement. As we see, the insomnia of 5.4 is defined not only by the narrator's sense of isolation (introduced by *solus egerem,* 2), but by the delusion of his senses, thereby making his experience more dreadful. By asking what *error* or *crimen* he has committed at the outset of the poem, the narrator admits he doesn't know why he is being punished, and his questions foreshadow his tone of helplessness in the rest of the poem.[407] The narrator's characterization of himself as *miser* (line 2) and his use of *aegras* to describe his *genas* in lines 7-8 serve to reinforce the narrator's suffering during his bout with insomnia. Furthermore, the fact that he mentions that this is the seventh night he has gone without sleep (*septima iam rediens Phoebe mihi respicit aegras / stare genas...,* 7-8) underscores his increasing desperation. The narrator has reached a point at which sleep deprivation becomes unsustainable.

*Silvae* 5.4 offers a vivid portrayal of the negative consequences of Somnus' decision to withhold his gifts, but the poem hints at the opposite phenomenon, namely the disadvantages of the god's over-indulgence. This aspect is reminiscent of Somnus' malevolent power in the *Thebaid.* B. J. Gibson observed in his analysis of *Silvae* 5.4

[407] Thus the narrator questions his insomnia, implying that he considers it a punishment for a transgression, and that he is perhaps guilty of some crime which he cannot identify. This uncertainty has parallels with the circumstances of some of the characters in the *Thebaid,* who are unaware of the reasons for their suffering. Just as the narrator of *Silvae* 5.4 suffers an insomnia which is unproductive and futile, the characters of the *Thebaid* are doomed to suffer an insomnia which reflects the futility of fighting a battle whose outcome has already been sealed by a vindictive curse.



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that its last lines could suggest a link between sleep and death. In his reading, the immersion described by the phrase *totas infundere pennas* (line 16) refers to an overdose of sleep in the form of death.[408] Hoping to avoid this fate, the narrator begs for just a hint of the god's offering in the form of the wand's tip. Gibson supports his claim by interpreting the *turba laetior* of lines 17-18 as a reference to the crowds of the Islands of the Blessed in the Underworld.[409] Although I agree with Gibson's observation about the poem's lethal connotations, I am not convinced that we need to equate these happier sleepers with the dead, particularly because the term *turba* could easily refer to the anonymous masses who are steeped in deep sleep, in contrast with the predicament of the narrator. In fact, this opposition recalls the beginning of the poem, where the narrator imagines the rest of the living world to be asleep and, therefore, "happier" than he.[410] But there is certainly an interesting connection between the deepness of sleep and its proximity to death. If the transience of Somnus' presence and the brevity of his visit ensure that the sleeper will only remain under his spell temporarily, there is less chance that he will cross over into death or be mistaken for dead. It is also less likely that the narrator will stay asleep for long. I read a significant resignation in the narrator's

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[408] It is interesting to compare this image of sleep's enfolding wings with that of Somnus in book 10 of the *Thebaid* (already discussed in chapter 3). When the winged Somnus alights upon the battlefield at the beginning of book 10, the death pall is immediately felt. There is a certain connection between the sweep of his wings and the smothering of death.

[409] Gibson (1996) 465-66.

[410] The phrase *turba laetior* marks the narrator's first reference to other human beings; recall that in the first catalogue, he referred only to beasts and bodies of water. Perhaps the reuse of the noun *cacumen* in line 18 is meant to draw the reader's attention back to the narrator's isolation from the normal, sleeping world via the *curvata cacumina* of line 4. Somnus' *cacumen* also has an earlier parallel in the *flagellum* of Tithonia (line 10), with which the goddess brings temporary relief to the insomniac. See above for the combination of adjective and noun *extrema cacumina* to refer to sleeping treetops in *Thebaid* book 10.



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declaration that he will settle for a modicum of sleep, rather that his full abundance. The narrator has accepted that he is not entitled to a long or full sleep, so long as he can have a respite from his torture. By opposing himself to the happier masses, the narrator concedes the gift of full, deep sleep to others occupied by different concerns. Thus as the narrator's demands change toward the poem's end, we begin to see the increasing threat of Somnus' all-encompassing power, which plays such a prominent role in the *Thebaid.* This evolution creates a tension that is integral to the divided tone of the poem.

The tension between immersion and brief contact reaches its peak in the last line of *Silvae* 5.4: after the narrator begs Somnus to touch him with the tip of his wand, he also offers an alternative, that Somnus pass lightly (*leviter,* line 19) over him. This image of a nimble Somnus stands in contrast with his characterization in the *Thebaid,* where his presence is long-enduring and oppressive. In book 10, for example, when Somnus appears on the scene, summoned by Iris to enter the Theban camp, he is said to lie upon the camp itself (*incubuit,* line 149). As I have already shown, he acts as a sleeper does in "lying down" across the Theban soldiers, as he forces them to sleep. His menacing stance in the epic context derives from his oppressiveness. Statius sets up a contrast between a full and a brief encounter with Somnus in order to establish the potentially fatal danger of submersion in sleep.

As we know from the precedent of earlier epic, Somnus is usually summoned by a god to intervene in the lives of humans. In *Silvae* 5.4, however, Statius depicts the mortal version of the appeal to Somnus, and the human hope that the gods respond to such entreaty. In both instances we see a deity who does not traditionally leap to action



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of his own accord, but instead responds to invocation. But the narrator's individual appeal to the god in *Silvae* 5.4 reminds the reader of the intensely personal and subjective feeling of alienation created by insomnia. The characterization of Somnus in the *Thebaid* derives much of its power from Statius' development and exploitation of the tense dual perspective between external force and individual experience. This very juxtaposition of external power and internal agony is deftly and succinctly encapsulated by the 19 lines of *Silvae* 5.4.

**Insomnia in the *Silvae* and the epilogue to the *Thebaid***

Statius mentions his bouts with insomnia in other *Silvae* as a way of illustrating the arduous task of writing and completing the *Thebaid.* For example, in 3.5 the poet tries to convince his wife to join him on a journey to Naples by praising her virtue and listing the advantages of Naples over the bustle of Rome. In lines 33-36 of the poem Statius writes,

> *...tu procurrentia primis*
> *carmina nostra sonis totasque in murmure noctes*
> *aure rapis vigili; longi tu sola laboris* 35
> *conscia, cumque tuis crevit mea Thebais annis.*
>
> ...you catch with wakeful ear
> my verses as they flow from me in their first utterances
> and entire nights while I whisper away;
> you alone know the extent of my hard work,
> and my *Thebaid* has grown in step with you.



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Here the night's vigil is transferred from the poet to his wife, but it is clear that she was kept awake and listening, because he was awake and working.[411] This point is further emphasized by Statius' use of the phrase *totas noctes* to communicate the all-encompassing nature of his work. That he calls writing the epic a *longus labor* is the final proof of the connection between hard work and lack of sleep.[412] This description emphasizes the disruptiveness of Statius' sleepless toil. Furthermore, we recognize this sleeplessness and its external effects as literal and realistic; it is not simply a metaphor for personal agitation, but a commentary upon the difficult life of a competitive poet. In the hands of Statius, insomnia is not merely synonymous with one night's inspiration, but rather, it is a long-enduring state, which is communicated in mundane terms and intimately bound up with the daily rhythms of his life. Statius' relationship with his wife is made parallel to the creation of his epic: as his *Thebaid* grows old with her, she

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[411] We have been aware of her distress since the opening of the poem, where her nighttime sighs are indicative of a worried insomnia: *Quid mihi maesta die, sociis quid noctibus, uxor, / anxia pervigili ducis suspiria cura?* (1-2). We are never given a direct answer to the question, but its prominent position hints that the unidentified source of her insomnia preoccupies the poet. As we find out in line 86, the very move to Naples that he advocates will ensure *...numquam turbata quies somnique peracti.* Thus their relocation is presented specifically as a cure for insomnia, whatever its cause.

[412] This sentiment is echoed in the final line (143) of *Silvae* 3.2, *quaeve laboratas claudat mihi pagina Thebas.* This is uttered in the context of a farewell to a friend who is leaving on a long journey. Statius envisions that the friend, upon his return, will regale Statius with tales of the many lands he has visited. Statius' contribution in reply will consist of his description of the culmination of his epic. The duration of the *labor* is emphasized by his mention of the final page of the work (*quaeve...claudat...pagina).* The poet's progress towards the end parallels the duration of his friend's journey. Compare line 14 of Catullus 50, where he describes the effort of writing his poem as a *labor* which has left his limbs exhausted. But rather than lament either the hardship or the duration of this, as Statius does in *Silvae* 3.5, Catullus entwines it with the language of love making, thereby leaving the reader to think of it as an erotic, enjoyable nighttime activity.



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becomes habituated to the side-effects of Statius' creative process. Disrupted sleep, which is normally an intrusion, becomes habitual for husband and wife.[413]

In *Silvae* 4.7, Statius alludes again to the labor he has put into writing the *Thebaid.* Statius praises his friend Vibius Maximus as follows (lines 25-28): *quippe te fido monitore nostra / Thebais multa cruciata lima / temptat audaci fide Mantuanae / gaudia famae.* In this example, however, although there is no explicit connection between the poet's diligence and insomnia, Statius introduces a new association: that between hard work and his rivalry with Virgil. From this statement about his poetics, we realize that Statius allies himself with the Callimachean aesthetic of a finely-honed, revised work, and we understand that he associates such editing, undoubtedly a tortuous process (*cruciata),* with improvement, the goal of which is to emulate the Mantuan Virgil and the fame he has enjoyed.[414] The pain of diligently editing his text will emerge into joy (*gaudia famae)* if the writer is willing to submit his text (and himself) to torture.[415] His joy will be defined (and justified) by the longevity of his work's

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[413] The habitual or recurrent nature of their disrupted sleep might be indicated by the prominent reference in lines 1-2 to his wife's anxiety, which surfaces by day and by night.

[414] See Coleman (1988) 203-04 for a list of similar expressions of allegiance with Callimachean poetics made by Roman poets. See also McNelis (2000) 126-65. It is perhaps ironic that Callimachus received the inspiration to create this kind of finely-honed work in a dream (cf. *somni non inflati Callimachi* from Propertius 2.34), and, therefore, as he slept, while his successors, who try to emulate his poetics, do so at the expense of their own sleep.

[415] The phrase *gaudia famae* appears again, this time modified by the adjective *ventosa,* in *Silvae* 4.4, line 50. In this context, Statius refers to the fickle nature of poetic glory. In lines 51-52 Statius reveals that he is enjoying his time in Naples, (*en egomet somnum et geniale secutus / litus...*), which is characterized specifically by his ability to sleep. Furthermore, we learn in the lines which follow that he also passes the time by singing his verses beside Virgil's tomb: *tenues ignavo pollice chordas / pulso, Maroneique sedens in margine templi / sumo animum et magni tumulis accanto magistri* (53-55). Here again we see the union of the motifs of sleep and rivalry with Virgil. As we find out later in the poem, Statius has finished his



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reputation. The themes of diligence, its frequent by-product, insomnia, and the competitiveness that fosters it are interrelated. Statius articulates the correlation between hard work, sleeplessness, and poetic rivalry in his most prominent statement of poetic program, the sphragis of the *Thebaid.*

In the epilogue to his *Thebaid* (book 12), Statius addresses his work as follows,

> *Durabisne procul dominoque legere superstes,* 810
> *o mihi bissenos multum vigilata per annos*
> *Thebai? iam certe praesens tibi Fama benignum*
> *stravit iter coepitque novam monstrare futuris.*
> *iam te magnanimus dignatur noscere Caesar,*
> *Itala iam studio discit memoratque iuventus.* 815
> *vive precor; nec tu divinam Aeneida tempta,*
> *sed longe sequere et vestigia semper adora.*
> *mox, tibi si quis adhuc praetendit nubila livor,*
> *occidet, et meriti post me referentur honores.*
>
> Will you endure long from now, and will you be read,
> outlasting your creator, my *Thebaid,* the product of 12 years' sleeplessness?
> Fama, who already certainly favors you, has paved you a kind path
> and begins to reveal what you hold for future generations.
> Already great minded Caesar thinks you worthy of acquaintance,
> The youth of Italy are already eager to learn and memorize your words.
> Live, I pray! Don't attempt to rival the divine *Aeneid,*
> but follow at a distance instead, and always honor its footsteps.
> If any envy clouds you with gloom, it will soon die down,

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*Thebaid,* so perhaps this accounts for the return of his normal sleep habits. In lines 88-89 of this poem, Statius compares his finished epic to a ship docked in port: *iam Sidonios emensa labores / Thebais optato collegit carbasa portu.* Again, Statius mentions the *labor* of writing the *Thebaid,* but in this instance, the effort of writing the epic has come to an end, and its author can seek in sleep an escape from his burdens on the bay of Naples while acknowledging his competition with Virgil and remarking upon the uncertain fame which might result from this. The poem ends with the announcement that he has begun a new poem, the *Achilleid,* which he defines as a new burden, asking, *...stabuntne sub illa / mole umeri an magno vincetur pondere cervix?* (97-98). From this statement, we can assume that the cycle of hard work, sleeplessness, and the challenge of responding to a predecessor would have begun again.



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and deserved honors will follow after I'm long gone.

Here we learn that the number of years Statius spent writing his epic equaled its number of books; this is cast in lines 811-12 as a period of intensified (*multum)* wakefulness. In a study on conventions used for prose prefaces, Tore Janson includes the epilogue to the *Thebaid* in his discussion of the theme of "nocturnal studies," where he writes, "perhaps the most common way of emphasizing one's diligence, however, was to mention the nights spent in study."[416] Indeed, the motif of sleeplessness in statements about poetic endeavor has traditionally been read as a metaphor for hard work, rather than a literal statement about the experience of insomnia.[417] In other words, commentary has focused on the process that leads to insomnia (diligence) rather than upon the choice of insomnia to represent the consequence of labor. Charles McNelis has observed more recently that Statius' protestations in *Silvae* 3.2 and 4.7 about the hard work required for writing the *Thebaid* establish his poetic program in accordance with the "aesthetic strictures of Callimachean, neoteric and Augustan poetry," where intense labor and editing are paramount for paring down one's work to perfection. But when discussing the epilogue to the *Thebaid,* McNelis still puts the phrase "sleepless nights" in quotation marks, in

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[416] Janson (1964) 97. Janson includes this reference to the end of the *Thebaid* even though his work treats primarily prose and prefaces. I think that it is significant that Statius' statement about insomnia comes at the *end* of his epic, after the reader has understood the significance of sleep and its lack for the narrative of the *Thebaid.* Considering the effects of culmination, it is difficult to dismiss any reference to sleep experience as simply metaphorical.

[417] One could compare the programmatic statement made by Pliny the Elder in the preface to his *Naturalis Historia.* In section 18, he claims to have written this work by night, as his days were occupied by public work for the Flavian court. In her analysis, Citroni Marchetti (2003) 240 notes that Pliny uses his claims of nightly vigil to excuse some of the shortcomings of his work. Thus his declaration of intentional insomnia serves a practical rather than simply metaphorical purpose.



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order to mark it as a metaphor for diligence, rather than a literal declaration of nights spent awake.[418]

In the epilogue to the *Thebaid,* the concepts of poetic rivalry and acknowledgment of predecessors are also important. Statius professes his sense of competition with Virgil's *Aeneid* through a declaration of admiration for it, as he urges his epic to follow in the footsteps of its forerunner in book 12, lines 816-17: *vive, precor; nec tu divinam Aeneida tempta, / sed longe sequere et vestigia semper adora.* This seemingly deferential statement is also an assertion of Statius' pride in his creation, for the mere mention of his poem alongside that of his predecessor elevates the status of the *Thebaid* to that of a ready competitor.[419] The tone of Statius' sphragis in book 12 is remarkably similar to Propertius' speculation about his place in a poetic lineage. As Propertius' respect for *Fama* as the agent of his poem's fate (line 94) adds a note of modesty to the tone of his speculation about the future of his poems, the placement of his name in the same line position as those of his predecessors, however, challenges this modesty. Statius' mention of his own work in direct relation to Virgil's establishes the importance of recognizing literary precedents in creating his own poetics. Statius'

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[418] McNelis (2000) 164-65.

[419] Recently Nugent (1996) and Pagán (2000) have argued for the feminine quality of Statius' epic vis-à-vis its predecessor, thus reading Statius as less confident about his poem's future. In conclusion to her larger argument about Hypsipyle as an Aeneas figure in the *Thebaid,* Nugent makes a specific connection between Virgil's characterization of Creusa trailing behind Aeneas in *Aeneid* 2 and Statius' description of his poem following obediently behind Virgil's. She writes that "the specific text echoed here [in the epilogue] leads us to configure the relation between the two epics differently: not in fact as master and apprentice, but virtually as husband and wife," 70. Sander Goldberg has suggested to me that Statius' characterization of the relationship of the *Thebaid* to its predecessor might reflect Aeneas' advice to his son Ascanius in *Aeneid* 2.724: *sequiturque patrem non passibus aequis.* This allusion would encourage the reader to think of the fate of the *Thebaid* on analogy with Ascanius' role in carrying on the line of his progenitor, rather than in conjunction with Creusa's premature death.



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deference to *Fama* as the ultimate arbiter of his poem's fate: *iam certe praesens tibi Fama benignum / stravit iter...* (lines 812-13), recalls the end of Propertius' poem 2.34 and thus reinforces the connection between the two passages as simultaneously competitive with and respectful of their forbears. Each poet places his declaration at the end of a unit (in Statius' case, at the end of his epic; in Propertius' case, at the end of a book) and each admits uncertainty about his poem's future while conscious of the influence of the past.

Statius' declared sleeplessness in lines 811-12 of his epilogue has literary precedents in Catullus and Propertius, in whose work a complaint about insomnia is an indication of excitement by and respect for the work of a friend, rather than simply a metaphor for hard work and the difficult task of editing poems. If writing the *Thebaid* has demanded from Statius an extended period of sleeplessness (one which matches both the number of books in his own epic and in the *Aeneid),* perhaps this insomnia does not only reflect the labor of writing the epic, but also the excitement of a challenge engendered by reading and interpreting Virgil's *Aeneid.* We can imagine from his epilogue that he has developed an admiring rivalry that fuels his desire to perfect his own work, and to see it enter the race to achieve posthumous fame as Virgil's did. But Statius' other comments on insomnia undermine an attempt to align his relationship to Virgil with the lighthearted and erotically charged interaction familiar from love poetry. Statius' insomnia, while acknowledged as necessary, is difficult to endure.

I suggest that Statius' reference to insomnia at the close of the *Thebaid* is not merely symbolic. Rather, considered along with other instances of insomnia in his



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writing, it actually influences the way one understands the *Thebaid*. Whereas Statius' sphragis at the close of the *Thebaid* is obviously a bold biographical statement that stands in great contrast to the third person narration of the epic itself, *Silvae* 5.4 seems less personal due to the absence of a clear reference to Statius' life or work. But its incongruity with the rest of the corpus of *Silvae* should invite consideration of the poem in a new light, one which aligns it more closely with the narrative of the *Thebaid*. *Silvae* 5.4 depicts insomnia as an abnormal condition that fosters a sense of marginality in the narrator desperate for sleep. Keeping in mind the poem's presentation of inverted norms, let us consider the negative sleep experiences endured by the characters in the *Thebaid*, particularly the kings and princes directly affected by civil strife.

**Insomnia in the *Thebaid's* Narrative**

Sleeplessness and Imminent War

Insomnia caused by regretful grief and anger, such as we see in Homer's *Iliad*, for example, where Achilles tosses and turns in mourning over Patroclus' death (book 24, lines 1-13), is perhaps a paradigm for the scenes of insomnia in the *Thebaid*. Noting that Achilles' insomnia is coupled with his enraged abuse of Hector's body, the activity to which he turns as a result of his inability to sleep, we recognize a possible model for the anger-driven insomnia of the *Thebaid*. Statius' episodes of insomnia that come toward the beginning of the epic, however, are also premonitory in addition to expressing the characters' concerns about past action. Whereas Achilles' insomnia is the culmination of sustained anger and regret, and thus presents a point of closure for the arc of Achilles' character, the insomnia of the Theban princes is symbolic of the condition



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enforced by their father's curse. They are anxious or indignant about the past but ignorant of the grim future and consequently helpless to avert it. In both cases, their worries are futile.

Polynices, victim of his father's curse, is forced to suffer insomnia without being conscious of a crime; he feels instead that he has been wronged, and can think only that the war he is poised to fight against his brother will bring him justice. We learn in book 2 that Polynices has been consumed night and day by memories of his expulsion from Thebes: *tunc quos excedens hilaris, quis cultus iniqui / praecipuus ducis, et profugo quos ipse notarat / ingemuisse sibi per noctem ac luce sub omni / digerit* (316-19). The prince's preoccupation is made specific a bit later. Polynices, the first character whose insomnia is given extended treatment in the epic, lies restless beside his wife Argia in lines 331-37:

> *non alias tacita iuvenis Teumesius iras*
> *mente acuit. sed fida vias arcanaque coniunx*
> *senserat; utque toris primo conplexa iacebat*
> *aurorae pallore virum, 'quos, callide, motus*
> *quamve fugam moliris?' ait 'nil transit amantes.* 335
> *sentio, pervigiles acuunt suspiria questus,*
> *numquam in pace sopor...'
>
> The Teumesian youth stoked no other anger
> with silent demeanor. But his devoted wife sensed the paths
> of his thought and secrets; as she lay entwined with him in bed
> she said at the first pale light of dawn, 'crafty one, what
> movements, or flight do you contrive? Nothing escapes
> lovers. I notice that late-night laments sharpen your sighs,
> you never sleep peacefully...'

This passage recalls Statius' description of his own wife's inability to sleep while he is preoccupied in *Silvae* 3.5 (discussed above). In both passages, the reference to insomnia



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is connected to discussion of a journey by husband and wife. Furthermore, in both instances insomnia causes anxious sighs (*suspiria).* The late-night laments of Polynices (*pervigiles questus)* in line 336 have a parallel in the late-night worry (*pervigili cura)* of Statius' wife in *Silvae* 3.5.2. Similarly, we learn of Polynices' insomnia through a description of its effects upon another character. For it is through Argia's questions that we discover the cause of Polynices' insomnia: anxiety about the upcoming war, which will pervade the rest of the narrative. While the poet's sleeplessness bespeaks a dedicated productivity, the insomnia of Polynices foreshadows a series of destructive acts that will eventually lead to his own death. Polynices' and Argia's shared late-night worries set the tone for the general anxiety which will anticipate the war itself.

By contrast, Eteocles experiences insomnia caused by anxiety over a decision he has made. At the beginning of book 3 (lines 1-6) he lies awake worrying about the delayed return of the soldiers he has sent to ambush Tydeus, an envoy from Polynices:

> *At non Aoniae moderator perfidus orae* 1
> *nocte sub ancipiti, quamvis umentibus astris*
> *longus ad auroram superet labor, otia somni*
> *accipit; invigilant animo scelerisque parati*
> *supplicium exercent curae; tum plurima versat* 5
> *pessimus in dubiis augur timor...*
>
> But the treacherous controller of the Aonian shore did not
> welcome sleep's restful gift on this fraught night, although
> the dewy stars still had a long journey to dawn;
> the king's worries kept him awake and encouraged
> punishment for the crime he planned; then fear, the
> worst harbinger in moments of doubt, came in many guises ...

Eteocles' cares gnaw at him, preventing him from sleeping and punishing him for his unwise decision. In fact, the night itself is invested with Eteocles' sense of uncertainty



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about what he has done, as it is literally "in two minds" (*nocte ancipiti,* 2). Eteocles' predicament is specifically placed in opposition to what is normal. In lines 2-3 Statius establishes that this is the dead of night, the time when all the world should be sleeping, as the stars still have a long course to cover until dawn. Eteocles' disharmony with nature reminds us of the marginalized narrator of *Silvae* 5.4, who also acts in opposition to nature. The dichotomy between sleeping and waking is also made explicit by the juxtaposition of the nouns *labor* and *otia* in line 3. This episode foreshadows Eteocles' recurrent inability to comprehend the consequences of his decisions and to learn from his mistaken attempts.

That troubled sleep was also a problem which affected those associated with the brewing conflict between the sons of Oedipus is confirmed by the experience of the Argive king Adrastus whom we encounter for the first time in book 1.[420] Polynices arrives at the palace of the king in the midst of a storm, weary from his flight from Thebes as a reluctant exile (lines 386-89):

> *...actutum regia cernit*
> *vestibula; hic artus imbri ventoque rigentes*
> *proicit ignotaeque adclinis postibus aulae*
> *invitat tenuis ad dura cubilia somnos.*
>
> .....he sought out the royal courtyard immediately;
> he flung his limbs stiff from rain and wind
> and he welcomed fitful sleep to his hard bed
> leaning against the doors of this unfamiliar hall.

[420] See chapter 3 for elaboration of this idea.



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Against the doors of Adrastus' palace, he seeks sleep, here called fitful, *tenuis...somnos* (line 389). We learn from the fact that his resting place is a set of doors, described metaphorically as *dura cubilia,* that his sleep will hardly be comfortable. But this is reinforced by contrast with the content of the next line. In line 390, we are introduced to Adrastus as follows: *rex ibi* ***tranquille,*** *medio de limite vitae / in senium vergens, populos Adrastus habebat* (line 390-91). The adverb *tranquille* appears to jar with the sense of tumult in the lines which precede it, thus creating a contrast which is further emphasized by the physical referents of the line.[421] Polynices and his imminent violence lie on the threshold of the palace where, up until this point, peace has reigned. His journey is halted momentarily at the doors which become beds and allow Polynices to slip from his waking exhaustion into sleep.

By line 400, we are already aware that the characteristic tranquility of Adrastus' rule is ebbing away, *tantum in corde sedens aegrescit cura parenti.* With these lines, Statius gives the first indication that the acquaintance of Polynices and the king will mark the beginning of a new period of increased anxiety and instability. After we learn of Tydeus' arrival and subsequent scuffle with Polynices at the gates, their violence manages to permeate the palace doors and affect Adrastus physically. The *cura* from line 400 has grown in strength by lines 432-34: *...**magnis** cui sobria **curis** / pendebat*

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[421] Vessey (1973) 95 observes that, "in the first line devoted to the Argive monarch, the word *tranquille* occurs, just as *impia* served to introduce Oedipus. Tranquility is the keynote of Adrastus' past; he appears to have enjoyed the *apatheia*, the virtuous and serene contentment of a Stoic sage. Now, for the first time, a current of anxiety is disturbing his placid existence" and "the violence of the heroes' arrival is accentuated by its contrast with the normal serenity of the Argive realm. Adrastus' own virtue is mirrored in his kingdom." I would add to this observation that it is significant that the collision of these two disparate worlds occurs at night when the vast wanderings of Polynices finally end in sleep and the peace to which Adrastus is accustomed is shattered, as manifested by his anxiety-ridden sleep.



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*somno iam deteriore senectus,* and the disruption of the king's sleep indicates conclusively that his tranquil reign can exist no longer. Adrastus is the first instantiation of the king who suffers the foreboding agitated sleep from earlier in book 1 (line 146). Adrastus' particular shift in ability to sleep reflects the change that the inevitable battle between brothers--into which he is reluctantly drawn--brings about for those involved. The king's experience comments upon the shocking transition from the pre-epic world to the realm of the epic itself.[422]

Adrastus addresses his violent visitors and soon to be sons-in-law with the following outraged questions in which he emphasizes their foreign and unfamiliar status:

> *sanguineo videt imbre genas: "quae causa furoris,*
> *externi iuvenes--neque enim meus audeat istas*
> *civis in usque manus--, quisnam implacabilis ardor* 440
> *exturbare odiis* ***tranquilla*** *silentia noctis?*
> *usque adeone angusta dies et triste, parumper*
> *pacem animo somnumque pati?..."*
>
> He sees their cheeks washed in blood, and asks, "what
> is the reason for this madness, foreigners--for no one of
> my citizens would dare come to blows to this extent--
> what insatiable passion causes you to disturb the
> peaceful silence of the night with your hatred?
> To what degree is the day so short, and is it
> terrible to suffer peace of mind and sleep for a little while?..."

Their arrival is treated as an invasion of hostility that is unfamiliar to the usual peace of Adrastus' palace, and by metonymy, his realm. Their presence at his doorstep is immediately characterized as antithetical to the behavior of his subjects. We are reminded of the link between the incipient violence between the sons of Oedipus, of

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[422] For a discussion of the encounter between Adrastus and his soon-to-be sons-in-law in terms of contrasts between images of darkness and light, see Moreland (1975) 26 ff.



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which we have been given a preview in Polynices' fight with Tydeus here, and the loss of sound sleep in the king's next lines. He questions their loud fighting and disregard for those around them, because it is not only out of step with the behavior of peaceful citizens, but it seems to be incongruous with the rest of the world. Rather than accuse them of simply disturbing his own sleep, Adrastus charges that their fighting has interrupted the *tranquilla silentia noctis* (line 441), the night's peaceful silence, which presumably held the entire land under its spell.[423] The fact that he uses the adjective *tranquilla* here to describe the night is also telling, because it links this scene with the description in line 390 of Adrastus' normally peaceful rule (see above). Both the peace of night and the peace of Adrastus' kingdom have been adversely affected by the arrival of Polynices, and this rupture marks the beginning of the progression towards the mutual destruction of the sons of Oedipus.[424]

In his commentary on this episode in the *Thebaid,* David Vessey remarks that, "enough has been said of Statius' carefully maintained system of antitheses for us to see how there is a symbolic confrontation at this climactic point between two irreconcilable forces: light and darkness, tranquility and violence."[425] The arrival of Polynices at Argos

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[423] This is corroborated by the fact that earlier, in his description of Tydeus' arrival in Argos (line 403), Statius used the phrase *sub nocte sopora* to describe the conditions under which he traveled, i.e. during the dead of night, when the rest of the land slept.

[424] The link between lack of sleep and disruption of peace is also made explicit in line 443, where Adrastus questions why the two strangers are unable to put off their quarrel until daytime, which would be more hospitable to their commotion. In asking whether it is terrible to suffer *pacem animo somnumque,* Adrastus draws a link between peace of mind and sleep, implying that the former is contingent upon the latter. By using the noun *pax* Statius also alludes to the connection between peace time (as opposed to war) and the ability to sleep. This is a foreshadowing of the incipient war and its attendant disruption of sleep.



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and its subsequent deleterious effects on the palace of Adrastus are certainly underscored by these polarized contrasts. But because this incident happens at night, it also sets the tone for the recurrent contrast that centers upon sleep and insomnia throughout the epic. That Adrastus' fall from tranquility is manifested in an anxiety that prevents peaceful sleep is important in establishing the role of sleep in the rest of the epic.

That this attention to sleep is a Statian innovation is apparent from a brief comparison with a source passage in book 7 of the *Aeneid,* where as Vessey notes (94), Statius finds his model for Adrastus in Virgil's Latinus. King Latinus, the Laurentian ruler upon whose doorstep Aeneas and his men arrive and disturb the peace, is given similar characterization. Vessey discusses the likenesses between the descriptions of the two kings as they are introduced into the narrative, where he notices that both kings are aged, peaceful rulers with no male heirs. Both are anxious at having received disquieting prophecies concerning their daughters' marriages. But despite the numerous similarities between the situations of the two native kings, Virgil does not mention the disturbed sleep of his Latinus as a feature of his turmoil or as an indication of the violent fighting soon to break out on his soil. On the contrary, the Trojan envoys approach Latinus during the day, the time that is appropriate for such an embassy. Furthermore, this embassy follows shortly after the night Latinus has spent in incubation at the temple of Faunus. Here he received the prophecy to shun an alliance between his daughter and a native Latin prince in favor of marrying her to one of the foreign men about to reach his shores, because this would be beneficial for his kingdom. Although his level of

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[425] Vessey (1973) 96.



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anxiety about the marriage of his daughter is equally intense and is made worse by a series of frightening portents, it is clear that he is not losing sleep over this, as does Adrastus. Rather, Latinus uses his sleep productively to gain insight into his daughter's future and that of his people.

Statius' characterization of Adrastus' experience is a reminder of the link between sleeplessness and the anticipation of conflict. As is characteristic of his vigilant rivalry with and admiration for Virgil, Statius emphasizes his deviation from his predecessor in this scene by recapitulating the king's sleep experience as more fraught, while maintaining other aspects of the allusion. In the *Aeneid* Latinus has a productive sleep experience that adds clarification to the plot at the midpoint of the epic, while in the *Thebaid* Adrastus' sleep is disturbed in the first book of the epic and contributes an ominous sense of future events instead of clarity.[426] This difference underscores the teleologies of each epic: Aeneas is on a journey to found a nation and perpetuate the Trojan race through his family line, while Polynices is on a path to the destruction of his family and himself, effectively putting an end to his family line. The union of Aeneas and Lavinia is sanctioned by Faunus' message to Latinus in his sleep, so this experience of productive sleep is essential for confirming to the reader that Aeneas' destiny is on course. The fact that Adrastus' sleep is disturbed by the arrival of his sons-in-law, and

[426] This is further bolstered by the revelation that Adrastus too had received an oracle (this time from Phoebus), this time foretelling the arrival of two husbands, a lion and a boar (lines 396-97). Statius comments that neither Adrastus nor the seer Amphiaraus could interpret the oracle (lines 398-99), but that the oracle's obscurity was a source of anxiety for Adrastus: *tantum in corde sedens aegrescit cura parenti* (400). The inscrutability of the oracle, accompanied by the sense of dread it instills creates a further distinction between Statius' and Virgil's narratives.



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that this heralds the beginning of a wave of anxiety and disruption of sleep for the king, compounded by initial confusion over who his sons-in-law are, or where they are from, shows a significant departure from Virgil's paradigm episode.[427]

Sleep vs. sleeplessness: signaling opposition

In the following section I suggest that Statius also uses the *Thebaid*'s sleep episodes to mark crucial transitions in the narrative, and that the contrast between sleep and insomnia is an important feature of Statius' system of antitheses and his understanding of the conflict between opposing forces that drives his narrative. Furthermore, the structural role of the antithesis between sleep and insomnia reflects upon the power of Somnus as an externalized force, as his power to grant sleep as well as to withhold it is imposed upon the characters of the epic and helps to define their opposition at the level of narrative.

In specific instances, Statius uses sleep's effects as a narrative device for highlighting transition between opposing forces.[428] Frequently, the deep sleep of one

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[427] The insomnia of Thoas, king of Lemnos, in book 5 is reminiscent of Adrastus' restlessness in book 2. On the night of the Lemnian massacre Hypsipyle makes her way to her father's home amidst the carnage. When she arrives, she finds her father awake and distracted: *...ille quidem dudum--quis magna tuenti / somnus?--agit versans secum, etsi lata recessit / urbe domus, quinam strepitus, quae murmura noctis, / cur fremibunda quies?...* (lines 241-44). By interjecting his question, *quis magna tuenti / somnus?* (lines 241-42), Statius makes explicit the connection between lack of sleep and a king's anxiety about the safety of his kingdom. Both kings are troubled by nighttime chaos in their usually peaceful realms, although the nature of the disturbance is different in each instance. By including this as a feature of the experiences of both the Lemnian and Argive kings, Statius reinforces the relevance of his observation in book 1 that imminent destruction within his realm will deprive a king of the ability to sleep well. Sleeplessness is an indicator of the narrative's looming conflict.

[428] This has an early precedent, for example, in Homer's *Odyssey* book 19.588 ff., where Penelope tells the disguised Odysseus of her need to sleep. Athena puts her to sleep, and her slumber is immediately contrasted with Odysseus' insomnia in book 20.1 ff. The tension surrounding Odysseus' return, and his stealth in doing so is highlighted by the disparity in sleep experience between wife and husband.



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party is emphasized in direct contrast with the insomnia of its enemies; thus the ability to sleep becomes a marker for the shift in power between one group and another to which it is opposed.[429] This phenomenon is of interest for the narrative of Statius' poem; as I will show, sleep personified as the god Somnus wields great power in this text. It is of further significance that the power afforded to the sinister figure of sleep and the proliferation of negative sleep experiences such as insomnia and nightmares in Statius' text is an innovation in the epic tradition. It is no surprise then that sleep becomes the focal point for the transitions between the fortunes of enemies.

This narrative of transition is exemplified by the shift in setting between Thebes and Argos in book 2, across lines 133-34: *ductor in absentem consumit proelia fratrem / et iam Mygdoniis elata cubilibus alto.* Vessey notes that "the change of scene is introduced by the contrast of light and darkness,"[430] which indeed serves to demarcate a shift in scene.[431] But the impact of the contrast between times of day at Thebes and Argos is enhanced by the disparity in sleep experience between the brothers in each

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[429] Tension between opposites is crucial for the war narrative of Statius' *Thebaid.* The first line of the epic establishes the importance of this antithesis by introducing the opposed *fraternas acies* and their *alterna regna.* The armies of brothers stood opposed and fought to the death (*decertata,* line 2) as a result of their failure to share alternating years of rule at Thebes. The emphasis upon alternation in this epic is paramount, manifesting itself in the opposition between the brothers, Eteocles and Polynices; the Argives and the Thebans; the gods who favor either side in the war; the men and women who have different perspectives on the conflagration; and the elderly and the young members of both sides. The division between the sleeping and the waking is one further instance of importance of dichotomy for this narrative.

[430] Vessey (1973) 136.

[431] The play between images of light and darkness, night and day, is a device common in epic. For specific discussion of this phenomenon in Virgil, see Osmun (1962) 31, where he comments upon Virgil's use of night as the backdrop for certain types of action, such as "supernatural manifestations and erotic scenes". His conclusion that Virgil's night scenes are "in harmony with epic technique" in that they contain action which is important to epic, such as divine intervention and erotic encounters, is weak, but his catalogue of scenes in which night plays a critical role is useful. He is primarily interested in the incidents which take place at night, namely dreams and night visions.



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place. After Eteocles' nightmare encounter with his grandfather Laius, from which he wakes lusting for battle with his exiled brother, the narrative shifts to the scene at Argos, where his brother has slept peacefully at Adrastus' palace. His enjoyment of sleep's bounty provides a direct contrast to Eteocles' nightmare-induced insomnia. Whereas Eteocles' characteristic inactivity is challenged by the news his grandfather brings, Polynices' rest is his deserved reward after a grueling journey from Thebes. Each of the brothers is given a distinct characterization through his sleep experience, and this dichotomy sets the tone for the eventual conflict between the brothers and the shifts in fortune between their sides.[432]

Polynices' deep slumber is further contrasted, once the transition in scene has been made, with the insomnia of Adrastus as he suffers from *tenuis quies* in 145. As Statius makes clear by using the adjective *tenuis* to describe his fitful sleep, the restlessness associated with Polynices' family curse and ill-omened arrival has now infused his father-in-law. The very adjective which he had ascribed to Polynices' restlessness in book 1 at Adrastus' doors in the phrase *tenuis somnos* (line 389), now characterizes the torment of the aged king. From this point on as the narrative continues, Polynices and Adrastus will share a level of anxiety linked with Polynices' desire for

[432] Polynices' tranquility is temporary, however, as is Eteocles' burst of activity. In 2.306 ff., Polynices, newly married, turns his thoughts towards his return to Thebes. His wife Argia notices his agitation and his *numquam in pace sopor* (line 337, discussed above). His fleeting night of rest, memorable for its contrast with the turmoil of his brother the same night, is now recognizable as an anomaly, and a feature only to be associated with a warrior temporarily free from his cares.



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revenge against his brother. The peace which Adrastus once knew has been banished by his alliance with Polynices.[433]

Another instance in which the division between Argives and Thebans hinges upon sleep (productivity) and its absence (fear) comes in book 7, as the Argives arrive in Thebes and set up camp. The physical confrontation between enemy sides, the point towards which the narrative has been progressing, is characterized by the juxtaposition of their nighttime activities. Exhausted from their journey, the Argives fall into a deep sleep; the Thebans, who have waited for their enemy's arrival, are preoccupied by fear and unable to rest.[434] Those who do rest, are said to dream of war. This division is not unlike that in book 2, in which Polynices, who has been on the move, sleeps deeply from exhaustion, while Eteocles, who has not moved from Thebes, is tormented by the ghost of his grandfather in sleep, and then left to fantasize about war with his brother when he should be asleep. The contrast between sides in book 7 is described in the following lines:

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[433] In book 3, after returning to Argos from his embassy to Thebes, Tydeus falls asleep and is able to dream of victory (lines 418-19), lines which I have discussed at greater length earlier in this section. Immediately preceding this line, however, in lines 417-18, Statius has given us the divergent conditions of Adrastus and Polynices: *Nox* (from line 415) *illa quidem cunctis, sed non tibi mitis, Adraste, / labdacioque duci...* This image further emphasizes the bond between Adrastus and Polynices--neither is able to sleep, and their insomnia is allied through its stark contrast with the slumber of the rest of the Argives (*cunctis*). In this variation of Dido's *"nox erat"* scene, Polynices and Adrastus are isolated together, replacing the solitary individual who is traditionally left alone in the misery of insomnia.

[434] Smolenaars (1994) 198 writes, "the contrast between the sleeping army and the restless city is a striking application of a well-known topos". Then he gives a comprehensive list of examples of the 'captured-city' motif in Latin literature, as well as its typical characteristics (199). Statius adapts the traditional dichotomy between productive army and panicked city to fit it in with his recurring division between sides across the boundary of sleep and unrest. He achieves this by emphasizing specifically the unrest associated with the fear and panic of the Thebans.



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*...donec sol montibus omnis* 450
*erepsit rebusque dedit sopor otia fessis.*
*quis queat attonitas dictis ostendere Thebas?*[435]
*urbem in conspectu belli suprema parantis*
*territat insomnem nox atra diemque minatur.*

...Until all the sun had set along the mountains
and sleep brought repose to exhaustion.
Who is able to describe terrified Thebes with words?
Black night menaced the sleepless city in the face of war
preparing doom and threatened it with day's approach.

The polarized experiences of both sides is emphasized by Statius' varied vocabulary. Sopor brings his gift of peace to the weary Argives, while the city of Thebes is *insomnem*. But Statius deepens the contrast by using the words *sol* and *nox* in his description of their divergent experiences. In lines 450-51, we see a natural progression: the sun sets and sleep arrives; in line 454, the night, rather than provide cover for sleep, frightens and threatens the Thebans. The city's frenzy is described in terms of sleeplessness in order to contrast with the *otium* of the Argives.[436]

But not everyone in Thebes remains awake and tormented. Statius mentions that those Thebans who sleep do so fitfully and dream of war: *...si tenuis demisit lumina somnus, / bella gerunt; modo lucra morae, modo taedia vitae / attonitis, lucemque timent*

[435] The fact that Statius adds a rhetorical question about the effectiveness of words to describe such horrors is extraordinary, and again emphasizes the contrast between the "normal" situation of the Argives and the panic at Thebes. By questioning his method of description, Statius hints at his reluctance to express the consequences of the march of brother against brother, whose outcome is inevitable. This claim that words fail his description is paradoxical, for he continues with a lengthy description of events in lines 455 ff. Perhaps a lack of confidence in the poet's ability to retell that night's events enables the reader to appreciate the particularly visually evocative picture of activity in Thebes that night. This question itself works as a hinge between Statius' descriptions of sleep and its absence for the enemy sides, and draws our attention to the literary devices he uses to overcome the difficulty of writing about Thebes' predicament.

[436] This passage contrasts directly with the situation at Thebes in 2.74 ff., where the Thebans spend a sleepless night (*insomnem...noctem)* reveling rather than panicking (see Smolenaars (1994) 203-04).



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*lucemque precantur* (463-65). Even in sleep it is impossible to escape the terror of war and the anticipation of death. This instance illuminates the similarity between insomnia and nightmare and reminds the reader of the abnormality that characterizes sleep in the epic. This contradiction embodied by the sleep that provides no rest is emphasized by the paradoxical pairs in lines 464-65, both of which explain the ambivalence of the epic's characters towards the approach of the inevitable battle. Delay seems like salvation, while life is untenable for some. The approach of the day is simultaneously feared and desired, since at least the onset of war will end the torture of the wait (as well as their insomnia). Furthermore, we are reminded of the cause of the division between brothers and armies by mention of Oedipus a few lines later in 467-69: *Tisiphone...fratrem huic, fratrem ingerit illi / aut utrique patrem: procul ille penatibus imis / excitus inplorat Furias oculosque reposcit.* While sleep casts down the eyes of the Thebans in their vain attempt to shut out the next day's destruction, Oedipus longs to regain his sight in order to witness the battle which he has willed. The cruel wish of the father who has inflicted his own blindness to come out of physical and mental seclusion just to witness the destruction of his sons underscores the inversion of norms which will prevail in this war.

**Defining Statius' poetics of sleep**

As I have shown, the theme of insomnia in neoteric poetry, love elegy, and both Statius' *Silvae* and *Thebaid* functions as a mode for a poet's self-definition. I believe that Statius' attitude towards insomnia in his statements about his writing finds its roots in the theme of sleeplessness in love elegy. In *Silvae* 5.4, sleeplessness is punitive; in the *Thebaid,* it is a symptom of the tension and anxiety of the characters doomed to fight



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a war which fulfills a sinister curse. In the epilogue to the *Thebaid* and in *Silvae* 3.5, sleeplessness is synonymous with the laborious process of writing an epic which will inevitably be compared to its acknowledged forebear. In the *Thebaid* we see the ultimate transformation of sleep into an agent of death, an incarnation to which *Silvae* 5.4 alludes. In Statius' poetry the theme of sleeplessness evolves from simple metaphor for the exigencies of writing poetry. In *Silvae* 5.4, when the narrator appeals to Somnus to abandon a pair of ungrateful lovers and come to him, he is acknowledging his departure from the paradigm of the insomniac experience in love poetry and establishing his own poetics of insomnia. Thus rather than consider the poem an anomaly to be studied in isolation from the rest of Statius' poetry, or an indicator of the poet's reaction to the events described in the poem that precedes it, it is more fruitful to read the poem in conjunction with other references to sleeplessness in his poetry. Instead of thinking in terms of biographical consistency, we should try to reconstruct Statius' poetic attitude towards a specific phenomenon. Furthermore, an acknowledgment of Statius' noteworthy combination of declarations of hard work, references to sleeplessness, and expressions of competitiveness with Virgil is integral to understanding an under-appreciated aspect of his poetics.

*Silvae* 5.4 is compelling because it conveys succinctly both the personal torment of the insomniac experience and the role of Somnus as an external force responsible for the individual's ability (or inability) to sleep. These distinctions can be loosely mapped onto the thematic differences between the psychological characteristics of elegy and the traditional representation of Somnus as a personification in epic. But the division is not



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so simple, for the insomniac experience described by the narrator of this poem would likely be more familiar to the tormented characters of epic than to the agitated lover of elegy. Rather than reject Somnus willingly as did his forebears in love poetry, this narrator is resigned to be ignored by the god.

By making reference to elegiac poetry in *Silvae* 5.4, Statius both reminds the reader of the origins of the nexus between eroticism, rivalry, and insomnia, and acknowledges his departure from his sources by summoning Somnus away from that realm. The insomniac's antagonism toward the lovers who squander their opportunity to sleep registers the poet's distance from the erotic pleasures of creating elegiac poetry while unable to sleep. As Statius makes known in the epilogue to his *Thebaid,* the duration of the insomnia is commensurate with the length of the poem; an epic cannot be dashed off in a ludic and giddy night of unrest. If we read *Silvae* 5.4 in connection with Statius' other descriptions of insomnia, it becomes a cautionary tale about the marginalization and delusion of the insomniac, and a warning about the baleful power of Somnus. When considered alongside the grim, destructive subject matter of his epic, in which many of the characters suffer from insomnia and nightmares, as opposed to the contemplation of personal vicissitudes which occupy the love poets, the poet's warnings about the dangers of insomnia and the power of Somnus become relevant for our understanding of the role of sleep in the *Thebaid.*

*Silvae* 5.4 paints a contradictory picture of Somnus: the *placidissimus divum* of line 1 is also capable of cruel deprivation; as a god who greatly desired, he is also



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harshly elusive.[437] This duality gives him great power. One difference between the Somnus of *Silvae* 5.4 and the Somnus of the *Thebaid* lies in the fact that in the former, the god terrorizes the insomniac with his absence, and in the latter, it is the presence of Somnus that disturbs the sleeper either through his kinship with death, or because he enables nightmares. When a character is deprived of Somnus' pleasures, as occurs throughout the *Thebaid,* this is a manifestation of the sense of anxiety that runs through the epic, rather than a character's meditation upon his own guilt. In fact, the characters of the epic suffer nightmares or insomnia that foreshadow misfortunes they cannot anticipate, rather than as punishment for crimes they are conscious of committing. The tense desperation inherent in the insomniac's appeal to Somnus, crucial to his characterization in *Silvae* 5.4, is present as a narrative tension in the *Thebaid,* where restful sleep is also elusive, and the contrast between sleepers and insomniacs exemplifies Somnus' control over narrative transition. The anguish of insomnia is central to the effectiveness of *Silvae* 5.4; its torture is similarly palpable in the *Thebaid.* In both cases, the insomniac's lack of understanding of the cause for his suffering increases the pathos of the experience. If we keep these features in mind as we consider the sphragis of the *Thebaid,* we appreciate the alignment between Statius' own experience writing the story and the experience of the characters in his tale.

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[437] For the use of the adjective *placidus* to describe Somnus, see also Ovid *Met.* 11.623, where Iris addresses the god as *placidissime somne deorum* in a captatio benevolentiae, and *Fasti* 3.185 (*in stipula placidi capiebat munera somni)* In the latter case the adjective is used descriptively rather than protreptically or with an ironic sense as in *Silvae* 5.4.



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# Conclusion

## Tracing a Poetics of Sleep

By defining a dream poetics in her 2004 article, Vered Lev Kenaan makes a significant contribution to the study of the representation of dreams in literary narratives. Her work clarifies our understanding of the relationship of ancient dream discourses to an author's presentation of his narrative and to a reader's understanding of this presentation. Lev Kenaan also firmly establishes the study of the representation of dreams in fictional contexts and the use of the dream as a metaphor for other fantasies of fiction, that is, the "dreamlike," as a fruitful subject for the study of dreams in antiquity, one that extends beyond dream analysis or dream interpretation.[438] The complex of stylistic choices that a poet makes in creating topoi such as the retelling of a dream, or the inability to sleep restfully, and the consequences of these choices for his overarching

[438] One need only compare Lev Kenaan's work with another publication from the same year, Pick and Roper's (2004) *Dreams and History,* to appreciate the innovation of her work. Pick and Roper's collection, which is certainly valuable for the history of dream interpretation in different cultures from antiquity to Freud, hews to the traditional focus of studies on dreams: the editors are interested exclusively in interpretation and its modern incarnation, dream analysis, and all of the essays contained in the collection reflect this. Charles Stewart's essay, "Dreams and desires in ancient and early Christian thought", the second in the collection (the first is an essay on Freud, which sets the tone for the entire collection), serves as a spring point for the essays that follow. Only two essays in this collection, Hans-Jürgen Bachorski's "Interpreting dreams in medieval literature" and Stephanie Heraeus' "Artists and the dream," deal with the representation of the dream experience in fictional contexts. Even Heraeus' essay, which focuses on the depictions of dreams in nineteenth century art, is about the reaction of these artists to the scientific dream discourses of the age, precursors to the discipline of psychology. It is illuminating to contrast the role of Artemidorus' *Oneirocritica* in Stewart's essay and in Lev Kenaan's article. For Stewart, Artemidorus is cited in connection with Freud, where he notes that Artemidorus' entries for "oedipal" dreams, those in which a man dreams of sleeping with his mother, were excised from the translation of his work read by Freud. Thus Artemidorus' role as the forefather of dream interpretation is preserved (see Price (1986) and Walde (1999) for comparative discussions of Freud and Artemidorus). For Lev Kenaan (2004) 253, "ancient dream hermeneutics, which preside over a mostly anonymous gallery of ordinary dreamers (authors), can help construct fresh meanings for literary concepts such as author, text, and reader." This application of Artemidorus' work is one of Lev Kenaan's most noteworthy contributions.



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poetic themes, comprise his "poetics of sleep." This rubric broadens the scope of Lev Kenaan's inquiry and reduces its emphasis upon dreaming alone. As Lev Kenaan notes, a psychological dream (*insomnia)* was considered in antiquity "the source of subjective imagination;"[439] in her work, this type of dream becomes a powerful metaphor for the imaginative world created by Apuleius in his novel. My approach acknowledges the tension between subjective and objective in the ancient distinction between types of dreams, and reveals that this tension is also present in ancient beliefs about sleep itself as well as in representations of the sleeping figure. To understand an author's poetics of sleep, we must consider how this tension reflects larger divisions, such as those between internal / external, personal / impersonal, and contemporary / mythological, all of which are significant factors in poetic self-definition.

Just as Artemidorus collected dream symbols and created a typology of their meanings in a handbook that would be of use to future generations of dream interpreters, I have tried to gather here the components that I think are important for recognizing the successful *representation* of dreams and other nighttime phenomena in poetic and artistic contexts. One important part of defining a poetics of sleep has been to identify the individual factors that categorize an author's or an artist's use of the sleep experience in his work. We might call these "taxonomies of sleep." Once we begin to account for the verbal and the visual vocabulary that recurs in these instances, we can see the individual components that characterize an author's particular representation of the sleep experience and hence, his poetics of sleep. The value of this procedure becomes clear

[439] Lev Kenaan (2004) 265.



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when we consider the representation of a dream in a poem of Propertius that is not specifically a dream poem. Paying close attention to these taxonomies in the poem, I will illustrate the intersection of internal and external elements in the dream experience described and suggest its relevance for Propertius' poetic program.

In Propertius' elegy 4.4, the young Tarpeia, smitten by Tatius the Sabine king, falls asleep the night before she plans to betray Rome to unite with him. The scene, which, as John Warden has noted, strongly echoes the tormented madness of Dido and Amata in Virgil's *Aeneid,*[440] is described as follows (lines 63-73):

*'et iam quarta canit venturam bucina lucem,*
*ipsaque in Oceanum sidera lapsa Cadunt.*
*experiar somnum, de te mihi somnia quaeram:*
*fac venias oculis umbra benigna meis!'*
*dixit, et incerto permisit bracchia somno,*
*nescia, vae, furiis accubuisse novis.*
*nam Vesta, Iliacae felix tutela favillae,*
*culpam alit et plures condit in ossa faces:*
*illa ruit, qualis celerem prope Thermodonta*
*Strymonis abscisso pectus aperta sinu.*
*urbi festus erat (dixere Parilia patres)...*

'already the fourth trumpet signals the coming dawn,
the stars slide down exhausted toward the ocean.
I will give sleep a try, and I will seek out dreams about you:
May you come as a friendly vision before my eyes!'
She finished speaking and gave her arms over to uncertain sleep.
Alas! She did not know she had bedded down with new furies.
For Vesta, favorable protector of the Iliac embers,
nurses her sin and lodges more fiery torches in her bones:
She races just like a Thracian bacchant along the swift
Thermodon with a rent garment and her breast exposed.
The next day was the festival which the elders called the Parilia...

[440] See Warden (1978) 182 ff. Cf. in particular, *Aeneid* 1.491 and 4.101, 1.299, 4.81, and 4.300 ff. (among others) for Dido; 7.346 ff. and 374 ff. for Amata Camilla in *Aeneid* 11 also provides a paradigm for the Amazon-like female warrior.



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In lines 65-66 Tarpeia expresses a wish that is typical of the elegiac narrator, namely to dream of one's absent lover.[441] But the way in which Tarpeia's desire is articulated is significant both for our understanding of the role of the visual in Propertius' poetry and for our appreciation of his treatment of dreams. The couplet in lines 65-66 confuses the distinction between the symbolic dream image and the actual visitation, while it conflates the active (subjective) and passive (objective) experiences of dreaming. In line 65, Tarpeia uses an active verb (*quaeram)* to imply her ability to choose the subject of her dream, while line 66, (*fac venias...)* indicates that the vision of her lover will appear to her of his own will, regardless of her specific desire to seek him out. Furthermore, the visual experience of the dream is emphasized here, thus drawing attention to the conception of the dream as an external object *to be viewed (fac venias oculis...meis).* This division is also explicit in Propertius' choice of words to describe the nature of the dream itself. First Tarpeia hopes for dreams of him (*de te somnia*); then she expresses the wish that she will see a vision (*umbra)* of him.[442] In neither case will she see him as he appears to her during her waking hours.[443] These dichotomies correspond to two of the central preoccupations of Propertius' dream poems: the slippage between the

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[441] See Warden (1978) 184 n. 29 for mention of precedents for this wish in Hellenistic epigram.

[442] Of course, the noun *umbra* has funereal connotations; cf. the vision of Cynthia in 4.7, where she is described by the narrator as an *umbra* in line 2.

[443] Contrast with this, for example, *vidi te...* of 2.26a.1, where the context for the sighting is ambiguous until we read *in somnis.* The use of the pronoun *te* in this instance reaffirms that the dream is of the 'psychological' rather than visitation type.



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external and internal sources for dreams, and the idea that the dream is experienced visually.

We learn in the following lines that, as soon as she submits to sleep, Tarpeia is at the whim of a goddess, who allows the girl's desire to run beyond merely an encounter with her would-be lover.[444] The description of her sleep indicates a state of abandon, wherein sleep itself is given the characterization of her conflicted feelings (*somno... incerto).*[445] Thus the fitfulness of her sleep is a reflection of her treacherous passion for Rome's enemy aside from being a simple manifestation of her excitement. The more forceful *experiar somnum* of line 65, where *somnus* is the object of Tarpeia's action, has transformed into an act of surrender, with the dative *somno* as the recipient of her passive gesture. Furthermore, the phrase *permisit bracchia* has important resonance for understanding the vulnerability of the sleeper. As Richardson notes, this is "an etymological use of the verb: 'stretched out her arms' with the ambiguity 'surrendered her embrace.'"[446] But he overlooks its resonance with the depictions of various sleepers in artistic representation, whose abandonment in sleep is signified by the arm (usually the right) flung and relaxed over the head. Because this feature creates a visual image of

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[444] The manuscripts read *vesta* in line 69. Richardson (1977) and Goold (1990) emend to *venus*, for the intervention of this goddess seems to make more sense in the context of fanning the girl's flame of desire. It is, however, difficult to reconcile Venus as *Iliacae felix tutela favillae*. See Richardson (1977) 439 for a persuasive argument for *venus* as "guardian of Aeneas on the voyage that brought the fire from Troy."

[445] This is reminiscent of a transference that I have documented in the context of Statius' *Thebaid*, where the characterization of sleep as fitful or uncertain reflects the anxiety of the characters. In the *Thebaid*, the source of anxiety is not love, but the disruption of a savage, inter-fraternal war.

[446] Richardson (1977) 439. Lyne (1971) 376 argues that Tarpeia surrenders herself as though to a lover, replaced here by Somnus himself.



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the sleeping figure as a physical being, it also invites the reader to act as a viewer might, and thus to start imagining the sleeping figure's dream. In fact, the new demons with which Tarpeia beds (*nescia vae furiis acubuisse novis*, line 68) usurp the place of the desired vision of Tatius in her dreams. Thus the adjective *novus* hints at the movement from objective to subjective dream type, which is exemplified by the transition from Tarpeia's own desire for what she will dream to the actual outcome of her surrender to sleep. I propose that Vesta's intervention banishes the *umbra* of Tatius and thus allows Tarpeia, newly maddened, to see instead a dream image of herself.

Lines 71-72 are the climax of the most subjective part of the poem, Tarpeia's monologue; after this point, Propertius returns to an objective, third person narration of the events.[447] These lines are traditionally read as an explanation of what happens to Tarpeia as a result of her increased passion: she responds to her newly enflamed state by waking up and racing about in a torn garment like a cross between a bacchant and an Amazon.[448] In her recent book on Propertius, Jeri DeBrohun identifies the scenario described in lines 71-72 as a "fitful dream,"[449] but her subsequent analysis does not elaborate upon this point. We know from context that Tarpeia has gone to bed on the night before the Parilia (*cras, ut rumor ait, tota pigrabitur urbe,* line 47), and that the

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[447] For more on the transition from third person to first person narration in this poem, see Stahl (1995) 298.

[448] See Richardson (1977) 439: "Tarpeia rushes to her destruction by love...", Stahl (1985) 298: "out of her sense, Tarpeia gets up and rushes to nowhere -- like a Bacchant.", and Janan (2001) 78: "let us return for a moment to the Bacchant-Amazon whom Tarpeia imitates under Vesta's goading: this woman in mad career cannot easily be located in anything like recognizable space." Warden (1978) 177 is most explicit about her waking state when he writes, "she awakes (so we must infer) and in her reduplicated frenzy rushes..." Neither Fedeli (1965) nor Camps (1965) refers to this analogy as a dream description.

[449] DeBrohun (2003) 194-95.



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following day is the day of the Parilia (*Urvi festus erat...*, line 73). Therefore, what is contained between lines 47-73 must take place during the intervening night; it is conceivable that this occurs during sleep.

As I have already noted, Propertius' evocation of the Virgilian Dido as a bacchant-Amazon in this passage presents a striking juxtaposition of epic and elegiac material. We must include among its referents Virgil's description of Dido's dreams in 4.465 ff., in which Aeneas pursues the raving Dido (*agit ipse furentem / insomnis ferus Aeneas...*, 465-66), a passage that Warden neglects to include in his catalogue. Virgil also blends genres in this dream description by alluding to precedents in tragedy, as Dido's rushing is compared to the madness of Pentheus and Orestes (cf. *scaenis,* line 471) in their pursuit by the Furies. This kind of generic miscegenation is typical of Propertius' other dream poems. In poem 4.7, for example, the specter of Cynthia appears as a dream vision in a manner familiar from epic precedents, such as the ghost of Hector and the disguised fury Allecto in the *Aeneid.*[450]

Remembering these models for the mixing of genres in the context of a dream, let us return to the simile in 4.4, where the interweaving of Virgilian references should encourage us to read this as a description of Tarpeia's dream. The word that introduces the analogy, *qualis,* should influence our appreciation of this as the description of a dream. For this is the only use of the qualitative adjective introducing a mythological

[450] This integration is also a feature of the dream in Propertius 3.3, where epic themes are articulated as counterpoints to their elegiac equivalents. The poet is advised by Apollo and the Muses to pursue the latter. As I showed in chapter 4, the overlap between epic and elegy was used successfully (albeit with different effect) in Statius' *Silvae* 5.4.



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analogy in all of Propertius' poetry, whose referent is a single female figure besides those examples from poems 2.26a (a dream) and 1.3 (a dreamlike experience) discussed above.[451] We can support this interpretation by drawing upon the precedent that Propertius has established in poems 1.3 and 2.26a, where *qualis* introduces mythological analogies that help to explain the narrator's visual experience.

In its succinct description of the emotional state of Tarpeia, the analogy of the bacchant-Amazon rushing beside a swift river also expresses the incoherence of the dream experience. John Warden comments upon the various degrees of "inappropriateness" of the simile.[452] As commentators have noticed, it is not only a double analogy, evoking images of both a bacchant and an Amazon, but it mixes up its geography, placing the woman from Thrace (contained in the adjective *Strymonis,* a reference to the river Strymo on the Thracian-Macedonian border) on the bank of the Thermodon river in Pontus near the Black Sea.[453] These two conflations confuse the

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[451] There is one other example of its usage. This comes in poem 2.2, lines 9 and 11, where Propertius introduces a comparison of Cynthia to Ischomache and Brimo with the word *qualis*. There are problems with the text. Fedeli (1984; 1994) preserves the lines; Goold (1990) follows Richardson (1977) in transferring them to poem 2.29b, where he feels they make better sense. In this new context, Propertius uses these analogies to describe Cynthia as she looks when she has just awoken from sleep. Thus the simile plays a role very similar to that of the analogies in 1.3, and could be used in support of my observation that all uses of the adjective *qualis* in Propertius' poetry, when they introduce mythological analogies and have a single female referent, are in some way connected with dreams and sleep.

[452] Warden (1978) 181. Most of his elucidation of the mixed reference to the violent behaviors of the bacchant and the Amazon is devoted to uncovering the passage's multiple allusions to Virgil's Dido in *Aeneid* 1 and 4 as a referent for Tarpeia.

[453] Janan (2001) 78 notices this confusion, asking "if she is a woman from Strymon, why does she run alongside the Thermodon a thousand miles from her home?" She goes on to speculate about the implications of Propertius' "surreal geography" for the instability of categories in his poetry but does not categorize this instability as dreamlike. I think that any reference to visual representation (however distorted or reconfigured to fit the simile) gives more fodder to out interpretation of the simile as a description of Tarpeia's dream.



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reader both as he tries to envision the person and the place described, and as he tires to make sense of the diverse motivations of the bacchant and of the Amazon in their frenzy. It would be too facile to write off the complexity of these overlays by chalking their incoherence up to the familiar disjointedness of a dream (although this feature certainly does not detract from such an interpretation). Instead, let us look at a further distortion in the reference that adds another dimension to the reader's ability to visualize the scene.

Warden refers to a possible artistic precedent for this image of Tarpeia , and is tempted to believe that Propertius may have actually seen this very depiction.[454] Whether or not Propertius and his readers had seen this particular image,[455] they were no doubt familiar with images of bacchants and Amazons in frenzied motion, both of which have a long pedigree going back to Greek vase-painting. What is of greater interest to this brief analysis is Warden's next comment about the incongruity of the visual referent and the implied meaning of the simile: "there is a tug-of-war between the reader's sensual and cerebral responses; he is provided with an immediate visual illustration and a delayed narrative comment."[456] This could easily describe the situation in either 1.3 or 2.26a, where the putative visual referents are never just clean analogies for the dynamic or tableau described, as they might at first seem. As with a dream, the sensual is in

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[454] Tarpeia is depcited bare-breasted and holding out her hands in a gesture of appeal in a frieze from the Basilica Aemilia dated to around 14 B.C. Warden describes her (1978) 181 "in headlong motion"; the flow of her garments appears to support this. For an image of the frieze with detailed discussion, see Carettoni (1961).

[455] There is some debate about this, as the last datable reference in Propertius' poetry (in poem 4.6) is to an event of the year 16 B.C., so it is possible that book 4 predates the creation of the frieze. It is, of course, impossible to know the order in which the poems of book 4 were written.

[456] Warden (1978) 181.



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conflict with the rational, and the visual description wrestles with the verbal when in the endeavor to describe what has been seen or experienced. The possibility that Propertius evokes and conflates images from artistic representation while drawing attention to the impossibility of this through distortions of meaning gives more fodder to an interpretation of the simile as a description of Tarpeia's dream. The fact that she races about *(ruit)* in her mind while she has given her limbs over to sleep's embrace is another manifestation of the dream's contradictory imagery.

In poems 1.3 and 2.26a the adjective *qualis* is used by the narrator to introduce mythological analogies which comment upon his visual interaction with his lover, whether she is a dreamed image, or a sleeper dreaming of images that the viewer cannot know. In poem 4.4, the adjective is seemingly used by the narrator to describe and elaborate upon the action *(illa ruit)* of another character's dream. It is also possible, however, that the scene described in the simile is what the dreamer herself sees in her dream, and that the entire simile is to be read in apposition to the couplet that precedes it, as the manifestation of Tarpeia's increased passion.[457] This ambiguity underscores the role of this episode as a hinge between the subjective and objective portions of the narrative -- the point at which Tarpeia's extended description of herself (lines 31-66, told in the first person) merges into the narrator's description of what happens to her. In either case, reading the simile as a dream enables us to connect this passage to its context

[457] Goold (1990), following Baehrens, emends *ruit* to *furit*. Although I do not believe this change is necessary, it would lend support to reading the analogy as a dream. The verb *furo* is not used to describe dreaming, but the connections between madness and dreaming, as pointed out by Lucretius and Cicero, for example, were common in antiquity. Even Propertius alludes to the similarity in poem 3.8, discussed in chapter 1.



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both within the poem and, on a larger scale, within the corpus of Propertius' poetry. We need not use the confusion caused by the geographical and mythological tensions presented by the simile -- the main source for criticism on this passage -- merely as a convenient excuse for labeling the simile as a dream. Rather, we can work backwards from the simile, reading its mingling of elements as complements to the shift between subjective and objective narration in the poem, and the powerful opposition between the internal and external types of dream in this specific episode.

In submitting to *somno incerto,* Tarpeia thus succumbs disarmed to the trickery of a goddess and to transformative dreams. This scene of nighttime manipulation might remind us of an episode in *Thebaid* book 10, where the Argives take advantage of the Thebans' deep sleep to slaughter their enemies, whose dreams are replaced by scenes of carnage. The seer Thiodamas announces the opportunity to his comrades as follows: *nox fecunda operum pulchraeque accommoda fraudi / panditur augurio divom...* (lines 192-93). The *pulchra fraus* that the night accommodates is precisely the cruel deceit of this secret attack. Taking these lines out of context for a moment, I will borrow them from Statius to illustrate a point: night has been a fertile subject for my work. Dreams, sleep, and insomnia, the common occupations of the night, could each stand alone as the subject for an individual study. But I have tried to demonstrate in this dissertation that an inclusive study of these nighttime phenomena can reveal important parallels in the Roman attitude towards sleep and dreams. By considering the central themes of visuality and the tension between internal and external in connection with the representations of sleep and dreams in the poetry of Propertius and Statius, I have tried



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to draw attention to the features of the Roman attitude towards these phenomena that were well-suited for poetic and artistic representation. My *opera,* so to speak, have included not only texts, but also works of visual art. I hope it is obvious from the preceding chapters that the integration of art and text can illuminate some of the common problems shared by poets and artists in representing the visual experience of dreaming, the sleeper's embodiment of the intrigue of the private dream, and the conception of sleep itself as a personified form external to the sleeper.

We can also tease out the paradox contained in the phrase *pulchra fraus* in order to apply it to the subjects of this dissertation. In general, night is a time where familiar forms seem altered. Because of the night's darkness, certain things that are normally conspicuous are able to slip by unnoticed; hence the possibility for deception is heightened. But deception is a facet of night's occupations as well. The dreamer, while he dreams, is convinced that what he experiences is reality; it is only upon waking that he realizes the perceptual distance between what he thinks he has experienced and what he experiences in his waking life. Like the viewer of an illusionistic painting, who appreciates the artifice of what he has seen when he turns his eyes away from it, the dreamer accounts for the amazement of this deception in his retelling of the dream. Furthermore, the very image of his dream may consist of one figure convincingly disguised as another, the reanimation of a dead person, or an image which is otherwise physically impossible -- all deceptions to which the dreamer would be less susceptible while awake. The sleeping figure exercises power over its viewer, compelling the viewer to wonder about the thoughts or actions behind the closed eyes of the sleeper's



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inscrutable façade once he has established that the sleeper is in fact asleep rather than lifeless. Contrary to the implications of its frequent epithet *placidus,* sleep is also capable of hostile action: in its capacity for debilitation, sleep is able to render a sleeper vulnerable to manipulation, assault, or death; just as often, he is capable of cruel deprivation, causing unwelcome insomnia in his victims. All of these traits are contained in his personification as the deity Somnus.

As I have explained, dreaming tends to be privileged and excerpted from its context, because the experience of dreaming works so nicely as an analogy for the creation of fiction, while dream interpretation provides a ready template for reading and hence decoding an author's fiction. This bias can in part be traced to the unique status of Artemidorus' *Oneirocritica* as the sole extant example of a "handbook" for dream interpretation from the Greco-Roman world, and therefore, its function in modern scholarship as a sort of encyclopedia against which to check the relevance of certain literary dream images. But this is not the only way to forge connections between the different dream discourses from antiquity. In fact, as I hope I have shown, there is much to say about the interconnections among the literary, artistic, and philosophical treatments of dreams and sleep by looking at the common impulses of their creators in crafting their representations.



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APPENDIX 1: *Silvae* 5.4 and translation

*Crimine quo merui, iuvenis, placidissime divum,*
*quove errore miser donis ut solus egerem,*
*Somne, tuis? tacet omne pecus volucresque feraeque*
*et simulant fessos curvata cacumina somnos,*
*nec trucibus fluviis idem sonus; occidit horror* 5
*aequoris et terris maria acclinata quiescunt.*
*septima iam rediens Phoebe mihi respicit aegras*
*stare genas; totidem Oetaeae Paphiaeque revisunt*
*lampades et totiens nostros Tithonia questus*
*praeterit et gelido spargit miserata flagello.* 10
*unde ego sufficiam? non si mihi lumina mille*
*quae sacer alterna tantum statione tenebat*
*Argus et haud umquam vigilabat corpore toto.*
*at nunc, heu, si aliquis longa sub nocte puellae*
*bracchia nexa tenens ultro te, Somne, repellit,* 15
*inde veni; nec te totas infundere pennas*
*luminibus compello meis (hoc turba precetur*
*laetior); extremo me tange cacumine virgae*
*sufficit), aut leviter suspenso poplite transi.*

For what misdeed or mistake do I deserve to be the only
wretch who misses out on your gifts, Somnus,
young and most peaceful of the gods? All the cattle are silent,
as are the birds and beasts and even the curved tree tops
seem to slump from exhaustion, there is not a sound from the coursing
rivers; the sea's crests slumber and her waves curl up
to sleep on the shores. Phoebe now making her seventh round
spies my anguished face; the Oetaean and Paphian lights in
the sky peek at me just as often, and Tithonia,
having witnessed my laments no fewer times, moved to pity,
and lashes me with her cooling whip. Where will I get the strength to
endure this? I couldn't do it, even if I had one thousand eyes
to take turns like Juno's sacred Argus whose entire body was never
awake at once. But now, oh!, if someone caught up in his lover's
embrace through the long night shoves you off, Somnus,
come to me instead; and I don't mean you have to immerse my eyes in
the comfort of your wings' embrace--I'll leave that to those more
fortunate; just touch me with the farthest tip of your wand--
that's enough!, or skip lightly, just hovering over me with bent knee.



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